

Order of Dawn's Light - Original Campaign Conversations with Claude

Chat 1: LEARNING D&D THROUGH A GUIDED CAMPAIGN

Claude, I'm sick in bed and I can't do much. I was wondering if you could be a DM and guide me through a D&D campaign so I can learn to play it on my own

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: I'd be happy to run a D&D session for you!

I'd be happy to run a D&D session for you! This is a great way to learn the game while you're resting up.

Let me set the scene and we'll keep things simple to start. I'll guide you through the mechanics as we go, so don't worry about knowing all the rules upfront.

Character Creation (Quick Version)

First, let's make your character. To keep it simple, pick:

1. Race - Human, Elf, Dwarf, or Halfling?
2. Class - Fighter (melee combat), Rogue (stealth & skills), Cleric (healing & magic), or Wizard (offensive magic)?
3. Name - Whatever you'd like!

I'll handle the stats and mechanics behind the scenes to keep things moving.

Once you've chosen, I'll drop you into the adventure. Here's the setup:

The Village of Thornhaven

You're a traveling adventurer who's just arrived in the small village of Thornhaven. The villagers seem anxious - livestock has been disappearing at night, and strange howls echo from the nearby Darkwood Forest. The village elder has posted a notice offering a reward to anyone who can investigate.

Go ahead and tell me your character choices, and we'll begin! As we play, I'll explain things like ability checks, combat, and dice rolls when they come up. Sound good?

You said: Ok, I'll be Riv Freeborn, male human cleric!

Ok, I'll be Riv Freeborn, male human cleric! I have dice here, so I'm happy to roll if needed!

How long have I been on the road for? I should probably settle in at the tavern for a warm bed and meal before I head into the forest

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Perfect! Riv Freeborn, human cleric - excellent choice. Clerics are versatile, with healing magic, some combat ability, and divine spells.

You've been on the road for about a week, traveling from the larger town of Millford to the south. Your boots are dusty, your traveling cloak is road-worn, and a hot meal sounds incredible right now.

The Sleeping Giant Tavern

You push open the heavy wooden door of the village's only tavern. The warmth hits you immediately - a crackling fireplace, the smell of roasted meat and ale, and the low murmur of conversation. A few locals sit at tables, speaking in hushed tones. Behind the bar stands a burly woman with her hair tied back, wiping down mugs.

She looks up as you enter. "Welcome, traveler. Name's Gerda. You look like you could use a meal and a bed. Five silver pieces gets you both, plus breakfast in the morning."

As she speaks, you notice a weathered notice pinned to a board near the bar - the reward posting about the missing livestock and strange occurrences in Darkwood Forest. It mentions 50 gold pieces for solving the problem.

You also spot:

- A nervous-looking farmer sitting alone, staring into his ale
- Two local hunters sharing a table, speaking quietly
- An older man in the corner who looks like he might be the village elder

What do you do?

You said: How much money do I have on me?

How much money do I have on me?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good question!

Good question! Let's figure out your starting funds.

As a starting cleric, you'd typically have $5d4 \times 10$ gold pieces.

Go ahead and roll 5d4 (five four-sided dice) and tell me what you get. Then we'll multiply the total by 10 to see how many gold pieces Riv has in his coin purse.

(For reference: 1 gold piece = 10 silver pieces, so that meal and bed Gerda mentioned would cost you half a gold piece)

You said: 2, 2, 2, 1, 2

2, 2, 2, 1, 2

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: That's a total of 9, so you have 90 gold pieces!

That's a total of 9, so you have 90 gold pieces! Not bad - you're not rich, but you're comfortable enough. That 5 silver piece meal and bed is no problem (that's half a gold piece), and you'd still have plenty left over.

Back in The Sleeping Giant

Gerda waits for your response, cloth still in hand. Your coin purse feels reassuringly heavy at your belt - 90 gold pieces should see you through this investigation and then some.

The nervous farmer takes another sip of his ale, his hands trembling slightly. The two hunters glance your way briefly before returning to their hushed conversation. The elder in the corner seems to be watching you with interest.

What would you like to do?

- Pay Gerda for the room and meal?
- Talk to someone first (the farmer, hunters, or elder)?
- Read the notice board more carefully?
- Something else?

You said: "Thank you for your hospitality, Gerda.

"Thank you for your hospitality, Gerda. I would be honored to take the room, and a hot meal would be heavenly right now. I saw the posting about the howls coming from Darkwood Forest. Can you tell me anything about what's going on?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Gerda nods approvingly and takes your silver pieces, tucking them into her apron.

Gerda nods approvingly and takes your silver pieces, tucking them into her apron. "I'll have Mara bring out a plate for you - mutton stew with fresh bread. Room's upstairs, second door on the right."

She leans against the bar, her expression growing more serious as she lowers her voice. "Aye, the forest trouble. Started about two weeks ago. First it was old Brennan's chickens - whole coop emptied overnight, just feathers and blood left behind. Then Tomás lost three sheep." She gestures toward the nervous farmer. "That's Tomás there, poor bastard. Lost another two just last night."

She glances toward the window, where dusk is starting to settle. "The howling... it's not natural. Wrong pitch for wolves, if you ask me. And whatever it is, it's getting bolder - coming closer to the village each night."

A young woman - presumably Mara - emerges from the kitchen with a steaming bowl of stew and a hunk of bread, setting it at the bar for you.

Gerda continues, "Elder Wren posted that reward. He's the one in the corner there." She nods toward the old man. "The hunters - Dagmar and Finn - they tried tracking whatever it is two days back. Came back empty-handed and spooked."

What do you do next?

You said: "Sounds like some real trouble.

"Sounds like some real trouble. I'll head over to speak with the Elder. What is his drink of choice? I'll take two mugs for his table"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Gerda's stern expression softens into an approving smile.

Gerda's stern expression softens into an approving smile. "Smart lad. Wren's partial to spiced mead - the good stuff, not the swill most folk drink. That'll be 5 silver pieces for two mugs."

She pours two clay mugs of amber liquid that smells of honey, cinnamon, and cloves, then slides them across the bar to you.

"He'll appreciate the gesture. Wren's a good man - been leading this village for twenty years. This business with the forest has him more worried than I've ever seen."

You pick up your stew, bread, and the two mugs of spiced mead, carefully making your way across the common room to Elder Wren's table.

As you approach, the old man looks up. He's perhaps seventy, with a weathered face, sharp gray eyes, and hands gnarled from decades of work. He's dressed simply but with a silver chain of office around his neck marking his position.

He studies you for a moment, taking in your travel-worn clothes and the holy symbol of your deity hanging at your chest.

"A cleric, unless my eyes deceive me," he says, his voice gravelly but strong. "And bearing gifts, no less. Please, sit."

How do you introduce yourself?

You said: Who is my deity?

Who is my deity?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great question!

Great question! As a cleric, your deity is central to your character. Let me give you some common options that would fit well:

Pelor - God of the sun, light, and healing. Lawful Good. (Popular choice for traveling clerics who help those in need)

Helm - God of protection and guardians. Lawful Neutral. (Watchers and defenders)

Ilmater - God of endurance and suffering. Lawful Good. (Martyrs who ease others' pain)

Tempus - God of war and battle. Chaotic Neutral. (For a more martial cleric)

Tymora - Goddess of luck and fortune. Chaotic Good. (Adventurers and risk-takers)

Or you can choose a deity from your own imagination or create one!

Which deity does Riv serve? This will influence your personality, your healing/combat style, and how NPCs might react to you. Take your pick!

You said: Do I need to be the alignment of the god in order to serve them?

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Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good question!

Good question! In D&D 5th edition (which is what most people play now), no - you don't need to match your deity's alignment exactly. You just need to be within one step and generally uphold their values.

For example:

- A Lawful Good deity like Pelor could have Lawful Good, Neutral Good, or Lawful Neutral clerics

- You couldn't be Chaotic Evil and serve Pelor, but you could be Neutral Good even if he's Lawful Good

The key is that your character's actions and beliefs should generally align with the deity's portfolio and values, even if you're not exactly the same alignment.

What alignment are you thinking for Riv? And does any particular deity call to you, or would you like to create your own?

(For reference, common alignments are: Lawful Good, Neutral Good, Chaotic Good, Lawful Neutral, True Neutral, Chaotic Neutral, Lawful Evil, Neutral Evil, Chaotic Evil)

You said: Well, Riv generally helps those in need, though he seeks material comforts (warm bed and meals, the opportunity to bathe, keeping his gear in order) when possi...

Well, Riv generally helps those in need, though he seeks material comforts (warm bed and meals, the opportunity to bathe, keeping his gear in order) when possible. He doesn't always do good just for the sake of being good. Sometimes he does it to pay the bills. He tries to make the right decisions. He's also a bit power-hungry. He seeks ever greater knowledge of the world around him, pursuing knowledge and spells that help grow his power. He wants greatness, to be remembered as a great healer and hero to the people; sometimes his lust for that greatness overshadows the good that he does

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Excellent character depth!

Excellent character depth! Riv sounds like Neutral Good with some ambitious tendencies - he genuinely wants to help people, but he's pragmatic about it and has personal goals beyond pure altruism. That hunger for greatness and power is a great character flaw that could lead to interesting choices.

Given that description, here are some deities that fit well:

Pelor (Sun, healing, light) - The classic. Riv could serve Pelor while being more pragmatic than the typical "saint" cleric. Pelor values helping others, which Riv does, even if his motivations are mixed.

Lathander (Dawn, renewal, vitality) - God of new beginnings and creativity. Values ambition and self-improvement alongside compassion. This fits Riv's drive for greatness perfectly.

Savras (Divination, truth, fate) - God of knowledge and seeing the future. Good fit for someone who craves knowledge and understanding of the world.

Mystra (Magic, knowledge, spells) - Goddess of magic itself. Perfect for someone hungry for magical power and spell knowledge.

I'd suggest Lathander - the Morninglord embraces both compassion AND ambition, which perfectly captures Riv's duality. His symbol is a sunrise, and his clerics are known as driven, optimistic people who want to make their mark.

Does Lathander work for Riv, or would you prefer another?

You said: Yes, Lathander sounds right!

Yes, Lathander sounds right! Ok, so, to resume:

"Yes, Honored Elder, a cleric of Lathander. I understand your village is under siege. As I've just arrived, I would like to know more - about your current troubles and about your village's history. Is this an isolated incident?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren accepts the mug of spiced mead with a grateful nod, taking a slow sip before setting it down carefully.

Elder Wren accepts the mug of spiced mead with a grateful nod, taking a slow sip before setting it down carefully.

"A servant of the Morninglord - a welcome sight in dark times." He gestures for you to sit. "Riv Freeborn, you say? I am Wren, elder of Thornhaven these past twenty years."

He wraps his gnarled hands around the warm mug, his eyes growing distant as he considers your question.

"Isolated? No, I fear not - though the form this trouble takes is new." He leans forward, lowering his voice. "Thornhaven sits at the edge of Darkwood Forest, and we've always had our share of dangers - wolves, the occasional bear, bandits using the deep woods to hide. But we've lived in balance with the forest for generations."

He takes another drink. "This started two weeks ago. The howling... it's unlike anything we've heard before. And the killings are methodical. Whatever this creature is, it's not hunting for food - it's killing more than it eats, leaving carcasses torn apart. It's almost as if..." he pauses, choosing his words carefully, "as if something is sending a message."

Wren's expression darkens. "Three nights ago, young Willem - Tomás's son - swears he saw something at the forest edge. Man-shaped, he said, but hunched and wrong. Covered in fur. When his father went to investigate the next morning, they found tracks. Wolf tracks... that became human footprints halfway back to the tree line."

He meets your eyes. "I fear we're dealing with a lycanthrope, Riv. A werewolf."

How do you respond?

You said: Riv takes a deep breath.

Riv takes a deep breath. "I've dealt with lycanthropes in the past. Even they are not outside the healing powers of an experienced cleric, though we must approach them with care. I understand your hunters recently had an encounter with it. The two gentlemen at the table over there" [Riv gestures vaguely in the direction of the table the two hunters sit at]. Tell me, are these men experienced hunters? Do you trust them?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren glances over at Dagmar and Finn, his expression thoughtful.

Elder Wren glances over at Dagmar and Finn, his expression thoughtful.

"Dagmar - the broad-shouldered woman with the bow - she's been hunting these woods for fifteen years. Best tracker in Thornhaven, maybe best in the region. Her father was master huntsman before her." He takes another sip of mead. "Finn's younger, perhaps twenty-five, but he's skilled enough. Been Dagmar's apprentice for seven years now."

Wren's brow furrows. "I trust them with my life, Riv. Which is why what happened troubles me so deeply."

He leans closer, voice dropping. "They went into Darkwood two days past, following the tracks from Tomás's farm. They're both seasoned - they've faced down bears, tracked wounded boars through dense thicket, even fought off bandits once. But they came back after only four hours, pale as ghosts."

He pauses, weighing his words. "Dagmar wouldn't speak of it at first. Finally, she said they found the creature's den - or what they thought was its den. A cave about two miles into the forest. But when they got close..." He shakes his head. "She said the wrongness of the place hit them like a physical force. An unnatural dread. Finn wanted to press on, but Dagmar's instincts told her they needed silver weapons and more preparation. When cooler heads prevail even in experienced hunters, I listen."

He looks at you seriously. "If you mean to face this thing, they might be willing to guide you - or at least tell you what they saw. But you should know: whatever's out there frightened two people who don't frighten easily."

What do you do?

You said: Does Riv have any knowledge of warding barriers or anything he can set up to protect the town for the night?

Does Riv have any knowledge of warding barriers or anything he can set up to protect the town for the night?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good thinking!

Good thinking! Let's see what Riv knows and can do.

As a cleric of Lathander, you have knowledge of protective magic. At low level, your options are somewhat limited, but you do have some tools:

Spells you might have prepared:

- Protection from Evil and Good - You could cast this on individuals (lasts 10 minutes, protects against aberrations, celestials, elementals, fey, fiends, and undead - unfortunately, lycanthropes are humanoids, so this won't directly protect against a werewolf)
- Ceremony (if you have it) - Could bless an area, but it takes an hour

What you know about werewolves: Riv would know that werewolves are vulnerable to silvered weapons. Regular weapons can hurt them in human form, but in hybrid or wolf form, they have resistance to non-magical, non-silvered damage.

Practical protection: As a cleric, you'd know that creating a proper ward requires:

- Time (rituals take at least an hour)
- Holy symbols or blessed water placed at key points
- Possibly divine intervention through prayer

You could suggest to Elder Wren:

- Posting guards with torches/fire (werewolves fear fire)
- Keeping livestock and people indoors after dark
- You could bless the village perimeter, though it would take several hours

Would you like to:

1. Ask Wren if the village has any silver weapons?
2. Suggest defensive measures for tonight?
3. Offer to attempt a blessing ritual?
4. Something else?

You said: "Tell me, Elder: what does the town have in the way of silvered weapons or symbols?"

"Tell me, Elder: what does the town have in the way of silvered weapons or symbols? Is there a guard you could muster?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren grimaces, setting down his mug.

Elder Wren grimaces, setting down his mug. "That's the heart of our problem, I'm afraid."

He counts off on his weathered fingers. "For silver weapons - precious little. Old Garrick the blacksmith has a silvered shortsword that's been in his family for generations. Hung above his forge, more decoration than tool these days. Dagmar has a handful of silvered arrowheads - maybe six or seven - her grandmother made them years back for 'just in case.' Beyond that?" He shakes his head. "We're farmers and tradesmen, Riv. Silver's expensive, and most folk here have never faced anything that required it."

He takes another drink, considering your second question. "As for a guard... we have no formal militia. Most able-bodied folk can handle a pitchfork or a woodaxe, and perhaps a dozen can use a bow well enough to hunt. In a crisis, I could muster maybe twenty people willing to stand watch, but they're farmers and craftsmen, not soldiers."

Wren's expression is grim but resolute. "We've been keeping the livestock penned close and posting watches at night since this began. Two-person shifts watching the village perimeter. So far the creature has stayed to the outlying farms, but each night it grows bolder. Last night it took sheep from Tomás's pen - and his farm is only half a mile from the village center."

He meets your eyes. "We're out of our depth, cleric. That's why I posted the reward. Fifty gold pieces is nearly everything in the village coffers, but if this continues..." He doesn't finish the sentence.

What's your next move?

You said: "I understand" [Riv says, as he eats his stew, dipping the bread in to soak up the salted liquid], "and I have a plan.

"I understand" [Riv says, as he eats his stew, dipping the bread in to soak up the salted liquid], "and I have a plan. I'll need to speak with Dagmar and Finn. Would you introduce me?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren nods approvingly and rises from his seat, taking his mug with him.

Elder Wren nods approvingly and rises from his seat, taking his mug with him. "Of course. Come."

He leads you across the common room to where the two hunters sit. As you approach with your bowl of stew, you get a better look at them:

Dagmar is a solidly built woman in her mid-thirties, with short-cropped dark hair and a weathered face that speaks of years in the wilderness. A well-maintained longbow rests against the wall beside her, and she wears practical leather armor. Her hands, wrapped around her ale mug, are calloused and scarred.

Finn is leaner, with sandy brown hair tied back and a nervous energy about him. He's younger - mid-twenties as Wren said - with a hunter's watchful eyes. A quiver of arrows sits on the bench beside him.

Both look up as Wren approaches.

"Dagmar, Finn - this is Riv Freeborn, a cleric of Lathander. He's come about our... situation." Wren's tone makes it clear this is official business.

Dagmar studies you with sharp, assessing eyes, then gestures to an empty seat at their table. "A cleric, eh? Come to deal with our beast?" Her tone isn't mocking, but there's a wariness to it - she's clearly seen something that's shaken her confidence.

Finn nods a greeting but stays quiet, watching you.

How do you introduce yourself and what do you ask them?

You said: "I understand that you are the most experienced hunters in Thornhaven."

"I understand that you are the most experienced hunters in Thornhaven. I would like to approach the lycanthrope by day, but that means surviving tonight. How is your aim over a mid-length distance? If I could draw the lycanthrope into conversation, could you strike it with an arrow from afar?"

"My plan is thus: to first speak with the lycanthrope and attempt to heal him of his affliction. Lycanthropy is just as much as disease as anything else, and my God requires that I approach this test in a way that results in a peaceful resolution before attempting a more martial solution. Should I fail, however, I would have you and your apprentice perched further afield ready to fire upon him with one of your few silvered arrowheads. Is that something you feel confident in?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Dagmar and Finn exchange a quick glance.

Dagmar and Finn exchange a quick glance. Dagmar leans back, her expression serious as she considers your plan.

"My aim?" She says it without boast or false modesty. "At fifty paces I can put an arrow through a rabbit's eye in dim light. Finn's nearly as good - he can reliably hit a man-sized target at sixty paces, even seventy if conditions are right." She takes a drink. "Distance isn't the problem, cleric."

She leans forward, lowering her voice. "The problem is what you're proposing. You want to talk to it?" There's no mockery in her tone, but clear concern. "We tracked it to its den two days back. The wrongness of that place..." She shakes her head. "I've hunted for fifteen years and never felt anything like it. A dread that crawls into your bones."

Finn speaks up, his voice tight. "It wasn't natural fear, like facing a bear. It was wrong. Like the forest itself was warning us away."

Dagmar continues, "And if you think you can reason with this thing - the kills we've seen aren't the work of someone who's simply sick. The brutality..." She pauses. "But you're the cleric. If Lathander guides you to try mercy first, I won't argue with your god."

She drums her fingers on the table, thinking. "Here's what I can do: I have seven silvered arrowheads. If you're set on confronting it, Finn and I can position ourselves with clear sightlines. But understand - if this creature is in its beast form and charges you, even our best shots might not drop it before it reaches you. Werewolves are fast."

She meets your eyes. "Are you certain about this approach? And when were you thinking - tonight, or waiting for daylight?"

How do you respond?

You said: "We should wait for daylight; and I aim to approach it in human form, if I can."

"We should wait for daylight; and I aim to approach it in human form, if I can. My hope is you will stand by should it change. As for tonight, I will do what I can to shield the town from the danger this beast poses. Elder Wren, can you recall your folk towards the center of town? The closer together we are, the more certain we can be of my barrier working properly."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren nods firmly.

Elder Wren nods firmly. "I can do that. Most folk are already keeping close after dark, but I'll send word to the outlying farms - Tomás and the others - to bring their families and livestock into the village center for the night." He pauses. "That's four farms, maybe thirty people total plus their animals. We can pen the livestock in the town square and have families stay here at the tavern or with neighbors."

Dagmar looks thoughtful. "If you're planning to ward the village center, that might actually work. The creature's been striking at the edges - isolated farms. If we consolidate, it either stays away or has to come through your barrier."

Finn adds nervously, "And if it does come through?"

"Then we'll know your barrier failed before it reaches anyone's throat," Dagmar says bluntly. She looks at you. "How long will this protection last, cleric? And what do you need to set it up?"

Elder Wren is already standing. "I'll start sending runners to the farms immediately. How much time do you need, Riv?"

Good questions to consider:

- What ritual/spell are you planning to use?
- How long will it take to set up?

- Do you need any materials (holy water, holy symbols, etc.)?
- The sun is setting - you probably have about an hour before full darkness.

What's your plan for the barrier, and what do you tell them?

You said: I'd better get started right away.

I'd better get started right away. You said the ritual takes about an hour to complete, right? I'll perform a ceremony to bless the town's center, but we'll need holy symbols or blessed water if any is to be found.

"We should have a number of folk placed as guards, all armed with torches inside the circle of protection. Let's ensure that myself, Dagmar, Finn, and any others who feel fit for making contact with the lycanthrope on the morrow are able to get some rest tonight"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Elder Wren nods decisively.

Elder Wren nods decisively. "I'll see it done."

He turns to address the group. "Dagmar, Finn - spread the word. I want the outlying families brought in within the half hour. Gerda," he calls to the tavern keeper, "we'll need space for folk to sleep tonight. Common room, upstairs, anywhere warm."

Gerda nods grimly from behind the bar. "I'll make room."

Wren looks back to you. "For holy symbols and blessed water - the village shrine to Chauntea is just across the square. She's the goddess most folk here pray to for good harvests. The shrine keeper, old Mother Nelle, maintains a basin of blessed water there. I'll have her bring what you need. Will symbols of Chauntea work for a ritual by a cleric of Lathander, or do you need something specific to the Morninglord?"

Mechanically: The Ceremony spell can bless an area and typically takes 1 hour to cast. You'd be creating a protective ward around the village center. Holy symbols of any good-aligned deity should work for this purpose, though having your own symbol of Lathander would be ideal.

Current situation:

- Sun is setting - maybe 45 minutes of daylight left
- You need to start the ritual soon
- Families and livestock are being gathered to the center

Questions:

1. Do you have your own holy symbol of Lathander with you?
2. Where exactly do you want to center the ritual - the town square?
3. Do you want to do anything else before starting?

What do you tell Wren, and what do you do?

You said: [I have a symbol of Lathander around my neck]

[I have a symbol of Lathander around my neck]

"I will head to the center of town to begin my ritual. Please have Mother Nelle bring anything she thinks will help us. I'm sure Chauntea and Lathander will see us through the night."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Wren clasps your shoulder firmly.

Wren clasps your shoulder firmly. "Lathander's light upon you, cleric. I'll have Mother Nelle meet you in the square immediately."

You finish the last of your stew quickly and head outside into the dimming evening. The village square is a modest open area - perhaps sixty feet across - with a well at its center and a few market stalls shuttered for the night. To one side stands a small wooden shrine to Chauntea, goddess of agriculture, decorated with carved wheat sheaves.

The air is cooling rapidly, and you can already hear the sounds of activity as villagers respond to Wren's call - families emerging from homes with bundled belongings, the bleating of nervous sheep being herded toward the square.

An elderly woman in simple robes approaches - Mother Nelle. She's perhaps seventy, with kind eyes and silver hair bound in a braid. She carries a clay vessel of blessed water and several wooden holy symbols of Chauntea.

"Cleric Riv," she says with a respectful nod. "Elder Wren told me of your plan. I've brought what we have - blessed water from our shrine, and these symbols." She pauses, studying you. "I've maintained Chauntea's shrine for forty years, but I've never attempted a warding of this scale. Tell me how I can assist you."

Around you, families are beginning to gather. Children cling to their parents, livestock mill nervously, and you can see torches being lit as darkness approaches.

You have about 40 minutes of fading light left.

How do you want to perform this ritual? Do you:

- Ask Mother Nelle to help you in the casting?

- Have her place the holy symbols at specific points?
- Mark out the perimeter yourself?
- Something else?

What do you do?

You said: "Mother Nelle, thank you for your help in building this warding circle with me.

"Mother Nelle, thank you for your help in building this warding circle with me. We have limited time before darkness falls. Please place our holy symbols at the 4 cardinal points. I will create the circle using our blessed water to trace the lines between the symbols. Once all 4 symbols are placed, please position yourself at the center and begin your prayer to Chauntea. As soon as the circle is drawn, I will join you. Together, we will protect these people from the threat outside the gates!"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Mother Nelle's weathered face breaks into a determined smile.

Mother Nelle's weathered face breaks into a determined smile. "Chauntea guides the harvest, and Lathander brings the dawn. Together, they will see us through." She gathers the holy symbols - carved wooden discs depicting sheaves of wheat - and moves with surprising speed for her age.

You watch as she paces out the square, marking the four cardinal directions with precision born of decades tending the land and observing the sun's path. North, East, South, West - she places each symbol carefully, pressing them into the earth and murmuring quick prayers at each point.

Meanwhile, you take the clay vessel of blessed water. The liquid glows faintly in the dimming light - truly sanctified by faith and ritual. You begin at the North point, where Mother Nelle placed the first symbol.

Let me have you roll a Religion check to see how well you perform the ritual.

Roll a d20 and add your Wisdom modifier (as a cleric, your Wisdom is probably +2 or +3 at low level - let's say +2 for now).

Tell me what you roll!

Around you, villagers watch in hushed silence. Families huddle together, children's eyes wide. The bleating of sheep quiets as if even the animals sense something sacred occurring. Elder Wren stands at the edge, torch in hand, while Dagmar and Finn ensure everyone stays within the boundary you're creating.

The sun touches the horizon. Darkness is coming fast.

Roll your d20!

You said: 18!

18!

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $18 + 2 = 20$!

$18 + 2 = 20$! An excellent roll!

You move with practiced grace and unwavering focus, pouring the blessed water in a continuous line from symbol to symbol. The water doesn't simply soak into the earth - it glows, leaving a faint luminescent trail that connects each cardinal point. Your faith in Lathander is absolute in this moment, and the Morninglord answers.

As you complete the circle, connecting back to the North point, a subtle shimmer rises from the glowing line - like heat haze, but cool and pure. The air within the circle feels different: calmer, warmer, safer.

You stride quickly to the center where Mother Nelle waits, already deep in prayer to Chauntea. Her voice is steady, speaking words of growth, protection, and harvest. You join her, raising your holy symbol of Lathander high - a silver sunburst that catches the last rays of the setting sun and seems to blaze with inner light.

Your voice rings out clear and strong:

"Lathander, Morninglord, Lord of Birth and Renewal! As dawn breaks the darkness, so let your light shield these people through the night! Let no corruption, no curse, no creature of evil darkness cross this threshold!"

The shimmer intensifies. For a moment, a dome of soft golden light - mixed with the green-gold of growing things - arcs over the entire village center before fading to near-invisibility. But you can still feel it. Everyone can.

The ritual is complete.

A collective exhale ripples through the gathered villagers. A child laughs nervously. Someone begins to weep with relief.

Mother Nelle opens her eyes and looks at you with profound respect. "Well done, cleric. The gods have heard us."

Elder Wren approaches, awe on his weathered face. "Riv Freeborn... that was remarkable."

The ward is set. It will last until dawn.

Darkness falls fully now. Beyond the circle, the forest looms black and threatening. Torches are lit around the perimeter - six villagers stand watch, armed with whatever they could find.

What do you do now?

- Rest and recover your strength for tomorrow?
- Stay on watch?
- Speak with someone?
- Something else?

You said: Do I have the ability to use a shortsword, like the silvered one the blacksmith owns?

Do I have the ability to use a shortsword, like the silvered one the blacksmith owns?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good question!

Good question! Let's check your proficiencies.

As a Cleric, you are proficient with:

- Simple weapons (club, mace, quarterstaff, light crossbow, etc.)
- Your deity may grant additional proficiencies

Shortsword is a martial weapon, which clerics aren't normally proficient with. However, some cleric domains grant martial weapon proficiency.

For a cleric of Lathander, you'd most likely have the Life Domain or Light Domain:

- Life Domain = Heavy armor proficiency (no martial weapons)
- Light Domain = Medium armor proficiency (no martial weapons)

So technically, no - you wouldn't be proficient with a shortsword, which means you could use it but wouldn't add your proficiency bonus to attack rolls (+2 at low level).

HOWEVER, you could use:

- A mace or warhammer (simple weapons you're proficient with)
- Ask the blacksmith to silver one of those instead
- Or use the shortsword with a slight penalty to hit

Alternatively, if you want Riv to have trained with a shortsword in his background, we could say you have proficiency. It's your character!

What would you like to do? Should we:

1. Have Riv use the silvered shortsword (with or without proficiency)?
2. Ask if the blacksmith can silver a mace instead?
3. Rely primarily on your spells and let Dagmar/Finn handle the silver weapons?

You said: How about the nobility domain?

How about the nobility domain? I just did a quick search of Lathander's domains and that one seems right for Riv to follow: (Nobility: This domain represents his connection to self-perfection and striving for one's best.) Any chance that has martial proficiency? Even if it doesn't, let's assume that's my domain, since I think it fits Riv's personality the best

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: I like that choice - the Nobility domain fits Riv's ambition and drive for greatness perfectly!

I like that choice - the Nobility domain fits Riv's ambition and drive for greatness perfectly!

However, I should mention that Nobility domain isn't in the standard 5th edition rules - it might be from earlier editions or homebrew. But you know what? For this campaign, let's use it anyway since it fits Riv so well thematically!

Looking at similar domains, Nobility-themed clerics often get:

- Heavy armor proficiency
- Martial weapon proficiency ✓

So yes, let's say Riv is proficient with martial weapons, including the shortsword! This makes perfect sense for someone who sees himself as a future great hero - he'd have trained in proper combat alongside his divine studies.

Back in the village square:

The ward shimmers faintly overhead. You feel the divine energy you've channeled settling into place, and your thoughts turn practical. Tomorrow you face a werewolf, and while your faith is strong, a silvered blade might make the difference between life and death.

Do you want to:

1. Seek out Garrick the blacksmith now to discuss borrowing his silvered shortsword?

2. Get some rest first and speak with him in the morning?
3. Something else?

The night is young, and you can still hear families settling in around the square. Elder Wren is organizing the watch rotations.

What's your next move?

You said: I would like to speak with Garrick now before heading back to my room at The Sleeping Giant

I would like to speak with Garrick now before heading back to my room at The Sleeping Giant

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: You make your way through the gathered villagers, stepping carefully around families huddled with their belongings and penned livestock.

You make your way through the gathered villagers, stepping carefully around families huddled with their belongings and penned livestock. The square has transformed into a temporary refuge - children bedding down on blankets, adults speaking in low, worried tones, the smell of torch smoke mixing with the earthy scent of sheep and chickens.

You ask around and are directed to a broad-shouldered man in his fifties, standing near the eastern edge of your protective circle. He's got soot permanently stained into the creases of his hands and a thick leather apron over his clothes. His iron-gray beard is neatly trimmed, and despite the chaos, he's calmly checking that the penned animals have water.

"Garrick?" you ask.

He turns, sizing you up with the practiced eye of someone who's spent a lifetime judging the quality of metal and men alike. "Aye. You're the cleric who made that ward." It's not a question - he watched the whole ritual. "Hell of a thing. Name's Garrick Ironheart, though most just call me Garrick."

He wipes his hands on his apron. "I'm guessing you didn't come over here just to admire my way with livestock. What can I do for you?"

The forge-master's direct manner suggests he appreciates people who get to the point.

What do you say to him?

You said: "I understand you own a family heirloom - a silvered shortsword.

"I understand you own a family heirloom - a silvered shortsword. As one of the few silvered weapons in town, I would like to take it with me when I face the lycanthrope in the morning. I would be more than happy to purchase it from you, or just as happy to return it should I come back hale and healthy"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Garrick's expression grows thoughtful, his jaw working as he considers your words.

Garrick's expression grows thoughtful, his jaw working as he considers your words. He's quiet for a long moment, studying you - your bearing, the holy symbol of Lathander at your chest, the confidence in your stance.

"My great-grandfather forged that blade," he says finally. "Garrick the Elder, they called him. Made it during the Goblin Wars, seventy years back, when silver was needed against darker things than goblins." He crosses his arms. "It's hung above my forge for thirty years. Never thought I'd need to take it down."

He glances toward the dark forest beyond your glowing ward, then back to you.

"I won't sell it - it's not mine to sell, it belongs to my line. But..." He extends a calloused hand for a firm shake. "I'll lend it to you, cleric. On two conditions."

He holds up two fingers. "First - you bring it back, or you don't come back at all. I won't have that blade lost in some beast's gullet or lying in the forest rot. Second..." His expression softens slightly. "You kill that thing, or cure it, or whatever it is Lathander guides you to do. My niece is married to Tomás. Those sheep it killed? That's her family's livelihood. This creature ends tomorrow."

He looks you dead in the eye. "Do we have an agreement, Riv Freeborn?"

How do you respond?

You said: "A third option occurs to me, if you would consider it: you are stout of heart and spirit.

"A third option occurs to me, if you would consider it: you are stout of heart and spirit. You seem to love this village and these people, and you have the build of a trained fighter. Dagmar and Finn are following me tomorrow from a distance, that they may act should things go poorly. Would you wield this family heirloom yourself at my side?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Garrick's eyebrows rise in surprise, then a slow smile spreads across his weathered face - the kind of smile that suggests you've said exactly the right thing.

Garrick's eyebrows rise in surprise, then a slow smile spreads across his weathered face - the kind of smile that suggests you've said exactly the right thing.

"Now that's an offer I didn't expect." He lets out a low chuckle, flexing his broad shoulders. "I'm a blacksmith, cleric, not a soldier. But my da made damn sure I knew how to use every weapon that came off our anvil. Can't sell a man a sword you can't swing yourself, he used to say."

He looks down at his calloused, powerful hands - hands that have shaped metal for decades. "Haven't been in a real fight in... gods, fifteen years? Broke up a tavern brawl that got out of hand. But a werewolf?" He meets your eyes, and there's steel there - the same steel he's been forging all his life.

"Aye," he says firmly. "I'll stand with you. That blade's been waiting seventy years for a purpose beyond decoration. Might as well be wielded by a man whose blood forged it." He extends his hand again, this time not just for agreement, but for brotherhood. "Tomorrow at first light, we face this thing together. Dagmar and Finn at range, you with your god's power, and me with great-grandfather's silver."

His grip is like iron when you shake.

"I'll fetch the blade from my forge tonight - it's outside your ward, but close enough. I'll have it sharpened and ready by dawn." He grins. "Haven't felt this alive in years, cleric. Lathander chose well when he sent you to Thornhaven."

What do you do next?

You said: "Outside my ward doesn't afford much protection."

"Outside my ward doesn't afford much protection. Even if just a short walk from here, this night is too dark for you to go alone. Let's fetch the blade together"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Garrick's grin widens with approval.

Garrick's grin widens with approval. "Smart. And I appreciate a man who doesn't send others into danger he won't face himself." He turns and calls out across the square, "Wren! The cleric and I are stepping outside the ward to fetch my sword. We'll be quick about it."

Elder Wren looks alarmed but nods grimly. "Take torches. And for the gods' sake, be fast."

Dagmar overhears and stands from where she's been checking her bowstring. "I'm coming too. If that thing's out there, you'll want eyes watching the treeline." She doesn't wait for agreement, simply slings her bow over her shoulder and grabs a torch.

The three of you approach the shimmering edge of the ward. You can feel it as you get close - a gentle pressure, like walking against a mild breeze. Mother Nelle and several villagers watch nervously as you prepare to step through.

Garrick lights two torches, handing you one. "My forge is just there -" he points to a sturdy stone building perhaps sixty yards away, outside the village center. "Two minutes there, two minutes back. In and out."

The night beyond the ward is dark. The moon is only a sliver, and the forest looms like a black wall in the distance. Somewhere out there, something howls - distant, but wrong, just as Wren described. It raises the hairs on the back of your neck.

Dagmar nocks an arrow, though she doesn't draw yet. "Ready when you are."

Roll a Wisdom (Perception) check as you step through the ward - just a d20 + your Wisdom modifier (+2).

What do you roll?

You said: 12

12

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $12 + 2 = 14$ - A solid, aware roll.

$12 + 2 = 14$ - A solid, aware roll.

You step through the ward, and the difference is immediate and unsettling. Inside felt safe - warm, protected. Out here, the night presses in close. The torch casts dancing shadows that seem to move with malicious intent.

You scan the darkness carefully. The forge is clearly visible - its chimney still trailing a thin line of smoke from the day's work. The area between you and it is open ground, just packed earth and a few storage sheds. No movement that you can see.

But your senses pick up details:

- The normal night sounds - crickets, a distant owl - are absent. The forest is too quiet.
- There's a faint smell on the wind... something animal and musky, but you can't pinpoint it
- The hairs on your neck stay raised

Dagmar notices it too. "Too quiet," she mutters, scanning the treeline with practiced eyes. "Something's out there. Maybe watching. Maybe not close, but..." She keeps her arrow nocked.

Garrick moves with purpose, not running but not dawdling either. "Come on. Let's not give whatever it is time to get brave."

The three of you cross the open ground quickly. Garrick's forge is well-built - stone walls, a heavy wooden door with iron banding. He produces a key and unlocks it, pushing the door open. Inside, the residual heat from the day's forge-work makes the air warm and close. The smell of coal, metal, and oil is thick.

Above the cold forge, mounted on the wall, hangs the sword.

Even in the dim torchlight, you can see it's a beautiful weapon. The blade is perhaps two and a half feet long, slightly curved, with a silvered edge that gleams. The crossguard is simple but elegant, and the grip is wrapped in worn leather that speaks of use by previous generations.

Garrick reaches up reverently and lifts it down. He draws it partially from its scabbard - the blade catches the torchlight and seems almost to glow. "Garrick the Elder's masterwork," he says quietly. Then he slides it home and belts the scabbard to his hip.

"Right then. Let's get back inside that ward before—"

HOWL.

Much closer this time. Maybe a quarter mile away, from the forest's edge. It's a sound that shouldn't come from any natural throat - too deep, too resonant, and with an edge of rage and hunger that makes your stomach clench.

Dagmar spins toward the sound, bow raised. "Move. Now."

What do you do?

- Run for the ward?
- Hold position and look for the source?
- Something else?

You said: There's no time.

There's no time. I usher Dagmar and Garrick ahead of me towards the ward and we sprint back, me taking rear-guard

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: "GO!"

"GO!" you shout, pushing them toward the door.

Dagmar doesn't need to be told twice - she's already moving, torch in one hand, bow in the other, her hunter's instincts screaming danger. Garrick is right behind her, one hand on his new sword's hilt, the other holding his torch high.

You follow, but turn backward as you run, keeping your eyes on the darkness beyond. Your torch cuts a swath of light into the night, but the shadows seem to writhe at its edges.

Roll an Athletics check to run - d20 + Strength modifier (probably +1 or +2 for a cleric). This is to see how quickly you can sprint while moving backward and watching for threats.

And roll another Perception check (d20 + 2) to see if you spot anything in the darkness.

Give me both rolls!

Ahead, you can see the ward's shimmer. Mother Nelle and Elder Wren are at its edge, watching with horror. Villagers are pulling children back, creating space for you to re-enter.

The howl comes again - closer still, perhaps only a hundred yards. And this time, it's answered by another howl from a different direction.

Two of them.

You said: 12 and a 12

12 and a 12

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Athletics: $12 + 1 = 13$ (assuming +1 STR)

Athletics: $12 + 1 = 13$ (assuming +1 STR) Perception: $12 + 2 = 14$

You're moving fast - not Olympic-sprinter fast while running backward, but quick and controlled. Your footwork is solid, born of training in armor and combat. Thirty yards from the ward. Twenty-five.

Your perception catches it: movement.

To the left, near a storage shed - a shadow detaches from the darkness. Low to the ground. Fast. It's circling, trying to cut you off from the ward. You catch a glimpse - something large, hunched, moving on all fours but wrong. The torchlight reflects off eyes that glow an unnatural amber.

To the right - another shape, this one more man-like in posture but still wrong, still hunched. It's pacing parallel to your group, keeping to the edge of your torchlight.

Dagmar sees them too. She skids to a halt just inside the ward's edge and spins, drawing her bow fully. "RIV! TEN SECONDS!"

Garrick crashes through the ward's shimmer, stumbling but catching himself. He whirls around, drawing the silvered blade - it rings as it clears the scabbard.

You're fifteen yards out. Ten.

The creature on the left lunges - a blur of fur and muscle, impossibly fast. It's going to reach you before you reach the ward.

COMBAT TIME!

Roll Initiative - d20 + Dexterity modifier (probably +1 or +2).

Tell me what you roll!

You said: 16

16

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 16 + 1 = 17 - Excellent initiative!

16 + 1 = 17 - Excellent initiative!

INITIATIVE ORDER:

1. Riv (17) - YOU
 2. Werewolf #1 (16) - The one lunging at you
 3. Dagmar (14)
 4. Werewolf #2 (11)
 5. Garrick (8)
-

ROUND 1 - YOUR TURN

The creature is mid-leap, a mass of fur, claws, and rage hurtling toward you. You're about 10 feet from the ward's edge - close, but not inside yet.

In the torchlight you see it clearly for the first time: a grotesque hybrid of man and wolf. Its body is covered in matted gray fur, its limbs are too long and end in wicked claws, and its face is a nightmare - a wolf's muzzle with far too much human intelligence in those amber eyes. Saliva drips from fangs the length of your fingers.

You have several options:

MOVE: You could try to dash for the ward (10 feet, you'd make it)

CAST A SPELL:

- Sacred Flame (ranged spell attack, radiant damage - werewolves have no resistance to this)
- Guiding Bolt (spell attack, radiant damage, costs a 1st level spell slot)
- Shield of Faith (give yourself +2 AC as a bonus action)

ATTACK: You likely have a mace or warhammer as your weapon

DODGE: Make yourself harder to hit

What do you do? Remember, you can move AND take an action, or you can use your full action to Dash (double movement).

What's your play?

You said: I'd like to cast Sacred Flame at the nearest one

I'd like to cast Sacred Flame at the nearest one

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Excellent choice!

Excellent choice! Sacred Flame is perfect - radiant damage that werewolves can't resist, and it forces the creature to dodge rather than you needing to hit it.

SACRED FLAME

You raise your holy symbol of Lathander high, and golden light blazes from it like a miniature sun. A column of divine fire erupts around the lunging werewolf, engulfing it in searing radiant energy.

The werewolf must make a Dexterity saving throw against your spell save DC.

Your spell save DC = 8 + proficiency bonus (+2) + Wisdom modifier (+2) = DC 12

I'll roll for the werewolf...

rolls The werewolf gets a 9 - FAIL!

The creature howls in agony as the sacred flames burn into its corrupt flesh. The smell of singed fur fills the air.

Roll damage: 1d8 radiant damage.

What do you roll?

The werewolf's leap is interrupted - it crashes to the ground about 5 feet from you, smoking and snarling, its fur blackened in patches. It's hurt, but very much still a threat.

Roll your d8!

You said: 3

3

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 3 radiant damage!

3 radiant damage!

The sacred flames sear the creature, burning away patches of fur and leaving angry red burns on its flesh. It's not a devastating blow, but the werewolf clearly feels it - radiant damage bypasses its natural resistances entirely.

The creature hits the ground hard, stumbling from the divine fire. It snarls, shaking its massive head, amber eyes fixed on you with pure hatred.

WEREWOLF #1'S TURN

The creature recovers quickly - too quickly. Despite the burns, it launches itself at you again with terrifying speed, claws extended.

It attacks with its claws!

rolls Attack roll: 14

What's your Armor Class? (As a cleric with the Nobility domain, you likely have chain mail or scale mail - probably AC 16 or so, unless you have a shield which would make it 18)

Let me know your AC!

While we wait for that, Dagmar is drawing her bow at the ward's edge, and the second werewolf is circling closer from the right side. Garrick has his silvered sword ready but he's inside the ward - he can't reach you without stepping back out.

You said: Let's say I have chain mail, no shield.

Let's say I have chain mail, no shield. Can Garrick throw me his sword?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good thinking!

Good thinking! Yes, Garrick absolutely could throw you his sword, but that would be on his turn, which comes after both werewolves in the initiative order.

Right now we're still resolving Werewolf #1's attack on you.

With AC 16 (chain mail), the werewolf's attack roll of 14 misses!

The creature's claws rake through the air inches from your face as you twist away. You feel the wind of the strike, smell the beast's rancid breath, but the blow doesn't connect. Your armor and reflexes save you.

The werewolf lands in a crouch between you and the ward, blocking your direct path to safety. It's only 5 feet from you now, snarling and circling.

DAGMAR'S TURN

"Get DOWN!" Dagmar shouts.

Do you drop prone/duck, or stay standing? This is a quick reaction - just tell me what you do!

If you duck, she'll have a clear shot. If you stay standing, you might be in her line of fire but you'll be ready to move on your next turn.

What do you do?

You said: She says down, I drop to my knees

She says down, I drop to my knees

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Smart move - you trust the expert!

Smart move - you trust the expert!

You drop to your knees instantly, and an arrow screams over your head so close you feel the fletching brush your hair.

THWACK!

Dagmar's arrow buries itself in the werewolf's shoulder. The creature roars - not the killing blow she was hoping for, but solid contact. Dark blood, almost black in the torchlight, streams from the wound.

"Not silver!" she curses, already nocking another arrow. "It'll heal that in moments!"

She's right - you can already see the wound beginning to close, the flesh knitting together with unnatural speed. Regular arrows can hurt it, but won't stop it.

WEREWOLF #2'S TURN

The second werewolf, seeing its pack-mate engaged, charges from the right. But it's not coming for you - it's going for Dagmar, who's standing right at the ward's edge.

It SLAMS into the magical barrier.

CRACK!

There's a flash of golden-green light as your ward and Mother Nelle's blessing holds. The creature is thrown back, howling in pain and fury, smoking slightly where it touched the divine protection. It scrambles back, snarling at the shimmering barrier, pacing like a caged animal.

The ward is holding - but you're on the wrong side of it.

GARRICK'S TURN

"RIV!" Garrick shouts. He makes a split-second decision.

He steps THROUGH the ward, silvered blade gleaming, and charges at the werewolf standing over you. "Get inside, cleric! I've got this bastard!"

Garrick attacks with the silvered shortsword!

rolls Natural 20!

CRITICAL HIT!

The silvered blade flashes in the torchlight and bites deep into the werewolf's side. The creature screams - a sound of genuine agony. Silver burns it from the inside, preventing regeneration. Black blood sprays across the ground.

rolls damage The werewolf takes 12 slashing damage - and because it's silver, the wound stays open, smoking and festering.

The werewolf staggers, badly hurt now. It turns its hate-filled eyes on Garrick.

ROUND 2 - YOUR TURN

You're on your knees, 5 feet from the ward. Garrick is now between you and the injured werewolf, silvered blade dripping black blood. The second werewolf is pacing outside the barrier, looking for a way in.

What do you do?

You said: Can I cast Shield of Faith on Garrick?

Can I cast Shield of Faith on Garrick?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Absolutely!

Absolutely! Shield of Faith is a bonus action, so you can cast it on Garrick AND still do something else (move, attack, cast a cantrip, etc.)!

YOU CAST SHIELD OF FAITH ON GARRICK

Still on your knees, you thrust your holy symbol toward the blacksmith and shout a prayer to Lathander. A shimmering field of divine protection envelops Garrick - faint golden light that pulses around him like a second skin.

Garrick's AC increases by +2 for the next 10 minutes (concentration)!

Garrick feels the blessing settle over him and grins fiercely. "I feel it, cleric! Lathander's with us!"

You still have your ACTION and MOVEMENT.

Options:

- MOVE: Get up and dash for the ward (it's only 5 feet away)
- SACRED FLAME: Hit the wounded werewolf again while Garrick has it distracted
- GUIDING BOLT: Bigger damage with a 1st level spell slot
- Move + Cantrip: Get to safety AND cast Sacred Flame

What do you do?

You said: Let's strike while it's wounded with the guiding bolt.

Let's strike while it's wounded with the guiding bolt. Maybe the attack will cause the other werewolf to flee

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Excellent tactical thinking!

Excellent tactical thinking! Finish the wounded one and maybe break the pack's morale.

GUIDING BOLT

You rise to your feet, holy symbol blazing with the light of dawn itself. Golden radiant energy coalesces in your hand, forming a bolt of pure divine power. You hurl it at the wounded werewolf with a shout to Lathander!

Make a ranged spell attack: Roll d20 + your Wisdom modifier (+2) + proficiency bonus (+2) = d20 + 4

The werewolf is distracted by Garrick and badly wounded - you have a good shot!

Roll your d20!

Garrick sees the light building and instinctively shifts his stance, giving you a clear line of fire. The wounded werewolf, still reeling from the silvered blade in its side, doesn't see you preparing the spell.

What do you roll?

You said: 15

15

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $15 + 4 = 19$!

$15 + 4 = 19$! That's a HIT!

The bolt of radiant energy slams into the werewolf's chest like a spear of sunlight. The creature's howl cuts off mid-scream as divine fire erupts through its body. The radiant damage combines with the still-smoking silver wound, and the werewolf's regeneration can't keep up.

Roll damage: 4d6 radiant damage!

This is going to hurt. Roll those dice!

The wounded werewolf staggers backward, smoke rising from the impact point. Its fur is singed, its flesh burning from the inside out. It's barely standing.

And remember - Guiding Bolt has a secondary effect: the next attack roll made against this creature before the end of your next turn has advantage, because it's now glowing with divine light!

Roll your 4d6!

You said: 4, 6, 5, 3

4, 6, 5, 3

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 18 radiant damage!

18 radiant damage!

The bolt of divine light detonates inside the werewolf's chest. The creature throws its head back in a final, agonized howl as golden fire consumes it from within. The radiant energy combines catastrophically with Garrick's silver wound - flesh blackens, fur ignites, and the creature's regeneration fails completely.

The werewolf collapses, twitching once, twice... then lies still. Smoke rises from its corpse, and even as you watch, the body begins to shift - the monstrous features melting away, fur receding, until what lies on the ground is the naked body of a middle-aged man, burned and broken.

Garrick stares, breathing hard. "Gods above..."

WEREWOLF #2'S REACTION

The second werewolf sees its pack-mate fall. It stops pacing, amber eyes fixed on the corpse. For a moment, intelligence wars with bestial rage in those eyes.

Then it runs.

Not toward you - away. It turns and bolts for the forest with supernatural speed, disappearing into the darkness in seconds. You hear crashing through underbrush, growing more distant, and then... silence.

COMBAT ENDS

Dagmar keeps her bow raised for another thirty seconds, scanning the darkness. Finally, she lowers it. "It's gone. Running scared."

Garrick sheathes his silvered blade with shaking hands and looks at you with newfound respect. "That was... Lathander's own fury, that was."

From inside the ward, Mother Nelle and Elder Wren are staring in shock. Villagers murmur in awe and relief.

You're standing outside the ward, alive, next to the corpse of a werewolf. Your Shield of Faith still glimmers around Garrick.

What do you do?

You said: "Does anyone know this man?"

"Does anyone know this man?" Riv says, gesturing to the body of the werewolf

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A heavy silence falls over the gathered villagers.

A heavy silence falls over the gathered villagers. People press closer to the ward's edge, craning to see. Torchlight flickers across the dead man's face.

Then a strangled gasp.

"Gods... that's... that's Marcus."

The voice comes from Tomás - the nervous farmer you saw earlier in the tavern. He's gone pale as death. "Marcus Greywood. He... he worked my farm. Helped with the sheep during shearing season."

Elder Wren's face is grim. "Marcus disappeared three weeks ago. We thought he'd moved on to find work in Millford. He was... he was a good man. Quiet. Hard worker."

A woman in the crowd begins to weep softly.

Garrick kneels beside the body, examining it more closely. "Three weeks ago... right when this all started." He looks up at you. "He was the first victim, not the first attacker."

Dagmar lowers her bow completely, her expression troubled. "Which means the one that got away..." She looks toward the dark forest. "That's the one that made him. The original werewolf. And it's still out there."

Mother Nelle speaks from inside the ward, her voice heavy with sorrow. "Poor Marcus. He didn't choose this curse."

Elder Wren meets your eyes. "You said you wanted to heal the lycanthrope, cleric. You tried. But Marcus... there was nothing left of him to save by the time you arrived."

Tomás chokes back a sob. "He killed my sheep. My livelihood. But he... he taught my son Willem how to whittle. He was good."

The weight of this settles on everyone. This wasn't just a monster - it was their neighbor, transformed and lost.

What do you say or do?

You said: Riv addresses the crowd: "Marcus and the lycanthrope.

Riv addresses the crowd: "Marcus and the lycanthrope... they weren't one and the same. We killed the werewolf, but the werewolf killed Marcus. And as a good man of this village, Marcus deserves a proper funeral. Is there a mausoleum we can keep his body in until this mess is over? Surely Mother Nelle can preside over his earthly remains once we're ready to bury him."

Turning to Dagmar and Garrick, Riv says, "You both fought well tonight. Get some sleep, recover yourselves. Food and drink are on me tonight. Tomorrow, at dawn, we hunt the original werewolf to ensure that this disease doesn't take anyone else from us."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Your words cut through the shock and grief like a bell, giving the villagers something to hold onto - purpose, dignity, and hope.

Your words cut through the shock and grief like a bell, giving the villagers something to hold onto - purpose, dignity, and hope.

Mother Nelle nods solemnly. "Yes. Marcus deserves proper rites. We have a small stone building behind Chauntea's shrine - cool and blessed ground. We'll keep him there until..." She pauses, then continues firmly, "Until you've finished what you've started. Then we'll lay him to rest with honor."

Tomás wipes his eyes roughly. "Thank you, cleric. Marcus would have... he would have wanted to be remembered as himself, not as that thing."

Elder Wren signals to several men. "Help Mother Nelle. Wrap the body respectfully and take it to the shrine building." He turns to you. "You've already saved lives tonight, Riv Freeborn. That creature would have torn through us without your ward."

Garrick clasps your shoulder, his grip still strong despite the combat. "Food and drink sound like heaven. And cleric?" His voice drops. "You saved my life out there with that blessing. I felt Lathander's shield around me - without it, that beast's claws might have found my throat." He hefts the silvered blade. "Tomorrow at dawn, we end this. Together."

Dagmar nods, slinging her bow. "I'll have my silvered arrows ready. And now we know - the real threat is still out there, and it's smart enough to run. That makes it more dangerous." She meets your eyes. "But if it thinks running will save it from what's coming at dawn, it's about to learn otherwise."

The three of you step back through the ward. The shimmer welcomes you like warm water, and the immediate sense of safety is palpable. Villagers part respectfully, some reaching out to touch your arm or murmur thanks.

Gerda is waiting at the tavern door. When she sees you all alive, she lets out a breath. "Right then. Stew's still hot, ale's cold, and you three drink free tonight. Lathander's work deserves Lathander's reward."

It's going to be a long night, but you're safe for now. The ward holds. And tomorrow, you hunt.

What do you do for the rest of the evening?

- Rest immediately to recover spells?
- Talk strategy with Dagmar and Garrick?
- Speak with someone else?

- Something else?

You said: What time is it?

What time is it? How much time is left before morning?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good question - let's figure out the timeline.

Good question - let's figure out the timeline.

Current situation:

- You arrived at the tavern around dusk (let's say 6 PM)
- The ritual took about an hour (7 PM when complete)
- The confrontation with the werewolves and everything after took maybe 30-45 minutes
- Current time: approximately 7:45-8:00 PM

Dawn breaks around 6:30-7:00 AM in early winter

So you have roughly 10-11 hours until dawn.

Important mechanical note: As a cleric, you need a long rest (8 hours of sleep) to regain your spell slots. You've used:

- 1st level spell slot (Guiding Bolt)
- Sacred Flame (cantrip - unlimited)
- Shield of Faith (1st level, still active on Garrick for 9 more minutes via concentration)
- Ceremony ritual (not a spell slot, but significant effort)

If you want to face the werewolf at dawn with full resources, you should probably:

- Eat and strategize for an hour or so (9 PM)
- Sleep from 10 PM to 6 AM (8 hours)
- Wake, pray for spells, and prepare (6-7 AM)
- Hunt at first light (7 AM)

Does this timeline work for you? What would you like to do with your evening before resting?

You said: Yes, let's adhere to that timeline.

Yes, let's adhere to that timeline. Let's head inside the tavern and have some light dinner (we already ate, but something light to fortify us). Riv sits at a table with Dagmar, Finn, and Garrick.

"Well, I think it's safe to say our strategy for tomorrow has changed. Instead of marching in to confront this evil in conversation, we must instead venture towards the werewolf lair with the goal of removing its taint from these lands. Dagmar, Finn... if you are unable to face the werewolf's lair again, we will absolutely understand. You have already helped so much. To ask more would be unjust."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The four of you settle at a corner table in The Sleeping Giant.

The four of you settle at a corner table in The Sleeping Giant. Gerda brings over bread, cheese, cold roasted chicken, and four mugs of dark ale - simple fare, but hearty. The common room is crowded with displaced families, but they give your group respectful space.

Dagmar takes a long drink of ale before responding. Her jaw is set, but you can see the conflict in her eyes.

"I won't lie to you, cleric." She sets down her mug carefully. "That place... the wrongness of it got into my bones. I've tracked wounded bears into their dens, faced down bandits in ambush, hunted through storms that would freeze a man solid. But that cave..." She pauses, choosing her words. "It wasn't natural fear. It was like the forest itself was screaming at us to leave."

Finn shifts uncomfortably beside her, his youthful face troubled. "I wanted to press on. I thought Dagmar was being overcautious. But she was right - something about that place was..." He struggles for the word. "Wrong. Like standing too close to a cliff edge, except the cliff was in every direction."

Dagmar meets your eyes directly. "But Marcus is dead. A good man, cursed and killed. And that thing that made him - that created this nightmare - it's still out there." She tears off a piece of bread with more force than necessary. "I've been a coward for two days, sitting here while people lost their livelihood. While Marcus lost himself."

She leans forward. "So yes. I'll guide you. I'll face that cave again. And this time, I won't turn back." Her hand moves to touch the quiver at her side. "Seven silvered arrows. If they're not enough..." She shrugs grimly. "Then at least I'll die doing what needs doing."

Finn swallows hard, then nods. "I'm with Dagmar. If she's going, I'm going."

Garrick, who's been quietly eating and listening, finally speaks. "Well, that makes four of us then." He pats the silvered sword at his hip. "Great-grandfather's blade has tasted werewolf blood. It's thirsty for more."

Dagmar pulls out a worn piece of parchment and a bit of charcoal from her pack. "Right then. Let me sketch what we found."

She begins drawing - a rough map showing:

- The village
- The forest edge (about half a mile out)
- A game trail heading northwest
- Various markers for streams and landmarks
- Finally, about 2 miles into Darkwood, a cave entrance marked with an X

"The cave is here," she taps the X. "Natural limestone formation, entrance maybe eight feet high and six feet wide. Inside..." She hesitates. "We only got about twenty feet in before the dread hit us. But I could see it opened into a larger chamber. There were... bones. And the smell." She grimaces. "Death and rot and something else. Something unnatural."

She looks at each of you. "The approach is through dense forest. Lots of cover, but that works both ways - we won't see an ambush coming easily. The werewolf knows that territory. We don't."

Garrick studies the map. "Two miles of hostile ground, then a cave fight with a cornered, intelligent predator." He doesn't sound afraid, just... pragmatic. "What's the plan, cleric? Do we try to draw it out, or go in after it?"

All three look to you. Despite Dagmar's experience and Garrick's steady presence, they're deferring to your leadership. You're the one who made the ward, killed Marcus-turned-werewolf, and carries a god's blessing.

What's your strategy for tomorrow?

You said: "The beast doesn't have the advantage during the day."

"The beast doesn't have the advantage during the day. With sunlight guiding our path, we can at least eliminate shadows from its strategy. I say we keep it outside the cave, if we can. Draw it out and try to trap it. I would still like to try to talk to it, if we can. If we can't... we'll all do what we must. Dagmar, Finn - do you have any traps we can bring with us? Anything we can place near the entrance to slow it?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Dagmar considers this, drumming her fingers on the table.

Dagmar considers this, drumming her fingers on the table. "Traps... aye, I have some options. Nothing that'll hold a werewolf for long, but enough to give us an edge."

She ticks off on her fingers:

"Bear traps - I have two at my workshop. Iron jaws, strong enough to break a bear's leg. Won't kill a werewolf, but it'll hurt like hell and slow it down, maybe even pin it for a few seconds while it tears free. We'd need to set them along likely escape routes from the cave."

"Snare wire - Good for tripping, not holding. Might buy us a second or two if it charges. Better than nothing."

"Caltrops - I don't have proper military caltrops, but I can get iron nails from Garrick's forge and scatter them. Werewolf paws will heal fast, but pain is pain."

Finn adds, "I could prepare some oil and rags. If we need to create a fire barrier or smoke it out..." He glances at Dagmar. "Though fire in a dry forest is risky."

Garrick nods slowly. "I can provide nails, and I have some chain at the forge - not enough to bind the creature, but we could string it across the cave mouth if we had time to prepare. Force it to break through, slow its charge."

Dagmar leans back, thinking tactically. "Here's what worries me: if we want to draw it out and talk, we need to approach the cave openly. No ambush positions. But if it comes out in a rage..." She looks at you seriously. "Cleric, werewolves are fast. If you're standing at that cave mouth trying to parley and it decides to charge instead of talk, you'll have maybe two seconds before it's on you. Maybe less."

She sketches a quick diagram on the parchment:

"What I'd suggest: We set the bear traps here and here -" she marks spots about fifteen feet from the cave entrance, flanking it, "- hidden under leaves. You approach from the center with Garrick - he's got the silvered blade for close defense. Finn and I position ourselves here and here -" she marks two elevated positions about forty yards back, "- with clear shots. If it charges, it has to come through the trap zone first."

Finn nods. "And if you can talk to it, we hold fire unless you signal or it attacks."

Garrick looks at you. "That puts you and me as the bait. I'm good with that - someone needs to be close enough to talk, and someone needs to have silver ready if talking fails." He grins without humor. "Just promise me one thing: if it goes wrong, hit it with more of that golden fire before it tears my throat out."

Dagmar studies you carefully. "You really think this thing can be reasoned with? After what it did to Marcus? After it ran tonight instead of fighting?"

What do you think, Riv? Does the werewolf's behavior tonight - the coordinated attack, the intelligent retreat - suggest it might be reasoned with? Or was it just tactical cunning?

And do you agree with Dagmar's proposed setup?

You said: "It's hard to say."

"It's hard to say. What I can say is this: that thing wasn't always a werebeast - something turned it. And until 3 weeks ago, no werewolf set foot in Thornhaven. There's something more at play here. If we kill it, we've removed it from the board, but we still don't know who the other player is, if there is

one. This strategy feels sound to me. Try to get some good sleep, tonight, everyone. Prepare as though your lives depend on the outcome of this trap. I expect us up and ready by first light."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Your words land heavily.

Your words land heavily. The tactical discussion shifts into something more - the recognition that this might be part of a larger pattern, a deeper threat.

Dagmar's eyes narrow thoughtfully. "You're right. Werewolves don't just appear. Someone - or something - created this one. And if it came here deliberately, three weeks ago..." She trails off, the implications clear.

Finn looks unsettled. "You think someone sent it? To Thornhaven specifically?"

"Or it's fleeing from something worse," Garrick suggests grimly. "Either way, the cleric's right - we need answers, not just a corpse."

Dagmar nods slowly, accepting this. "Then we do it your way. Try to talk first. But cleric -" her voice is firm, "- the moment I see it gathering to charge, I loose an arrow. I won't watch you die for information we might never get."

"Fair enough," Garrick agrees, standing and draining the last of his ale. "I'll gather chain and nails from my forge in the morning. Two bear traps, caltrops, and defensive positions." He clasps your shoulder. "Dawn comes early. Lathander guide your dreams, Riv."

Finn stands as well, looking younger and more nervous now that the planning is done. "I'll check our equipment before bed. Make sure the bowstrings are fresh."

Dagmar rises last, rolling up her crude map. "Six-thirty AM. We meet here, gear up, and move out by seven." She looks at each of you in turn. "Whatever's waiting in that cave, we face it together."

The group disperses. Around you, the tavern is settling for the night - families bedding down, children finally asleep, the murmur of worried conversations fading.

Gerda appears with a key. "Your room, cleric. Second door on the right, as promised. Bed's clean, fire's laid if you want it." She pauses. "My grandmother always said: the Morninglord's servants should sleep well, because dawn comes whether you're ready or not."

You climb the narrow stairs, exhausted from the ritual, the fight, and the weight of tomorrow's task. Your room is simple - a bed, a washbasin, a small window looking out over the village square where your ward still shimmers faintly in the darkness.

You have a few moments before sleep. Do you:

- Pray to Lathander for guidance?

- Review your spells for tomorrow?
- Look out the window at the ward?
- Simply collapse into bed?

What does Riv do?

You said: I wash up, prepare for sleep, and take another look outside at my ward.

I wash up, prepare for sleep, and take another look outside at my ward. I search the darkness for any sign of danger

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: You pour water from the pitcher into the washbasin - it's cold, but clean.

You pour water from the pitcher into the washbasin - it's cold, but clean. You scrub away the sweat, soot, and grime of the evening's combat. The water turns gray as you wash your face and hands, and you can see dark smudges where werewolf blood splattered during the fight.

The simple ritual of cleanliness feels grounding after the chaos. You remove your chain mail carefully, setting it aside within arm's reach - a warrior's habit. Your muscles ache from the weight of it, from the running, from channeling divine power through the ceremony.

Dressed in your simple underclothes, you move to the window.

Roll a Perception check - d20 + 2

Let me know what you get.

The window offers a clear view of the village square below. Your ward is still there - harder to see now that full darkness has fallen, but you can sense it more than see it. A faint shimmer in the torchlight, like heat haze. The four holy symbols of Chauntea remain at the cardinal points, glowing ever so faintly.

Inside the perimeter, you can see the shapes of sleeping families, livestock settled and quiet. Six guards pace the inner edge with torches, looking outward into the darkness. Their presence is more symbolic than practical - if something breaches your ward, mortal guards won't stop it.

Beyond the ward, the night is oppressive. The forest is a black wall against the star-filled sky. No moon to speak of - just a thin crescent offering almost no light.

What do you roll for Perception?

You said: I roll a 15

I roll a 15

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $15 + 2 = 17$ - Sharp eyes, even in exhaustion.

$15 + 2 = 17$ - Sharp eyes, even in exhaustion.

You scan the darkness carefully, your gaze methodical and practiced. At first, there's nothing but shadow and the occasional flicker of torchlight from the guards below.

Then you see it.

At the forest edge, perhaps two hundred yards out - movement. Not the random sway of branches or the scurrying of normal wildlife. Something large, deliberate, pacing along the treeline.

You watch for a full minute. The shape moves from one side of your view to the other - low to the ground sometimes, then upright and man-like. It's keeping to the shadows, but you catch glimpses: the hulking shoulders, the unnatural gait.

The surviving werewolf. It's watching the village.

Not attacking. Not howling. Just... watching. Studying your ward, perhaps. Or waiting. The intelligence in that behavior sends a chill down your spine - this isn't a mindless beast. It's thinking, planning.

After several minutes, it melts back into the forest and disappears completely. You strain your eyes but see nothing more. Either it's gone, or it's simply moved to where you can't observe it.

The guards below haven't noticed - they're looking outward, but not far enough, and their torchlight ruins their night vision. They have no idea they're being watched.

Your ward holds. The shimmer remains constant, strong. Whatever the creature was doing, it wasn't testing the barrier - just observing from a distance.

The tactical implications are clear: it's intelligent, patient, and learning about its enemies.

You stand at the window for a few more minutes, but see nothing else. The night remains quiet except for the normal sounds of the village settling to sleep.

Finally, exhaustion pulls at you. Your body needs rest. Your mind needs rest. And tomorrow, you'll need every ounce of strength Lathander can provide.

You move to the bed - simple but clean, with wool blankets that smell faintly of lavender. As you lie down, your hand instinctively reaches for your holy symbol, still around your neck.

Do you offer a prayer before sleep, or simply let exhaustion take you?

You said: I always pray before bed.

I always pray before bed. I pray for strength, for curiosity, for practicality in my decisions. I pray for those who trusted me that I failed and I pray for another day with warm food and a comfortable bed

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: You close your eyes, fingers wrapped around the sunburst symbol of Lathander resting on your chest.

You close your eyes, fingers wrapped around the sunburst symbol of Lathander resting on your chest. The metal is still warm from being against your skin all day, from channeling divine power through it.

Your prayer comes quietly, spoken only in your mind and heart:

Morninglord, Lord of Dawn and Renewal...

Grant me strength for tomorrow - not just the strength of arm, but strength of spirit. Let me face what comes with courage, not recklessness.

Grant me curiosity - to ask the right questions, to see beyond the obvious threat. Help me understand what drives this creature, what brought it here. Let me seek truth, not just victory.

Grant me practicality in my decisions. I seek greatness, yes - but let me not sacrifice wisdom for glory. Let me choose the path that serves these people, not just my own ambition.

I think of those I've failed - those I couldn't reach in time, couldn't heal, couldn't save. Marcus Greywood was already lost before I arrived. But there will be others. Let me learn from every failure, carry every loss as a lesson, not a burden.

And... thank you. For warm food. For a comfortable bed. For the simple mercies that make this calling bearable. I am your servant, but I am also human. Let me remember both.

When dawn breaks tomorrow, let me rise worthy of your light.

Until then... watch over Thornhaven. Watch over those who trusted me with their lives.

The prayer settles over you like a blanket. The anxiety of tomorrow doesn't disappear, but it... softens. Becomes manageable.

Your breathing slows. The warmth of the bed seeps into your tired muscles. Outside, your ward shimmers in the darkness, holding strong.

Your last conscious thought is of dawn - of light breaking over the forest, of facing whatever waits in that cave.

Then sleep takes you.

You rest. Your spells will be restored. Dawn is coming.

[End of Session 1]

Zach, this was fantastic! You played Riv beautifully - thoughtful, tactical, ambitious but not reckless, and with real character depth. The prayer at the end especially showed who he is: someone who wants greatness but knows he's still learning, still human.

How are you feeling? Want to continue to the dawn hunt, or would you like to stop here and pick it up another time? Either way, I hope this helped you learn D&D mechanics while giving you something engaging to think about while you're resting up!

You said: This was wonderful!

This was wonderful! I'm going to create a project folder here for these sessions so we can continue with new sessions whenever I have some time to engage. I'll admit, I had no idea where the story was going. It felt like it was being shaped by my actions, though I could feel the core theme running through it. I thought maybe the werewolves would end up being Tomas and Garrick's niece; that would have been an emotional twist. I also thought that maybe these werewolves would be forward scouts and that they would be forming an army to assault the village with. That would actually be a really fun scenario to play - fortifying the village, training the guard, enjoying days of simple living all while preparing to hold the village in an all-out assault... Maybe that could be something for the future. I also thought that maybe villagers would turn into werewolves during the fight! I had no idea, and that uncertainty shaped my playstyle.

Thank you for building this for me. I want more, but let me create the project folder and start a new chat for Session 2

Show more

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: I'm so glad you enjoyed it!

I'm so glad you enjoyed it! Your instincts about the uncertainty shaping your playstyle are exactly what makes D&D special - I was genuinely responding to your choices and rolling with where you took things. The fact that you considered all those possibilities (villagers turning, Tomás/the niece

being werewolves, an army forming) shows you were thinking like a real player, weighing threats and considering twists.

And honestly? Some of those ideas are fantastic and could absolutely come into play. The surviving werewolf is still out there, and you're right - you don't know who the "other player" is yet. That siege defense scenario you mentioned? That could be incredible - building defenses, training militia, the calm before the storm... I'm taking notes!

What I loved most was how you played Riv with real depth - he's not a saint, he's ambitious and wants comfort and recognition, but he also genuinely cares and tries to do right by people. That prayer at the end was perfect characterization.

For the project folder: When you create it and start Session 2, just give me a quick recap or reference this chat so I have context on where we left off. We'll pick up at dawn with the hunt for the original werewolf.

Rest up, feel better, and I'm excited to continue Riv's story whenever you're ready! 🌅

You said: Can you create a quick recap for me to instruct the project on what we're building?

Can you create a quick recap for me to instruct the project on what we're building?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: D&D Campaign Project: Riv Freeborn's Adventures

D&D Campaign Project: Riv Freeborn's Adventures

Character:

- Name: Riv Freeborn, male human cleric of Lathander (Nobility Domain)
- Personality: Ambitious and power-hungry, seeks greatness and to be remembered as a hero. Values material comforts (warm beds, good meals, well-maintained gear). Genuinely helps people but pragmatically - sometimes for pay, sometimes for glory. Wants to make the right decisions but his lust for recognition can cloud judgment.
- Mechanical Details:
 - Nobility Domain grants martial weapon proficiency (can use shortswords, etc.)
 - Starting gold: 90 GP (rolled 9 on 5d4)
 - AC 16 (chain mail, no shield)
 - Spells used Session 1: Sacred Flame (cantrip), Guiding Bolt (1st level), Shield of Faith (1st level), Ceremony (ritual)

Campaign Setting: Village of Thornhaven

- Small agricultural village on the edge of Darkwood Forest
- Led by Elder Wren (elderly village leader, 20 years in position)
- Key NPCs:
 - Dagmar: Expert hunter/tracker (35, female, 15 years experience, best in region)
 - Finn: Dagmar's apprentice (25, male, 7 years training)
 - Garrick Ironheart: Village blacksmith (50s, owns family heirloom silvered shortsword)
 - Mother Nelle: Shrine keeper of Chauntea (70, maintains blessed water/holy symbols)
 - Gerda: Tavern keeper of The Sleeping Giant
 - Tomás: Farmer who lost livestock, father of Willem

Current Quest: The Werewolf Threat

- Timeline: Trouble started 3 weeks ago with livestock killings
- Marcus Greywood: Farm worker who disappeared 3 weeks ago, was turned into a werewolf, killed by Riv in Session 1
- The Original Werewolf: Still alive, intelligent, fled after Marcus was killed. Last seen observing the village from forest edge after dark.
- The Mystery: Something/someone created the original werewolf. Why did it come to Thornhaven 3 weeks ago? Is there a larger threat?

Session 1 Summary: Riv arrived in Thornhaven, learned about werewolf attacks, performed a protective ward ritual with Mother Nelle (successful Ceremony covering village center). Fought two werewolves outside the ward with Dagmar and Garrick - killed Marcus (the turned villager) with Guiding Bolt, but the original werewolf escaped. Discovered Marcus was a good man cursed 3 weeks ago. Planned dawn hunt with Dagmar, Finn, and Garrick to track the original werewolf to its cave lair 2 miles into Darkwood Forest. Strategy: Set bear traps, approach openly to attempt peaceful resolution/gather information, prepared for combat if negotiation fails.

Session 2 Setup: Dawn hunt begins. Party of 4 (Riv, Garrick with silvered shortsword, Dagmar and Finn with 7 silvered arrows total) heading to cave. Goal: Talk to the werewolf if possible to learn who/what created it, eliminate threat if necessary.

Tone & Style:

- Collaborative storytelling where player choices genuinely shape outcomes

- Uncertainty and multiple possible story threads
- Character-driven with real emotional stakes
- Balanced tactical combat and roleplay
- Teach D&D mechanics naturally through play

Chat 2: SECOND SESSION SETUP

Ok, so second session! First, please take a look at the other chat in this project to familiarize yourself with what we did in the first session. Then, let's get started!

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Looking for relevant chats in this project...

Looking for relevant chats in this project...

Perfect! I've caught up on the first session. What a great start to your D&D journey! You've:

- Created Riv Freeborn, a human cleric
- Investigated the werewolf threat in Thornhaven
- Performed a protective ritual with Mother Nelle
- Fought off two werewolves (killed Marcus, the cursed villager, but the original werewolf escaped)
- Gathered a hunting party and prepared for a dawn expedition into Darkwood Forest

You're about to head out with Dagmar (expert tracker), Finn (her apprentice), and Garrick (blacksmith with the silvered sword) to find the werewolf's cave lair. Your goal: try to talk to the intelligent werewolf to learn who or what created it, and eliminate the threat if negotiation fails.

Dawn at Thornhaven

The eastern sky is just beginning to lighten from black to deep blue. The air is cold and crisp, your breath misting in front of you. You stand at the village edge with your companions:

- Dagmar checks her bow and the silvered arrows, her movements practiced and efficient
- Finn adjusts his pack nervously, clearly less experienced but determined
- Garrick tests the weight of his family's silvered shortsword, jaw set with grim purpose

Dagmar looks at you. "Two miles northeast through the forest. The cave is in a rocky outcrop. We've got about an hour of hiking." She pauses. "Last chance to change the plan, Cleric. Are we still trying to talk first?"

How do you respond, and are you ready to head out?

You said: "We are, yes."

"We are, yes. We need to find out where this other werewolf came from, who they were, and who else we're up against. I have high hopes that we'll discover something worthwhile."

Can we run through a gear check before we go? Garrick is the town's blacksmith and I have 89.5 gold; maybe there's something in his stores that can help us

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great thinking!

Great thinking! A gear check is smart before heading into danger.

Gear Check

Garrick nods approvingly. "Good instinct, Cleric. Let me think about what I've got back at the forge that might help..."

Your Current Equipment:

- Chain mail armor (AC 16)
- Mace (your primary weapon)
- Holy symbol of your deity
- Healer's kit
- 50 feet of rope
- Waterskin
- Rations for several days

- Your spell components

Garrick's Available Inventory: (He runs a small village forge, so inventory is limited)

- Shields - A simple wooden shield would boost your AC by +2 (making it AC 18). Cost: 10 GP
- Silvered Weapons - He only has the one family heirloom silvered shortsword he's carrying. Making more takes weeks of work.
- Bear Traps - He mentions they set 3 traps near the cave entrance yesterday evening. "Those should still be there."
- Oil Flasks - 3 available. Can be thrown and ignited for fire damage. Cost: 1 SP (silver piece) each, so about 0.1 GP each
- Caltrops - Bag of metal spikes to scatter on ground and slow pursuit. 1 GP
- Torches - 6 available, free (he insists)
- Basic healing potions - He doesn't have any, but mentions "Mother Nelle might have some blessed water that could help in a pinch"

Quick Stop at Mother Nelle's Shrine? Dagmar adds: "The shrine is on the way out of town. We could stop by if you want to check for supplies. Would only delay us five minutes."

What would you like to purchase or acquire before heading out?

You said: As our frontline of defense, I suggest that Garrick take his shield with him.

As our frontline of defense, I suggest that Garrick take his shield with him. I'll happily pay for it - he will be better equipped with a sword and shield than he is otherwise. "Yes, let's stop at Mother Nelle's shrine", Riv says

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Preparing for the Hunt

Preparing for the Hunt

Garrick looks surprised, then nods with gratitude. "That's... generous of you, Cleric. Aye, sword and shield will serve me better than sword alone." He heads back to the forge and returns a moment later with a sturdy wooden shield, testing its weight. "Haven't used one of these in years, but the arm remembers."

You spend 10 GP. Remaining gold: 79.5 GP

The four of you make your way through the quiet village to Mother Nelle's shrine. The elderly shrine keeper is already awake despite the early hour, tending to candles at the altar of Chauntea.

Mother Nelle's Shrine

She turns as you enter, her weathered face breaking into a gentle smile. "Riv Freeborn. I felt you might come before you left." She moves to a small cabinet. "I don't have much, but what I have is yours."

Mother Nelle's Inventory:

- Blessed Water (3 vials) - Can be used to harm undead or fiends, or in healing rituals. She offers them free of charge. "Take them. Chauntea's blessing goes with you."
- Spare Holy Symbols (2) - Simple wooden symbols. Free.
- Healing Herbs - A pouch of medicinal herbs. With your healer's kit, these could give you advantage on a Medicine check to stabilize someone. 2 GP.

She places her hand on your shoulder. "That ward we placed will hold for now, but it won't last forever. Be careful in those woods, child. There's something dark at work here."

What would you like to take, and is there anything you want to ask or say to Mother Nelle before you depart?

You said: "Mother, I cannot take this all free of charge."

"Mother, I cannot take this all free of charge. Please, accept a donation of 10 gold pieces for your aid. I cannot thank you enough for your help last night." Riv pulls Mother Nelle aside, away from his companions, and continues in a hushed voice, "I wonder... are there many healing herbs in the area around the village? If so, might you do me a small favor? I have this... feeling. I fear things may become worse before they become better. If you can take a small group with you to pick medicinal herbs while we're gone, maybe some wood with which to carve holy symbols... I fear we may need stockpiles of these before this nightmares ends."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Cleric's Foresight

A Cleric's Foresight

Mother Nelle's eyes widen slightly at your donation, then soften with understanding. She accepts the coins with a solemn nod. "Your generosity honors Chauntea, Riv."

When you pull her aside, she listens intently to your quiet words. Her expression grows more serious, the lines on her face deepening. She's quiet for a long moment, studying you.

"Your instincts serve you well, child," she says softly. "A cleric learns to listen to such feelings - they're often the gods whispering warnings." She glances toward the forest, then back to you. "Yes. The forest edges have yarrow, comfrey, and elderflower. And ash wood grows plentifully - good for carving, and sacred besides."

She straightens, resolve settling over her features. "I'll speak with Gerda and some of the other women. We'll gather what we can today." Her voice drops even lower. "You think Marcus and this other werewolf... they're not the end of it, do you?"

She searches your face, then squeezes your arm. "Go carefully. Return to us. I'll prepare what I can, and I'll keep the shrine fires burning. If something happens... if you don't return by nightfall... I'll make sure the villagers are ready."

You spend 10 GP on donation. Remaining gold: 69.5 GP You receive: 3 vials of blessed water, 1 pouch of healing herbs

Dagmar calls from the doorway. "Dawn's breaking, Cleric. We should move."

Are you ready to head into Darkwood Forest?

You said: Yes, let's set off

Yes, let's set off

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Into Darkwood Forest

Into Darkwood Forest

The four of you leave the village as the sun breaks over the horizon, painting the sky in shades of gold and pink. The forest looms ahead - ancient oaks and pines creating a dense canopy that swallows the morning light.

Dagmar takes point, moving with practiced silence. Finn follows close behind her, and Garrick walks beside you, shield now strapped to his arm, silvered sword ready.

The forest is eerily quiet. No birdsong. No rustling of small animals. Just the crunch of frost-covered leaves beneath your boots.

Survival Check (Dagmar)

After about forty minutes of hiking, Dagmar holds up a fist - the universal signal to stop. She crouches, examining the ground, then points.

"Tracks," she whispers. "Wolf prints, but huge. Human-sized stride in places." She traces the path with her finger. "These are fresh - maybe three, four hours old. Headed toward the cave, like it returned after fleeing last night."

She looks up at the rocky outcrop ahead - you can just make out a dark opening in the cliff face, perhaps 200 feet distant through the trees.

"The three bear traps are set in a triangle around the cave entrance, about 30 feet out," Garrick murmurs. "Hidden under leaves."

Dagmar studies the approach. "How do you want to do this, Cleric? We could:

- Approach openly from here, calling out as we walk - shows we want to talk
- Send you forward alone while we hang back with bows ready
- Scout closer first to see if there's any sign of activity"

The forest remains unnaturally silent. Somewhere ahead, the werewolf waits.

What's your approach?

You said: Can Dagmar perform a perception check or will that fall to me as the player character?

Can Dagmar perform a perception check or will that fall to me as the player character?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great question!

Great question! This is actually a good teaching moment about D&D mechanics.

How Ability Checks Work:

As the player, you're controlling Riv, so when I ask for checks, those are for you to roll. However, NPCs in your party can also make checks - I'll roll those behind the scenes (or tell you the results) since they're supporting characters.

In this case, since Dagmar is an expert tracker and scout, I can have her make a Perception check to scout ahead and report what she sees. You can absolutely ask your companions to use their skills!

However, you can also make your own Perception check to see what Riv notices with his own eyes. Sometimes you'll both notice different things, or one of you will spot something the other missed.

So let's do both:

Dagmar's Perception check: She's going to carefully scout the area around the cave entrance. (I'll roll for her: she gets a 16 - pretty good!)

Your turn: Would you like to roll a Perception check for Riv? Roll a d20 and add your Wisdom modifier.

For Riv's Perception:

- Roll 1d20

- Add your Wisdom modifier (let's say +3 for a Cleric)
- Tell me your total!

What do you roll?

You said: 14

14

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Perception Checks

Perception Checks

Dagmar (16 total): She creeps forward about 50 feet, using the trees for cover, studying the cave and surrounding area. After a few tense minutes, she returns.

"The cave entrance is dark, can't see inside from here. No movement I can spot. BUT..." She points to the ground. "More tracks. The werewolf definitely went in, but look here—" She indicates disturbed earth near the cave mouth. "Something's been digging. Fresh. And there's..." She sniffs the air. "Blood. Old blood."

Riv (14+3 = 17 total): Your eyes are sharp. As you scan the area, you notice something Dagmar missed - on the rock face above the cave entrance, maybe 10 feet up, there are deep claw marks gouged into the stone. They're savage, violent. But what catches your attention is that they seem almost... deliberate. Not random scratches from climbing. Almost like tally marks.

You also notice something else: there are birds in the trees behind you, but they're completely silent and watching the cave. They haven't fled. They're waiting.

Finn whispers nervously, "It knows we're here, doesn't it?"

Garrick adjusts his grip on his sword. "Probably. Question is whether it's waiting for us to come in, or preparing to come out."

The cave entrance yawns before you like a dark mouth. The bear traps are hidden somewhere in the brush between you and that opening.

How do you want to proceed?

You said: I know where the bear traps are, right?

I know where the bear traps are, right? We set them, so I'm not going to accidentally trigger them on my approach. "We stick to the plan. Dagmar, Finn, you flank from elevated positions. Garrick - you and I get to approach on foot. We try talking first. If that doesn't work, Dagmar and Finn, loose those arrows. Garrick, if a fight does break out, try to draw it into the traps we've laid."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Plan in Motion

The Plan in Motion

Dagmar nods approvingly. "Good. Finn, with me." She and her apprentice move silently into position, circling around to higher ground on either side of the cave. You can see them take cover behind trees about 60 feet out, arrows nocked. Dagmar gives you a subtle hand signal - ready.

Garrick steps up beside you, shield raised, sword ready. "Let's hope your god gave you a silver tongue to match your holy symbols, Cleric," he mutters. Then, more seriously: "If it charges, I'll try to angle it toward the traps. You stay behind me until we know what we're dealing with."

The Approach

You and Garrick walk forward slowly, deliberately. The bear traps are positioned at roughly 30 feet from the cave - you both know their locations and carefully step around them.

At about 40 feet from the entrance, you stop.

The cave is silent. Dark. You can smell it now - what Dagmar noticed. Old blood, and something else. Wet fur. Decay.

This is your moment. How do you want to call out? What do you say to the werewolf?

(This is pure roleplay - say whatever feels right for Riv. Your Persuasion skill might come into play depending on what you say and how the werewolf responds.)

You said: "I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander.

"I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. With me is Garrick Ironheart, village blacksmith. We seek to parley with the master of this cave"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Werewolf Emerges

The Werewolf Emerges

Your voice echoes off the stone. For a long moment, there's only silence.

Then, from deep within the cave, you hear it—a low, rumbling growl that raises the hair on the back of your neck. Not animal. Not human. Something between.

Movement in the darkness. Two eyes catch the dawn light filtering through the trees—amber, glowing, intelligent.

The werewolf steps into the cave entrance.

It's massive, easily seven feet tall, covered in matted gray and black fur. Its muzzle is scarred, one ear torn. But what strikes you most is its posture—it's not crouched to pounce. It's standing upright, almost... cautiously. Warily.

It speaks. The voice is rough, distorted by the wolf's throat, but unmistakably human underneath. Male.

"Lathander's priest." The words come slowly, painfully. "Come to... finish it. Like you finished... Marcus."

There's grief in that voice. Raw and bitter.

The werewolf's claws flex, but it doesn't move forward. "You should have... let him live. He was... innocent."

Behind you, you can sense Dagmar's bow trained on the creature. Garrick's shield is up, but he's holding position as you asked.

The werewolf's amber eyes bore into yours, waiting.

What do you say?

You said: "Lycanthropy is a disease."

"Lycanthropy is a disease. I understand. I have cured many suffering from the curse before. By all accounts, Marcus was a good man. Had he not attacked... no. The fault is mine. I should have taken the time to subdue him, brought him back to his senses. I should not have attacked. I cannot make up for the loss you've endured - but I can ensure that you come back to town with us, unharmed and free of your curse. Will you allow me to cure you of this disease?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Moment of Truth

A Moment of Truth

The werewolf's eyes widen. For a moment, the bestial features seem to shift—surprise, hope, suspicion all flickering across its face.

"Cure?" The word comes out half-growl, half-gasp. "You... you can cure this?"

It takes a stumbling step forward, then stops abruptly, as if catching itself. The claws dig into the earth.

"No. No, you... you lie. There is no cure. I've been this way for... months. I searched. Temples, healers, hedge witches... all said the same. Silver or death. Those are the only cures."

The werewolf's voice cracks with something like desperation.

"I tried. I TRIED to control it. Came here, to the forest, away from people. But the hunger... and then I..." It looks away, toward the village. "I turned Marcus. Three weeks ago. I didn't mean to. The moon was full and I... I couldn't..."

The creature's whole body is shaking now—rage, grief, shame all warring in its posture.

"If you truly can cure this... why would you? I'm a monster. I killed livestock. I cursed Marcus. I..."

The werewolf looks back at you, and you can see tears in those amber eyes.

"What's your price, priest? What do you want from me?"

This is a pivotal moment. The werewolf wants to believe you but is afraid to hope.

What do you say? And just to clarify—do you actually have a way to cure lycanthropy, or were you hoping to find one? (This is important for me to know so I can adjudicate fairly!)

You said: Well, that's a question I actually have for you!

Well, that's a question I actually have for you! I assumed that as a cleric I could cure it, that my holy symbols and through prayer my God could help me remove the curse. Is that not something I can actually do? Riv believes he has the ability to cure lycanthropy - but we never worked out the mechanical aspects of it

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great question!

Great question! Let's figure this out together.

In D&D 5th Edition, lycanthropy is tricky:

The Rules:

- Remove Curse (3rd-level spell) can cure lycanthropy, BUT only if the person was infected (not born a werewolf) AND hasn't fully embraced the curse
- However, Riv is currently level 2 (based on Session 1), so you don't have access to 3rd-level spells yet
- Clerics get 3rd-level spells at character level 5

Our Options:

1. Riv genuinely believes he can cure it (which fits his character), but discovers he needs more power/a higher level ritual. This could lead to a quest to find a way.
2. We retroactively say Riv is level 5+ so you have Remove Curse available now. This is totally fine if you want!

3. A special ritual with Mother Nelle - perhaps combining both your powers, using blessed materials, could work (requires a successful Religion check and some creative problem-solving)
4. There's a more powerful artifact or location that could cure it - giving you a secondary quest

What feels right to you? I want this to be a learning experience, so I'm happy to adjust Riv's level, or we can make this a more complex challenge. What would be more fun/interesting for you?

You said: I don't want to adjust my level - this learning experience may reveal a flaw in Riv's character more than anything.

I don't want to adjust my level - this learning experience may reveal a flaw in Riv's character more than anything. Riv believes he can cure lycanthropy - but his belief might not be enough. That said, we did set the campaign by saying that Riv is exceptionally well-studied; perhaps he has a scroll that can lift the curse? Something he discovered in a library? That would fit Riv's character and background without breaking the rules of the game, right?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Perfect! That's a great solution and very D&D.

Yes, this works perfectly within the rules! Clerics can use spell scrolls, and it's entirely reasonable that a well-studied traveling cleric would have acquired a scroll of Remove Curse during his studies or travels. Spell scrolls are exactly the kind of thing an adventurer might carry for emergencies.

Here's how it works mechanically:

- You have a Scroll of Remove Curse (3rd-level spell)
- To use it, you need to make a spellcasting ability check: roll d20 + your Wisdom modifier + your proficiency bonus
- The DC (difficulty) is 13 (10 + spell level)
- If you succeed, the spell works and the scroll is consumed
- If you fail, the scroll is wasted and nothing happens

This also creates beautiful dramatic tension - Riv believes he can help, he has the means, but there's still uncertainty about whether he can pull it off.

Back to the scene:

Riv reaches into his pack, remembering the scroll he acquired months ago from that dusty monastery library. His fingers find the aged parchment, sealed with wax.

"I have this," you say, holding up the scroll. "A Remove Curse spell. I cannot cast it myself yet - I lack the power. But I can channel it through this scroll. It may work. It... should work."

The werewolf stares at the scroll, then at you.

How does Riv respond to the werewolf's question: "What's your price?"

You said: "My price is knowledge.

"My price is knowledge. I have this... feeling. Like something called me to Thornhaven; like something much worse is coming for this village. How did you come to be here? Who sent you? Who were you before? And what is coming? If you agree to answer these questions, whether I succeed or not, I vow to cure you - whether through this scroll or, failing that, when I become powerful enough to do so"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Bargain Struck

A Bargain Struck

The werewolf stares at you for a long, tense moment. Then, slowly, it sinks down to sit on the cave floor—still wary, but no longer ready to fight. The posture is almost... defeated. Exhausted.

"Knowledge. You want... knowledge." A sound that might be a bitter laugh. "All right, priest. I'll tell you everything. Gods know... it might be a relief to finally say it out loud."

The creature takes a shuddering breath.

"My name is—was—Aldric Thorne. I was a merchant. Traveled the trade roads between Millford and the northern settlements. Good business, good life."

The werewolf's claws trace patterns in the dirt.

"Four months ago, I was on the road north of Millford. Late evening, took a shortcut through the woods. Stupid. There was... something waiting. Not a normal werewolf. It was... WRONG. Too intelligent. Too deliberate."

Aldric's voice drops to almost a whisper.

"It spoke to me. Before it bit me. Said I was 'chosen.' Said I would serve 'the Master' when the time came. I fought, but..." He holds up his clawed hands. "Three days later, first full moon. I transformed. Lost control. Hurt people."

"I fled. Tried to find help. But everywhere I went, I could feel... something. Like being watched. Like something was herding me. And then, three weeks ago, I felt a PULL. Not physical. In my mind. Compelling me. It drew me here. To Thornhaven."

He looks up at you, fear clear in those amber eyes.

"I've been fighting it ever since. The compulsion. It wants me to do something. I don't know what. But whatever created me, whatever this 'Master' is... Thornhaven is important to it somehow. And I think... I think I'm not the only one it's sent."

Garrick shifts beside you, tension radiating off him. From the trees, you can hear Dagmar's sharp intake of breath.

Aldric continues: "Two nights ago, before you arrived, I heard howling. Far to the north. Multiple voices. Pack hunting. They're coming."

The weight of this settles over you. This isn't just about one werewolf. There's a larger threat.

Aldric looks at you with desperate hope. "Now... will you keep your word, Cleric? Will you try?"

What do you do?

You said: "Let's prepare."

"Let's prepare. Please, allow me to gather the rest of my team for this ritual. No matter what happens, success or failure, now that we've had the chance to talk, I do not want you harmed. If I fail, if this ritual cannot be completed, I swear upon my life as a Cleric of Lathander that I will find a way to cure you." Riv signals Dagmar and Finn, who approach warily. Riv begins to prepare the curative ritual.

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Gathering for the Ritual

Gathering for the Ritual

Dagmar and Finn emerge from their positions, bows still at the ready but lowered. Dagmar's eyes are sharp, assessing, but she nods at your signal. Finn looks nervous but follows her lead.

"Everyone, lower your weapons," you say firmly. "This is Aldric Thorne. He was cursed, not born to this. And he's told us something critical—there are more coming. A pack. He's been fighting the compulsion that brought him here."

Garrick keeps his shield up but doesn't advance. "More coming? How many?"

Aldric's voice is hoarse. "I don't know. At least three, maybe more. They'll arrive... soon. Days, maybe."

Dagmar swears under her breath. "Then we need to move fast. Do what you need to do, Cleric."

Preparing the Ritual

You unfurl the scroll—the parchment is old but well-preserved, covered in intricate divine script and arcane formulae. The spell is complex, meant to sever supernatural curses from the soul.

Setting the scene:

- Aldric kneels before you, trembling but willing
- Your companions form a protective circle around you both
- You pull out your holy symbol of Lathander, the Morninglord—bringer of renewal and hope

The Mechanics: This is your moment. To cast the spell from the scroll successfully:

- Roll 1d20 + your Wisdom modifier (+3) + your proficiency bonus (+2)
- You need to meet or beat DC 13
- That means you need to roll 8 or higher on the die

Before you roll, is there anything Riv does to prepare? Any prayers, any blessings, any way he centers himself? This is a big moment—feel free to roleplay it!

Then, when you're ready: Roll your d20.

You said: "Lathander.

"Lathander. Morninglord. Please bless this champion of yours with your light. Allow me to bring this wayward adventurer back from this curse. Blessed are you who brings the dawn. Blessed are you who ensures I sleep well each night with a full stomach and fresh linens. Blessed are you among merchants and wardens, among watchmen hopeful to see tomorrow's light."

I've rolled a 14

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Light of Dawn

The Light of Dawn

Total: 14 + 3 (Wisdom) + 2 (Proficiency) = 19 Success!

As you speak the prayer, your holy symbol begins to glow—soft at first, then brighter, like the first rays of dawn breaking over the horizon. The scroll ignites with golden light, the divine script lifting from the parchment and swirling around you in luminous ribbons.

You place your hand on Aldric's head. He gasps, his body going rigid.

The ancient words of the spell flow from your lips—not in Common, but in Celestial, the language of the divine. Your voice resonates with power beyond your own as Lathander answers your call.

The transformation is violent and beautiful:

Aldric screams—not in pain, but in release. The werewolf form fights to hold on. You can see it—black, oily tendrils of curse-magic writhing beneath his fur, desperately clinging to his soul. But your light is relentless. It burns through the darkness like dawn consuming night.

The fur begins to recede. The claws retract. The muzzle shortens.

There's a sound like glass shattering, and suddenly Aldric collapses forward—human. Completely human. Naked, shivering, covered in old scars, but human.

He's gasping, sobbing, his hands—his human hands—pressing into the dirt.

"It's... it's gone. I can't feel it anymore. The hunger. The compulsion. It's GONE."

The scroll crumbles to ash in your hands, its purpose fulfilled. Your holy symbol dims back to normal.

Garrick immediately shrugs off his cloak and throws it over Aldric's shoulders. Finn lets out a breath he'd been holding. Dagmar lowers her bow completely, a look of genuine wonder on her weathered face.

"By the gods," she murmurs. "You actually did it."

Aldric looks up at you, tears streaming down his face. He's perhaps forty years old, with dark hair going gray at the temples, lean from months of living rough.

"Thank you," he whispers. "Thank you. I... I thought I'd die as that thing. I thought—" His voice breaks.

But then his expression changes. Fear flashes across his face.

"Wait. The compulsion is gone, but... Cleric, you need to understand. Whatever sent that thing to bite me, whatever this 'Master' is—it WANTS Thornhaven. And if I could feel the pack coming, then they're close. We need to warn the village. We need to prepare."

He struggles to his feet, Garrick steadying him.

"I'll tell you everything I know. Every detail. But we need to move. NOW."

What do you do?

You said: "Dagmar, Finn, take a look around."

"Dagmar, Finn, take a look around. Let's gather anything of use to us. Garrick, let's pack up the traps. Aldric, hold a moment. Allow us a moment to look around. Is there anything in your cave that might be of use to us going forward?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Searching the Cave

Searching the Cave

Aldric nods, still unsteady on his feet but clear-eyed. "There's... not much. I've been living like an animal. But there are some things from before. My merchant pack. And..." He hesitates. "There's something else. Something I found two weeks ago, buried near the cave entrance. I think... I think it was left here deliberately. For me to find."

The Search Begins

Dagmar and Finn move to scout the perimeter and check the bear traps. Garrick begins carefully disarming and collecting the traps—this will take him a few minutes.

You and Aldric enter the cave.

Inside the Cave: The space is larger than it appeared from outside—maybe 30 feet deep, widening into a natural chamber. The smell is strong: wet fur, old blood, animal remains. Your eyes adjust to the dimness.

You can see:

- A torn merchant's pack in the corner—leather, good quality but weathered
- Scattered bones—mostly animal (deer, rabbits), evidence of Aldric's hunting
- A bedroll, filthy but functional
- Near the cave mouth, disturbed earth where something was recently dug up

Aldric limps over to the merchant pack and pulls out a few items:

- A journal, leather-bound, water-stained
- A small coinpurse—he tosses it to you. "About 30 gold. Take it. Payment for saving my life."
- A silver merchant's ring on a chain—clearly personal

Then he moves to the disturbed earth and kneels, digging with his hands. After a moment, he pulls out a wrapped bundle.

"This," he says quietly. "This is what I found."

He unwraps it carefully.

Roll a Religion check (d20 + your Wisdom modifier + proficiency bonus) to see if you recognize what it is.

What do you roll?

You said: 16

16

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 16 + 3 (Wisdom) + 2 (Proficiency) = 21.

16 + 3 (Wisdom) + 2 (Proficiency) = 21. Excellent success.

As Aldric unwraps the cloth, you feel it before you see it—a cold, oily sensation that makes your holy symbol grow uncomfortably warm against your chest. A warning.

Inside the bundle is a small idol, roughly carved from black stone. It's crude but deliberate: a twisted, wolf-like figure with too many limbs, standing upright. But what makes your blood run cold are the symbols carved into its base.

You recognize them immediately.

They're profane runes—the script of Malar, the Beastlord. God of the hunt, of bloodlust, of savage nature. But these aren't the typical prayers to Malar used by hunters or barbarian tribes. These are corrupted. Twisted. The kind of dark magic used by his most fanatical cultists.

What you know:

- Malar's cult has been growing in the northern territories over the past year
- They believe in "culling the weak" and "returning civilization to the wild"
- His most devoted followers use lycanthropy as a "gift"—deliberately spreading it to create packs of werewolves
- This idol is a cursed object—it radiates dark magic meant to compel and control lycanthropes

"This was calling to me," Aldric says quietly, staring at the thing with revulsion. "Every night. Whispering. Telling me to gather others. To prepare for 'the Hunt.' I tried to bury it, destroy it, but I... I couldn't. The compulsion was too strong."

He looks at you. "Now that I'm cured, I can barely stand to look at it. What is this thing, Cleric?"

From outside, Dagmar calls: "Riv! We've got the traps packed. But you need to see this—Finn found tracks. Fresh ones. Heading south."

What do you do with the idol, and how do you respond?

You said: Speaking to Aldric: "It's a thing of evil.

Speaking to Aldric: "It's a thing of evil. We'll take the idol. Mother Nelle and I can destroy it together - or find a way to cleanse it. Grab your pack and your belongings. Leave the bedroll. You'll be my guest at the Sleeping Giant Inn, should you decide to stay. If not, I'll have a new bedroll made for you. You are a beast no longer; you deserve the comforts of humanity."

Calling out to Dagmar, "We're on our way."

Turning back to Aldric, "Tell me.. was Marcus the only person you turned? What lies to the South?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Aldric's Confession

Aldric's Confession

Aldric's face crumples with guilt as he pulls on his worn clothes from the merchant pack.

"Marcus was... the only one. I swear it. Three weeks ago, the first night the compulsion really took hold. I was hunting, lost control, and he was out checking his sheep. I remember... fragments. The taste of blood. His screams." He shakes his head violently, as if trying to dislodge the memory. "After that, I stayed away from the village. Fought the urge every night. If you hadn't come when you did..."

He looks south, toward where Dagmar called from.

"South? That's back toward the village. And beyond that... Millford. The main trade road. Farms, settlements, travelers." His eyes widen with realization. "If the pack is coming from the north and heading south... they're not just targeting Thornhaven. They're going to sweep through EVERYTHING between here and Millford. Dozens of farms. Hundreds of people."

You carefully wrap the cursed idol in cloth—even through the fabric, you can feel it pulsing with dark energy. Your holy symbol continues to burn warm, a protective ward against its influence.

Outside the Cave

You emerge to find Dagmar and Finn examining the ground near the forest edge. Garrick has the three bear traps bundled and ready to transport.

Dagmar points to the tracks. "Wolf prints. At least three different animals, maybe four. Huge. Werewolf-sized. They passed through here maybe... six hours ago? Just before dawn. Heading southeast."

She looks up at you, her expression grim. "They're not moving toward Thornhaven directly. They're circling. Scouting. Or..." She pauses. "Or they're heading for the Tomás farm first. It's isolated, southeast of the village, about a mile from here."

Tomás—the farmer who lost livestock. The father of young Willem.

Finn speaks up nervously: "If they hit the farm in daylight... in human form... no one would know they're werewolves until nightfall."

Aldric, now dressed and steadier, comes up beside you. "That's their strategy. Infiltrate during the day. Transform and attack at night when people are vulnerable. It's what the compulsion was pushing me to do—I just... fought it."

The Decision Point:

- Rush to Tomás's farm (1 mile southeast)—might catch the werewolves before they can establish themselves, but you'd be leaving the village center less protected
- Return to Thornhaven immediately (2 miles southwest)—warn everyone, fortify the village, but the farm might be compromised
- Split the party—some go to the farm, some to the village

What do you do?

You said: To Dagmar and Garrick: "If Mother Nelle followed my instructions, she should have gone out to gather healing herbs and wood."

To Dagmar and Garrick: "If Mother Nelle followed my instructions, she should have gone out to gather healing herbs and wood. We have a 3 decisions to make: who will go to the town center to warn Elder Wren to keep the townsfolk together and on alert; who will go to Tomás' farm; and who will check the wilds around the forest edges for Mother Nelle and Gerda? I won't make this decision for us all; who feels best suited to do what?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Council of War

A Council of War

Your companions exchange glances, quickly assessing the situation. These are practical people used to making hard decisions.

Dagmar speaks first, her voice decisive: "I'll go to Tomás's farm. I'm the fastest tracker here, and if those werewolves are there in human form, I'll be able to spot signs—disturbed earth, nervous livestock, things out of place. Finn, you come with me. Two sets of eyes, and your bow arm is solid enough now."

Finn nods, gripping his bow tighter. "Yes, master."

Garrick adjusts his shield: "I'll head to the village center. Elder Wren knows me, trusts me. I can get people organized fast—bring everyone to the center near your ward, get the men armed and watching the perimeter." He glances at the silvered sword at his hip. "And if something goes wrong, I can hold a line until help arrives."

Dagmar looks at you: "That leaves you and Aldric to find Mother Nelle and Gerda. You know where she'd likely be gathering herbs, and..." She nods toward the wrapped idol in your pack. "If something's drawn to that cursed thing you're carrying, better you have it than us. Plus, if they run into trouble, you've got healing magic."

Aldric speaks quietly: "I know these woods. Even as a man, I remember the paths. And I owe Mother Nelle—if she's in danger because of what I brought here, I need to help."

Dagmar's plan:

- Dagmar & Finn → Tomás's farm (1 mile SE, ~20 min travel)
- Garrick → Village center to warn Elder Wren (~30 min travel, faster if he runs)
- Riv & Aldric → Search forest edges for Mother Nelle & Gerda (~variable, depending on where they are)

"We meet back at the village center before sunset," Dagmar says firmly. "No one stays out after dark. Agreed?"

Does this plan work for you? Any adjustments?

You said: "Agreed."

"Agreed. When Aldric and I have found and escorted Mother Nelle and Gerda to safety, we'll head your way, Dag. If you're going to face down werewolves, you won't be doing so alone. Garrick, set those caltrops and oil flasks from your shop out and lay the bear traps to the South and East. We'll be back in the center of town before sunset. Let's move out, and may the Light of Lathander protect us all."

If I cast Shield of Faith on Dagmar and Finn, will it last long enough for their journey to Tomás' farm, or will it be wasted?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great tactical thinking!

Great tactical thinking!

Shield of Faith mechanics:

- Duration: 10 minutes (concentration)
- Travel time to Tomás's farm: ~20 minutes

So unfortunately, the spell would wear off before they even arrive at the farm. It would be wasted at this point.

Better options:

- Save your spell slots for when you might need healing or combat buffs later
- Cast Shield of Faith on Dagmar right before they expect combat (if you make it to the farm in time to help)
- You could cast Bless on the group before splitting up, which lasts 1 minute - just long enough for everyone to get clear of the immediate area and have a small boost for any initial encounters

However, you could offer them something else: one of your vials of blessed water or some of the healing herbs from Mother Nelle. Dagmar would probably appreciate the practical gesture.

The Party Splits

Garrick clasps your shoulder. "Lathander's light on you, Cleric. See you at sunset." He turns and starts jogging toward the village, shield on his back, moving with surprising speed for a man his age.

Dagmar checks her arrows one more time. "Don't take unnecessary risks looking for Mother Nelle. If you can't find them quickly, come straight to the farm." She and Finn head southeast, disappearing into the forest with practiced silence.

You're left with Aldric, who looks strange in his human form after you've only known him as a werewolf - lean, weathered, but clear-eyed and determined.

"Where would Mother Nelle go to gather herbs?" he asks. "I know these woods fairly well from my... time here."

Where do you think Mother Nelle would be gathering? What's your search strategy?

You said: (Let's assume that I took your advice and gave Dagmar a vial of blessed water before she departed)

(Let's assume that I took your advice and gave Dagmar a vial of blessed water before she departed)

"Mother Nelle said the healing herbs grew on the border of the forest and the village. We'll head south and look for them there. Have you ever been in a fight before, Aldric?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Search Begins

The Search Begins

Dagmar accepts the vial with a grim nod, tucking it carefully into her belt. "Appreciated, Cleric. Might be the difference." Then she and Finn are gone.

Aldric walks beside you as you head south toward the forest edge near the village. He's still getting used to his human body again—his movements are slightly unsteady, like someone relearning how to walk.

At your question, he gives a bitter laugh. "A fight? I've been a merchant for twenty years, Cleric. I've talked my way out of trouble, paid off bandits, run from danger... but actually stand and fight?" He shakes his head. "I brawled in taverns as a young man. That's about it. As the wolf, I was... strong. Fast. Deadly. But I wasn't in control."

He looks down at his human hands. "Now? I'm just a middle-aged merchant who hasn't held a weapon in decades. If we run into trouble, I'll do what I can, but..." He meets your eyes. "I'm no warrior. You'll be doing the protecting, I'm afraid."

He pauses, then adds quietly: "But I know how they think. The werewolves. How they hunt. That might be worth something."

Searching the Forest Edge

After about fifteen minutes of moving south along the forest border, you begin to see signs of gathering—broken stems of yarrow, disturbed undergrowth where comfrey was harvested.

Roll a Perception check (d20 + Wisdom modifier) to track their movements.

What do you roll?

You said: 7

7

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 7 + 3 (Wisdom) = 10.

7 + 3 (Wisdom) = 10. Moderate success.

You can see evidence that Mother Nelle and her group were here—broken stems, footprints in the soft earth, a woven basket left near a cluster of elderflower bushes. But the trail becomes confused. Multiple sets of footprints overlap, heading in different directions.

It looks like they split up to cover more ground—some went deeper along the forest edge heading west, others seem to have circled back toward the village.

Aldric kneels, examining the ground. "I'm no tracker, but... these prints are fresh. Maybe an hour old? They were definitely here recently."

Then you hear it—faint, but distinct. Voices. Female voices, coming from the west, deeper along the forest edge. You can't make out words, but there's an urgency to the tone.

Aldric tenses beside you. "Could be them. Or..." He doesn't finish the thought, but you understand. Could be someone—or something—else.

The voices are maybe 200 feet away, obscured by dense undergrowth and trees.

What do you do?

- Call out to identify yourself
- Approach quietly to see who it is first
- Send Aldric to scout while you hang back
- Something else?

You said: "Do those voices sound lycanthropic to you, Aldric?"

"Do those voices sound lycanthropic to you, Aldric?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Aldric listens intently, his head cocked.

Aldric listens intently, his head cocked. After a moment, he shakes his head.

"No. Werewolves in human form sound... normal. Completely human. There's no way to tell just by voice." He frowns, concentrating. "But the tone—that sounds like people working, maybe arguing about something. Not the casual conversation you'd expect from infiltrators trying to blend in."

He looks at you. "When I was under the compulsion, I could sense other lycanthropes nearby. Like a pull, a recognition. Now that I'm cured..." He closes his eyes, as if trying to feel for something.

"Nothing. I'm just human again. I can't tell if there are werewolves near us or not."

The voices continue—you can now make out that there are at least two people, possibly three. One voice sounds older, authoritative. Another younger, perhaps worried.

Aldric adds quietly: "If it IS Mother Nelle and Gerda, calling out would let them know help is here. But if it's NOT them... we'd be announcing ourselves to potential enemies."

He defers to you. "Your call, Cleric. You're the one with divine magic and combat training. I'll follow your lead."

What do you do?

You said: "I think I recognize Mother Nelle's voice."

"I think I recognize Mother Nelle's voice. Besides, werewolves would be drawn to this idol, wouldn't they? I can't imagine they'd try subterfuge with the compulsion drowning out their senses. Let's make our way over there and get our friends home"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Approaching the Voices

Approaching the Voices

Aldric nods, seeming relieved by your reasoning. "You're right. When I had that thing near me, it was... overwhelming. Subtle tactics weren't exactly on my mind."

You push through the undergrowth, moving toward the voices. As you get closer, you can make out words:

"—told you we should have stayed closer to the village edge!" That's definitely Gerda's voice, the tavern keeper.

"And I told YOU that the best elderflower grows deeper in. Stop fussing and help me—" Mother Nelle's voice, patient but strained.

You emerge into a small clearing and find them: Mother Nelle, Gerda, and two other village women you recognize from the tavern. They're gathered around a thick patch of brambles, clearly trying to harvest something, but one of them—a younger woman named Brea—is holding her arm, blood seeping through her fingers.

Mother Nelle looks up sharply at your approach, then her weathered face floods with relief. "Riv! Thank the gods." Then she sees Aldric and her eyes widen. "Is that...?"

"The werewolf," you confirm. "Cured. His name is Aldric Thorne."

Gerda has her hand on a heavy walking stick, clearly prepared to use it as a weapon, but she lowers it slowly. "Cured? Truly?"

Brea winces, still holding her bleeding arm. "I slipped into the brambles. It's not deep, just... painful."

Mother Nelle is staring at Aldric with a mixture of wonder and caution. "You actually did it. You cured lycanthropy." Then her expression sharpens. "But you're here in the middle of the day, instead of at the cave. Something's wrong."

How do you explain the situation? And do you want to heal Brea's wound first?

You said: Do I have any healing spells?

Do I have any healing spells? I have my healer's kit, but I may need that later. How many uses does my healer's kit have?

"We need to get back to the village. How did your search go? Do we have enough for the village stockpiles?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Your Healing Options:

Your Healing Options:

Spells:

- Cure Wounds (1st level): Heals 1d8 + your Wisdom modifier (so 1d8+3 HP)
- You have 3 first-level spell slots available (you used one for Guiding Bolt last session, but you would have rested since then)

Healer's Kit:

- Has 10 uses total
- Can stabilize a dying creature without needing a Medicine check
- Can be used to treat wounds and help with recovery
- With Mother Nelle's healing herbs, you'd have advantage on Medicine checks

For Brea's minor wound, a Healer's Kit use + Medicine check would be perfectly sufficient and save your spell slots for more serious injuries.

Mother Nelle's Report

Mother Nelle gestures to several full baskets nearby. "We've done well. Enough yarrow and comfrey for perhaps twenty poultices. A dozen elderflower bundles for tinctures. Gerda found wild garlic—useful for infections." She picks up a bundle of freshly cut ash branches. "And enough ash wood for fifteen, maybe twenty holy symbols if I work through the night."

Gerda adds: "We were just finishing up when Brea had her accident. We were about to head back."

You pull out your healer's kit and approach Brea. "Let me see that arm."

Roll a Medicine check: d20 + Wisdom modifier (+3). You have advantage (roll twice, take the higher) because of Mother Nelle's herbs.

What do you roll? (Roll 2d20 and tell me both numbers)

You said: 8

8

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Just to clarify - did you roll twice?

Just to clarify - did you roll twice?

Since you have advantage from Mother Nelle's herbs, you should roll 2d20 and take the higher result.

If you only rolled once and got 8, please roll one more d20 and tell me what you get - we'll use whichever is higher between the 8 and your second roll!

You said: 8 and 10

8 and 10

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 10 + 3 (Wisdom) = 13.

10 + 3 (Wisdom) = 13. Solid success.

You carefully clean Brea's wound with water from your waterskin, apply a poultice made from the healing herbs, and wrap it with clean bandages from your healer's kit. The bleeding stops quickly, and while she'll have some soreness, the wound is minor and shouldn't cause problems.

"Thank you, Cleric," Brea says with relief, flexing her arm experimentally.

Healer's Kit: 9/10 uses remaining

The Warning

Mother Nelle watches you work, then her eyes narrow as she studies your face. "You didn't answer my question, child. What's wrong? Why are you here instead of at the cave?"

You meet her gaze. "Because there's a pack of werewolves heading toward Thornhaven. At least three, maybe four. They passed through the forest this morning, heading southeast. Dagmar and

Finn have gone to Tomás's farm—we think the werewolves might hit there first. Garrick is warning Elder Wren and preparing the village center."

The color drains from Gerda's face. "A pack? Gods above..."

Mother Nelle's expression becomes steel. She immediately begins gathering the baskets. "Then we move. Now. No arguments."

Aldric speaks up quietly: "There's more. The werewolves aren't random. They're being sent by someone—a cult of Malar. They're deliberately spreading lycanthropy and targeting settlements." He looks haunted. "I was supposed to be one of them. To prepare the way."

The village women stare at him, fear and disgust warring on their faces.

Mother Nelle grips her walking staff. "Explanations later. Movement now. Riv, lead us back. Quickly."

The Journey Back

You have about 20-25 minutes of travel to get back to the village center. The group moves as fast as they can while carrying baskets of supplies.

As you travel, you can:

1. Ask Aldric more questions about the cult or the compulsion
2. Discuss defense strategy with Mother Nelle
3. Move in silence, staying alert for threats

Or do you want to head straight to Tomás's farm to support Dagmar and Finn instead of the village center?

What do you do?

You said: Let's walk together until they see the village border.

Let's walk together until they see the village border. During that time, I would say 10-15 minutes, I'd like to talk to Mother Nelle about the healing herbs and Gerda about a room for Aldric.

To Mother Nelle: "Once we're back, please do what you can to create those poultices and healing kits. If there's a small hut or storehouse in town, set it up as a healing tent. I aim to heal as many of these lycanthropes as possible, but it will take time and experience to learn these spells. In the meantime, we may have to deal with injured townsfolk and I want to be prepared. Set up beds and bedrolls to give the townsfolk comfort while we deal with the wider threat. We also have this to deal with," Riv says, showing her the corrupted idol. "We'll have to destroy or cleanse it, but until we do, it draws lycanthropes towards it. I won't send it back to town with you - but we'll need to focus our efforts sooner than later and deal with it. Do you have any advice?"

To Gerda: "Thank you for helping out today. When we get close to town, I'll be heading towards Tomás' farm. Please take Aldric back to town with you. Get him cleaned up, give him a room, and lay out food for him. Put it on my tab. He was a merchant prior to this and I'm sure he can help you organize your food stores or wine cellar or maybe negotiate with other merchants in town for aid for the coming days."

Once we see the village border and the walk back is safe, Riv parts ways with the group and makes his way towards Tomás' farm

Show more

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Walk to Safety

The Walk to Safety

As you guide the group back through the forest, you share your instructions.

Mother Nelle's Response:

She examines the wrapped idol with visible revulsion, her holy symbol growing warm just as yours did. "Malar's work. Twisted and foul." She doesn't touch it. "To destroy it properly, we'll need a consecration ritual—fire blessed by divine magic, holy water, prayers of banishment. It will take time to prepare, perhaps an hour of ritual work."

She looks at you seriously. "But you're right to keep it away from the village for now. If it draws lycanthropes, better they come to wherever you are—out in the open where you can see them coming—than sneaking into town following its call."

Regarding the healing preparations, she nods firmly. "There's a grain storehouse near the village center that's mostly empty this time of year. I'll commandeer it. With what we've gathered today and the supplies from my shrine, I can prepare for perhaps a dozen serious injuries. More if we're lucky." She grips your arm. "But Riv—if you're trying to cure lycanthropes in the middle of combat, you'll need protection. Don't be foolish. Save who you can, but stay alive."

Gerda's Response:

The tavern keeper looks skeptical when you mention Aldric, eyeing him warily. But then she sighs. "Fine. If you vouch for him, Cleric, I'll trust you. He gets a room, a bath, and hot food. But he's helping me organize those stores like you said—I won't have him sitting idle while the rest of us prepare."

She looks at Aldric directly. "You hear that? You work for your keep."

Aldric bows his head respectfully. "Yes, ma'am. Gladly. I... I need to be useful. To make amends."

At the Village Border

After about 15 minutes, you can see the edge of Thornhaven through the trees—fields, the first farmhouses, smoke rising from chimneys. The women look relieved.

Mother Nelle turns to you. "Go. Help Dagmar. We'll prepare the village." She places her hand on your shoulder in blessing. "Lathander's light guide you, child. Return safely."

Aldric looks torn—he clearly wants to help you fight, but he knows he's untrained and would be more liability than asset. "Be careful, Cleric. If they're in human form when you arrive... they'll seem innocent. Trust Dagmar's instincts."

Heading to Tomás's Farm

You break into a jog, heading southeast. The farm is about a mile away—perhaps 15-20 minutes at a quick pace.

As you run, you still have the cursed idol wrapped in your pack. You can feel it there, a cold weight, pulsing with dark energy.

Roll a Perception check (d20 + Wisdom modifier) as you approach the farm.

What do you roll?

You said: 14

14

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 14 + 3 (Wisdom) = 17.

14 + 3 (Wisdom) = 17. Good success.

Approaching Tomás's Farm

As you near the farm, moving through a patch of woods that borders the property, you slow your pace and move more carefully. Your senses are heightened—the idol's presence seems to make you more aware of... wrongness.

What you notice:

The farm looks deceptively peaceful at first glance. You can see:

- The farmhouse, a modest two-story building with smoke coming from the chimney
- A barn, doors partially open
- A fenced pasture with sheep grazing nervously
- A chicken coop

But something is off:

1. The sheep are clustered together at the far end of the pasture, as far from the barn as possible. They're not grazing—they're huddled, afraid.
2. No sign of Dagmar or Finn—but you can see where they entered the tree line to your left, their tracks clear to your trained eye. They would have approached from the north.
3. Three figures near the barn: Two men and a woman, all appearing to be farm workers. One man is chopping wood. The woman is carrying a bucket. The other man is... just standing there. Watching the tree line. Watching where Dagmar would have approached from.
4. Most telling: The chickens in the coop are completely silent. Chickens are never completely silent during the day. They're either dead, or too terrified to make noise.

Then you see it—a subtle movement in the hayloft window of the barn. Someone—or something—is up there. Watching.

Your holy symbol grows warm. A warning.

You're about 150 feet from the farmhouse, concealed in the tree line. You haven't been spotted yet.

What do you do?

You said: I'd like to use my perception to specifically try to find Dagmar or Finn in the trees.

I'd like to use my perception to specifically try to find Dagmar or Finn in the trees. If I can spot them, I can signal that I'm about to try to talk to these "farm workers" and they can have my back. If I can't... well, I'm going to approach anyway, but I would first cast Shield of Faith on myself

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Searching for Dagmar and Finn

Searching for Dagmar and Finn

Smart thinking. You scan the tree line carefully, looking for any sign of your companions.

Roll another Perception check (d20 + Wisdom modifier) to spot them.

What do you roll?

You said: 15

15

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $15 + 3$ (Wisdom) = 18.

$15 + 3$ (Wisdom) = 18. Excellent.

Spotting Your Allies

Your trained eye catches it—a subtle shift in the shadows about 80 feet to your left, north of your position. Dagmar, crouched behind a fallen log with excellent cover. Her bow is drawn, arrow nocked, aimed at the man who's just standing and watching.

About 20 feet from her, Finn is positioned behind a thick oak tree, also with bow ready.

They haven't moved in because they're waiting. Observing. Dagmar is too experienced to rush in without understanding the situation.

You catch Dagmar's eye. She sees you and makes a subtle hand signal:

- Points at the three figures near the barn (danger)
- Points at the hayloft window (unknown/watching)
- Makes a "wait" gesture

Then she notices you're about to move and her eyes narrow. She makes another signal—asking what your plan is.

You signal back: talking (pointing to yourself, then making a speaking gesture toward the farm workers).

Dagmar grimaces but nods. She and Finn will cover you. She points to herself, then makes an arrow-drawing gesture—we've got you.

Casting Shield of Faith

You whisper the prayer to Lathander, and a faint shimmer of divine protection settles over you like morning mist.

Shield of Faith active: AC 18 for 10 minutes (concentration) Spell slots remaining: 2/3 first-level slots

The three figures haven't noticed you yet. The man chopping wood continues his work. The woman with the bucket is heading toward the farmhouse. The watching man remains still, his gaze fixed on the tree line where Dagmar first approached.

How do you want to approach and what will you say?

You said: I walk directly out of the trees towards them, speaking loudly and clearly.

I walk directly out of the trees towards them, speaking loudly and clearly. "Hail! I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. How are you this day?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Confrontation

The Confrontation

You step out of the tree line confidently, your holy symbol visible on your chest, catching the afternoon sunlight. Your voice rings out clear and friendly across the farmyard.

All three figures freeze.

The man chopping wood stops mid-swing. The woman with the bucket turns sharply. But it's the watching man who reacts most tellingly—his head snaps toward you with unnatural speed, and for just a moment, you see his eyes. They're wrong. Too bright. Too focused. Predatory.

Then he composes himself, forcing his posture to relax. When he speaks, his voice is carefully casual, but there's something strained underneath:

"Cleric. Wasn't expecting... visitors." He's perhaps thirty years old, lean and muscular, wearing simple farm clothes. "We're well enough. Just doing the day's work. I'm... Gareth. This is my sister Mira, and that's Joff."

The woman—Mira—sets down her bucket slowly. She's younger, maybe mid-twenties, with dark hair. She doesn't speak, just watches you with similar too-bright eyes.

Joff, the one who was chopping wood, is older, grizzled. He rests the axe on his shoulder. "What brings a cleric out to Tomás's farm?" His tone is neutral, but his hand grips the axe handle tightly.

None of them are moving closer to you. They're maintaining distance, watching.

From the farmhouse, you hear a door creak open. A middle-aged man—you recognize Tomás from the tavern—steps out onto the porch. He looks... wrong. His movements are stiff, jerky. His eyes dart between you and the three "workers."

"Cleric Freeborn," Tomás calls out, his voice oddly flat. "What... what can I do for you?"

Behind him, through the open door, you glimpse movement. Someone else is inside.

In the tree line, you know Dagmar has her bow trained on these people.

What do you say or do?

You said: "Tomás, I was so sorry to hear about the loss of your livestock the other night."

"Tomás, I was so sorry to hear about the loss of your livestock the other night. It occurred to me, I never even thought to buy you a drink! I've been traveling for the better part of an hour and I'm thoroughly parched. Might I stop in for a quick sip of something before I make my way back to town?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Tense Gambit

A Tense Gambit

Tomás's face twitches. For a moment, something flickers in his eyes—fear? A plea for help? Then it's gone, replaced by that flat, stiff expression.

"I... yes. Of course. A drink." The words come out stilted, like he's reading from a script. "Come inside. We have... water. Ale."

He doesn't move from the doorway. Just stands there, waiting.

The three "workers" exchange glances. Gareth—the watching man—speaks up quickly:

"Actually, Tomás just asked us to help him move some equipment in the barn. Heavy work. Maybe the cleric could wait out here? We'll just be a minute."

His tone is too insistent. Too controlled.

Mira finally speaks, her voice honey-sweet but wrong: "Yes. You must be tired from your walk, Cleric. Why don't you rest here in the yard? We'll bring you something to drink."

They're trying to separate you from entering the house. Or trying to lure you toward the barn—where someone is watching from the hayloft.

Tomás's jaw clenches. His hands are trembling. "No. The cleric is my guest. He'll... come inside." Each word seems to cost him effort.

Joff shifts his weight, the axe still on his shoulder. "Tomás, we really should—"

"INSIDE." Tomás's voice cracks with sudden force, almost breaking the flat monotone. "Now."

The three "workers" go very still. Gareth's eyes flash with something dangerous.

The situation is balanced on a knife's edge.

What do you do?

You said: Riv smiles, an easy smile with no hint of stress or worry.

Riv smiles, an easy smile with no hint of stress or worry. "Wonderful. Thank you, Tomás. Your hospitality knows no bounds." Walking towards Tomás, Riv says, casually, "Oh, by the way, I caught up to the wolf that ravaged your livestock. Turned out it was just some poor merchant hungry for a night's meal. Lathander's light worked quickly to remove the curse on the young man. Such a shame that it could have been so much worse"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Mask Slips

The Mask Slips

You walk casually toward Tomás, your tone light and conversational. But your words hit like hammer blows.

All three "workers" stiffen visibly. Gareth's friendly facade cracks—his lips pull back slightly, revealing teeth that seem just a bit too sharp. Mira's hand clenches into a fist. Joff's grip on the axe tightens until his knuckles go white.

"You... cured it?" Gareth's voice is no longer trying to sound casual. There's rage underneath, barely controlled. "The merchant?"

Tomás's eyes widen—real emotion breaking through whatever compulsion holds him. Hope. Desperate hope.

"Yes," you say easily, still walking. "Remove Curse. Simple spell, really. Worked beautifully. He's human again, safe in the village."

You're now about 30 feet from the porch. 20 feet from the three "workers" who are positioned between you and Tomás.

Mira speaks, and this time her voice is cold: "That's... unfortunate. Aldric had such potential. The Master will be disappointed."

The pretense is gone.

Gareth takes a deliberate step toward you. "You shouldn't have come here, priest. You shouldn't have interfered."

From the hayloft, you hear a low growl. Not even pretending to be human anymore.

Tomás shouts from the porch: "RUN! CLERIC, THEY'VE GOT MY SON—"

Joff moves with inhuman speed, turning and hurling the axe. Not at you—at Tomás.

INITIATIVE!

Roll initiative: d20 + Dexterity modifier (let's say +1 for a Cleric)

What do you roll?

You said: 15

15

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 15 + 1 (Dexterity) = 16.

15 + 1 (Dexterity) = 16. Solid initiative.

COMBAT - ROUND 1

Initiative Order:

1. Riv (16) - That's you!
2. Dagmar (15) - In the trees with bow
3. Gareth (14) - The leader, transforming
4. Mira (12) - Female werewolf, transforming
5. Joff (10) - Threw the axe
6. Hayloft Werewolf (8) - Unknown
7. Finn (6) - In the trees with bow

The Scene:

- The axe is spinning through the air toward Tomás (30 feet from you)
 - Three werewolves are beginning to transform (20-25 feet from you)
 - Dagmar and Finn have clear shots from the trees
 - You have Shield of Faith active (AC 18)
-

YOUR TURN

You have several options:

Actions:

- Sacred Flame (cantrip) - Target must make Dex save or take 1d8 radiant damage

- Guiding Bolt (1st level spell) - Ranged spell attack, 4d6 radiant damage, next attack has advantage
- Cure Wounds - Heal someone (not useful right now)
- Dash - Move up to 60 feet total
- Ready an action - Prepare to do something when a trigger occurs

Bonus Action:

- None available currently

Movement:

- You can move up to 30 feet

The Question: Do you try to intercept/block the axe heading for Tomás (would require Dash to reach him + possibly an Athletics/Acrobatics check), or do you attack one of the transforming werewolves?

What do you do?

You said: Can I use Sacred Flame on the axe to remove it as an obstacle?

Can I use Sacred Flame on the axe to remove it as an obstacle? Otherwise, will the axe strike Tomás on my turn or at the end of the whole combat round? Could Finn realistically shoot the axe out of the air on his turn? How does the axe throw work?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Great questions!

Great questions! Let me clarify the mechanics:

How the Axe Throw Works:

- Joff made an attack roll when he threw it (this happened just before initiative)
- The axe is already in flight and will hit or miss based on that roll
- It will strike Tomás at the end of Joff's turn (which is coming up after Gareth and Mira)
- You can't use Sacred Flame on an object—it only targets creatures
- Finn could theoretically try to shoot it out of the air on his turn, but that would be an extremely difficult shot (very high DC, probably disadvantage)—and Finn goes after the axe hits

Your realistic options for saving Tomás:

1. Dash to him and try to physically intercept (shield block, push him aside, etc.)—would require moving 30 feet + Dashing another 30 feet to reach the porch, then probably a Dexterity save or Athletics check
2. Let the axe hit and focus on combat—Tomás might survive, might not. You could heal him later if he goes down.
3. Trust that Dagmar might save him—she goes right after you and is a skilled archer. She might try to shoot the axe down or shoot Joff to disrupt the throw somehow (though it's already in flight).

The tactical reality: Trying to save Tomás will cost you your attack this round and might fail anyway, leaving the werewolves free to act.

What do you want to do?

You said: My attack is strong and I can't risk not attacking with 4 hostiles on the field.

My attack is strong and I can't risk not attacking with 4 hostiles on the field. Realizing that Tomás' life may hang on what I do next, I use Sacred Flame on Joff

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Hard Choice

A Hard Choice

You make the tactical decision—four werewolves are too dangerous to ignore. You raise your holy symbol, channeling Lathander's light.

Sacred Flame on Joff:

Radiant light blazes down from above, attempting to engulf the werewolf who threw the axe.

Joff must make a Dexterity saving throw.

- $DC = 8 + \text{your Wisdom modifier (3)} + \text{proficiency bonus (2)} = DC 13$

I'll roll for Joff: He gets a... 9. Failed!

Roll damage: 1d8 radiant damage

What do you roll?

Meanwhile, the axe continues its deadly arc toward Tomás on the porch. The farmer's eyes are wide with terror, frozen in place.

You said: 8!

8! Nice!

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: CRITICAL HIT on the damage!

CRITICAL HIT on the damage! Maximum roll!

Sacred Flame - 8 Radiant Damage

Divine fire erupts around Joff, searing his flesh just as his transformation begins. He screams—a sound that's half-human, half-beast—and stumbles backward, smoke rising from burned skin. The radiant damage disrupts his lycanthropic healing, leaving charred wounds.

He's hurt, but still standing, his body continuing its horrific shift into wolf form.

DAGMAR'S TURN

From the trees, Dagmar makes her choice in a split second. She pivots her aim from Gareth to the flying axe.

"IMPOSSIBLE SHOT!" she mutters, and looses.

I'll roll for her: Attack roll with disadvantage (extremely difficult)... 18 and 11. Takes the lower: 11.

The arrow flies true but misses by inches, passing just under the spinning axe.

The axe strikes Tomás in the shoulder with a sickening thud. He cries out and staggers backward into the doorway, blood spreading across his shirt. He's badly hurt but still conscious.

From inside the house, you hear a child scream: "PAPA!"

Willem. Tomás's son.

GARETH'S TURN

The leader of the pack snarls, his transformation accelerating. Fur erupts across his body, bones crack and reform. In seconds, he's a massive werewolf—gray fur, scarred muzzle, intelligent amber eyes burning with rage.

He charges directly at you, covering the 20 feet in a blur of speed.

Werewolf Bite Attack: I roll: 16 to hit

Your AC is 18 (Shield of Faith). He MISSES!

His jaws snap inches from your throat, but Lathander's protective barrier shimmers, deflecting the attack. Gareth snarls in frustration.

MIRA'S TURN

She completes her transformation—smaller than Gareth, black fur, wickedly fast. She moves to flank you, trying to get around your defenses.

Claw Attack: I roll: 12 to hit

MISS! Your divine shield holds.

JOFF'S TURN

Still smoking from your Sacred Flame, Joff finishes transforming—a massive brown werewolf, older and battle-scarred. He moves toward you to join the pack, but he's still reeling from the radiant damage.

He holds position, snarling, waiting for an opening.

HAYLOFT WEREWOLF'S TURN

A fourth werewolf leaps from the hayloft window—a huge rust-colored beast. It lands in the farmyard with a ground-shaking thud and begins loping toward the fight.

It's 40 feet away—will reach you next round.

FINN'S TURN

"Dagmar, which one?!" Finn shouts.

"THE LEADER!" Dagmar yells back.

Finn looses a silvered arrow at Gareth.

I roll: 14 to hit. Gareth's AC is 13. HIT!

Roll 1d8+3 for Finn's silvered arrow damage.

Actually, I'll roll: 7 damage!

The silvered arrow buries itself in Gareth's shoulder. He howls in pain—silver burns werewolves even in their transformed state.

END OF ROUND 1

Status:

- You: Unharmed, AC 18, Shield of Faith active, 2 spell slots remaining
- Gareth (Leader): 7 damage, wounded, in melee with you
- Mira: Unharmed, in melee with you
- Joff: 8 damage, badly burned, 25 feet away
- Hayloft Werewolf: Unharmed, 40 feet away, approaching
- Tomás: Badly wounded, in doorway
- Willem: Inside house, screaming
- Dagmar & Finn: In trees, 80 feet away

You're surrounded by two werewolves (Gareth and Mira) with two more closing in!

ROUND 2 - YOUR TURN

What do you do?

You said: Do any of my spells do area damage?

Do any of my spells do area damage?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Good tactical thinking!

Good tactical thinking! Let me check your spell list:

Your Available Spells:

Cantrips:

- Sacred Flame - Single target
- Other utility cantrips (Light, Thaumaturgy, etc.)

1st Level Spells (2 slots remaining):

- Guiding Bolt - Single target, ranged attack
- Cure Wounds - Single target healing
- Shield of Faith - Already active (concentration)
- Bless - Buffs allies, not damage
- Sanctuary - Protection spell, not damage

Unfortunately, NO—you don't have any area-of-effect damage spells at your level.

Clerics get spells like Spirit Guardians (area damage) at higher levels, but at level 2, you're limited to single-target damage.

Your Options This Turn:

1. Sacred Flame on Gareth or Mira (1d8 radiant, they make Dex save)
2. Guiding Bolt on one target (4d6 radiant damage, attack roll, gives next attacker advantage)
3. Disengage (action) and retreat toward Dagmar/Finn
4. Dodge (action) - give attackers disadvantage on their attacks against you
5. Attack with your mace (melee weapon attack)
6. Try to reach Tomás to heal him (but you'd have to get past the werewolves)

You're surrounded by Gareth and Mira in melee. Two more werewolves closing in.

What do you want to do?

You said: Let me cast Sacred Flame again on Joff.

Let me cast Sacred Flame again on Joff. Maybe I can take him out

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Focusing Fire on the Wounded

Focusing Fire on the Wounded

Smart strategy—finish off the injured one before he can rejoin the fight!

You raise your holy symbol again, calling down Lathander's burning light on the already-scorched Joff.

Sacred Flame on Joff (25 feet away):

Joff must make a Dexterity saving throw (DC 13).

I'll roll for him: He gets a... 7. Failed again!

The werewolf is still reeling from the first blast—he can't dodge the second.

Roll 1d8 radiant damage!

What do you roll?

You said: 2

2

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Sacred Flame - 2 Radiant Damage

Sacred Flame - 2 Radiant Damage

The holy fire engulfs Joff again, searing his already-burned flesh. He howls in agony, staggering backward. Between the two Sacred Flames, he's taken 10 total radiant damage and is clearly hurting—fur singed, skin blistered, movements sluggish.

But he's still standing, still in the fight. Werewolves are tough.

DAGMAR'S TURN

"Keep hitting that one!" Dagmar shouts, recognizing your strategy. She draws and aims at the wounded Joff.

Silvered Arrow Attack: I roll: 19 to hit—easily hits!

Damage: Rolling 1d8+3... gets 8!

The silvered arrow punches through Joff's chest. He lets out a choking gasp, stumbles, and collapses—the combination of radiant damage and silver too much for even his regeneration.

Joff is DOWN!

"One down!" Dagmar calls. "Three to go!"

GARETH'S TURN

Enraged by Joff's fall and the arrow still embedded in his own shoulder, Gareth attacks you with savage fury.

Bite Attack: I roll: 14 to hit

Your AC is 18. MISS!

Again, your Shield of Faith deflects his jaws at the last second. Gareth is growing increasingly frustrated.

MIRA'S TURN

The black-furred werewolf tries a different approach—going low with her claws.

Claw Attack: I roll: Natural 20! CRITICAL HIT!

Her claws find a gap in your divine protection, raking across your side. You feel searing pain as claws tear through chain mail.

Damage: Rolling 2d4+2 for crit... gets 8 damage!

You take 8 damage!

You're bloodied but still standing. The wound burns—werewolf claws carry a vicious sting.

HAYLOFT WEREWOLF'S TURN

The rust-colored beast closes the distance, now only 10 feet away. Next turn it will be in melee with you.

"THREE ON ONE!" Finn yells desperately. "RIV, GET OUT OF THERE!"

FINN'S TURN

Finn looses another silvered arrow at Gareth.

I roll: 11 to hit. Gareth's AC is 13. MISS!

The arrow flies wide in Finn's panic.

FROM THE FARMHOUSE:

You hear struggling inside—crashing furniture, Willem screaming. Tomás groans from the doorway, trying to get up despite his bleeding shoulder.

END OF ROUND 2

Status:

- You: 8 damage taken, surrounded by 2 werewolves (about to be 3)
 - Gareth: 7 damage, wounded
 - Mira: Unharmed
 - Joff: DOWN/DEAD
 - Hayloft Werewolf: Unharmed, 10 feet away
 - Tomás: Badly wounded in doorway
 - Something happening inside the house
-

ROUND 3 - YOUR TURN

You're badly outnumbered and wounded. What do you do?

You said: I need to signal to Dagmar to get to the house.

I need to signal to Dagmar to get to the house. She probably can't get Tomás to safety, but she could at least try to get Willem away. I'm in a bad position. Werewolves are much stronger and faster than me. But I still have the idol! I can throw it and hope that it distracts them from me for long enough to barricade ourselves in the farmhouse. Would that keep us safe?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Brilliant tactical thinking!

Brilliant tactical thinking! Let me break this down:

Throwing the Idol:

- Yes, you can throw it as part of your action
- The werewolves are under compulsion from it—throwing it away from you should draw their attention
- However, there's uncertainty: will they chase it immediately, or will they finish you off first?
- This is a gamble, but a creative one!

Barricading in the Farmhouse:

- The farmhouse has wooden walls and doors—werewolves are incredibly strong and can break through wood
- It would buy you TIME (maybe 1-2 rounds before they break in), but not permanent safety

- However, time might be enough for Dagmar to get closer, or for you to heal/reposition

Signaling Dagmar:

- You could shout to her as part of your turn (free action)
- She's 80 feet away—it would take her several rounds of dashing to reach the house
- BUT she could start moving that direction and provide covering fire

Alternative consideration:

- There's also whatever is happening INSIDE the house with Willem—you don't know if there's a 5th threat in there
-

So your plan would be:

1. Shout to Dagmar about the house/Willem
2. Throw the idol away from you (maybe toward the barn or into the field)
3. Dash toward the farmhouse (you can move 30 feet normally + 30 feet with Dash = 60 feet total, easily reaching the porch)
4. Hope the werewolves chase the idol instead of you

Does this sound right? If so, let's do it! Where do you want to throw the idol?

You said: Let's do this instead: let's keep fighting.

Let's do this instead: let's keep fighting. I still have guiding bolt which I already know does a huge amount of damage. Surely I can remove one more of the werewolves with that, and hopefully Dagmar or Finn can get to the farmhouse.

"Finn! Something's happening in the farmhouse! Get in there! That boy needs our help!"

I launch my guiding bolt at the Hayloft Werewolf

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Standing Your Ground

Standing Your Ground

You make the call—trust your companions to save Willem while you hold the line. This is what clerics do.

"FINN! SOMETHING'S HAPPENING IN THE FARMHOUSE! GET IN THERE! THAT BOY NEEDS OUR HELP!" you shout, your voice ringing across the battlefield.

From the trees, you hear Finn respond: "ON IT!"

Guiding Bolt at the Hayloft Werewolf:

You channel divine energy, your holy symbol blazing bright. A bolt of radiant light streaks toward the rust-colored werewolf that's just closed in on you.

Make a ranged spell attack: Roll 1d20 + your Wisdom modifier (3) + proficiency bonus (2)

What do you roll?

(The werewolf's AC is 13, so you need 8 or higher to hit)

You said: 12

12

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $12 + 3 \text{ (Wisdom)} + 2 \text{ (Proficiency)} = 17$.

$12 + 3 \text{ (Wisdom)} + 2 \text{ (Proficiency)} = 17$. Solid HIT!

Guiding Bolt - STRIKE!

The bolt of pure radiant energy slams into the rust-colored werewolf's chest just as it closes in on you. The creature screams—a sound of pure agony—as holy light burns through fur and flesh.

Roll 4d6 radiant damage!

What do you roll?

You said: 3, 2, 2, 6

3, 2, 2, 6

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Guiding Bolt - 13 Radiant Damage!

Guiding Bolt - 13 Radiant Damage!

The radiant bolt explodes against the rust-colored werewolf's chest, burning a smoking crater through its torso. The creature staggers, howling in pain, its fur singed and flesh seared. It's badly wounded but still standing—barely.

And the next attack against it has advantage! (Guiding Bolt effect)

Spell slots remaining: 1/3 first-level slots

DAGMAR'S TURN

Dagmar sees the glowing mark your Guiding Bolt left on the rust-colored werewolf and doesn't hesitate.

"I've got the marked one!"

Silvered Arrow with ADVANTAGE: I roll: 17 and 14. Takes the 17—HIT!

Damage: Rolling 1d8+3... gets 9!

The silvered arrow buries itself in the werewolf's throat. Combined with your massive radiant damage, it's too much. The creature gurgles, collapses to its knees, and falls face-first into the dirt.

Rust-Colored Werewolf is DOWN!

"TWO DOWN!" Dagmar shouts triumphantly. "Two to go!"

GARETH'S TURN

The pack leader is enraged now—two of his pack dead, and this priest keeps surviving. He lunges at you with desperate fury.

Bite Attack: I roll: 19 to hit

Your AC is 18. That's a HIT!

His massive jaws clamp down on your shoulder. You feel teeth pierce through chain mail, grinding against bone. The pain is excruciating.

Damage: Rolling 1d8+2... gets 7 damage!

You take 7 damage! Total damage: 15

You're seriously hurt now, vision swimming with pain.

MIRA'S TURN

Seeing you wounded, Mira presses the attack.

Claw Attack: I roll: 13 to hit

Your AC is 18. MISS!

Shield of Faith saves you again—her claws scrape harmlessly off the divine barrier.

FINN'S TURN

True to his word, Finn breaks from cover and sprints toward the farmhouse, bow in hand. He's 80 feet away—he'll need multiple rounds to get there.

"I'M COMING, WILLEM!" he shouts.

FROM THE FARMHOUSE:

The crashing inside continues. You hear Willem scream again: "GET AWAY FROM ME!"

Tomás, bleeding from his shoulder, tries to crawl back inside. "My son... my son..."

END OF ROUND 3

Status:

- You: 15 damage taken (BADLY WOUNDED), surrounded by 2 werewolves, 1 spell slot left
 - Gareth: 7 damage, wounded, in melee with you
 - Mira: Unharmed, in melee with you
 - Joff: DOWN
 - Hayloft Werewolf: DOWN
 - Tomás: Badly wounded, crawling into house
 - Finn: Sprinting toward farmhouse (60 feet away)
 - Dagmar: In trees, providing covering fire
 - Unknown threat inside farmhouse with Willem
-

ROUND 4 - YOUR TURN

You're badly hurt and still surrounded by two werewolves. You have one spell slot left. What do you do?

Options:

- One more Sacred Flame (conserve your last spell slot)

- Guiding Bolt with your last spell slot (big damage)
- Cure Wounds on yourself (heal 1d8+3)
- Disengage and run for the farmhouse
- Something else?

What's your move?

You said: Guiding bolt on Gareth

Guiding bolt on Gareth

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: All In

All In

You're not backing down. One more big hit—finish the leader.

Blood streaming from your shoulder, you raise your holy symbol with a shaking hand and channel the last of your divine power into a blazing bolt of radiant energy aimed at Gareth.

Guiding Bolt at Gareth:

Make a ranged spell attack: Roll 1d20 + 5 (Wisdom + Proficiency)

What do you roll?

(Need 8+ to hit AC 13)

You said: 11

11

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 11 + 5 = 16.

11 + 5 = 16. HIT!

Guiding Bolt - STRIKE!

At point-blank range, you can't miss. The radiant bolt slams into Gareth's chest, right where Finn's silvered arrow is still embedded. The werewolf leader's eyes go wide with shock and pain.

Roll 4d6 radiant damage!

What do you roll?

You said: 5, 6, 5, 1

5, 6, 5, 1

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Guiding Bolt - 17 Radiant Damage!

Guiding Bolt - 17 Radiant Damage!

The radiant energy detonates inside Gareth's chest cavity. His howl cuts off abruptly as holy light burns through him from the inside out. The massive gray werewolf staggers backward, smoke pouring from his mouth and the wound in his chest.

He drops to one knee, then collapses sideways. His body twitches once, twice, then goes still.

Gareth is DOWN!

The pack leader is dead.

Spell slots remaining: 0/3 first-level slots

MIRA'S REACTION

The black-furred werewolf stares at her fallen leader, then at you—this bloodied, half-dead cleric who just killed three werewolves. You can see the calculation in her intelligent eyes.

Fear.

She's alone now. Outnumbered.

DAGMAR'S TURN

"LAST ONE! MIRA, YOU'RE SURROUNDED!" Dagmar shouts, drawing another silvered arrow.
"SURRENDER OR DIE!"

She looses the arrow.

Silvered Arrow Attack: I roll: 16 to hit—HIT!

Damage: Rolling 1d8+3... gets 7 damage!

The arrow strikes Mira in the side. She yelps in pain, spinning to face this new threat.

MIRA'S TURN

Wounded, alone, pack dead, Mira makes her choice.

She runs.

The werewolf breaks away from you, sprinting at incredible speed toward the forest edge—not toward Dagmar's position, but in the opposite direction. She's fast. Inhumanly fast.

"She's running!" Dagmar shouts. "Do we pursue?"

FINN'S TURN

Finn reaches the farmhouse porch, nearly stumbling over the wounded Tomás.

"Where's Willem?!"

Tomás points weakly inside. "Upstairs... locked himself in... something was chasing him..."

Finn bursts through the door.

COMBAT PAUSED

The immediate threat is over. Three werewolves dead, one fled. But:

- You're at 15 damage and have no spell slots left
- Tomás is badly wounded from the axe
- Willem is inside, possibly in danger
- Mira is escaping into the forest
- You still have the cursed idol

What do you do?

You said: I need to heal myself and I need to heal Tomás.

I need to heal myself and I need to heal Tomás. Dagmar needs to go inside with Finn to check on Willem

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Triage and Assessment

Triage and Assessment

You stagger toward the porch, pain lancing through your shoulder with every step. Your chain mail is torn and blood-soaked.

"Dagmar! Inside! Help Finn with Willem!" you call out, your voice hoarse.

Dagmar doesn't hesitate. She slings her bow and sprints toward the farmhouse, covering the distance quickly. "On it!" She disappears through the door.

Healing Options - The Problem:

You kneel beside Tomás on the porch. He's pale, breathing shallowly, the axe wound in his shoulder still bleeding.

Your situation:

- 0 spell slots left - No Cure Wounds available
- Healer's Kit: 9/10 uses remaining
- Blessed water (3 vials) - Not for healing living creatures
- Healing herbs from Mother Nelle - Can help stabilize/treat wounds

Using the Healer's Kit:

With your healer's kit and the medicinal herbs, you can:

1. Stabilize Tomás - Stop the bleeding, bandage the wound (Medicine check)
2. Treat yourself - Bandage your own wounds (Medicine check, but treating yourself is harder)

You can't restore hit points without magic, but you can stop the bleeding and prevent things from getting worse.

From Inside:

You hear Dagmar's voice: "Finn, upstairs! I hear him!"

Footsteps pounding up stairs. Then Finn's voice: "Willem! It's okay! We're here to help!"

A muffled child's voice: "Is it gone? Is the monster gone?"

What do you do first - treat Tomás or yourself?

(Roll Medicine check: d20 + Wisdom modifier, with advantage from the healing herbs)

You said: Treat myself

Treat myself

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Self-Treatment

Self-Treatment

You grit your teeth and pull out your healer's kit. Your hands are shaking from blood loss, but you need to be functional if there's more danger ahead.

You use the medicinal herbs Mother Nelle gave you, pressing poultices against the deep bite wound on your shoulder and the claw marks on your side. The herbs sting but immediately begin drawing out infection.

Medicine Check to treat yourself (with advantage from healing herbs):

Roll 2d20 + your Wisdom modifier (+3), take the higher result

What do you roll?

You said: 17

17

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 17 + 3 (Wisdom) = 20.

17 + 3 (Wisdom) = 20. Excellent success!

Expert Field Medicine

Despite the pain and your shaking hands, your training takes over. You work with practiced efficiency:

- Clean the wounds with water from your waterskin
- Apply the medicinal poultices to draw out any lycanthropic contamination from the bites
- Bind everything tightly with clean bandages
- Use a makeshift sling to support your injured shoulder

The bleeding stops. The pain dulls to a manageable throb. You won't be at full strength, but you can function.

While you can't restore hit points without magic, your wounds are stabilized and won't get worse. The excellent roll means you've minimized the risk of infection or lycanthropic curse transmission.

Healer's Kit: 8/10 uses remaining

Treating Tomás

You turn to the farmer, who's watching you with glazed eyes. The axe wound is serious—deep into the shoulder muscle, still bleeding.

Medicine Check for Tomás (with advantage from healing herbs):

Roll 2d20 + 3, take the higher result

What do you roll?

You said: 17

17

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 17 + 3 (Wisdom) = 20.

17 + 3 (Wisdom) = 20. Another excellent success!

Saving Tomás

You work quickly on the farmer. The axe wound is deep and dangerous—it could have killed him if left untreated. But your hands are steady now, your training sharp.

- Remove torn fabric from the wound
- Apply pressure to stop the bleeding
- Pack the wound with healing herbs and poultices
- Bind it tightly with bandages
- Fashion a sling to immobilize his arm

Tomás gasps as you work, but color begins returning to his face. The bleeding stops. He'll need proper rest and care, but he'll survive.

"Thank you... Cleric," he whispers hoarsely. "My son... is Willem...?"

Healer's Kit: 7/10 uses remaining

From Upstairs

You hear a door opening, then Finn's gentle voice: "It's okay, Willem. Come on out. The clerics and hunters killed the monsters. You're safe now."

Footsteps on the stairs. Dagmar emerges first, her expression grim but relieved. Behind her, Finn is carrying Willem—the boy is maybe seven years old, tear-streaked, trembling, but physically unharmed.

When Willem sees his father, he breaks from Finn and runs to Tomás. "PAPA!"

"I'm okay, son. I'm okay," Tomás says weakly, wrapping his good arm around the boy.

Dagmar's Report

Dagmar approaches you, keeping her voice low. "There was a fifth werewolf. In the house. It chased Willem upstairs, but when the pack leader died outside..." She gestures. "It transformed back to human form. Dead. Just... collapsed."

She looks at you seriously. "It's still upstairs. Human now. Male, maybe late twenties. Never seen him before—not from Thornhaven."

"When the alpha dies, sometimes the compulsion breaks," she continues. "The weaker ones can't sustain the transformation. This one's heart just... stopped."

The Situation:

- Three werewolves dead outside (Gareth, Joff, Hayloft werewolf)
- One dead upstairs (fifth werewolf, died when Gareth fell)
- Mira escaped into the forest
- You and Tomás are stabilized but wounded
- Willem is safe but traumatized
- The cursed idol is still in your pack
- Sunset is approaching (maybe 2-3 hours of daylight left)

What do you want to do?

You said: To Dagmar and Finn: "Let's pile the bodies and burn them."

To Dagmar and Finn: "Let's pile the bodies and burn them. Do a brief perimeter sweep and just make sure everything is locked down. We'll have to take Tomás and Willem back to the village with us when we head out."

To Tomás: "Where is your wife? We'll be leaving to head back to the village as soon as we clean up here. Pack a bag - you'll have to come with us"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Securing the Farm

Securing the Farm

Dagmar nods grimly. "Agreed. We'll burn them—can't risk anyone stumbling on werewolf corpses and getting ideas about curses or trophies." She and Finn head outside to begin dragging the bodies into a pile.

Tomás's Answer

The farmer's face falls at your question. He holds Willem closer, and you see the boy bury his face in his father's good shoulder.

"She... she died two years ago," Tomás says quietly. "Fever took her. It's just been Willem and me since then." He looks around at his farm—the home he's built, the life he's tried to maintain. "This place is all we have."

But he sees the logic in your eyes and nods reluctantly. "You're right. We'll pack. Just... give me a few minutes to grab what we need."

Willem looks up at you with wide, frightened eyes. "Are the monsters really gone? All of them?"

You think of Mira, fled into the forest. Of the "Master" who sent them. Of the larger threat Aldric warned about.

What do you tell the boy?

Outside

You hear Dagmar and Finn working—the sound of bodies being dragged across dirt. Then Finn calls out: "Found oil in the barn! Should burn clean!"

The sun is lower in the sky now. Maybe two and a half hours until sunset.

Do you:

1. Help with burning the bodies
2. Check the upstairs corpse yourself
3. Do a perimeter sweep

4. Help Tomás and Willem pack
5. Something else?

You said: Riv doesn't tell the boy anything.

Riv doesn't tell the boy anything. Just pats his shoulder as he and his father start to pack. Riv heads upstairs to retrieve the other body for the burn pile. It'll give him a chance to examine the body himself

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Upstairs

Upstairs

You climb the narrow farmhouse stairs, each step sending dull pain through your wounded shoulder. The second floor is modest—two bedrooms and a small storage area.

You find the body in Willem's room. The door hangs open, a chair wedged under the handle from the inside—the boy's desperate attempt to keep the monster out.

The Fifth Werewolf

The corpse lies sprawled on the floor near the doorway, naked as all werewolves are when they transform back. Male, as Dagmar said, perhaps late twenties. Brown hair, lean build, several old scars across his torso.

His face is frozen in an expression of shock and pain. Whatever killed him happened fast—the moment Gareth died outside, this one's heart simply stopped.

Roll an Investigation check (d20 + Intelligence modifier, let's say +0 for a Wisdom-focused Cleric) to examine the body more closely.

What do you roll?

You said: 10

10

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 10 + 0 (Intelligence) = 10.

10 + 0 (Intelligence) = 10. Moderate success.

Examining the Body

You kneel beside the corpse, studying it carefully.

What you notice:

1. No personal effects - He was naked when he transformed, and there are no clothes, weapons, or belongings nearby. If he had gear, it's either outside or he arrived with nothing.
2. Ritual scarring - On his chest, partially hidden by other scars, you see deliberate cuts forming symbols. They're crude but recognizable: the same profane runes of Malar that were on the cursed idol. These were carved into his flesh, likely part of the ritual that turned him into a werewolf.
3. Recent feeding - His mouth and chin have dried blood. Not human blood—animal. He'd been hunting recently, probably livestock.
4. Cause of death - No visible wounds. His heart simply stopped when the alpha died. The compulsion binding him to Gareth was so strong that breaking it killed him.
5. He's thin - Not starving, but lean. He hasn't been eating well. Living rough, like Aldric was.

What strikes you most: This wasn't a volunteer. The scarring, the compulsion, the way he died—this was someone forced into lycanthropy and enslaved by the cult's magic. A victim, like Aldric. Like Marcus.

From Downstairs:

You hear Tomás and Willem moving around, gathering belongings. The sounds of a life being hastily packed.

Outside:

Smoke begins to rise. Dagmar and Finn have started the pyre.

What do you do with this body?

You said: I haul the body to the pyre.

I haul the body to the pyre. Once I dump the body, I check if the farmer is ready to go, and ask him if there's anything in the house that might help us fortify the village when the time comes.

Does Dagmar find anything in her perimeter sweep?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Pyre

The Pyre

You wrap the body in a sheet from Willem's room—the boy won't want it back anyway—and haul it downstairs. The corpse is surprisingly light; the man was lean, half-starved.

Outside, the fire is already roaring. Dagmar and Finn have built a proper pyre with wood from the barn. The three werewolf corpses are already burning, the smell acrid and unpleasant. You add the fourth body to the flames.

"May Lathander grant you peace," you murmur, despite everything. "You were enslaved. Not willing."

Dagmar's Perimeter Sweep

Dagmar approaches, wiping soot from her hands. "Checked the barn, the fields, the tree line. No sign of Mira—she's long gone, heading north by my read of the tracks. Found something else though."

She holds up a leather satchel. "Hidden in the barn loft. Belonged to the pack."

Inside you find:

- A crude map showing Thornhaven, Tomás's farm, and several other isolated farmsteads marked with X's
- Dried meat (rations, possibly human origin—you don't examine too closely)
- Three vials of dark liquid - you recognize these: alchemical potions that temporarily enhance transformation. Malar cultists use them.
- A symbol carved in wood - another Malar token, smaller than your idol

"They were planning to hit multiple farms," Dagmar says grimly. "Systematic. Turn the farmers, then move on the village center when they had enough numbers."

Tomás's Supplies

You head inside. Tomás has packed two bags and is helping Willem into a warm coat.

"Is there anything here that might help us fortify the village?" you ask.

Tomás thinks, then nods. "In the barn—tools. Hammers, nails, lumber I was saving for repairs. Not much, but..." He pauses. "And my hunting crossbow. Three dozen bolts. Willem's mother was a better shot than I ever was, but I kept it."

He looks around his home one last time. "The livestock—the sheep. I can't take them. If we're abandoning the farm..."

The sheep are still huddled in the far pasture, terrified but alive.

The Sun

Lower now. Maybe two hours until sunset.

Options:

- Take the tools and crossbow, leave the sheep
- Try to herd the sheep back to the village (would take significant time)
- Something else?

And do you want to examine that crude map more closely, or head back immediately?

You said: We'll examine the map when we're back at the Inn.

We'll examine the map when we're back at the Inn. I put it in my pack and we grab the tools and the crossbow, as well as the idol, and the dark liquid. As much as I'd like to herd the sheep back with us, it's almost dark and we've got two wounded and a child in our care. We have to get back to the village center.

"Tomás, I will make this up to you. The light of Lathander will shine on your farm once again. I promise you. For now, we must make our way to the village center so we can prepare for what's to come." We start our journey back to the village, hoping to arrive before sundown.

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Journey Home

The Journey Home

Tomás nods, his jaw tight as he takes one last look at his farm—his home, his life's work. Willem clutches his father's hand, a small bag slung over his shoulder.

You gather the supplies:

- Tools, lumber, nails from the barn
- Tomás's hunting crossbow and bolts
- The satchel with the map, dark potions, and Malar symbol
- The cursed idol (still wrapped, still pulsing with dark energy)

Finn and Dagmar help distribute the load. Everyone carries something.

"Let's move," Dagmar says, scanning the darkening sky. "Double time. I want walls around us before nightfall."

The March Back

Your group sets off toward Thornhaven:

- You and Tomás are wounded but mobile
- Willem walks between his father and Finn, the young hunter keeping the boy's spirits up with quiet conversation
- Dagmar takes point, bow ready, eyes constantly scanning
- The pyre burns behind you, sending dark smoke into the twilight sky

The journey is about 1.5 miles, roughly 30-40 minutes at a quick pace with wounded and a child.

As You Walk

The forest feels different now. Watching. The unnatural silence you noticed this morning is even more pronounced as evening approaches.

Halfway back, Dagmar holds up a fist. Everyone stops.

"Tracks," she whispers, kneeling. "Wolf. Big. Crossing our path maybe... thirty minutes ago."

She looks up at you, her expression grim. "Heading toward the village. Not Mira—different size. This is a sixth one."

Finn's face goes pale. "How many are there?"

Aldric's words echo in your mind: "I heard howling. Far to the north. Multiple voices. Pack hunting."

Dagmar makes a decision: "We keep moving. Fast. No stopping."

The group picks up the pace, practically jogging now despite the burden and the wounded.

Approaching Thornhaven

As the village comes into view through the trees, you see:

- Smoke rising from the village center (cooking fires, hopefully)
- Figures moving on the perimeter (guards that Garrick organized?)

- The sun touching the horizon (maybe 20 minutes until full dark)

You're almost there.

Then you hear it—from the village—a bell ringing. Sharp, urgent. The alarm.

Dagmar breaks into a run. "MOVE! NOW!"

You reach the village edge just as the sun sets behind the western hills.

What do you see?

You said: Barricades are up and Riv sees Garrick behind them pointing out into the darkness, directly at our party.

Barricades are up and Riv sees Garrick behind them pointing out into the darkness, directly at our party. We're pulled in past the barricades around the center of town.

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Into the Fortified Village

Into the Fortified Village

As you burst from the tree line, multiple crossbows and bows swing toward you—then recognition hits.

"HOLD! IT'S RIV!" Garrick's voice booms. "OPEN THE GATE!"

Hastily constructed barricades—wagons, lumber, furniture—have been pulled across the main approaches to the village center. Villagers armed with whatever they could find stand behind them: pitchforks, axes, kitchen knives, Tomás's donated tools already being put to use.

Hands reach out, pulling you through a gap in the barricades. Tomás and Willem are ushered in. Finn and Dagmar slip through, and the gap is immediately sealed behind you with a heavy cart.

The Village Center

You're in the heart of Thornhaven now, the area protected by the ward you and Mother Nelle created last night. Perhaps fifty villagers are gathered here—everyone who made it in before dark. You see:

- Elder Wren directing people, her voice steady despite obvious fear
- Mother Nelle moving between the makeshift healing station (the grain storehouse) and the shrine, her arms full of supplies

- Gerda organizing food distribution from the tavern
- Aldric, cleaned up and in borrowed clothes, helping reinforce barricades alongside other men
- Armed villagers at every approach, watching the darkness

Garrick rushes over to you, relief flooding his face. "Thank the gods. We heard the bell at Tomás's farm—saw the smoke. Thought the worst."

Then he sees Tomás's shoulder, your wounds, the grim expressions on everyone's faces.

"How many?" he asks quietly.

"Four dead. One escaped," Dagmar reports. "But there's more. At least one more heading this way. Maybe more than that."

The Bell

"Why did you ring the alarm?" you ask.

Garrick points into the darkness beyond the barricades. "Movement in the forest. Multiple contacts. They're circling us. Started maybe ten minutes ago."

As if to punctuate his words, you hear it—a howl. Long, mournful, intelligent. From the north.

Then another answers it. From the east.

Then a third. From the south.

They're surrounding the village.

Elder Wren approaches, her weathered face grave. "Cleric Freeborn. Garrick told us everything. About the cult, the pack, the threat." She looks at the frightened villagers. "We've prepared as best we could. But night has fallen."

Mother Nelle joins you, her eyes going immediately to your wounds. "Riv, you're hurt. Come with me—"

But before she can finish, Aldric calls out from a barricade: "CLERIC! You need to see this!"

You move to where he's pointing.

Just beyond the torchlight, at the edge of the forest, figures are emerging. Tall. Fur-covered. Amber eyes reflecting the firelight.

Werewolves. Five of them. Standing in a line. Watching.

And in the center, smaller, black-furred: Mira.

They're not attacking. Just... waiting.

What do you do?

You said: To Mother Nelle: "We have to cleanse these totems."

To Mother Nelle: "We have to cleanse these totems. I have two now. With our barrier up, the werewolves shouldn't attack us; but so long as these totems are in town, we risk everything."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Totems

The Totems

Mother Nelle's eyes widen as you pull out the wrapped bundle—the large cursed idol from Aldric's cave—and the smaller wooden token from the satchel.

Even through the wrappings, she can feel their malevolent energy. Her holy symbol grows warm in response.

"You brought them HERE?" she hisses, then catches herself. "No, you're right. Better here where we can destroy them under the ward's protection than out there drawing more of them to scattered farms."

She looks at the werewolves waiting in the darkness, then at the gathered villagers. "But if we perform the cleansing ritual now, it will take time. An hour, perhaps more. And it will be... loud. Bright. The divine fire needed to burn away Malar's corruption—it will draw their attention."

Aldric overhears and turns, his face pale. "She's right. When I had that idol, it whispered to me constantly. If you destroy it, they'll know. They'll feel it. It might provoke them to attack."

Garrick grips his sword. "Then we hold the line while you work. How long do you need?"

Mother Nelle calculates quickly. "With both of us working together? Forty-five minutes for a proper consecration. Maybe thirty if we rush it, but rushing risks failure."

The Situation:

- Five werewolves (including Mira) are currently visible, watching from the forest
- More may be out there based on the howls and tracks

- Your ward protects the village center but won't hold forever
 - Destroying the totems will take 30-45 minutes and will definitely alert the pack
 - You have no spell slots left and are wounded
 - It's full dark now
-

Elder Wren speaks up: "Or we wait until dawn. Fight defensively through the night, then perform the ritual in daylight when we can see them coming."

Dagmar counters: "Every hour we wait, more of them could arrive. That 'Master' could send reinforcements. We hit them now, while we know how many there are."

What's your call, Cleric?

You said: "Dagmar is right."

"Dagmar is right. We can't risk this turning into a full siege tonight. We need to destroy these totems and take the time to prepare a proper defense. Fighting them on their terms will doom us all. Garrick, Dagmar, can you hold the line while we work?"

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: The Decision Made

The Decision Made

Garrick pounds his fist against his shield. "Aye. We'll hold. Whatever comes."

Dagmar nods grimly, checking her remaining silvered arrows. "I've got four arrows left. Finn has three. We make every shot count." She raises her voice to the defenders: "ARCHERS TO THE BARRICADES! Anyone who can loose a bolt, get ready!"

The villagers scramble into position. You see fear in their eyes, but also determination. This is their home.

Mother Nelle takes charge: "Riv, with me. We do this in the shrine—it's the most consecrated ground we have."

She turns to Gerda: "Bring oil, lots of it. And torch fuel. We'll need fire."

To Aldric: "You—gather every holy symbol we carved today. We'll need them for the circle."

Everyone moves with purpose.

The Shrine

Mother Nelle leads you into the small shrine of Chauntea. She's already prepared—herbs, blessed water, candles arranged in a circle. The wooden holy symbols Aldric brings are placed at cardinal points.

You unwrap the cursed idol and the wooden token, placing them in the center of the circle. Even here, in sacred space, they radiate wrongness. The candle flames flicker and dim.

"We do this together," Mother Nelle says, taking your hand. "Your strength with mine. Lathander's dawn fire and Chauntea's nurturing earth. We'll burn away this corruption."

She begins the prayer in Old Common, and you join her, your voice interweaving with hers.

Outside

As your ritual begins, the air itself seems to change. The werewolves at the forest edge react.

They begin to pace. To snarl. Mira throws her head back and howls—a signal.

From deeper in the forest, answering howls. More than before.

Garrick grips his sword tighter. "Here they come."

Roll a Religion check for the ritual (d20 + Wisdom modifier + Proficiency bonus). Mother Nelle is helping, giving you advantage.

Roll 2d20 + 5, take the higher result.

Meanwhile, the battle begins outside...

What do you roll?

You said: 12

12

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: 12 + 5 = 17.

12 + 5 = 17. Strong success.

The Ritual Begins

Your voices rise together, prayers flowing in ancient cadence. The candles flare brighter despite the malevolent presence of the totems. Golden light—Lathander's dawn—begins to fill the shrine, mixing with the warm green glow of Chauntea's blessing.

The cursed idol screams. Not with sound, but with psychic pressure. You feel it pushing against your mind, trying to break your concentration.

Mother Nelle squeezes your hand. "Hold fast, child! We're breaking its grip!"

The wooden totems begin to smoke, black tendrils of corrupted magic writhing as holy fire consumes them.

Time remaining: ~30 minutes if you maintain this pace.

Outside - The First Wave

The werewolves charge.

Five visible werewolves burst from the tree line, sprinting toward the barricades with supernatural speed. Mira leads them, her black fur a shadow in the torchlight.

"LOOSE!" Dagmar shouts.

A volley of arrows and crossbow bolts flies into the darkness.

Dagmar's shot: I roll: 18. HIT! Her silvered arrow takes one werewolf in the chest. It stumbles but keeps coming.

Finn's shot: I roll: 14. HIT! Another arrow finds its mark.

Villager crossbows: Rolling for the group... mixed results. Two more hits, minor damage.

The werewolves crash into the barricades. Claws tear at wood. Garrick meets the first one over the wall with his silvered sword—CLANG—blade meets claw in a shower of sparks.

"HOLD THE LINE!" he roars.

In the Shrine - 5 Minutes In

The totems are beginning to crack, fissures of golden light spreading across their surface. But the psychic pressure intensifies. You feel something pushing back—not just the totems, but something distant. Aware.

The Master.

A presence touches your mind briefly—cold, ancient, hungry.

"Priest. You meddle in affairs beyond your understanding."

Then it's gone, but the message is clear: You've been noticed.

Constitution saving throw to maintain concentration despite the psychic assault:

Roll d20 + Constitution modifier (let's say +2 for a Cleric)

What do you roll?

You said: 19!

19!

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $19 + 2 = 21$.

$19 + 2 = 21$. Exceptional success!

Unshakeable Faith

The cold presence recoils from your mind like a hand thrust into flame. Your faith is a fortress—Lathander's light burns so brightly within you that the Master's psychic touch cannot find purchase.

"You want to see what's beyond my understanding?" you think back, defiant. "Watch me burn your corruption to ASH."

The totems crack audibly, golden light pouring from the fissures like molten metal. The shrine blazes with divine radiance so bright that light spills through the windows, illuminating the battle outside.

Mother Nelle gasps in awe. "Riv... your faith... I've never seen..."

The ritual accelerates. What should take 30 minutes might take only 20 with this intensity.

Time remaining: ~15 minutes.

Outside - The Battle Intensifies

The sudden flare of divine light from the shrine stuns the werewolves momentarily. They recoil, snarling, shielding their eyes.

"NOW!" Garrick seizes the moment, vaulting the barricade with his silvered sword. He drives the blade deep into the wounded werewolf's side. The creature shrieks and collapses.

One werewolf DOWN.

But the reprieve is brief. From the forest, more howls. And then you hear it—heavy footfalls. Something bigger than the others is coming.

Aldric, standing at a barricade with a pitchfork, goes white. "No. No no no. That sound... I know that sound..."

From the darkness emerges a massive werewolf, easily nine feet tall, covered in scarred gray fur. Its eyes burn with intelligence and malice. Around its neck: a crude collar made of bones and carved with Malar's symbols.

An Alpha. Sent by the Master.

Dagmar takes one look and her voice cracks slightly: "Cleric... how much longer?!"

In the Shrine - 10 Minutes In

The totems are almost destroyed, but this final phase is the most dangerous. The corruption fights hardest when it's dying.

Dark smoke fills the shrine. Whispers in a language you don't recognize. Promises of power. Threats of suffering.

Mother Nelle is struggling now, sweat beading on her forehead. "Riv... it's fighting back... I can barely..."

You need to finish this. Another Religion check (with advantage from Mother Nelle's aid, though she's weakening):

Roll 2d20 + 5, take the higher.

What do you roll?

You said: 19

19

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: $19 + 5 = 24$.

$19 + 5 = 24$. CRITICAL SUCCESS!

Divine Annihilation

Your prayer becomes a roar of holy fire. The shrine explodes with golden radiance so intense that the windows shatter outward, showering the village square with blessed glass that glitters like stars.

"BY LATHANDER'S ETERNAL DAWN, I CAST YOU OUT!"

The totems don't just break—they disintegrate. The cursed idol and wooden token explode into ash and divine flame. The corruption is obliterated, not just cleansed. Every trace of Malar's influence burns away in an instant.

The psychic scream that follows is felt by every lycanthrope for miles.

Mother Nelle staggers, catching herself on the altar. "Merciful gods... Riv, what you just did..."

The wave of divine energy pulses outward from the shrine like a shockwave of dawn light, washing over the entire village center. Every shadow flees. Every corrupted thing recoils.

The ritual is complete. The totems are DESTROYED.

Time elapsed: Only 12 minutes.

Outside - The Shockwave Hits

The werewolves at the barricades scream as the divine energy washes over them. It doesn't harm them directly—your ward was always meant to protect, not attack—but the destruction of the totems, the annihilation of the compulsion that drove them...

The four remaining werewolves (not counting the Alpha) FLEE.

They break away from the barricades, running in different directions into the forest, howling in confusion and pain. Mira is among them, her black form disappearing into the trees.

The villagers cheer—"They're running! The monsters are running!"

But the Alpha remains.

The massive werewolf stands at the forest edge, unmoving. It watched its pack flee. Now it stares at the shrine, at the golden light still radiating from within.

It speaks, its voice a deep growl that carries across the square:

"PRIEST."

The word silences the celebration.

"You have destroyed my Master's tools. Freed his slaves. You have made this... personal."

The Alpha steps forward, into the light of the torches. You can see it clearly now—scars covering its body, ritualistic brands burned into its flesh. This is no recent convert. This is a true believer.

"I am Korthak, First of the Pack. I have served the Beastlord for twenty years. I have brought his gift to hundreds."

It draws a massive crude sword from its back—clearly forged for its werewolf form.

"Your ward will not hold forever, priest. And when it falls, I will kill everyone in this village. Starting with you."

Then it turns and walks back into the forest. Not fleeing. Just... waiting.

You emerge from the shrine, exhausted but triumphant. The villagers look to you—relief mixing with lingering fear.

Garrick approaches, breathing hard. "One dead, the rest fled. But that big one..."

Dagmar finishes: "That's not a random pack member. That's a cult champion. And he's not leaving."

Elder Wren steps forward. "How long will the ward hold, Cleric?"

Mother Nelle answers quietly: "A day. Maybe two if we're lucky. It was meant to be temporary."

The Immediate Situation:

- Totems destroyed - No more compulsion drawing werewolves here
- Four werewolves fled - Including Mira, scattered and confused
- Korthak the Alpha remains - Waiting for the ward to fall
- One werewolf corpse at the barricades
- You're exhausted, no spell slots, wounded
- It's still night - Several hours until dawn

What do you do?

You said: I address the gathered crowd: "People, we have won a victory tonight that will be felt for generations to come."

I address the gathered crowd: "People, we have won a victory tonight that will be felt for generations to come. We have held out against insurmountable odds. We are alive tonight because of you and your devotion to our Gods. We praise Chauntea and Lathander this night for their gifts. So

rest. Enjoy the comfort of your loved ones. Our ward will hold tonight and under its protection, we are safe. Tomorrow, however, the real work begins."

To Elder Wren: "I have no intention of moving on until this crisis is dealt with. If you grant me office within the village, I will pledge myself to your cause. We will forge Thornhaven into an impenetrable stronghold against the werewolf threat."

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: A Pledge Sworn

A Pledge Sworn

Your voice rings out across the square, strong despite your wounds and exhaustion. The villagers—bloodied, terrified, but alive—listen with rapt attention.

As you speak of their courage, of divine protection, you see shoulders straighten. Tears of relief flow freely. Neighbors embrace. Parents hold their children close.

"Tonight, we survived. Tomorrow, we FORTIFY."

The crowd erupts in cheers—exhausted, cathartic relief mixed with hope.

Elder Wren's Response

The elderly village leader steps forward, her weathered face grave but grateful. She places both hands on your shoulders, mindful of your wounds.

"Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. You came to us a stranger. In two days, you have saved us twice—once from the curse, once from annihilation." Her voice carries across the square so all can hear. "By the authority vested in me as Elder of Thornhaven, I grant you the title of Village Defender and seat you on our council."

She removes a simple bronze medallion from around her neck—the symbol of Thornhaven, a sheaf of wheat crossed with an oak branch—and places it around yours.

"Your word carries weight in this village now. Your plans will have our support. We are yours to lead in this fight."

The villagers cheer again, this time with real hope.

Garrick pounds his fist against his chest in salute. Dagmar nods with respect. Mother Nelle smiles warmly despite her exhaustion.

Even Aldric, standing at the edge of the crowd in borrowed clothes, bows his head in gratitude—the man you saved, now part of this community you're protecting.

Mother Nelle approaches quietly as the crowd begins to disperse:

"Before you make grand plans for tomorrow, child, you need REST. You're wounded, you've expended every ounce of divine power you possess, and you've barely slept in two days." She takes your arm firmly. "Come. Let me treat those wounds properly. The ward will hold through the night—Korthak was right about that much. You can plan in the morning with a clear head."

She's right. The adrenaline is fading, and exhaustion crashes over you like a wave. Your shoulder throbs. Your vision swims slightly.

The Night Winds Down:

- Garrick organizes a watch rotation—four shifts through the night
 - Dagmar and Finn will scout the perimeter at first light
 - Villagers settle into the tavern and surrounding buildings, keeping close to the ward
 - Tomás and Willem are given a room, the boy finally able to sleep after his ordeal
 - The werewolf corpse is burned, the pyre tended through the night
-

Where do you rest?

- The Sleeping Giant Inn (comfortable, Gerda will ensure you're not disturbed)
- Mother Nelle's shrine (sacred ground, but less comfortable)
- Stay on watch despite your wounds (inadvisable but possible)

And before you sleep, is there anything you want to do or anyone you want to speak with?

You said: "Mother, please tend to Tomás as well."

"Mother, please tend to Tomás as well. I will take what healing you offer, but I must retreat to my room at the Sleeping Giant after."

No, I need sleep.

But I do want to ask you about leveling up. I hit Level 2 at the end of the first session, and I'm assuming I'll hit Level 3 at the end of this session. Talk to me about my choices when I level up

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: Healing and Rest

Healing and Rest

Mother Nelle tends to both you and Tomás in her makeshift healing station. She redresses your wounds with fresh poultices, uses the last of the blessed water to cleanse any lingering corruption from the werewolf bites, and wraps everything in clean bandages.

"You'll be sore for days, but nothing permanent," she says. "The bite didn't take—your faith burned away any curse before it could root. You're lucky."

Tomás thanks you again, quietly, before settling in with Willem for the night.

You retreat to the Sleeping Giant. Gerda has your room ready—clean sheets, a warm fire, food on the table that you barely have the energy to eat.

You collapse into bed, and sleep takes you immediately.

LEVELING UP - Let's Talk Mechanics!

Great question! Yes, you've absolutely earned Level 3 after this session. Let me break down what happens when you level up as a Cleric:

LEVEL 3 CLERIC BENEFITS:

1. Hit Points:

- Roll 1d8 (or take the average of 5) and add your Constitution modifier (+2)
- This increases your maximum HP

2. Spell Slots: You gain access to 2nd-level spells! Your spell slot progression becomes:

- 1st-level slots: 4 per day (up from 3)
- 2nd-level slots: 2 per day (NEW!)

3. New Spells Prepared: As a Cleric, you can prepare spells equal to your Wisdom modifier + Cleric level = 3 + 3 = 6 spells (up from 5)

You can choose from any Cleric spells of 1st or 2nd level. Some powerful 2nd-level options:

- Spiritual Weapon (bonus action attack that lasts 1 minute—VERY useful in combat)
- Lesser Restoration (cure diseases and conditions—could cure lycanthropy early stages!)
- Aid (buff yourself and allies' max HP)
- Hold Person (paralyze a humanoid—great for stopping werewolves in human form)

- Prayer of Healing (heal multiple people out of combat)

4. Channel Divinity: This is HUGE. At level 3, you gain Channel Divinity, usable once per rest. The effect depends on your Divine Domain. We never specified which domain Riv follows!

Common domains and their Channel Divinity:

- Life Domain: Preserve Life (heal multiple creatures at once)
- Light Domain: Radiance of the Dawn (blast undead/enemies with radiant damage)
- War Domain: Guided Strike (add +10 to an attack roll)

Which domain feels right for Riv? Based on his character (healing focus, dawn imagery, protective nature), Life or Light Domain seem like natural fits.

MY RECOMMENDATION FOR RIV:

Domain: Light Domain (fits Lathander perfectly, gives combat options)

HP Roll: Let's roll that 1d8 when we start next session!

New 2nd-level spells to prepare:

- Lesser Restoration (for curing early-stage lycanthropy and diseases)
- Spiritual Weapon (for consistent combat damage without using spell slots every turn)

Keep preparing:

- Sacred Flame (cantrip)
 - Cure Wounds
 - Guiding Bolt
 - Shield of Faith
 - Bless or Command
-

Does this make sense? Any questions about leveling or what you'd like Riv to focus on?

You said: Hit Points: I rolled an 8!

Hit Points: I rolled an 8!

New Spell: I'll take Lesser Restoration and Spiritual Weapon. Good call.

Domain: I like the Light Domain

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: LEVEL UP COMPLETE!

LEVEL UP COMPLETE!

Excellent rolls and choices! Let me record Riv's new stats:

RIV FREEBORN - LEVEL 3 CLERIC (LIGHT DOMAIN)

Hit Points:

- Previous max HP: Let's say you started with ~20 HP at level 2
- New HP: $20 + 8 \text{ (roll)} + 2 \text{ (Con modifier)} = 30 \text{ HP maximum}$
- Current HP after rest and healing: 30/30 (fully restored after sleep!)

Spell Slots:

- 1st-level: 4 slots per day
- 2nd-level: 2 slots per day

Spells Prepared (6 total):

1. Sacred Flame (cantrip) - Your reliable radiant damage
2. Cure Wounds (1st) - Healing
3. Guiding Bolt (1st) - Big damage + advantage for allies
4. Shield of Faith (1st) - AC boost
5. Lesser Restoration (2nd) - Cure diseases/conditions/early lycanthropy!
6. Spiritual Weapon (2nd) - Bonus action floating weapon attack

Light Domain Features:

- Warding Flare: When attacked, use reaction to impose disadvantage (Wisdom modifier times per day = 3 uses)
 - Channel Divinity - Radiance of the Dawn: (1/rest) Dispel magical darkness and deal $2d10+3$ radiant damage to hostile creatures within 30 feet (Constitution save for half)
-

This is HUGE for tomorrow's planning. You now have:

- A way to potentially cure early-stage lycanthropy (Lesser Restoration)
- Better sustained combat capability (Spiritual Weapon)
- An AoE nuke option (Radiance of the Dawn)
- More spell slots overall

Korthak and any remaining werewolves just got a much bigger problem on their hands.

Ready to start the next morning in Thornhaven? Or do you want to wrap this session here and pick up fresh next time?

You said: Let's end this session here.

Let's end this session here. This was great! Did I get any loot out of this session? I imagine probably not, since we didn't search any chests or anything. Does my office within the village grant me anything?

Dec 6, 2025

Claude responded: SESSION 2 WRAP-UP!

SESSION 2 WRAP-UP!

This was fantastic! You've made incredible progress. Let me tally up what you've gained:

LOOT & RESOURCES ACQUIRED:

From Aldric's Cave:

- Aldric's merchant journal (could have useful trade route info)
- 30 gold pieces from Aldric
- Small coinpurse (already added to your total)

From Tomás's Farm:

- Hunting crossbow + 3 dozen bolts (now in village armory)
- Tools, lumber, nails (for fortifications)
- Crude map showing marked farmsteads (intelligence on cult targets)

- 3 vials of dark liquid (alchemical transformation enhancers - could be studied or weaponized)
- Second Malar wooden token (destroyed in ritual)

Your Current Gold: 69.5 GP (after donations and purchases)

TITLE & BENEFITS:

Village Defender of Thornhaven grants you:

Political Power:

- Seat on the village council
- Your word carries authority in defensive matters
- Can requisition resources for village defense
- Bronze medallion (symbol of office)

Practical Benefits:

- Free room and board at the Sleeping Giant (indefinitely)
- Access to village resources (forge, supplies, labor)
- Villagers will volunteer to help with your plans
- First claim on any useful items found

Social Capital:

- Respected by Elder Wren, Garrick, Dagmar, Mother Nelle
 - Trusted by the villagers
 - Aldric owes you his life and will help however he can
-

NOTABLE RELATIONSHIPS:

- Aldric Thorne: Cured merchant, deeply grateful, has trade connections
- Mother Nelle: Spiritual ally, combined ritual power
- Garrick Ironheart: Loyal warrior, trusts your leadership

- Dagmar & Finn: Skilled hunters, respect your tactical mind
 - Tomás & Willem: You saved their lives and farm
 - Elder Wren: Granted you authority
-

THREATS REMAINING:

- Korthak the Alpha (waiting outside the ward)
 - 4 fled werewolves (including Mira, scattered and confused)
 - The Master (cult leader, now personally aware of you)
 - Ward expires in 1-2 days
-

NEXT SESSION PREVIEW: Dawn breaks on a new Thornhaven. You have authority, allies, and a plan to build. But Korthak waits in the forest, and the Master's cult won't forget what you've done.

Excellent work tonight! You've truly become the defender this village needs. See you next session!



Chat 3: PREPARING THORNHAVEN'S DEFENCES

Alright, heading into the third session, which I'm going to play tonight. Before we go into the third session, I want to learn more about the village of Thornhaven - its layout, how many buildings it has, what those buildings are, its defenses (if any), nearby natural resources, trade routes, distance to nearby settlements, and any natural borders. Also, lay out for me the surrounding countryside and landscape. I want to think about how to build the defenses we need when the Alpha comes back. Please look at sessions 1 and 2 as a guide, and also list out our major NPCs, gear, and available assets. Let's make sure we get this all down before we start the session.

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: I'll search through our previous sessions to gather all the details and create a comprehensive overview of Thornhaven.

I'll search through our previous sessions to gather all the details and create a comprehensive overview of Thornhaven.

Searched memory

Searched memory

Perfect! I've reviewed both sessions. Let me create a comprehensive overview of Thornhaven and the strategic situation before we begin Session 3.

THORNHAVEN - COMPLETE OVERVIEW

VILLAGE LAYOUT & BUILDINGS

Village Center (Protected by ward - expires in 1-2 days):

- The Sleeping Giant Tavern - Run by Gerda, main gathering place, your free lodging
- Shrine to Chauntea - Mother Nelle's domain, simple stone building with healing station
- Village Square - Central open area where the ward ritual was performed
- Elder Wren's House - Village leadership, council meetings
- Garrick's Forge - Blacksmith shop, limited inventory, village armory
- Grain Storehouse - Now also serving as makeshift healing station
- General Store - Basic supplies, run by a merchant family
- Approximately 15-20 houses - Mix of families and single residents

Outer Village (Beyond ward protection):

- Scattered farmsteads - Including Tomás's farm (now evacuated)
- Aldric's merchant wagon - Parked near village edge
- Outlying homesteads - Most residents have moved into village center

Population: Approximately 150-200 residents total, with ~50-60 currently sheltering in the fortified village center

CURRENT DEFENSES

Existing:

- Makeshift barricades (wagons, lumber, furniture) at main approaches
- The divine ward covering village center (1-2 days remaining)
- Armed watch rotation (organized by Garrick)
- 3 bear traps near the forest edge (if still intact)

Available Resources from Tomás's Farm:

- Hunting crossbow + 3 dozen bolts
- Tools, lumber, nails
- Additional wood from barn

Village Armory Assets:

- 1 silvered shortsword (Garrick's family heirloom, currently with Garrick)
 - Standard weapons (axes, pitchforks, hunting bows, kitchen knives)
 - Your hunting crossbow and bolts
-

SURROUNDING GEOGRAPHY & TERRAIN

Thornhaven's Location:

- Situated on gently rolling farmland
- Western edge: Darkwood Forest begins ~200 yards from village edge, dense ancient oaks and pines
- Eastern side: Open farmland extending several miles
- Northern approach: More farmland, gradual slope upward
- Southern approach: The main road from Millford (nearest large town)

Natural Features:

- Darkwood Forest - Dense, old-growth forest to the west and north, home to wolves, deer, and apparently werewolf lairs. Cave systems in rocky outcrops ~2 miles in (Aldric's cave location)
- Small stream - Runs along the eastern edge of village, provides water
- Rolling hills - Natural elevation changes, highest point is north of village

Natural Resources:

- Timber - Abundant in Darkwood (ash, oak, pine)
- Medicinal herbs - Forest edges have yarrow, comfrey, elderflower
- Stone - Rocky outcrops in the forest, limited quarrying capability
- Farmland - Fertile soil, wheat fields, grazing pastures
- Water - Stream and wells

TRADE & NEARBY SETTLEMENTS

Millford (Closest major town):

- ~30 miles south along main road
- 2-3 days travel by wagon, 1.5 days on horseback, 2 days on foot
- Regional market town, has garrison, temple, proper shops
- Population ~1,500
- Where Aldric was traveling from when cursed

Trade Routes:

- Main road runs north-south through Thornhaven
- Aldric's merchant journal mentions trade connections
- Village exports: wheat, wool, timber
- Village imports: metal goods, salt, luxury items

Other Settlements: (Not yet encountered, but logically exist)

- Smaller hamlets within 10-15 miles
- Isolated farmsteads dotting the region
- Logging camps deeper in Darkwood

MAJOR NPCs

Village Leadership:

- Elder Wren - Village leader, granted you title and authority, weathered and wise
- Riv Freeborn (YOU) - Village Defender, seat on council, political authority

Spiritual Allies:

- Mother Nelle - Priestess of Chauntea, powerful ritualist, your primary magical ally, elderly but capable
- Currently organizing herb gathering and holy symbol production

Military Assets:

- Garrick Ironheart - Blacksmith, carries silvered shortsword and shield, loyal warrior, trusts your leadership
- Dagmar - Expert tracker and hunter, bow specialist, pragmatic
- Finn - Dagmar's apprentice, less experienced, willing

Rescued/Grateful:

- Aldric Thorne - Cured merchant, owes you his life, has trade connections and 30 GP investment in you
- Tomás - Farmer, wounded but alive, evacuated with son Willem
- Willem - Young boy, traumatized but safe

Tavern:

- Gerda - Tavern owner, practical, organizing food distribution

CURRENT THREATS

Immediate:

- Korthak the Alpha - Cult champion of Malar, 20-year veteran, ritualistic scars, wielding massive crude sword, waiting outside ward for it to fall, has promised to kill everyone starting with you
- Intelligence and tactics - Not a mindless beast
- Ward expiration - 1-2 days maximum

Secondary Threats:

- 4 fled werewolves including Mira (black-furred female) - scattered, confused, no longer under compulsion but still dangerous
- "The Master" - Cult leader, now personally aware of you, identity unknown
- Remaining cult members - Unknown number

Strategic Situation:

- Totems destroyed = no more compulsion drawing werewolves to Thornhaven
- Korthak's personal vendetta = threat is now focused and intentional
- You've made this personal with the cult

YOUR CURRENT ASSETS

Equipment:

- Chain mail (AC 16)
- Shield (AC +2, so AC 18 total)
- Mace
- Holy symbol of Lathander
- Healer's kit
- 3 vials blessed water
- 1 pouch healing herbs
- Bronze medallion (Village Defender symbol)
- 50 feet rope, waterskin, rations

Gold: 69.5 GP

Special Items:

- Aldric's merchant journal (trade route info)
- Crude cult map showing marked farmsteads (intelligence)
- 3 vials dark liquid (alchemical transformation enhancers - could be weaponized or studied)

Level: 3rd level Cleric (Light Domain)

STRATEGIC CONSIDERATIONS FOR DEFENSE

Strengths:

- Central position with existing ward (temporary)
- Motivated population
- Your authority and organizational capability
- Mother Nelle's ritual magic
- Access to timber and basic materials
- Aldric's trade connections for supplies

Weaknesses:

- Ward is temporary (1-2 days)
- Limited proper weapons (only 1 silvered weapon)
- No professional soldiers
- Village is spread out - hard to defend all farmsteads
- Korthak is experienced and intelligent
- Unknown cult strength

Key Questions for Your Planning:

1. Fortification focus - Defend entire village or consolidate into center?
2. Weapon production - Can Garrick make more silvered weapons? (Takes time)
3. External help - Send for aid from Millford? (2-3 days travel)
4. Offensive vs Defensive - Hunt Korthak proactively or prepare defenses?
5. The fled werewolves - Are they still threats or potential allies if freed from compulsion?
6. Time management - Ward expires soon, what's achievable in 1-2 days?

Ready to start Session 3? Dawn breaks on Thornhaven, and you have perhaps 48 hours before Korthak makes his move. What's your first priority?

You said: I'm ready to start session 3 and I have big plans for the defense of the town and other operations.

I'm ready to start session 3 and I have big plans for the defense of the town and other operations. We ended Session 2 falling asleep at The Sleeping Giant. I'd like to start Session 3 waking up for my morning ritual before joining my companions for breakfast

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: SESSION 3 BEGINS

SESSION 3 BEGINS

Dawn of a New Day

You wake in the small but comfortable room at The Sleeping Giant as the first rays of sunlight filter through the shuttered window. Your body aches from yesterday's battles—the fight at Aldric's cave, the desperate sprint to Tomás's farm, the siege at the village, and finally the intense ritual that destroyed the cult's totems.

But you're alive. And you have work to do.

The room is quiet. Through the walls, you can hear the muted sounds of the village stirring—footsteps, low voices, the clatter of pots from the kitchen below. Outside your window, you hear the changing of the guard, Garrick's voice giving orders to the morning watch.

You estimate it's perhaps an hour after sunrise. You slept hard—exhausted from channeling so much divine power yesterday.

Morning Ritual

You rise, wash your face in the basin, and prepare for your morning prayers to Lathander. The Morninglord's presence feels particularly strong today—perhaps because of yesterday's victories, or perhaps because the need is so great.

As you prepare your ritual space, you notice:

- Your wounds from yesterday have scabbed over but still ache
- Your holy symbol feels warm to the touch
- Through the window, you can see the village square—people are already moving about, working on the barricades even in the early morning

Your Morning Prayer Ritual

As a 3rd-level Cleric, you can prepare 6 spells for the day (4 + Wisdom modifier, assuming +2):

Your Domain Spells (always prepared):

- Burning Hands
- Faerie Fire

Choose 6 additional spells from the Cleric list to prepare:

Some suggestions based on what might be tactically useful today:

- Healing Word (bonus action healing at range)
- Cure Wounds (stronger healing when you have time)

- Bless (boost allies in combat)
- Shield of Faith (boost AC for tough fights)
- Guiding Bolt (your proven damage dealer)
- Spiritual Weapon (bonus action attacks)
- Lesser Restoration (remove diseases/conditions)
- Aid (boost max HP for multiple allies)

What spells do you prepare for the day ahead?

You said: Let's prepare Shield of Faith, Bless, Lesser Restoration, Spiritual Weapon, Guiding Bolt, and Healing Word

Let's prepare Shield of Faith, Bless, Lesser Restoration, Spiritual Weapon, Guiding Bolt, and Healing Word

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect spell selection!

Perfect spell selection! A solid mix of defense, support, healing, and offense. Smart choices for what's ahead.

The Morning Prayer

You kneel facing the eastern window, your holy symbol catching the golden rays of dawn. As you pray, you feel Lathander's warmth wash over you—a renewal of purpose, a rekindling of divine power.

"Lathander, Morninglord, Lord of Birth and Renewal. Grant me strength to protect these people. Grant me wisdom to lead them through the darkness ahead. Let your light drive back the shadows that threaten Thornhaven."

The familiar tingling sensation flows through you as your spell slots replenish. You feel renewed, ready.

Full spell slots restored:

- 1st level: 4 slots
- 2nd level: 2 slots

Spells prepared and ready.

As you finish your prayers and don your armor, you hear a soft knock at your door.

"Riv?" It's Garrick's voice, quiet but urgent. "Sorry to interrupt, but when you're ready, Elder Wren has called an emergency council meeting. Everyone's gathering in the tavern common room. The situation... we need to make decisions. Fast."

You hear his footsteps retreat down the hallway.

Through your window, you can see the forest edge. Somewhere out there, Korthak waits. The ward shimmers faintly in the morning light—invisible to normal eyes, but you can sense it. It feels... thinner than yesterday. Time is running out.

You're fully prepared and ready to face the day. Do you head down to the council meeting immediately, or is there anything else you want to do in your room first?

You said: Before I head downstairs, I sit at my desk and write a letter to the head of my order.

Before I head downstairs, I sit at my desk and write a letter to the head of my order. The letter won't make it to him in time, but Elder Cleric Alaric Velen needs to know why I've been delayed. I've been traveling through the countryside on a pilgrimage for Lathander, to spread his light and word. The letter details what I've uncovered and tells of how long I expect to be while fighting Korthak and The Master (I say no more than 3-5 months, but I beg forgiveness if this holy mission takes longer). Should I die while fighting these beasts, others of my order should be made aware of the situation. I seal the letter and place it in my pack before heading downstairs to the meeting.

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: A Letter to the Order

A Letter to the Order

You sit at the small wooden desk, pulling out parchment and ink from your pack. Your hand is steady as you write, though the weight of what you're documenting is heavy.

To Elder Cleric Alaric Velen, High Priest of the Dawnbringer Temple,

I write to inform you of a delay in my pilgrimage, though I pray this letter finds you well.

I have come upon the village of Thornhaven, where a cult of Malar has been cursing innocents with lycanthropy. Over two days, I have destroyed their compulsion totems, freed several victims, and earned the title of Village Defender. However, the threat remains.

An alpha werewolf named Korthak—a twenty-year champion of the Beastlord—has vowed to destroy this village. Behind him stands "The Master," a cult leader whose identity and strength remain unknown. The people here are good, faithful folk who deserve Lathander's protection.

I cannot in good conscience abandon them. I estimate this holy mission may require 3-5 months to see through, though I beg forgiveness should circumstances demand longer. Should I fall in this fight, know that others of our order must be made aware—this cult's reach may extend beyond Thornhaven.

I serve the Morninglord's light, wherever it is needed most.

In faith and duty, Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander

You seal the letter with a small amount of wax, pressing your holy symbol into it as a mark. The letter goes into your pack—you'll need to find someone traveling to Millford who can carry it onward.

Taking a deep breath, you stand, strap on your mace, adjust your chain mail, and head for the door.

The Council Meeting

You descend the stairs into the tavern's common room. The atmosphere is tense but organized. Around a large table sit:

- Elder Wren at the head, looking exhausted but determined
- Mother Nelle, her weathered hands folded in prayer
- Garrick, still in his armor from the morning watch
- Dagmar, checking her bowstring absently
- Aldric, looking uncomfortable but present—he's not officially council, but he's here
- Gerda, arms crossed, practical as ever

Several other villagers stand around the edges—concerned citizens wanting to hear the plan.

As you enter, all eyes turn to you. Elder Wren stands.

"Village Defender Freeborn. Thank you for joining us." Her tone is formal, but there's genuine relief in her eyes. "We have much to discuss, and little time to do it. Please, sit."

Garrick pulls out a chair for you at the table, beside Mother Nelle.

Elder Wren remains standing, addressing the room:

"Our situation is dire. The ward will fail—Mother Nelle estimates we have perhaps 36 hours, maybe less. Korthak waits in the forest. We've seen no sign of the other werewolves since they fled, but we can't assume they won't return. And somewhere, this 'Master' is plotting our destruction."

She looks directly at you.

"You've earned authority here, Riv Freeborn. You've proven yourself a leader and a warrior of the Light. We need a plan. What do you propose?"

The room is silent, waiting for your response.

What do you say? What's your strategic vision for Thornhaven's defense?

You said: "Thank you all for trusting my plans thus far."

"Thank you all for trusting my plans thus far. Truly, we are indebted to Lathander and Chauntea both for seeing us through to this point. We have much to do in 36 hours. I won't lie to you - this will be challenging. We will be pushed to our breaking point. But I do have a plan.

First, we must evacuate the young, the elderly, the infirm, and anyone unable or unwilling to hold a weapon or assist medically. I suggest we send the with armed escort South to Millford. There, we may request aid, inform the Millfordians of the incoming threat, and ensure those of us who are unable to fight find security and comfort. I would like to suggest Dagmar and/or her young apprentice Finn take up the challenge of escorting these citizens, along with 2-3 members of the watch. Once word has been spread, these defenders will return to us to shore up our defenses. Aldric, please go with this group and utilize your merchant connections. We need arms, armor, anything silver. We also need rations and healing supplies. Elder, what can you tell me of the town's coffers? Have we enough for Aldric to take and trade with?

Second, we should look to this map [I pull out the crude map from the werewolves at Tomás' farm] for clues about which local settlements need our help. Garrick, this is going to be our job, provided you have a deputy you can put in charge here to continue organizing our defenses. Is there any member of the watch you feel comfortable handling that while we step away?

Lastly, Gerda, I want to fortify The Sleeping Giant. This will be our fallback position should the barricades fall. Board up the windows, barricade all entrances, and ask around town - see if you can stockpile food, blankets, water, and anything else we might need.

What does everyone think?"

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Council's Response

The Council's Response

Your words land with the weight of real authority. The room is silent for a moment as everyone processes the comprehensive plan. You see nods, thoughtful expressions, and a few worried faces.

Elder Wren speaks first, her voice measured:

"The town coffers hold approximately 200 gold pieces—funds for emergencies and communal projects. Given the circumstances, I believe the council would authorize up to 150 gold for supplies and mercenaries if Aldric can find them." She looks at you seriously. "We're betting everything on survival. Spend what's needed."

Aldric straightens, clearly relieved to have a concrete task:

"I can do this. I know merchants in Millford—including an arms dealer who owes me a favor. Silver is rare and expensive, but I can try for silvered arrows, maybe a weapon or two." He pauses. "I also know a retired captain of the Millford garrison. If I can convince him this threat is real... he might muster volunteers. No promises, but I'll try."

He looks at the map you've laid out, his merchant's mind already calculating travel time. "If I leave within the hour, I can reach Millford by tomorrow evening. Assuming I can arrange everything quickly, I could be back with supplies in three days... maybe four."

His face falls slightly. "That's after your ward expires. I'm sorry, Riv. Even if I succeed, I won't make it back in time for the first assault."

Dagmar leans forward, conflicted:

"Cleric, I understand the logic, but..." She struggles with the words. "You're asking me to leave. To run south while Korthak circles this village." Her jaw tightens. "I'm the best tracker here. The best shot. If you're going to investigate those farmsteads on the map, you need someone who can read signs, spot ambushes."

She looks at Finn, then back to you. "Send Finn. He's young, fast, knows the roads. He can guide the refugees and return with Aldric's supplies. But let me stay and fight. Please."

Finn looks torn between pride at being trusted and fear at the responsibility.

Garrick nods slowly at your question:

"My deputy would be Harlon—he's steady, older, fought in the border skirmishes twenty years back. Not as strong as he once was, but he knows tactics and the men respect him." He grips his sword hilt. "I'm with you, Riv. If we're going to warn those farmsteads and maybe hunt down those

scattered werewolves before they regroup, we need to move fast. The map shows... what, five marked locations?"

He studies it. "If we're smart about our route, we could hit three, maybe four of them before we need to return. But that's a full day of riding, probably into tomorrow."

Mother Nelle adds quietly:

"I can extend the ward, perhaps. Not by much—another 12 hours at most—but every moment counts." She looks at you with concern. "But Riv, if you leave the village to investigate these farmsteads, you won't be here to help prepare defenses. You'll have to trust others to do that work."

Gerda pounds her fist on the table:

"The Giant can be fortified. I've got strong doors, a cellar that could hold thirty people if needed, and a second floor we can defend. Give me ten volunteers and I'll turn this place into a fortress." She eyes you shrewdly. "But understand—if we fall back to the tavern, we're admitting we've lost the outer defenses. It becomes a siege. How long could we hold? Days? A week? Eventually we'd run out of food and water."

Elder Wren synthesizes the discussion:

"So we're looking at several operations running simultaneously:

- Evacuation convoy to Millford (Finn, Aldric, 2-3 guards, refugees)
- Farmstead reconnaissance (You, Garrick, Dagmar)
- Defense preparation in village (Harlon, Mother Nelle, remaining villagers)
- Fallback fortification of the tavern (Gerda, volunteers)

She looks at you directly. "This spreads our forces thin, Riv. But it might be our only chance. However, I have concerns:"

"First—those farmsteads. If the cult marked them, they might be traps now. Or the families there might already be dead. Are you certain this reconnaissance is worth the risk?"

"Second—you're proposing to leave the village for a full day. What if Korthak attacks while you're gone?"

"Third—three days minimum before Aldric returns with help. Can we hold that long?"

She's not challenging your authority—she's testing your plan, making sure you've thought it through.

The room waits for your response. How do you address these concerns?

You said: "The farmsteads might be traps."

"The farmsteads might be traps. We'll hit the first and see what we can see. Sending 2 to 3 refugees back here increases our chances of living through an assault, and we'll be saving lives in the process. If the first isn't a trap, we'll go to the second. If it is, we'll take care of it and return. Our barrier is up. We already know it repels the weaker werewolves and Garrick has done some phenomenal work in the past 10 hours enforcing our guard. It's a risk to leave the village, but between Mother Nelle, Harlon, Gerda, you, and the remaining townsfolk, I have faith that Lathander will see you through. Still, you're right. I'm leaving you without a true fighting force. Garrick and Dagmar. I will take only one of you and leave the other here to defend the village. Who will come with me? As for Aldric - he will return in time. Whether we've rebuffed a single assault or more, we risk more by not sending him than if we do. If we don't send him, we definitely don't receive aid. If we do - there's a chance of a last minute group riding in to pull our feet from the fire. I say it's a chance worth taking."

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Decisions and Sacrifice

Decisions and Sacrifice

The room absorbs your words. You can see the logic settling in, the grim acceptance that this plan—risky as it is—might be their best shot.

Garrick and Dagmar exchange a long look. Years of working together, hunting together, fighting together. An entire conversation passes between them in silence.

Finally, Dagmar speaks:

"I'll go with you, Cleric." Her voice is firm. "Garrick's the better leader—the men trust him, and he knows fortification. I'm the tracker. If we're investigating farmsteads and potentially running into cult activity, you need someone who can read terrain, spot ambushes, and put arrows exactly where they need to go."

Garrick nods slowly, though you can see it pains him to watch another expedition leave without him:

"She's right. Harlon can handle tactics, but he can't inspire like I can. The villagers need to see me on those walls." He clasps Dagmar's shoulder. "Watch his back out there. Both of you come home."

"Count on it," Dagmar replies.

Aldric stands, already preparing mentally for the journey:

"I'll gather what I need and be ready to leave within the hour. Finn—" he looks at the young hunter—"you'll need to help organize the refugees. Who's going, what they can carry, how to keep the group moving quickly."

Finn swallows nervously but nods. "I can do this. I know the roads."

Elder Wren adds: "I'll identify who should evacuate. Families with young children, our elderly who can't fight, anyone wounded or sick. We'll aim for a group of twenty to twenty-five people, small enough to move quickly but large enough that Finn and the guards can protect them."

Mother Nelle rises, her joints creaking:

"I'll prepare to extend the ward. It will require another ritual—perhaps an hour of work—but it will give us until tomorrow evening instead of this evening. That gives you more time to investigate and return." She looks at you meaningfully. "But Riv... I'll need your holy symbol for part of the ritual. Can you leave it with me before you depart?"

[NOTE: This would mean traveling without your spellcasting focus, requiring component pouches instead, or performing the ritual with her before you leave]

Gerda is already mentally cataloging her supplies:

"I'll get started on fortifying the Giant immediately. We've got lumber from Tomás's farm, nails, tools. Windows boarded by nightfall, stockpiles in the cellar by dawn tomorrow." She looks at you with grudging respect. "You've got guts, Cleric. Let's hope Lathander's watching over you."

Elder Wren stands, her decision made:

"Then we have our plan. The council approves." She addresses the room. "Evacuation convoy departs within the hour. Defense preparations begin immediately. Village Defender Freeborn and Dagmar will investigate the marked farmsteads, returning by nightfall tomorrow at the latest."

She turns to you. "Two questions before we disperse:

First—horses. Do you want to take horses for speed, or go on foot for stealth? We have four decent riding horses in the village, though they're not warhorses.

Second—the vials of dark liquid you recovered from Tomás's farm. Those transformation enhancers. What do you want done with them? Destroyed? Studied? Weaponized somehow?"

The council waits for your final decisions on these details, then you can begin preparations for departure.

What's your call on:

1. Horses vs. on foot?
2. The alchemical vials?
3. Mother Nelle's request for your holy symbol—participate in the ritual first, or find another solution?

You said: To Mother Nelle: "I will perform the ritual with you now.

To Mother Nelle: "I will perform the ritual with you now. My symbol cannot leave my body - so say the tenets of my order. I'd like you to look at one of the vials, as well. See what you can glean from it. My gut says we destroy them, but something else says that we came to them for a reason. See what you can figure out, but be very careful!"

To Garrick: "My friend, I trust you will see our defenses well and truly fortified. But don't neglect care for yourself! Ensure you and Harlon both get your rest and care for the defenders. Morale is just as important as training. Additionally, how long would it take you to craft a few more shields for our fighting force? Is it possible with your current materials?"

To Elder Wren: "Give Aldric a horse - let him ride ahead of the convoy and get to Millford ahead of the rest. We will go on foot. A stealthy approach makes sense."

To Aldric: "Aldric, thank you for everything you're doing here. You don't belong to this village, yet you go above and beyond making things right. You are a true ally to Thornhaven. I would ask one additional favor of you, however - please take this letter and post it when you arrive in Millford. It is a letter to my order. They must know of the delay in my return."

To Dagmar: "I will assist Mother Nelle with the ritual to extend it. While I do that, please ensure that Finn is equipped to travel and take these 20 gold pieces to the general store. Make sure we're prepared to spend the night on the road tonight if we don't make it back from the nearby settlements."

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Final Preparations

Final Preparations

Your commands flow with natural authority. The council members nod and immediately begin acting on your orders.

Mother Nelle accepts one of the dark vials carefully, holding it up to the morning light. The liquid inside is thick, almost oily, with an unsettling dark red color.

"I'll examine it carefully, child. If there's knowledge to be gained without risking corruption, I'll find it." She tucks it into her robes. "Come. Let's begin the ward extension ritual. The sooner we start, the more time you'll have for your mission."

She gestures toward the shrine. "It will take an hour, perhaps a bit more. Your presence will strengthen the working considerably."

Garrick straightens, accepting the responsibility:

"I'll see to the defenses and the men both. As for shields..." He considers. "Simple wooden shields? I could make three, maybe four in a day with help from the carpenters. Proper shields that'll turn a werewolf's claws? That takes time I don't have. But something is better than nothing."

He grips your shoulder firmly. "Stay safe out there, Riv. We need you back here."

Aldric takes your letter with a solemn nod, tucking it carefully into his traveling pack:

"I'll see it posted the moment I arrive in Millford. And Riv..." His voice grows thick with emotion. "You saved my life. Saved my soul. If I can help save this village in return, it's the least I can do."

He clasps your hand firmly. "I'll ride hard. I'll find help. I promise you."

Dagmar takes the 20 gold pieces and nods:

"I'll get us properly supplied. Bedrolls, rations for three days, waterskins, rope, tinderboxes. Anything else we might need for overnight wilderness travel." She pauses. "Should I pick up any silvered arrows if the general store has any? Or healing supplies beyond what you already carry?"

She glances toward Finn, who's already organizing nervous refugees near the door. "I'll make sure the boy knows what he's doing before we leave. He's green, but he's got heart."

The Room Begins to Empty

People disperse to their tasks. You can feel the energy shift—from planning to action. The village is mobilizing.

Elder Wren approaches you one last time before you head to the shrine:

"Village Defender Freeborn. You've given us hope and a path forward. Whatever happens in the next few days..." She places a weathered hand on your arm. "Thank you. For everything."

Then she's gone, heading to organize the evacuation.

At the Shrine - The Ward Extension Ritual

Mother Nelle has already begun preparations when you arrive. Candles are lit, herbs burning in small braziers, and she's drawn a circle of holy symbols around the shrine's interior—mixing symbols of Chauntea and Lathander.

"This will be different from our first ritual," she explains. "We're not creating new protection—we're reinforcing what exists, feeding more divine energy into the working. It's like... adding logs to a fire before it burns out."

She gestures for you to take position opposite her, the altar between you.

"We'll pray together, channeling our faith into the ward. I'll need you to expend one of your spell slots—not to cast a spell, but to fuel the ritual itself. Can you spare a 1st-level slot?"

She begins the prayer, her voice rising in an ancient hymn to Chauntea. The air in the shrine begins to shimmer with golden-green light.

Do you:

1. Expend a 1st-level spell slot to fuel the ritual (leaving you with 3x 1st-level slots for the mission)
2. Offer a 2nd-level slot instead for a potentially stronger effect (more costly but might extend the ward further)

And as you pray with Mother Nelle, is there anything specific you ask of Lathander? Any guidance you seek for the mission ahead?

You said: I will use a first level slot, yes.

I will use a first level slot, yes.

"Lathander, my lord and god, Thornhaven is besieged by evil. Your champion and humble servant both, I beg of thee: lend me the strength to turn this evil, cleanse the land, and bring safety to these

people. Thank you, Lathander, for the comforts you give me, the food in my stomach, the pillow beneath my head. You are the light of the dawn and strength that feeds my mortal soul."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Ward Extension Ritual

The Ward Extension Ritual

Your prayer mingles with Mother Nelle's hymn, the two voices creating a harmony of faith. As you offer up your divine energy, you feel the familiar sensation of a spell slot draining—but instead of manifesting as a specific spell, the power flows outward, spreading through the entire village center like ripples on a pond.

The ward, invisible to most, blazes briefly with golden-green radiance—visible even to ordinary villagers for just a moment. You hear gasps from outside the shrine as people see the divine protection renewed.

Mother Nelle's eyes are closed, her face serene with concentration:

"By grain and harvest, by root and seed..." "By dawn and renewal, by light and hope..." "We bind this protection, we strengthen these walls..." "Let no darkness enter, let no evil pass..."

The light pulses one final time, then settles—invisible again, but you can feel it. Stronger. More stable.

Mother Nelle opens her eyes, breathing heavily but smiling:

"It's done. The ward will hold until tomorrow evening—perhaps even into the night if we're fortunate. You've bought us precious time, Riv."

She steadies herself against the altar, then produces the dark vial you gave her. She's been studying it during the ritual.

"This liquid... it's alchemical, but also profane. Ground wolfsbane mixed with corrupted blood—lycanthrope blood, I think—and something else I can't identify. Dark magic binds it together." She looks troubled. "It's designed to enhance the transformation, make it faster and more violent. A victim dosed with this would turn almost immediately after being bitten, with less control over the beast."

She holds it carefully. "We could destroy it. Or..." She hesitates. "With the right ritual, I might be able to reverse its properties—create something that suppresses lycanthropy temporarily instead of enhancing it. But that would take time. Days, maybe a week of work."

"What do you want me to do with these vials?"

Outside, you hear activity picking up:

- Horses being saddled
- Refugees gathering with their meager belongings
- Hammering as fortifications continue
- Dagmar's voice coordinating with the general store

The morning is advancing. If you're going to investigate those farmsteads, you should leave soon.

What's your decision on the vials, and are you ready to depart with Dagmar?

You said: "Mother Nelle, I need you here and focused."

"Mother Nelle, I need you here and focused. I need you stocking our healing herbs. Had we more time, we could make these weapons work for us. As it is, your time will be better spent helping the town prepare. Bury these vials near the river. Bury them deep and in a wooden box. Let us research them more fully when this battle is over."

From there, I make my way to Dagmar so we can depart

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Mother Nelle's Acceptance

Mother Nelle's Acceptance

Mother Nelle nods gravely, understanding the wisdom in your decision:

"You're right. We can't afford distractions now, and these vials are too dangerous to keep in the village during a siege." She tucks them away carefully. "I'll bury them deep, wrapped in blessed cloth inside a sealed box. When this is over, we can study them properly—or destroy them if that proves wiser."

She places both hands on your shoulders, her weathered face filled with concern and pride:

"Go carefully, child. Trust your instincts. Lathander walks with you." Then, more quietly: "Come back to us. Thornhaven needs its defender."

Departure

You step out of the shrine into the busy village square. The transformation since last night is remarkable:

- Barricades are being reinforced with additional lumber and furniture
- Watch posts have been established at the four main approaches

- Harlon is drilling a group of villagers with makeshift weapons
- Gerda is directing volunteers carrying supplies into The Sleeping Giant
- The evacuation convoy is nearly ready—you can see Finn helping elderly villagers onto a wagon, while two armed guards check their weapons

And there, near the village edge, is Dagmar. She's kitted out for wilderness travel: her bow across her back, a quiver of arrows (you count roughly 15), a pack of supplies, her hunting knife at her belt. She looks ready.

As you approach, she hands you a bedroll and a pack:

"Got us set up. Three days of rations each, rope, tinderboxes, waterskins, healing herbs from the general store, and blankets. Spent 15 gold of your 20—the rest I left with Gerda for the tavern fortifications."

She pulls out a small, crudely drawn copy of the cult map. "I traced this so we have our own. Five marked farmsteads total." She points:

"Closest is the Harrow family—about two hours northeast, edge of Darkwood. Then the Millstone farm, three hours east. The others are further out—four to six hours in different directions. If we're smart about our route and move fast, we could hit two today, maybe three if we push hard and don't run into trouble."

She looks at you seriously. "Your call, Cleric. Do we start with the closest, or do we prioritize a different target? And what's our approach when we get there—scout carefully first, or ride in openly?"

Behind you, you hear Aldric mounting his horse. He waves to you:

"Riding ahead now! I'll see you in three days with an army, gods willing!" Then he's off, galloping south toward Millford.

The refugees begin their slower march shortly after, Finn leading them with nervous determination.

Your mission begins. Where do you want to investigate first, and what's your approach?

Available targets:

1. Harrow family - 2 hours NE, edge of Darkwood
2. Millstone farm - 3 hours E
3. Three other farms - 4-6 hours in various directions

You said: "Dagmar, can you tell me anything about these farms?"

"Dagmar, can you tell me anything about these farms? Is there one that you would prioritize? I know the closest makes sense, but if any of the others offers more potential recruits or supplies, or was less likely to have been targeted by the werewolves yet, perhaps that would make more sense? I trust your decision and will follow your lead here."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar studies the map thoughtfully, her tracker's mind working through the tactical considerations. She crouches down and sketches in the dirt to help visualize:

"Good question. Let me think this through..."

The Harrow Family (2 hours NE, edge of Darkwood): "Old couple, maybe mid-sixties. They have one adult son, Jakob, who's a decent hunter. No other family. Small farm, mostly goats and chickens." She frowns. "They're close to the forest—vulnerable. If the cult was targeting them, they might already be hit. On the other hand, if they're still alive, Jakob can fight. One more body with a bow."

The Millstone Farm (3 hours E): "Big family. Thomas Millstone, his wife Clara, four adult children, and maybe a dozen grandkids. They run the largest wheat operation in the area." She taps the map. "Far from the forest, more exposed terrain. Harder for werewolves to approach unseen, so they might have seen threats coming and fortified. If they're intact, that's potentially six to eight people who can fight, plus supplies—they always have surplus grain."

"But here's the thing—if the cult wanted to cause maximum damage to the region's food supply, Millstone is the target. It's also the furthest east, away from our patrol routes."

The Other Three Farms: "The Brennan homestead to the south—young couple, two small kids. They'd be evacuation candidates, not fighters. The Voss farm northwest—single man, hermit type, tough but paranoid. And the Chen family west—skilled with animals, might have horses we could use."

Dagmar stands, her decision forming:

"Here's my read, Cleric. If I were the cult, and I marked these farms..." She points to the map.

"Harrow is close to the forest—easy for werewolves to hit. They probably got struck first. Millstone

is the strategic target—food supply, large family that could organize resistance. That's where I'd send my second wave."

"My gut says we should go to Millstone first. It's a longer walk, but if they're still alive, we gain more—fighters, supplies, and we save a lot of people. If they've already been hit... we might find survivors, or at least intelligence on cult movements."

She looks at you seriously. "But Harrow is closer, and if they're under attack right now, we could save them. It's the classic dilemma—help the nearest or go for the strategic objective."

She shoulders her pack. "What does your gut tell you, Riv? I'll follow your lead."

Which farm do you choose?

- Harrow (2 hours, closer, smaller gain but faster rescue if needed)
- Millstone (3 hours, strategic, larger potential gain, but further from help if under attack)

You said: "You're right - Millstone makes the most sense."

"You're right - Millstone makes the most sense. Higher risk, higher potential reward. Let's head there."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Journey to Millstone Farm

The Journey to Millstone Farm

Dagmar nods approvingly. "Good call. Let's move."

You set out east from Thornhaven, leaving the village behind. The morning sun is climbing higher, warming the autumn air. Behind you, the sounds of preparation fade—hammering, voices, the organization of defense. Ahead lies open farmland, rolling hills, and uncertainty.

The Terrain

The path to Millstone takes you through:

- Open wheat fields (mostly harvested, stubble remaining)
- Gentle hills providing occasional vantage points
- A few scattered copses of trees breaking up the farmland
- A small creek you'll need to ford about halfway there

The visibility is excellent—you can see for miles across the open country. This is good for spotting threats, but it also means you're visible to anyone watching.

Dagmar sets a steady pace, not rushing but moving with purpose. Every so often she pauses, scanning the horizon, checking the ground for tracks.

About an Hour In

You're crossing through a harvested wheat field when Dagmar suddenly stops, crouching low. She gestures for you to do the same.

"Movement. Northeast, maybe 400 yards."

You follow her gaze and see it—something moving through a distant tree line. Too far to identify clearly, but definitely large. Four-legged? Two-legged? Hard to say from this distance.

Dagmar quietly unslings her bow. "Could be deer. Could be wolves. Could be worse." She watches intently. "It's moving parallel to us, not toward us. Hasn't spotted us yet, I think."

The movement disappears into the trees.

"Your call, Cleric. Do we:

- Detour around, give it wide berth (adds 20-30 minutes)
- Continue straight, stay alert (faster but riskier)
- Investigate cautiously (could gain intel but burns time and risks encounter)

What do you want to do?"

You said: "Let's continue, but let's keep an eye out."

"Let's continue, but let's keep an eye out. Be ready for anything"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Pressing Forward

Pressing Forward

Dagmar nods, keeping her bow in hand now rather than across her back. "Smart. We can't chase every shadow, but we stay sharp."

You continue east, both of you more alert now. The pleasant autumn morning feels less peaceful, more watchful. Every distant bird call makes you pause. Every rustle of wind through the stubble draws your attention.

Crossing the Creek - 90 Minutes In

You reach the small creek Dagmar mentioned. It's only about fifteen feet wide, shallow enough to ford easily. The water runs clear over smooth stones.

As you approach the bank, Dagmar kneels suddenly, examining the muddy earth at the water's edge. Her expression darkens.

"Riv. Look at this."

She points to tracks in the mud—lots of them. Wolf prints, but massive. Some are clearly boot prints that shift mid-stride into paw prints. The tracks are recent, maybe 6-8 hours old.

"At least three of them crossed here, heading east." She follows the trail with her eyes. "Toward Millstone."

She looks up at you, her face grim. "These aren't the ones that fled last night—these tracks are older than that. This was a group moving with purpose, probably yesterday evening or early this morning."

She stands, checking her arrows. "We might be walking into an active situation."

You're about an hour from Millstone now. The farm lies ahead across more open fields. If werewolves hit it last night or this morning, the situation could be:

- Werewolves already gone, survivors hiding
- Werewolves still there, currently attacking or occupying
- No survivors, just aftermath

How do you want to approach the final stretch?

Options:

1. Move quickly and openly - Get there fast, risk being spotted if enemies are present
2. Approach slowly and carefully - Use cover, scout ahead, takes longer but safer
3. Split up - One scouts ahead while other hangs back (risky but efficient)
4. Other approach?

Also, do you want to prepare any spells or tactics before continuing?

You said: We're too far for my Shield of Faith to matter, but I'll cast it when we get closer.

We're too far for my Shield of Faith to matter, but I'll cast it when we get closer. Let's move faster until we're 10 minutes from the farm, then slow down and approach carefully

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Tactical Approach

Tactical Approach

Dagmar agrees immediately. "Good thinking. Speed first, then stealth. Let's move."

You pick up the pace, covering ground quickly across the open fields. Your chain mail clinks softly with each stride, and you're breathing harder from the exertion, but you're making excellent time.

The sun is nearly at its zenith now—approaching midday. You've been traveling for about two and a half hours.

Ten Minutes from Millstone

As you crest a low hill, you can finally see Millstone Farm in the distance—maybe half a mile away. Dagmar signals to slow down and drops into a crouch. You follow her lead, moving more carefully now.

What you can see from this distance:

The Millstone farm is substantial—a large two-story farmhouse, a massive barn, several outbuildings, grain silos, and fenced pastures. Much bigger than Tomás's place.

But something is wrong.

"Smoke," Dagmar whispers, pointing.

Thin wisps of smoke rise from one of the outbuildings—not the roaring blaze of an active fire, but the smoldering aftermath. Something burned, probably hours ago.

Through the distance, you can make out what looks like broken fencing. Some of the sheep or goats that should be in the pastures are scattered, some lying still (dead?).

No movement. No people visible.

Dagmar scans the area carefully, her hunter's eyes reading the scene. "I don't see anyone moving. No werewolves that I can spot, but they could be inside the buildings." She looks at you. "Could be the attack already happened and they left. Could be they're waiting in ambush. Could be survivors are hiding."

You're close enough now for Shield of Faith to matter if you want to cast it preemptively.

Do you:

1. Cast Shield of Faith on yourself (boosting AC to 20, lasts 10 minutes, uses concentration)
2. Cast Shield of Faith on Dagmar (boosting her AC, protect your ally)
3. Save the spell for now

And how do you want to approach the farm?

- Circle around to approach from a different angle?
- Move straight in, checking buildings systematically?
- Try to call out first, see if survivors respond?
- Something else?

You said: Let's split up.

Let's split up. I'll cast Shield of Faith on myself and we'll do what we did at Tomás' farm: I'll approach on foot and Dagmar can stick close to cover, keeping me safe with ranged attacks if necessary. The important thing is for her to stay out of sight until needed. Does she get critical damage on stealth attacks?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Tactical Setup

Tactical Setup

Great tactical question! In D&D 5th Edition, the mechanics work like this:

Sneak Attack is a Rogue class feature, not something all characters get. However, attacks made while hidden or unseen DO get advantage on the attack roll, which significantly increases chance to hit and chance to crit.

Dagmar isn't a Rogue—she's more of a Fighter/Ranger type—so she doesn't get Sneak Attack damage. But her advantages are:

- Expert marksmanship (high attack bonus)
- Advantage on attacks when hidden/unseen
- Higher chance of critical hits when attacking with advantage
- Element of surprise (enemies don't know she's there)

So the strategy you're describing is still very effective—she gets better accuracy and crit chance when shooting from concealment.

Shield of Faith

You murmur the prayer, touching your holy symbol. Divine light surrounds you briefly before settling into an invisible protective aura. Your AC is now 20 for the next 10 minutes.

You can feel Lathander's protection reinforcing your armor, a warm confidence settling over you.

Dagmar's Response

"Same as Tomás's place—I like it. You draw attention, I cover you from hiding." She's already scanning for good positions. "I'll move along that stone wall to the south, gives me clear sightlines to the house and barn. If something comes at you, I'll have shots."

She checks her arrows one more time. "Remember—if it's werewolves and they charge you, don't try to be a hero. Fall back toward me so I can support. And if you see survivors, get them to cover fast. We don't know if this is over or if threats are still active."

She clasps your shoulder briefly. "Lathander walk with you, Cleric."

Then she's moving, low and quiet, circling south to get into position.

Your Approach

You begin walking openly toward the farm, mace in hand, shield ready. The distance closes: 400 yards... 300... 200...

Still no movement.

The smoke from the burned outbuilding continues to drift lazily upward. You can smell it now—burned wood, and something else. Burned flesh.

At 100 yards, you can see more details:

- The barn doors are open, hanging crooked
- Bodies in the pasture—sheep, definitely dead
- The farmhouse windows—some broken, others intact
- A wagon overturned near the house

Still no people. No werewolves. Just eerie silence.

You're about to enter the farm proper.

Do you:

1. Call out loudly - "Millstone family! It's Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander! I'm here to help!"
2. Approach silently, checking buildings methodically
3. Head straight for the farmhouse (most likely place for survivors)
4. Check the barn first (could be hiding spot or danger)

Make a Perception check (d20 + Wisdom modifier) as you approach—let's see what Riv notices.

You said: Woohoo!

Woohoo! Nat 20!

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: NATURAL 20!

NATURAL 20! CRITICAL SUCCESS!

Everything Comes Into Focus

As you approach the farm, your senses sharpen to an almost supernatural degree—whether through Lathander's blessing or pure adrenaline, you notice everything.

What you see:

1. The bodies in the pasture - Not just sheep. There's a human body too, face-down near the fence. Adult male, wearing farmer's clothing. Massive claw marks across his back. Dead for hours, rigor mortis setting in.
2. The burned outbuilding - It's a chicken coop. Deliberately set ablaze, but the fire was contained—it didn't spread to other structures. Why burn only that?
3. Tracks everywhere - Your eyes, aided by what Dagmar has taught you, can now read them clearly. Multiple werewolf tracks, maybe 4-5 different individuals. They approached from the northwest (from the direction of Darkwood Forest), circled the farm, then... most of the tracks lead AWAY, heading further east. But two sets remain, leading into the barn.
4. The farmhouse second-floor window - You catch the briefest flicker of movement. A curtain shifting. Someone is in there, watching you.

5. Fresh blood - A trail of blood droplets leads from the overturned wagon to the farmhouse door. Someone wounded made it inside.
 6. The barn - The doors aren't just open, they're broken outward. Something large forced its way out. And those two sets of tracks leading in? They don't come back out. Something is still in that barn.
 7. Smell - Beyond the smoke, you smell blood, fear-sweat, and something else... wet dog. Recent. Very recent.
-

Your tactical awareness crystallizes:

- Survivors in the farmhouse (at least one, possibly wounded)
- Two werewolves likely in the barn (the tracks suggest they're still there)
- The main pack left hours ago, heading further east
- One confirmed dead in the pasture
- The attack happened maybe 6-10 hours ago (late last night or very early morning)

You're standing in an open area between the farmhouse (60 feet to your left) and the barn (80 feet ahead and right). You haven't called out yet.

From your peripheral vision, you spot Dagmar in position behind the stone wall, about 100 feet south. She has a clear shot at both the barn and the house. She's giving you a hand signal—she's seen the movement in the farmhouse window too.

What do you do?

The survivors know you're here. The werewolves (if they're still in the barn) might not have noticed you yet—or they might be waiting.

Your move, Cleric.

You said: I signal to Dagmar to watch the barn, and I turn towards the farmhouse, hoping to coordinate with the survivors

I signal to Dagmar to watch the barn, and I turn towards the farmhouse, hoping to coordinate with the survivors

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Coordination Attempt

Coordination Attempt

You make a clear hand signal to Dagmar—pointing at the barn, then at your eyes. Watch that barn.

She nods, her bow already trained on the barn doors. You can see her settling into a steady shooting stance, arrow nocked and ready.

You turn toward the farmhouse, keeping your shield up but lowering your mace slightly—trying to appear less threatening to potential survivors.

You call out, voice firm but not aggressive:

"Millstone family! I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander from Thornhaven! I'm here to help! Are you injured?"

For a long moment—nothing.

Then the curtain on the second floor shifts again, and you hear a voice—female, frightened, but trying to sound strong:

"How do we know you're really a cleric? How do we know you're not one of THEM?"

Fair question, given what they've been through.

Before you can answer, she continues, voice cracking slightly:

"They came last night. Five of them. They killed my father. They killed Thomas. They—" Her voice breaks. "My husband is badly hurt. And those... those THINGS are still in the barn. They've been in there for hours. We don't know what they're doing."

A pause, then desperately:

"Do you have silver? Can you kill them? Please, we need help!"

From the barn, you hear a sound. A low, rumbling growl. Then movement—something large shifting inside.

Dagmar's bow tracks toward the sound. She's ready.

What do you do?

Options to consider:

1. Prove you're a cleric (demonstrate divine magic, show holy symbol)

2. Promise to deal with the barn threat first before helping them
3. Try to get them to come out and evacuate while you handle the werewolves
4. Ask for more information about what's in the barn
5. Something else?

The tension is rising. Those werewolves in the barn are aware something is happening.

You said: I raise my holy symbol to the sky and proclaim: "I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander.

I raise my holy symbol to the sky and proclaim: "I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. I am a healer and a divine champion. Please, allow me the time to heal your husband that you may escape to Thornhaven. [Show them my healer's kit] I have herbs and skill to heal. I'll need but a few minutes to stabilize him."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Divine Proclamation

Divine Proclamation

You raise your holy symbol high—the sun-burst medallion of Lathander catches the midday light and seems to flare with golden radiance. Whether through divine intervention or perfect timing, the effect is unmistakable.

Your voice rings out with conviction:

"I am Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander! I am a healer and a divine champion!"

You hold up your healer's kit with your other hand. "I have herbs and skill to heal! Please, allow me time to stabilize your husband so you may escape to Thornhaven! I need but a few minutes!"

The Woman's Response

There's a moment of silence, then you hear hurried conversation inside—multiple voices, whispered but urgent. A decision being made.

The front door cracks open. The woman appears—maybe mid-thirties, blonde hair disheveled, face streaked with tears and dirt. She's holding a hunting rifle, though her hands are shaking.

"Clara. Clara Millstone." She swallows hard. "My husband Thomas is upstairs. He's... there's so much blood. I tried to stop it but..."

Behind her, you glimpse two teenage children (a boy and a girl, maybe 15 and 17) and an elderly woman holding two younger children (probably grandchildren, 6 and 8).

Clara's voice drops to a terrified whisper:

"Those things in the barn—they're not leaving. They've been in there since before dawn, just... waiting. Making noises. We think they're..." She shudders. "We think they're eating the horses."

From the Barn

As if on cue, another sound—wet tearing, crunching. Then a low, satisfied growl.

The barn doors are still partially open. You can't see inside from this angle, but whatever is in there is definitely occupied with something.

Dagmar catches your eye from her position. She makes a hand signal: Two targets confirmed. They haven't come out yet.

Clara is waiting for your next move:

Do you:

1. Go inside immediately to treat Thomas (takes you away from the barn threat, but helps the survivor)
2. Deal with the barn werewolves first (eliminates threat before healing, but delays medical care)
3. Have Clara and family evacuate NOW while you cover them, then deal with werewolves
4. Try to draw the werewolves out while Dagmar has the shot
5. Something else?

Thomas is badly wounded and time matters. But those werewolves could emerge at any moment.

What's your call?

You said: "I have a companion watching the barn."

"I have a companion watching the barn. If anything makes to come outside, we'll be ready. Can you use that rifle? Can your family fight?" I ask these questions, intending to give my mace and shield to the stronger of the two teenagers while I heal their father

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Assessing Combat Capability

Assessing Combat Capability

Clara nods shakily, gripping the rifle tighter:

"I can shoot. Not well, but I can shoot. My father taught me." She glances back at her family. "The kids..."

The teenage boy steps forward—tall, broad-shouldered, maybe 17. He's scared but trying to be brave:

"I'm Jakob. I can fight. I've got a woodcutting axe." He hefts it—a heavy, practical tool that could do real damage.

The teenage girl—the 15-year-old—speaks up:

"I'm Sarah. I can use a knife, and I'm fast. I can help."

The elderly woman holding the two young children shakes her head firmly:

"I'm Thomas's mother, Helena. I'll protect the little ones, but I can't fight. Not anymore."

Your Decision - Arming Jakob

You begin unbuckling your shield and offer your mace to Jakob:

"Take these. The shield will protect you, the mace is blessed. If those things come out of that barn, you stand between them and your family. Understood?"

Jakob takes the weapons with wide eyes, clearly overwhelmed but determined:

"I... yes. I understand. I'll protect them."

He straps on the shield (it's a bit large for him, but he manages) and grips the mace. You've just given a teenager holy weapons and asked him to face werewolves. But desperate times...

Your AC drops to 16 (chain mail only, no shield).

Clara's Urgency

"Please, Thomas doesn't have much time. He's upstairs, first room on the right. There's... there's so much blood."

She positions herself by a ground-floor window with her rifle, watching the barn. "Go. I'll watch from here. If those things move, I'll shoot."

From the Barn

The wet crunching sounds continue. Whatever they're doing in there, they're still occupied. But for how long?

Dagmar remains in position, bow ready. She can't see you going into the house, but she trusts you.

You head upstairs. The farmhouse is simple but well-built—solid furniture, family pictures on the walls, signs of a good life interrupted by horror.

First room on the right.

You push open the door and your healer's training immediately assesses the situation:

Thomas Millstone lies on the bed, pale as death. Mid-forties, strong build, but he's lost a LOT of blood. His shirt has been torn away, and you can see:

- Deep claw wounds across his chest and abdomen (four parallel gashes)
- A bite wound on his shoulder (concerning—lycanthropy risk)
- Makeshift bandages soaked through with blood
- Shallow breathing, skin clammy, going into shock

Medical Assessment: He's dying. Without magical healing or expert care in the next few minutes, he won't make it.

Your options:

1. Use Cure Wounds (1st-level spell, heals 1d8+3 HP, stabilizes him immediately)
2. Use Healer's Kit (Medicine check required, takes longer, no spell slot used)
3. Use both (spell first to stabilize, then kit to further treat wounds)

The bite wound is a problem—if he survives, he might be infected with lycanthropy. But that's a problem for later. Right now, he just needs to live.

What do you do?

You said: I'd like to cast two spells: Cure Wounds first to stabilize him and Lesser Restoration to scour his body of potential lycanthropy

I'd like to cast two spells: Cure Wounds first to stabilize him and Lesser Restoration to scour his body of potential lycanthropy

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Divine Healing

Divine Healing

You kneel beside Thomas, placing one hand on his chest near the worst of the claw wounds. His breathing is so shallow you can barely see his chest moving.

"Lathander, Lord of the Dawn, grant me your healing light. Mend what is broken, restore what is lost."

Cure Wounds - 1st Level

Golden radiance flows from your palm into Thomas's body. You feel the divine energy knitting torn flesh, stopping internal bleeding, pulling him back from death's edge.

Roll 1d8+3 for healing.

What do you roll?

(While you're rolling, I'll continue the scene...)

The effect is immediate and dramatic. Color returns to Thomas's face. His breathing deepens, becoming stronger. The worst of the wounds close—not completely healed, but no longer life-threatening. His eyes flutter open, unfocused but alive.

"Clara..." he whispers weakly. "The children...?"

Lesser Restoration - 2nd Level

Before he can say more, you keep your hand on him, channeling another prayer:

"Cleanse him of corruption, Lord of Renewal. Let no curse take root, let no darkness spread."

This spell is trickier. Lesser Restoration removes diseases and conditions, but lycanthropy from a werewolf bite is a curse, not a disease. However, if caught immediately—within hours of infection, before the curse fully takes hold—there's a chance.

You feel the divine energy probe through Thomas's body, seeking out the corruption. The bite wound on his shoulder burns with silver-white light. Thomas gasps in pain but doesn't pull away.

For a moment, you sense something dark and writhing trying to take root in his blood—the curse attempting to establish itself.

Then Lathander's power scours it away.

The bite wound smokes slightly, then the unnatural taint is... gone. You're certain of it. The curse never had time to fully manifest. You caught it in time.

Thomas is saved. Both from death and from lycanthropy.

Thomas's Response

He looks up at you with tears in his eyes:

"You... you're a cleric. A real cleric." His voice is still weak. "Thank the gods. My family—are they safe?"

Before you can answer, you hear from downstairs:

Clara's voice, sharp with fear: "THEY'RE MOVING! THE BARN DOORS!"

The werewolves are emerging.

You've used:

- 1x 1st-level spell slot (3 remaining)
- 1x 2nd-level spell slot (1 remaining)
- Your Shield of Faith is still active (AC 20 chain mail only, ~7 minutes remaining)

You're upstairs, unarmed (gave mace/shield to Jakob).

What do you do?

You said: Oh wow, I rolled an 8 for the Cure Wounds.

Oh wow, I rolled an 8 for the Cure Wounds.

"I am, and they are - for now. Tell me, how are you with that hunting rifle your wife has?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: 11 HP Healed!

11 HP Healed! (8+3)

Thomas's wounds close significantly with that powerful healing. He's still battered and weak, but he's definitely stabilized and conscious.

Thomas's Response

He tries to sit up, wincing but managing it:

"The rifle? That's mine. I'm a good shot—better than Clara." He looks down at his torn, bloody clothes, then at you with growing understanding. "You need me to fight."

It's not a question. He's a farmer who just watched monsters kill his father and nearly kill him. He knows what's at stake.

He swings his legs off the bed, steadier than you'd expect for someone who was dying moments ago. "Where's my rifle? And how many of those things are out there?"

From Downstairs

Clara's voice again, louder now:

"TWO OF THEM! COMING OUT OF THE BARN!"

Then you hear Dagmar's bow release with a sharp TWANG.

A howl of pain—she hit one.

Then Jakob's young voice, trying to sound brave: "Everyone get behind me!"

The Situation

- Two werewolves emerging from the barn
- Dagmar engaging from range (you hear another arrow fly)
- Jakob (armed with your mace and shield) trying to protect his family
- Clara with the hunting rifle at the ground-floor window
- You are upstairs with Thomas, currently unarmed
- Thomas is healed but exhausted, asking for his rifle

Quick decisions needed:

1. Give Thomas the rifle and have him shoot from the upstairs window (good vantage, keeps him out of melee)
2. Take the rifle yourself (you're not proficient, but you could use it)
3. Rush downstairs to support Jakob and cast spells
4. Other plan?

What's your move? The fight is starting NOW.

You said: Thomas needs his rifle and the upstairs window makes the most sense.

Thomas needs his rifle and the upstairs window makes the most sense. Jakob needs my help. I cast Shield of Faith on Jakob and rush downstairs to reclaim my gear, handing him back his axe

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Quick Tactical Response

Quick Tactical Response

You make your decision instantly:

"Your rifle—where is it?"

Thomas points to a corner of the room where the hunting rifle leans against the wall. You grab it and thrust it into his hands:

"Upstairs window. You've got the high ground and clear shots. Make them count!"

Thomas nods, already moving to the window with more strength than someone who was dying two minutes ago should have. Divine healing is remarkable.

Shield of Faith on Jakob

As you rush toward the stairs, you raise your holy symbol and call out:

"Jakob! Lathander's protection upon you!"

Golden light flares around the young man downstairs. His AC jumps from whatever it was to +2 higher. He's now wearing your shield, wielding your blessed mace, and surrounded by divine protection.

You've used your Concentration—Shield of Faith on Jakob replaces the one you had on yourself. Your AC remains 16 (chain mail only).

Remaining spell slots:

- 1st level: 3
- 2nd level: 1

Rushing Downstairs

You take the stairs two at a time, bursting into the ground floor common room.

The scene before you:

Outside, through the windows:

- Two werewolves in hybrid form, massive and terrifying, have emerged from the barn
- One is wounded—Dagmar's arrow sticks out of its shoulder, black blood dripping
- They're advancing toward the house, about 60 feet away
- Dagmar (hidden behind the stone wall) releases another arrow—THUNK—hits the wounded one again. It staggers but keeps coming.

Inside the house:

- Jakob stands in front of his family, shield raised, mace gripped in white-knuckled hands. The divine light of Shield of Faith shimmers around him. He's terrified but holding position.
- Clara is at the window, rifle raised but her hands are shaking badly
- Sarah (15-year-old) has a kitchen knife, standing next to her brother
- Helena has the two young children behind her, pressed into the corner

Jakob sees you:

"Cleric! They're coming! What do I do?!"

From upstairs, you hear Thomas's rifle CRACK.

The wounded werewolf jerks as the bullet hits its center mass. Not silver, so it won't kill it, but it's hurt badly now.

The werewolves howl in rage and break into a run toward the house.

40 feet away... 30 feet...

Your turn, Riv!

You need to:

1. Reclaim your mace and shield from Jakob (give him back his axe)
2. Position yourself for combat
3. Possibly cast a spell or prepare an action

What do you do? You have maybe 6 seconds before they reach the house!

You said: I grab Jakob's axe from where he left it, pull my mace from his hands (I let him keep the shield), I position myself front and center, and I cast Spiritual Wea...

I grab Jakob's axe from where he left it, pull my mace from his hands (I let him keep the shield), I position myself front and center, and I cast Spiritual Weapon

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Combat Positioning

Combat Positioning

You move with practiced efficiency:

- Snatch Jakob's woodcutting axe from where it leans against the wall
- Pull your blessed mace from his grip ("Keep the shield, lad! Stay behind me!")
- Thrust the axe into his hands
- Step in front of him, placing yourself between the door and the Millstone family

Jakob stumbles back, still glowing with Shield of Faith, now gripping his familiar axe. He looks relieved to have you in front but ready to fight if needed.

Spiritual Weapon - 2nd Level (Bonus Action)

You raise your holy symbol and speak the prayer:

"Lathander, grant me your radiant blade! Let dawn's light strike down these beasts!"

A glowing golden warhammer materializes in the air beside you—translucent but solid, radiating holy light. It hovers at shoulder height, waiting for your mental command.

This is one of your most powerful combat spells:

- Bonus action to attack each turn
- Doesn't require concentration (you can maintain Shield of Faith on Jakob)
- 2d8+3 force damage on hit
- Flies independently, can attack at range

Your remaining spell slots:

- 1st level: 3

- 2nd level: 0 (both used)
-

The Werewolves Charge

20 feet... 10 feet...

CRASH!

The first werewolf—the wounded one, already hit by two of Dagmar's arrows and Thomas's rifle—smashes through the front door, splintering it off its hinges.

It's horrifying up close: Eight feet tall in hybrid form, muscles rippling, black fur matted with blood, yellow eyes burning with rage. Saliva drips from its fangs.

The second werewolf is right behind it, circling toward the window where Clara stands.

INITIATIVE TIME!

Roll Initiative: d20 + Dexterity modifier (let's say +1 for a Cleric in chain mail)

What do you roll?

(While you roll, I'll set the scene for Round 1 of combat!)

Current battlefield:

- You: Front and center, mace ready, Spiritual Weapon floating beside you, AC 16
- Jakob: Behind you with axe and shield, AC boosted by Shield of Faith, scared but ready
- Wounded Werewolf: Just burst through the door, 10 feet from you
- Second Werewolf: Approaching the window where Clara is
- Dagmar: Outside, 100 feet away, bow ready
- Thomas: Upstairs window with rifle
- The Family: Huddled in the back corner

Let's see how fast you are!

You said: 9

9

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Initiative Order

Initiative Order

Your combat instincts are solid but not lightning-fast. Initiative: $9 + 1 = 10$

Let me roll for the others...

INITIATIVE ORDER:

1. Dagmar - 18 (expert hunter, quick reflexes)
 2. Wounded Werewolf - 16 (wounded but desperate)
 3. Second Werewolf - 14 (circling for Clara)
 4. Thomas - 12 (upstairs, reloading)
 5. YOU (Riv) - 10
 6. Jakob - 6 (terrified teenager)
 7. Clara - 4 (shaking hands)
-

ROUND 1 - COMBAT BEGINS!

DAGMAR'S TURN (Initiative 18)

From her position behind the stone wall, Dagmar has a clear shot through the broken doorway at the wounded werewolf that just burst in.

TWANG!

Her arrow flies true, striking the wounded werewolf in the back as it focuses on you. The creature howls—it's taken serious damage now (two arrows, one rifle shot, now a third arrow).

It's bleeding heavily, favoring one leg, but still very dangerous.

WOUNDED WEREWOLF'S TURN (Initiative 16)

The creature locks eyes with you and snarls, recognizing you as the primary threat—the one glowing with divine magic, the one who just healed the man upstairs.

It lunges at you with both claws!

First claw attack: The werewolf rolls... $14 + 4 = 18$ to hit

Your AC is 16 (chain mail). The attack hits!

The massive claw rakes across your shoulder. Roll for damage: The werewolf deals 7 slashing damage!

You grit your teeth as claws tear through the chain mail links and bite into flesh. Pain, but you stay standing.

Second claw attack: The werewolf rolls... $8 + 4 = 12$ to hit

Miss! You manage to deflect the second claw with your mace, turning it aside.

The wounded werewolf is now directly in front of you, 5 feet away, breathing its foul breath in your face.

SECOND WEREWOLF'S TURN (Initiative 14)

The second werewolf, seeing its companion engaged with you, smashes through the window where Clara is positioned!

Glass explodes inward. Clara screams and stumbles backward, dropping her rifle.

The werewolf attacks Clara with its claws!

Attack roll: $16 + 4 = 20$. Hit!

Clara takes 9 slashing damage and is thrown backward, crashing into the wall. She's badly hurt, bleeding, conscious but stunned.

Sarah screams: "MOM!"

THOMAS'S TURN (Initiative 12)

From upstairs, Thomas has reloaded. He leans out the window and takes aim at the second werewolf that just mauled his wife.

CRACK!

The rifle shot hits! The second werewolf jerks as the bullet strikes its flank. Not silver, but it still hurts. The creature snarls, momentarily distracted from Clara.

YOUR TURN (Initiative 10)

Current situation:

- Wounded werewolf directly in front of you (5 feet), heavily damaged but still fighting
- Second werewolf across the room (20 feet away), just mauled Clara, now distracted by Thomas's shot
- Clara is down, bleeding, against the wall
- You've taken 7 damage
- Spiritual Weapon is hovering, ready for your bonus action command

You can:

- Attack the wounded werewolf in front of you with your mace
- Use Spiritual Weapon (bonus action) on either werewolf
- Cast a spell (like Guiding Bolt for damage, or Healing Word to help Clara)
- Move to engage the second werewolf threatening Clara

What do you do? (Remember: you get one action, one bonus action, and movement if needed)

You said: I'm going to cast Guiding Bolt on the uninjured werewolf and then use Spiritual Weapon on the injured one

I'm going to cast Guiding Bolt on the uninjured werewolf and then use Spiritual Weapon on the injured one

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Divine Fury Unleashed

Divine Fury Unleashed

You make the tactical call—finish the wounded one with your Spiritual Weapon while blasting the fresh threat with your most powerful offensive spell.

SPIRITUAL WEAPON (Bonus Action)

You mentally command the glowing golden warhammer. It streaks across the room toward the wounded werewolf in front of you, swinging with divine force.

Attack roll: d20 + your spell attack bonus (Wisdom modifier + proficiency = let's say +5)

Roll a d20 for the Spiritual Weapon's attack!

(I'll wait for your roll, but let's continue the narrative...)

GUIDING BOLT (Action - 1st Level Spell)

You raise your holy symbol toward the second werewolf across the room—the one that just mauled Clara and is now turning back toward her for a killing blow.

"LATHANDER'S LIGHT STRIKE YOU DOWN!"

A brilliant bolt of radiant energy erupts from your holy symbol, streaking across the room like a miniature sun.

Attack roll: $d20 + 5$ (your spell attack bonus)

Roll a d20 for Guiding Bolt!

If it hits, roll 4d6 radiant damage!

The room is filled with golden light as both your attacks launch simultaneously—the spectral hammer swinging at the wounded werewolf in front of you, the radiant bolt blazing toward the one threatening Clara.

Give me both rolls:

1. Spiritual Weapon attack (d20)
2. Guiding Bolt attack (d20), and if it hits, 4d6 damage

Let's see if Lathander's wrath finds its marks!

You said: Spiritual Weapon: 12

Spiritual Weapon: 12

Guiding Bolt: 16

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Spiritual Weapon Attack: $12 + 5 = 17$

Spiritual Weapon Attack: $12 + 5 = 17$

The golden warhammer swings with divine precision at the wounded werewolf directly in front of you.

Werewolf AC is typically 12 in hybrid form. HIT!

Roll $2d8 + 3$ for Spiritual Weapon damage!

Guiding Bolt Attack: $16 + 5 = 21$

The radiant bolt screams across the room toward the second werewolf.

SOLID HIT!

Roll 4d6 radiant damage!

Give me both damage rolls and I'll narrate the devastating effect!

(Also noting: Guiding Bolt gives the next attack against that target advantage—very useful for whoever attacks it next!)

Remaining after this turn:

- 1st level slots: 2
- 2nd level slots: 0

You said: Spiritual Weapon: 3 and 6

Spiritual Weapon: 3 and 6

Guiding Bolt: 3, 3, 4, 5

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Spiritual Weapon Damage: $3 + 6 + 3 = 12$ force damage

Spiritual Weapon Damage: $3 + 6 + 3 = 12$ force damage

The golden warhammer SLAMS into the wounded werewolf's skull with a sickening crunch. The creature, already peppered with arrows and weakened by rifle fire, takes the full divine impact directly to the head.

Its eyes roll back. It staggers, tries to snarl one last time, then collapses forward—crashing to the floor at your feet with a heavy thud.

The wounded werewolf is DOWN.

Black blood pools around it. The house shakes from the impact of its massive body hitting the floorboards.

Guiding Bolt Damage: $3 + 3 + 4 + 5 = 15$ radiant damage

Your bolt of pure radiant energy strikes the second werewolf center mass, exploding with holy fire. The creature HOWLS in agony as the divine light sears its flesh, burning away fur and leaving scorched, smoking wounds.

It stumbles backward, away from Clara, clawing at the burning radiant energy still clinging to it like holy napalm.

The werewolf is badly hurt and glowing with residual divine light (next attack against it has advantage from Guiding Bolt's effect).

JAKOB'S TURN (Initiative 6)

The young man, seeing the werewolf reeling from your blast and his mother bleeding on the floor, finds his courage.

"GET AWAY FROM HER!"

He charges forward with his woodcutting axe, still protected by your Shield of Faith. His attack is clumsy—untrained—but desperate.

Attack roll: $8 + 2 = 10$. Miss.

The werewolf, despite its injuries, easily dodges the wild swing. But Jakob has positioned himself between the werewolf and his wounded mother. He's standing his ground.

CLARA'S TURN (Initiative 4)

Clara is hurt, bleeding, but conscious. She's slumped against the wall, trying to breathe through the pain. She can't fight this turn—she's stunned and wounded.

ROUND 1 COMPLETE

END OF ROUND STATUS:

Allies:

- You (Riv): 7 damage taken, AC 16, standing over dead werewolf
- Jakob: Unharmed (protected by Shield of Faith), between werewolf and Clara, has axe and shield
- Clara: Badly wounded (9 damage), stunned, on the ground
- Dagmar: Unharmed, positioned outside with clear shots

- Thomas: Unharmed, upstairs with rifle
- Other family members: Safe in back corner

Enemies:

- Wounded Werewolf: DEAD at your feet
 - Second Werewolf: Badly hurt (15 radiant damage + rifle shot), glowing with Guiding Bolt's effect (next attack has advantage), 10 feet from Jakob
-

ROUND 2 BEGINS

DAGMAR'S TURN (Initiative 18)

Dagmar has a clear shot through the broken window at the remaining werewolf. She fires with advantage thanks to your Guiding Bolt!

She rolls: Natural 18! Plus advantage! Definite hit!

Her silvered arrow punches into the werewolf's back, the silver burning as it penetrates deep. The creature screams—a very different sound from the previous howls. Silver hurts.

The werewolf is now critically wounded—multiple injuries, radiant burns, and now silver poisoning spreading through its system.

SECOND WEREWOLF'S TURN (Initiative 14)

The creature is in bad shape, but cornered animals are dangerous. It has two choices: flee or go down fighting.

It chooses violence.

The werewolf lunges at Jakob—the young man standing between it and escape.

Attack roll (with disadvantage because it's badly wounded):

First roll: 15

Second roll: 7

Takes the lower: $7 + 4 = 11$ to hit

Jakob's AC with your shield and Shield of Faith is probably around 15-16.

MISS!

Jakob blocks with your shield, the blessed metal turning aside the claws! The divine protection holds!

"I... I did it!" Jakob gasps, hardly believing it.

THOMAS'S TURN (Initiative 12)

Another rifle CRACK from upstairs. Thomas is protecting his family with everything he has.

Hit! The bullet strikes the werewolf's shoulder. Not silver, but it's one more injury stacking up.

YOUR TURN (Initiative 10)

The remaining werewolf is critically wounded, surrounded, and clearly on its last legs. One good hit might finish it.

Your options:

- Spiritual Weapon (bonus action) - Still active, can attack again
- Attack with your mace - You're close enough now (the werewolf is 10 feet away engaging Jakob)
- Cast another spell - Guiding Bolt again? Something defensive?
- Healing Word for Clara - She's badly hurt and unconscious/stunned

What do you do?

You said: I'll hit it with my Spiritual Weapon while casting Healing Word on Clara

I'll hit it with my Spiritual Weapon while casting Healing Word on Clara

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Divine Support and Assault

Divine Support and Assault

You split your focus with practiced precision—the mark of an experienced cleric managing a chaotic battlefield.

HEALING WORD (Bonus Action - 1st Level)

You keep your eyes on the werewolf but extend your hand toward Clara, speaking a quick prayer:

"Lathander's dawn renews! Rise, Clara!"

Roll 1d4 + 3 (Wisdom modifier) for healing!

What do you roll?

The golden light washes over Clara. Her eyes snap open, the worst of her bleeding stops, and color returns to her face. She gasps, alive and conscious.

SPIRITUAL WEAPON (Action)

Your glowing warhammer streaks across the room toward the cornered, critically wounded werewolf that's desperately trying to get past Jakob.

Attack roll: d20 + 5

Roll for the Spiritual Weapon attack!

The scene: Clara stirring back to consciousness as divine healing flows through her, while your spectral hammer swings toward the beast that nearly killed her.

Give me both rolls:

1. Healing Word: 1d4
2. Spiritual Weapon: d20

Remaining spell slots after this:

- 1st level: 1
- 2nd level: 0

You said: Healing Word: 3

Healing Word: 3

Spiritual Weapon: 17

Spiritual Weapon Damage: 4 and 6

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Healing Word: 3 + 3 = 6 HP restored to Clara

Healing Word: 3 + 3 = 6 HP restored to Clara

Golden light washes over Clara, knitting the worst of her wounds. She gasps, drawing a full breath for the first time since being mauled. The bleeding stops, her eyes clear. She's still hurt, still weak, but she's alive and conscious.

"The children..." she whispers, then sees Jakob standing between her and the werewolf, shield raised. "Jakob, no—"

Spiritual Weapon: $17 + 5 = 22$ - SOLID HIT!

Damage: $4 + 6 + 3 = 13$ force damage

The golden warhammer comes down like the wrath of dawn itself, striking the werewolf squarely between the shoulder blades with devastating force.

CRACK.

You hear bone shatter. The werewolf's spine breaks under the divine impact.

The creature collapses mid-lunge, crashing into Jakob (who stumbles but stays upright). It hits the floor hard, twitching, trying to crawl with its front claws, its back legs useless.

It's dying, but not quite dead—making horrible gurgling sounds, black blood pooling beneath it.

JAKOB'S TURN (Initiative 6)

The young man looks down at the broken, dying werewolf at his feet. It snaps weakly at him with its fangs, more reflex than real threat.

Jakob raises his woodcutting axe, his hands steadier now:

"For my grandfather. For my father."

He brings the axe down. Once. Twice.

The second werewolf stops moving.

Silence falls over the farmhouse.

Both werewolves are dead. The immediate threat is over.

Jakob stands there, axe dripping with black blood, breathing hard, staring at what he just did. He's shaking—adrenaline, fear, shock all catching up to him.

Clara pulls herself up against the wall, tears streaming down her face. "Thomas? Thomas!"

From upstairs: "I'm here! I'm coming down!"

You hear Thomas's footsteps on the stairs, still weak but moving.

From outside, Dagmar calls:

"Riv! Are you all right in there? I'm coming in!"

She appears in the broken doorway, bow still ready, scanning for threats. When she sees both werewolves dead, she lowers it.

"Well fought, Cleric. Well fought." Then she sees Jakob, still standing over the corpse, trembling. "You too, lad. You held the line."

The little ones are crying in the corner. Helena is trying to comfort them. Sarah is hugging herself, staring at the dead monsters.

Thomas stumbles down the stairs and immediately goes to Clara, pulling her into his arms. They hold each other, both crying.

You're standing in the middle of a farmhouse littered with broken furniture, shattered glass, two dead werewolves, and a family that just survived the impossible.

Your current status:

- 7 HP damage (out of your max, which at 3rd level Cleric is probably around 20-24)
 - Spell slots: 1x 1st level, 0x 2nd level
 - Spiritual Weapon still active (lasts 1 minute, combat is over)
 - Shield of Faith on Jakob still active (10 minutes duration)
-

What do you do now? There's aftermath to handle—the dead werewolves, the traumatized family, the farm to secure, and the question of whether more threats might be coming.

You said: Just for your information, my HP max is 30 - we came up with that at my 3rd level up.

Just for your information, my HP max is 30 - we came up with that at my 3rd level up. So that puts me at 23 HP right now with my wounds.

Everyone is healed, if not particularly well. Sadly, we need to move. I address the family: "Well fought. Lathander's light was with us this day. Clara, Thomas - we've begun fortifying Thornhaven. You and your family are stout fighters. We have a healing tent set up and have fortified the Inn. Please, with all due respect and understanding of what you've just been through, I would request you each pack a bag and join us in defending Thornhaven."

To Dagmar: "Dag, same as at Tomás' farm. Please light a pyre and burn the bodies, searching them for anything that might give us some clue as to their plans. When you've finished, please search the out-buildings and particularly the chicken coop. I don't know why it was set alight, but I suspect all is not as it seems there"

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect - noted!

Perfect - noted! 23/30 HP current.

The Millstone Family's Response

Thomas and Clara exchange a long look—the kind of wordless communication that comes from years of marriage. They're exhausted, traumatized, but you can see the steel in them. These are farming folk who've survived harsh winters, failed crops, and now werewolf attacks.

Thomas speaks first, his voice still weak but determined:

"Thornhaven fortified... that's where we should be. This place—" he looks around at the broken windows, splintered door, blood on the floors "—this place isn't safe anymore. Not with just us."

Clara nods, wiping her tears:

"We'll come. All of us." She looks at her children, at Helena holding the little ones. "But we need to bring what we can—food stores, weapons, blankets. We have wagons, horses that survived in the far pasture. Give us an hour to pack properly."

Jakob, still clutching your shield, looks at you with something like reverence:

"I'll fight. I held the line here, I can do it again in Thornhaven." He's trying to sound brave, but you can hear the tremor in his voice. He's seventeen and just killed his first monster.

Sarah adds quietly: "I can help with the wounded. I've assisted Mother Nelle before when she visited. I know some herbalism."

Helena, the grandmother, speaks up: "I'll watch the children and help where I can. These old hands can still cook and mend."

Thomas looks at the dead werewolves:

"There were five last night. We killed none. These two stayed behind in the barn—we could hear them... feeding... for hours." His face goes pale. "Where are the other three?"

He pulls out the crude cult map you showed him. "They were heading east when they left at dawn. That's... that's toward the Chen family's place, and beyond that, nothing but wilderness and eventually the Eastern Road."

"Do you think they're going to hit more farms? Or are they running?"

Dagmar's Acknowledgment

Dagmar nods grimly at your orders:

"Pyre and search—on it. I'll check the chicken coop especially." She looks at the dead werewolves with professional detachment. "These ones didn't have much on them—they were in beast form when they came—but I'll see what I can find."

She heads out, already gathering wood from the barn for the pyre.

As the Millstones begin organizing their evacuation, you have about an hour before they're ready to travel.

During this time, you could:

1. Help Dagmar search the bodies and investigate the chicken coop yourself
2. Rest and tend your wounds (short rest to recover HP and potentially a spell slot)
3. Talk to Thomas more about the attack (gather intelligence—timing, werewolf behavior, anything they said)
4. Prepare the family for the journey back (security concerns, travel formation)
5. Pray to Lathander for guidance about the other three werewolves heading east

What's your priority during this hour?

Also, you still have about 4-5 hours of daylight left—enough time to potentially investigate one more location if you wanted to push on, or head back to Thornhaven with the Millstones.

You said: I'd like to rest (how long is a short rest?)

I'd like to rest (how long is a short rest?)

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Short Rest Mechanics

Short Rest Mechanics

A short rest in D&D 5th Edition takes 1 hour—perfect timing since the Millstones need about an hour to pack anyway.

During a short rest, you can:

1. Spend Hit Dice to recover HP - As a 3rd level Cleric, you have 3d8 Hit Dice available. You can roll as many as you want and add your Constitution modifier to each roll to regain HP.
 2. Catch your breath, tend wounds, eat, drink
 3. You do NOT regain spell slots (those only come back on a long rest, which is 8 hours)
-

Taking Your Short Rest

You find a relatively clean chair in the Millstone kitchen, away from the blood and broken glass. Clara brings you water and some bread—simple farmer's fare, but welcome.

"Thank you," she says quietly. "For everything. For Thomas, for... all of us."

You clean and bandage the claw wounds on your shoulder while saying a quiet prayer of thanks to Lathander. The adrenaline is fading, and you can feel the exhaustion setting in.

Hit Dice Recovery:

You're currently at 23/30 HP (7 damage taken).

You have 3d8 Hit Dice available. You can spend as many as you want.

How many Hit Dice do you want to spend?

For each one you spend, roll 1d8 + Constitution modifier (let's say +2 for a Cleric).

Examples:

- Spend 1 Hit Die: Roll 1d8+2, regain that much HP
- Spend 2 Hit Dice: Roll 2d8+4 total
- Spend all 3: Roll 3d8+6 total

How many do you want to use, and what do you roll?

(Remember: You recover half your Hit Dice on a long rest, so if you use all 3 now, you'd get 1 back after sleeping tonight)

You said: I'll spend one: I rolled a 5

I'll spend one: I rolled a 5

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Hit Die Recovery: $5 + 2 = 7$ HP regained

Hit Die Recovery: $5 + 2 = 7$ HP regained

You're now at 30/30 HP - fully healed!

The wounds on your shoulder close as you tend them with blessed water and clean bandages. Between the rest, the food, and your natural constitution, you're back to full strength.

Hit Dice remaining: 2/3

During Your Rest

While you're recovering, you can see through the window:

Dagmar has built a pyre outside and is burning the two werewolf corpses. Black smoke rises into the afternoon sky. She's methodically searching around the bodies as they burn, looking for anything useful.

The Millstone family is moving with organized efficiency:

- Thomas (still weak but determined) is hitching horses to two wagons
- Clara and Sarah are packing food stores, blankets, tools
- Jakob is loading weapons—axes, a few hunting knives, Thomas's rifle
- Helena has the two young children helping carry lighter items

They're clearly experienced at this—farm folk know how to pack up and move when necessary.

Dagmar Returns

After about 45 minutes, Dagmar comes back inside, wiping soot from her hands. She's carrying a small cloth bundle.

"Found something. Nothing on the bodies themselves—they came as beasts, no gear. But in the chicken coop..."

She unwraps the bundle to reveal:

1. Another wooden token - Crude carving of Malar's symbol, similar to the ones you destroyed at Tomás's farm
2. Dried blood in a circle - Ritual marking on the coop floor
3. A scrap of parchment - Partially burned, but you can make out writing:

"...Millstone marked. Five for the taking. Master demands—"

The rest is too burned to read.

Dagmar's face is grim: "They burned the coop to try to destroy evidence. This was a targeted hit, just like Tomás's place. The cult marked them, sent a specific team."

She points to the token. "Want me to destroy this one too, or keep it as evidence?"

Thomas approaches, overhearing:

"They came specifically for us? Why? What do they want?"

The family is almost ready to leave. You have maybe 10-15 minutes before departure.

Do you:

1. Destroy the token immediately (prevent any lingering curse/tracking)
2. Keep it as evidence (might learn more later)
3. Ask Thomas more questions about the attack
4. Check on the family's readiness to travel
5. Something else?

You said: To Thomas: "They wanted to turn you.

To Thomas: "They wanted to turn you. That's what they're doing - focusing on unwilling new recruits for their dark cause. It's one of the reasons we're out here searching the farms; we're hoping to find locations they haven't been able to reach yet, to save those marked for the curse."

I'd like to send the family ahead to Thornhaven since the way back seems to be safe. If I can destroy the totem quickly, I'll do that

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Explaining the Cult's Intent

Explaining the Cult's Intent

Thomas's face goes pale as the implications sink in:

"Turn us? Into... into those things?" He looks at his family—his wife, his children, his elderly mother. "All of us?"

Clara wraps her arms around herself, trembling: "The bite... Thomas, you were bitten. If Riv hadn't—"

"I know," Thomas says quietly, pulling her close. "I know. The cleric saved me from more than just death."

He looks at you with profound gratitude mixed with horror: "How many others? How many farms are marked?"

You show him the map. Five locations. His is one. Tomás's was another.

"Gods above..." He steels himself. "Then we need to warn the others. The Chen family, the Harrows—"

Sending the Family Ahead

You assess the situation tactically:

"Thomas, Clara—your family needs to get to Thornhaven. The route back is clear; we came that way and saw no threats. Two wagons, your whole family, armed and moving together. You should reach the village by evening."

Thomas nods: "We can make good time with the wagons. We know these roads."

"When you arrive, ask for Elder Wren or Garrick Ironheart at the barricades. Tell them Riv Freeborn sent you, that you're fighters willing to help defend. They'll get you settled."

Clara looks worried: "What about you? You're staying out here?"

Destroying the Totem

You turn to Dagmar: "I'm destroying it. We can't risk any lingering connection."

You take the wooden Malar token outside, place it on the ground, and kneel. Your holy symbol in hand, you pray:

"Lathander, Lord of Dawn, cleanse this corruption. Let your light burn away all darkness."

You channel divine energy—not a spell slot, just a brief prayer and focus. The token begins to smoke, then ignite with golden fire. Unlike normal fire, this burns clean and bright, consuming the profane carving completely until nothing remains but ash.

The ritual takes maybe 2-3 minutes.

The partial parchment you keep—it's evidence, and it's already mostly destroyed anyway.

The Family Prepares to Depart

The Millstones are loaded and ready:

- Two wagons, horses hitched
- Food, blankets, tools, weapons
- Eight people total: Thomas, Clara, Jakob, Sarah, Helena, and three young grandchildren (you realize there's a third small child you hadn't noticed before)

Thomas climbs onto the first wagon, still weak but capable. Jakob sits beside him with his axe and your blessed shield (which you haven't asked for back yet).

Clara drives the second wagon with Sarah and the children.

Thomas looks down at you:

"Cleric Freeborn. We owe you our lives. All of us." He touches the place where the bite was, now just a clean scar. "When you return to Thornhaven, you'll have the Millstone family standing with you. Whatever comes."

They begin rolling south toward Thornhaven, leaving you and Dagmar at the farm.

Dagmar watches them go, then turns to you:

"So. We've got maybe 4 hours of daylight left. The cult map shows three more locations:"

1. Harrow family - 2 hours northwest from here, edge of Darkwood (the closest one to Thornhaven that we skipped)
2. Chen family - 3 hours west from here (the direction the three escaped werewolves were heading this morning)
3. Brennan homestead - 4+ hours south (young family, evacuation candidates)

"We could push to one more location before we need to head back, or we could return to Thornhaven now with the intelligence we've gathered."

She looks at you seriously: "Your call, Cleric. What's the move?"

You said: "I think we have to realize that the Chen family is likely gone by now."

"I think we have to realize that the Chen family is likely gone by now. If we go to the Harrow family, we may yet save someone. There's no evidence the werewolves have made their way there just yet. And, sadly, I fear the Brennans are too far from us. To venture there, we would have to spend the night in danger, or risk walking through the dark to make it home in time. What do you think, Dag?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar nods slowly, her tracker's mind working through the logistics:

"Your instincts are good, Cleric. Let me think this through..."

She crouches and sketches in the dirt with a stick:

"Chen family—you're probably right. Three werewolves heading east at dawn, it's been... what, eight hours now? They'd have reached the Chens by mid-morning. Either the family's dead, turned, or the werewolves moved on. Either way, we're too late."

She marks another spot: "Brennans—four hours south from here, minimum. Gets us there near dusk. Then it's either camp overnight in hostile territory, or try to travel back in the dark." She shakes her head firmly. "Bad tactical position either way. Werewolves hunt at night. We'd be vulnerable."

She looks northwest: "Harrow family though... two hours from here puts us there mid-afternoon. They're close to Darkwood, which makes them vulnerable, but we haven't seen evidence of werewolf activity in that direction. If they're still alive and we can evacuate them quickly, we could be back on the road to Thornhaven by late afternoon, reach the village by nightfall."

She stands, slinging her bow: "Plus, the Harrows are closest to Thornhaven geographically. If the cult hasn't hit them yet, they're the most immediate threat to our defensive perimeter. It makes tactical sense."

She looks at you directly: "I say we go for Harrow. Save who we can, gather intelligence, get back before dark. We've already done good work today—saved the Millstones, killed two more werewolves. Let's not push our luck camping in werewolf territory."

She pauses: "But there's one thing we should consider—Jakob still has your shield. Do you want to catch up to the Millstone wagons and get it back, or let him keep it for their journey?"

Current Status:

- Time: Early afternoon, maybe 1-2 PM
- Location: Millstone Farm
- Your HP: 30/30 (fully healed)
- Spell Slots: 1x 1st level, 0x 2nd level
- Spiritual Weapon/Shield of Faith: Both expired
- Daylight remaining: ~4 hours

Decisions:

1. Head to Harrow family? (2 hours northwest)
2. Shield - catch up to Millstones to retrieve it, or let Jakob keep it for protection?

What's your call?

You said: "No, Jakob has more than earned a shield in his fight."

"No, Jakob has more than earned a shield in his fight. Besides, they need the extra defense. You and I have experience and the defense of the Divine Lathander. Let's take 5 minutes and search the family home here for anything we might deem useful that they did not, and then let's away to the Harrow family farm"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Searching the Millstone Farmhouse

Searching the Millstone Farmhouse

Dagmar grins at your decision about the shield:

"Good call. That boy held the line when it mattered. He's earned it."

She follows you back into the farmhouse. "Five minutes—let's be thorough."

Quick Search

You and Dagmar move efficiently through the ransacked home, looking for anything useful the Millstones might have missed in their hurried packing.

Roll an Investigation check: d20 + Intelligence modifier (let's say +0 for a Wisdom-focused Cleric)

What do you roll?

Meanwhile, Dagmar searches the barn and outbuildings with her tracker's eye.

What Dagmar Finds (while you roll):

She returns after a few minutes carrying:

1. A coil of good rope (50 feet, better quality than what you have)
2. A small pouch of silver coins (8 silver pieces, probably overlooked in the chaos)
3. Oil lantern and flask of oil (for nighttime if needed)
4. A whetstone (for maintaining weapons)

"Not much, but it might come in handy," she says, adding them to your packs.

What do YOU find? Give me that Investigation roll and we'll see what Riv's search turns up!

You said: I roll a 13

I roll a 13

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Investigation: $13 + 0 = 13$ (Solid Success)

Investigation: $13 + 0 = 13$ (Solid Success)

Your methodical search of the farmhouse turns up several items the Millstones overlooked in their hurried evacuation:

In the Kitchen:

- Dried herbs and medicinal supplies - A small bundle that Mother Nelle would appreciate. Could supplement your healing kit.
- Two days' worth of travel rations - Dried meat, hard cheese, preserved fruit. Better than standard rations.

In Thomas's Study (small room off the main floor):

- A detailed regional map - Much better than the crude cult map. Shows all the local farms, roads, landmarks, and even marks a few old hunting trails through Darkwood Forest.
- A journal - Thomas kept records of merchant visits, trade deals, and local news. Flipping through, you notice an entry from two weeks ago: "Strange travelers asking about local farms. Rough types. Told them nothing. Don't trust them."

In a Hidden Compartment (under the stairs - you almost missed it):

- 12 silver pieces - Emergency fund
- A silver chain necklace - Not magical, but actual silver. Could be melted down or used as a component if needed.

Upstairs in the Master Bedroom:

- A sturdy traveling cloak - Well-made, waterproof. Better than your road-worn one.
-

Dagmar whistles when she sees the regional map:

"Now that's useful. This shows trails I'd forgotten about—shortcuts through the forest that could save us hours." She studies it. "Look, there's a hunting trail that cuts from here almost directly to the Harrow farm. Takes us through the edge of Darkwood, but it's faster than going around by road. Could save us 30-45 minutes."

She looks at you: "Faster but riskier—forest trail—or slower but safer—open roads?"

You pack everything useful:

- Regional map
- Thomas's journal (evidence of cult activity)
- Silver coins and necklace
- Extra rations
- Medicinal herbs
- Better cloak

Updated Inventory: You're well-supplied for wilderness travel now.

The sun is past its zenith—early afternoon. You need to make your decision.

To the Harrow farm:

- Road route: 2 hours, open terrain, safer but slower
- Forest trail: 1.5 hours via shortcut, edge of Darkwood, faster but riskier

Which route do you take?

You said: "The sun is still shining and the canopy of the wood won't hurt that visibility much on the edge - let's take the shorter hunting trail."

"The sun is still shining and the canopy of the wood won't hurt that visibility much on the edge - let's take the shorter hunting trail. The werewolves themselves may have missed it."

I'd like to hold the silver pieces aside in my pack - I intend to give them back to the family when I rejoin them in Thornhaven. I equip the improved cloak, though.

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Taking the Forest Trail

Taking the Forest Trail

Dagmar nods approvingly:

"Smart thinking. The cult's werewolves have been using main approaches—they're hunters, not scouts. They might not know these old trails." She studies the map one more time, tracing the route with her finger. "We follow the creek bed northwest for about twenty minutes, then pick up the hunting trail at the old lightning-struck oak. From there it's a straight shot through the forest edge to Harrow land."

You carefully separate the 12 silver pieces, wrapping them in cloth and tucking them safely in your pack with a mental note: Return to Millstone family. The improved cloak settles comfortably on your shoulders—well-made and warm.

Into the Forest Edge

You set off northwest, leaving the Millstone farm behind. The terrain shifts from open farmland to the transitional zone where cultivation meets wilderness. The trees here are younger, the undergrowth manageable—this is the edge of Darkwood, not its ancient heart.

Dagmar moves confidently, reading the land like a book. You follow the creek bed as planned, the sound of running water masking your footsteps.

About 15 minutes in...

Dagmar suddenly stops, holding up a fist. She crouches low, examining something on the ground.

"Tracks," she whispers. "Recent. Maybe two hours old."

She points to the muddy creek bank. You can see them clearly now—wolf prints, massive, with that telltale shift from paw to boot and back again in the stride pattern.

"Just one set. Heading northwest." She looks up at you, concerned. "Same direction we're going. Toward Harrow land."

The hunting trail beckons ahead—the lightning-struck oak is visible maybe 100 yards through the trees. But these tracks suggest a lone werewolf passed through here recently, heading in the same direction you're traveling.

Options:

1. Continue carefully - Stay alert, move quietly, hope to avoid or spot the werewolf first
2. Track it actively - Follow the prints, try to locate and eliminate the threat before reaching the Harrows
3. Detour around - Take a wider route, avoid potential confrontation (adds time)
4. Turn back - Abandon Harrow mission, too risky

What's your call?

You said: "Recent."

"Recent. We've killed more than our share of these creatures. Let's put your experience to the test", Riv says with a wry smile. "Let's track this thing and see if we can remove it from play before it reaches the Harrows."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Hunt Begins

The Hunt Begins

Dagmar's eyes gleam with professional focus. She returns your smile with a predator's grin:

"Now you're thinking like a hunter, Cleric. Let's see what we're dealing with."

She kneels by the tracks, studying them intently:

"Single werewolf, moving at a steady pace—not running, not stalking. Just... traveling. See how the stride is even? It's not hunting right now, it's going somewhere specific." She touches the edge of a print. "Heavy too. Big one. Male, probably."

She looks up the trail: "It's staying in the creek bed for cover, just like we are. Smart. Makes it harder to track from a distance."

Tracking Check

Dagmar is an expert tracker, so she'll lead this effort. But you can assist—your Wisdom and perception might spot things she misses.

Dagmar's Survival check: She rolls... $17 + 4 = 21$. Excellent tracking.

She begins following the trail with confidence, moving quietly through the underbrush.

About 20 Minutes of Tracking

You've covered maybe half a mile, staying low and quiet. The tracks continue northwest, parallel to the hunting trail but staying in natural cover.

Dagmar holds up another halt signal. She points ahead through the trees.

"Movement. 200 yards, near that rocky outcrop."

You crouch beside her, peering through the foliage. There—you can just make out a large shape moving through the trees. Still in the distance, but definitely something big.

Dagmar whispers: "That's our werewolf. And it's stopped moving. It's... waiting for something? Or watching something?"

She scans the area, then her face goes pale:

"Riv. Look left of the outcrop. Smoke."

You see it—a thin wisp of chimney smoke rising through the trees, maybe 300 yards ahead.

"That's not Harrow land yet. That's..." She checks the map quickly. "An isolated cabin. Not marked on the cult map, probably because it's so remote. Someone lives out here."

The werewolf is positioned between you and that cabin, seemingly watching it.

Tactical Situation:

- Werewolf: 200 yards ahead, near rocky outcrop, watching an isolated cabin
- Cabin: 300 yards ahead, occupied (chimney smoke), unknown inhabitants
- You and Dagmar: In cover, undetected so far
- Terrain: Forest, good cover, rocky areas providing elevation
- Time: Mid-afternoon, good visibility

Your options:

1. Ambush the werewolf now - Attack while it's distracted
2. Sneak closer - Get into better position before engaging

3. Try to warn the cabin - Risk alerting the werewolf but save potential victims
4. Observe longer - See what the werewolf does
5. Circle around - Bypass entirely, continue to Harrow farm

What's your move?

You said: Riv whispers to Dagmar: "How close can you get without spooking it?"

Riv whispers to Dagmar: "How close can you get without spooking it? I say we take this thing out now and check in on the cabin together."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar's Assessment

Dagmar studies the terrain with her hunter's eye, mapping out angles of approach:

"The outcrop gives good cover. See how the werewolf is focused on the cabin? Its attention is fixed forward." She points out a path. "I can use that ravine to get within 80, maybe 60 yards. At that range, with my bow and a silvered arrow..."

She checks her quiver quietly: "I've got 12 arrows left, three of them silvered. If I get a clean shot while it's distracted, I can put silver through its heart before it knows we're here."

She looks at you seriously: "But if I miss, or if it doesn't go down on the first shot, it'll know we're here. It might charge us, or it might attack the cabin out of spite. Your call—do you want me to try for the kill shot, or do we both move up together for a coordinated attack?"

Options:

1. Dagmar takes the shot solo - She sneaks into position (~60-80 yards), you stay back as backup. High risk/high reward—if she drops it with one arrow, the threat is eliminated silently. If not, things get messy.
2. Both advance together - You move up with her, cast a buff spell (like Bless), then coordinate a simultaneous attack (her arrow + your Guiding Bolt). More reliable but slightly higher chance of being detected during approach.
3. You create a distraction - You move to draw its attention while Dagmar flanks for the perfect shot. Risky for you, but gives her advantage.

Which approach do you prefer?

Also: Do you want to prepare any spells before engaging? You have 1x 1st-level slot remaining.

You said: "I trust you, Dagmar."

"I trust you, Dagmar. More than that, Lathander trusts you through me. I bless you, under Lathander's guidance, to bring this beast down quickly."

With that, Riv casts Bless on Dagmar

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Divine Blessing

Divine Blessing

You place your hand on Dagmar's shoulder, your holy symbol glowing softly with golden light. You speak the prayer quietly but firmly:

"Lathander, Morninglord, guide this hunter's hand. Let her arrow fly true, let her aim strike sure. Bless her with your dawn's precision."

BLESS CAST - Dagmar gains a d4 bonus to attack rolls and saving throws for the next minute (10 rounds). This could be the difference between a hit and a miss, between success and disaster.

Dagmar feels the divine energy settle over her—a warmth, a clarity, a steadying of her hands. She looks at you with genuine gratitude:

"Thank you, Cleric. I won't waste this."

She checks her bow one final time, selects one of her three precious silvered arrows, and nods.

"Stay here. Keep eyes on the cabin. If this goes wrong, be ready to engage fast. If it goes right..." She allows herself a small, predatory smile. "We'll be checking on those cabin folk in a few minutes."

Dagmar's Stalk

She moves like smoke through the forest—silent, low, using every bit of cover. You watch her progress: tree to tree, rock to rock, down into the ravine, then up along the far side.

The werewolf remains focused on the cabin, unaware.

Dagmar reaches her position—you estimate about 70 yards from the target. She's partially concealed behind a fallen log, with a clear line of sight. She nocks the silvered arrow, draws back slowly...

The Shot

Dagmar's Attack Roll:

- Base roll: 15
- Attack bonus: +5 (her proficiency and Dexterity)
- BLESS d4: She rolls... 3

Total: 15 + 5 + 3 = 23 to hit

The werewolf's AC is typically around 12-13 in hybrid form.

CRITICAL SUCCESS.

The Arrow Flies

TWANG.

The silvered arrow is a streak of death through the afternoon air.

It strikes the werewolf directly in the back, punching through between the shoulder blades and into the heart. The silver burns as it penetrates, the blessed metal searing corrupted flesh from within.

The werewolf tries to howl—

But nothing comes out except a wet gasp.

It staggers forward two steps, clawing at its back trying to reach the arrow, then crashes face-first into the rocky ground.

Silence.

Dagmar waits, arrow nocked again, watching for any movement.

Ten seconds. Twenty. Thirty.

The werewolf doesn't move. Doesn't breathe.

Clean kill. One shot.

Dagmar signals you forward with a wave. You emerge from cover and make your way to her position.

By the time you reach the rocky outcrop, Dagmar is standing over the corpse. The werewolf is massive even in death—nearly eight feet of muscle and fur, with old scars suggesting this was a veteran. The silvered arrow protrudes from its back, smoke still rising from where the blessed metal contacted lycanthropic flesh.

Dagmar pulls the arrow free carefully, checking it for damage. Still usable.

"Lathander's blessing made the difference," she says quietly. "That extra guidance... felt like the shot was meant to be."

She wipes the arrow clean and returns it to her quiver. "One threat down. Now let's check on that cabin."

The Isolated Cabin

You approach cautiously. It's a small, well-maintained structure—maybe 20 feet by 20 feet, with a stone chimney from which smoke still rises. There's a small garden plot (mostly harvested for winter), a woodpile, and what looks like animal snares hanging from a tree.

Someone lives here alone. A hermit, most likely.

As you get closer, you hear movement inside. Then a voice—male, older, suspicious:

"I can hear you out there. State your business or move along. I've got a crossbow and I know how to use it."

How do you approach this?

Your current status:

- HP: 30/30
- Spell slots: 0x 1st level (used Bless), 0x 2nd level
- Bless still active on Dagmar (about 9 rounds/54 seconds remaining)

You said: "Ho there, lone hermit."

"Ho there, lone hermit. I'm Riv Freeborn, divine champion of Lathander and Defender of Thornhaven. We just slew a werewolf watching your cabin. We wish to offer you shelter and request your aid in the defense of Thornhaven from these creatures."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Hermit's Response

The Hermit's Response

There's a long pause. You hear the sound of a crossbow being set down, then bolts being drawn back on the door.

The door cracks open, and a weathered face peers out—a man in his late fifties, gray-bearded, scarred, with sharp, intelligent eyes. He's wearing simple woodsman's clothing, and you can see the crossbow leaning against the wall behind him.

He looks you up and down—taking in your chain mail, holy symbol, mace, the fresh blood on your cloak from today's fighting. Then he looks at Dagmar with her bow.

"Werewolf, you say?"

He steps out cautiously, moving past you toward the rocky outcrop. When he sees the massive corpse, he stops dead.

"Hells and damnation. You weren't lying."

He approaches the body carefully, studying it. "Big male. Old scarring. This one's been turned for years, not weeks." He looks back at you with new respect. "You killed it clean. One shot to the heart, silver arrow. Professional work."

He returns to you, extending a calloused hand:

"Name's Voss. Henrik Voss. Been living out here fifteen years, mostly keeping to myself." His grip is firm. "You said it was watching my cabin?"

When you confirm, his face darkens:

"Then they know I'm here. Probably scouting, seeing if I was worth the effort." He spits. "I've fought lycanthropes before—back in my soldiering days. Nasty business. Thought I'd left that life behind."

He looks toward Thornhaven's direction, then back at his cabin:

"Defender of Thornhaven, you said? I've heard of that village. Small farming community, about... what, three hours west?"

Voss considers your offer:

"You want me to abandon my home and come fight werewolves with you." It's not quite a question. "What's the situation? How many of these things are we talking about? And what's Thornhaven offering besides the chance to get torn apart?"

He's skeptical but clearly experienced. This is a man who's seen combat before.

How do you convince him? What do you tell him about:

1. The cult threat (scope and danger)
2. Thornhaven's defenses (what you're building)

3. What he'd gain (safety, community, purpose?)

Also—do you mention the cult map and the marked farms, or keep that intelligence closer to your chest?

You said: "Our honor to meet you Voss.

"Our honor to meet you Voss. As I said, I'm Riv Freeborn. My companion here is Dagmar. If you've fought lycanthropes before you know what a danger they pose. These werewolves are organized, drawn together by a cult of Malar. They seem intent on taking Thornhaven, but we can't rule out their interest in Millford to the south. We've brought the stout of heart together to save this village; Garrick, our blacksmith, leads our defenses; Dagmar, here, and her apprentice Finn, support our ranged guard. Myself and Mother Nelle, well, we handle the divine judgment, though I'm proud to say I'm picking up lessons from both Garrick and Dagmar as well. We're on our way to the Harrow Farm where we hope to find survivors. With another experienced werewolf hunter like you, we may yet save some lives and bring peace to this country."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Voss's Decision

Voss's Decision

Voss listens intently, his soldier's mind clearly assessing the tactical situation. When you mention the cult of Malar, his expression hardens:

"Malar. The Beastlord." He shakes his head grimly. "I've seen his cultists' work before. This isn't random attacks—this is organized conversion. They're building an army."

He looks at the dead werewolf again, then back at you:

"You said you're heading to the Harrow farm? Old couple and their son Jakob, if I remember right. Good people. About an hour northwest from here through the woods." He pauses. "If the cult's hitting isolated homesteads systematically, the Harrows are perfect targets—close to Darkwood, far from help."

He makes his decision quickly:

"I'll come. But not just to Thornhaven—I'm coming with you to the Harrows first." He gestures to his cabin. "This place has been my sanctuary for fifteen years, but it's just wood and stone. If Malar's cult is operating in this region, nowhere's safe alone."

He moves with practiced efficiency, stepping back into his cabin. You hear him gathering supplies quickly—this is a man who knows how to pack for a mission.

He emerges two minutes later wearing:

- Studded leather armor (well-maintained, military grade)

- A longsword at his hip (the grip worn smooth from use)
- Crossbow and quiver (20 bolts)
- A weathered traveling pack

Most notably: He's carrying a small wooden box, which he opens to show you—four silvered crossbow bolts.

"Had these made years ago. Never thought I'd need them again." He loads one into his crossbow. "Let's go save the Harrows."

Your Party Has Grown:

Henrik Voss - Veteran monster hunter, experienced combatant, armed with silvered ammunition

Dagmar looks impressed: "Another fighter. Good. The odds just got better."

Voss takes point, leading through the forest:

"I know a direct route to Harrow land. We can be there in forty minutes if we move fast." He glances at the sun. "We've got maybe two and a half hours of daylight left. Let's make them count."

As you travel, Voss asks tactical questions:

"This cult—how many werewolves have you confirmed? What's their attack pattern? Any leaders identified?"

Do you share intelligence about:

1. Korthak the Alpha (waiting outside Thornhaven's ward)
2. The Master (cult leader)
3. The marked farms (the cult map)
4. Your victories so far (Aldric saved, Tomás farm, Millstone farm, totems destroyed)

What do you tell him as you travel?

You said: "I won't lie - we don't know their exact number."

"I won't lie - we don't know their exact number. We know a few things for certain. They're lead by The Master, though we haven't an inkling into who or what The Master is yet. There's an Alpha waiting outside Thornhaven; again, we don't know for what. But we're using every moment to

gather our defenses. We aren't without our victories either. I managed to turn one of the beasts back - a recently turned merchant, turned against his will. I saved him from the curse with an old scroll I found in a library years back. It wasn't easy, but it was worthwhile. He's been invaluable to us since. We saved two families in the past two days: Tomás and his young son, Willem; and the Millstones who had a farm about an hour from here. You may have dealt with them in the past. They're on their way back to Thornhaven now. We have reliable intelligence that's leading us towards marked farms - the Harrows are one such farm."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Voss Processes the Intelligence

Voss Processes the Intelligence

As you move through the forest at a steady pace, Voss listens carefully, his military training evident in how he absorbs tactical information:

"An Alpha waiting outside your ward... that's patience. Discipline." He frowns. "Most werewolf packs are chaotic—alphas lead through dominance and immediate violence. If this one is waiting, following orders from 'The Master,' you're dealing with something more organized than a typical lycanthrope pack."

When you mention saving Aldric with the scroll, Voss stops briefly to look at you with genuine respect:

"You broke the curse? Completely?" He shakes his head in amazement. "I've heard tales of such things, but never met anyone who actually managed it. Most clerics can only contain the curse, not reverse it." He nods approvingly. "Lathander chose well with you."

Regarding the families saved:

"Millstone—Thomas and Clara? Yeah, I traded with them a few times over the years. Good folk. Big family." He looks relieved. "If they made it out, that's... what, eight people? Ten? That's significant. Bodies that can fight or support."

About the Marked Farms:

Voss's expression darkens:

"Marked farms. So they're not just hunting randomly—they're targeting specific locations." His soldier's mind works through the implications. "That means reconnaissance, planning, coordination. This cult has been watching the area, identifying isolated targets."

He glances at you: "How many farms on your intelligence list?"

When you mention five total, he does quick mental math:

"You've hit two—Tomás and Millstone. Harrow makes three. That leaves two more potentially marked targets." He pauses. "Unless there are more marked locations you don't know about yet."

Approaching Harrow Land

After about thirty-five minutes of swift travel, Voss holds up a fist—the universal military signal to halt.

"Harrow farm is just ahead. Quarter mile through those trees."

He kneels, examining the ground, then his face goes grim:

"Fresh tracks. Multiple sets. Wolf prints, large." He traces them with his finger. "At least three, maybe four different individuals. Heading toward the farm."

He looks at the sun's position: "These are maybe... an hour old? Hour and a half?"

Dagmar kneels beside him, confirming: "He's right. Recent. And look—" She points to disturbed earth, scattered leaves. "They weren't being stealthy. They were moving with purpose."

Voss stands, checking his crossbow:

"We need to approach carefully. Could be three scenarios:

One: The attack already happened. Harrows are dead or turned, werewolves moved on.

Two: The attack is happening now. We arrive mid-assault.

Three: The werewolves are setting up an ambush or waiting for nightfall."

He looks to you—you're the leader here:

"How do we approach, Defender? Fast and loud to interrupt an attack in progress, or slow and careful to assess first?"

Your call:

Current status:

- Your HP: 30/30
- Spell slots: All expended (used on Millstone rescue and Bless)

- Party: You (unarmed except mace, no shield), Dagmar (bow, 12 arrows, 3 silvered), Voss (crossbow with 4 silvered bolts, longsword)
- Time: Late afternoon, ~2 hours of daylight remaining
- Bless: Expired

How do you approach the Harrow farm?

You said: "We move quietly."

"We move quietly. You both have ranged weapons. Let's get as close as we can, keeping to cover. I'll break cover first and move forward. You two keep me covered with ranged fire."

"It feels like we're developing a pattern here", Riv says quietly to Dagmar

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: A Familiar Strategy

A Familiar Strategy

Dagmar smirks despite the tension:

"Third time today using you as bait, Cleric. At least you're getting good at it." Her tone is teasing but there's genuine concern underneath. "Just remember—you don't have your shield anymore. You're more vulnerable than at Millstone."

Voss raises an eyebrow: "You've done this twice already today? And you're both still breathing?" He nods with grudging approval. "Then it's a tactic that works. I'll follow your lead."

The Approach

The three of you move forward in tactical formation:

- Voss takes the left flank, moving tree to tree with military precision
- Dagmar takes the right, her hunter's instincts guiding her through cover
- You advance carefully between them, ready to break into the open

The forest thins as you approach Harrow land. Through the trees, you begin to see the farm:

What You Observe (Quarter Mile Out):

A small homestead—much smaller than Millstone. One modest farmhouse, a barn, a chicken coop, and a goat pen. Simple, well-maintained, the kind of place worked by people who live close to the land.

But something is wrong.

- The goats are scattered and bleating nervously
- The front door of the farmhouse is closed but you can see scratch marks on it
- One of the barn doors hangs crooked, partially broken
- No smoke from the chimney (unusual for late afternoon when people would be preparing dinner)
- No movement that you can see

Most concerning: You smell smoke, but not cooking smoke—burning wood, like something was set ablaze recently and has since burned out.

Closer Approach (100 Yards Out):

Voss signals another halt. He's spotted something:

"There. By the barn. See it?"

You follow his gaze and your blood runs cold.

A body. Lying face-down in the dirt between the house and barn. Adult male, wearing farmer's clothes. Not moving.

Dagmar whispers: "Is that... is that Jakob Harrow? The son?"

Voss's jaw tightens: "Can't tell from this distance. Could be Jakob, could be old man Harrow."

50 Yards Out:

You're close enough now to see more details:

- The body has claw marks across the back—massive, deep gouges
- Dark blood pools around it, mostly dried (been there for hours)
- The scratch marks on the farmhouse door are fresh and violent
- One window is shattered from the inside

Still no movement. No sounds except the nervous goats.

Voss and Dagmar are in position behind solid cover—Voss behind a stone fence, Dagmar in a treeline with clear sightlines.

Both have weapons ready, covering you.

This is it. Decision point.

Voss whispers across the distance: "Ready when you are, Defender."

Dagmar nods, arrow nocked: "I've got you covered."

Do you:

1. Break cover and approach the farmhouse openly (original plan—draw out threats)
2. Approach the body first (check if it's survivable, gather information)
3. Call out loudly before approaching ("Harrow family! It's Riv Freeborn!")
4. Have Voss or Dagmar scout closer first while you hang back
5. Something else?

The farm is eerily quiet. Whatever happened here, it happened hours ago. But that doesn't mean the danger is gone.

What's your move?

You said: "I'm going to circle around and check the body."

"I'm going to circle around and check the body. Doesn't look promising, but worth checking out. Dag, cover me. Voss, take a closer look if you can. If there's more to know, I want to know it as soon as possible"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Tactical Movement

Tactical Movement

Voss nods sharply: "I'll circle left, check the barn and outbuildings. If there's anyone hiding—or anything waiting—I'll spot it."

Dagmar settles into her position, bow trained on the farmhouse: "Go. I've got overlapping fields of fire on both the house and barn. Anything moves, I'll drop it."

Approaching the Body

You move carefully from cover to cover, advancing in a wide arc toward the fallen figure. Chain mail doesn't allow for complete silence, but you move as quietly as you can.

30 yards... 20... 10...

The smell hits you first—blood, death, and something else. Fear-sweat. This person died terrified.

You reach the body and kneel beside it.

It's an adult male, mid-sixties, wearing simple farmer's clothing. The gray hair and weathered hands suggest this is old man Harrow, not Jakob the son.

Examining the body:

- Massive claw wounds across his back and shoulders—four parallel gashes that tore through cloth and deep into flesh
- Partially eaten—bite marks on the shoulder and side (you suppress the urge to be sick)
- Dead for hours—rigor mortis is setting in, blood is fully dried
- He died running—his position suggests he was fleeing from the barn toward the house when he was caught from behind

He never had a chance.

As you examine him, you notice something clutched in his stiffened hand:

A small wooden carving—crude, amateur work. It looks like a child's toy, maybe a horse or goat. Something a grandfather might make for a grandchild.

Despite everything, he was holding onto it when he died.

From your left, Voss's voice, quiet but urgent:

"Riv. Barn."

You look up. Voss is positioned near the barn entrance, peering inside. He gestures you over—carefully, quietly.

At the Barn

You move to join him, and he points inside without speaking.

The interior of the barn is a nightmare:

- Two more bodies—one clearly the old woman (Mrs. Harrow), the other a younger woman you don't recognize. Both savaged, partially consumed.
- Blood everywhere—walls, floor, straw
- The horses are gone—either killed and dragged off, or fled
- Signs of a struggle—overturned tools, broken wood

And in the back corner, barely visible in the dim light:

Someone is hiding.

You can see a huddled shape behind a pile of hay bales, trying to stay absolutely still.

Voss has his crossbow half-raised but hasn't fired. He's waiting for your call.

The shape is human-sized, breathing rapidly (you can see the movement), and clearly aware you're here.

It could be:

- A survivor (Jakob? Someone else?)
 - A turned werewolf in human form, pretending to be wounded
 - Someone infected but not yet turned
-

How do you approach this?

Do you:

1. Call out gently - Try to coax them out peacefully
2. Demand they show themselves - Authoritative but potentially frightening
3. Approach slowly with hands visible - Show you're not a threat
4. Have Voss keep them covered while you advance
5. Something else?

This could be the survivor you're looking for, or it could be a trap.

You said: "Voss, keep your silver trained on it, but don't fire unless it shows open hostility."

"Voss, keep your silver trained on it, but don't fire unless it shows open hostility. These creatures are compelled. We break the compulsion, they change a little bit. This might be an opportunity to learn something."

I make my way closer, hands raised to show I'm not holding a weapon and call out, gently: "I'm Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. I'm here to help"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: A Tense Encounter

A Tense Encounter

Voss keeps his crossbow leveled but nods: "Understood. I've got the shot if needed." The silvered bolt gleams in the dim barn light.

You move forward slowly, hands visible, holy symbol catching what light filters through the barn's cracks. Your voice is calm, reassuring:

"I'm Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. I'm here to help. You're safe now."

The Response

The huddled shape flinches at your voice, pressing further back into the corner. You hear rapid, panicked breathing—almost hyperventilating.

Then a voice, young, male, terrified:

"D-don't come closer! I don't... I can't control it... Stay back!"

It's Jakob Harrow. The son. Early twenties, not the teenager you were picturing.

He shifts slightly and you can see him now in the dim light:

- Covered in blood—some his, some clearly not
- Massive bite wound on his forearm—still bleeding, poorly bandaged with torn cloth
- Eyes wild with fear and pain
- Shaking uncontrollably

Most tellingly: His fingernails are elongating. Dark hair is beginning to sprout along his arms. The transformation has started.

"They bit me," Jakob gasps, tears streaming down his face. "Last night. They killed Ma and Pa and Sarah. I hid. I've been hiding all day but I can feel it... I can feel the beast..."

His eyes meet yours—still human, still desperate:

"Please. I don't want to become one of them. I don't want to hurt anyone." His voice cracks. "Can you... can you help me? Or should you just... just end it now before I turn?"

Voss's Assessment (quietly):

"He's mid-transformation. Hours into it, maybe eight or ten hours since the bite. The curse is taking hold." His finger stays near the trigger. "I've seen this before. He's got maybe minutes to hours before he loses himself completely. Once the first full transformation happens, breaking the curse becomes nearly impossible without powerful magic."

Your Options:

You used your Remove Curse scroll on Aldric already. You don't have another one. Your Lesser Restoration spell (which you used on Thomas Millstone) only works if caught within the first few hours—Jakob is well past that window.

Possible courses of action:

1. Attempt a ritual cleansing - Would require time you don't have, materials you don't have, and might not work this far into transformation
 2. Restrain him and bring him to Mother Nelle - She might have more powerful magic or knowledge. But transporting a partially-turned werewolf back to Thornhaven is extremely dangerous
 3. Try Lesser Restoration anyway - You're out of spell slots, so this isn't possible right now
 4. Mercy kill - End it before he fully turns and potentially kills others
 5. Try to talk him through resisting the transformation - Willpower and faith might slow it, but probably won't stop it
 6. Offer him a choice - Explain the options honestly, let him decide his fate
-

Jakob is looking at you with desperate hope—the hope that a cleric of Lathander can perform a miracle.

What do you do?

You said: "Jakob, I want you to stay with me."

"Jakob, I want you to stay with me. I'm going to be honest with you, but I need you to be honest with me too. First, do you feel a pull towards any particular place in your farm? Is there something here compelling you to turn?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Jakob's Struggle

Jakob's Struggle

Jakob closes his eyes, breathing hard, clearly fighting something internal. His hands clench and unclench—you can see the fingernails lengthening with each spasm.

"A pull... yes. There's..." He struggles to articulate it. "In the house. Upstairs. My parents' room. There's something there. I can feel it. Like... like it's calling to me. Promising power. Promising I'll never be weak again."

His eyes snap open, and for just a moment they flash yellow before returning to human brown.

"It wants me to go there. To complete the change. To embrace it." He shudders violently. "But I'm fighting it. I'm fighting so hard..."

Voss glances at you, his expression knowing: "Another totem. Like the ones you destroyed at the other farms. The cult marks their targets with cursed objects that draw and bind the transformed."

Jakob continues, his voice becoming more strained: "After they bit me, after they killed everyone... the big one, the leader, he dragged something upstairs. I heard him... chanting? Praying? To something called Malar. Then they left. But that thing stayed. And now it won't stop calling to me."

He looks at you desperately: "If you destroy it... whatever it is... will that help? Will it stop the change?"

Voss speaks quietly:

"The totems create compulsion and accelerate transformation. Destroying it might slow the curse's progression, maybe even give him a chance to fight it off if his will is strong enough." He pauses. "But the bite itself... that's already taken root. Destroying the totem isn't a cure, it's just removing one more push toward damnation."

Dagmar's voice from outside:

"Riv! We've got maybe 90 minutes of daylight left. If we're going to search that house, we need to do it now."

Jakob looks at you:

"Please. Destroy whatever's up there. Even if... even if it doesn't save me, at least no one else will be drawn here. At least I can fight it without that thing in my head."

Your decision:

1. Go destroy the totem immediately - Leave Jakob restrained/guarded, clear the house
2. Bring Jakob with you - Keep him close, destroy totem together (risky—what if he turns mid-mission?)
3. Have someone stay with Jakob while you investigate (splits the party)
4. Try something else first

What's your call?

You said: Riv calls out to Dagmar: "Dag, another totem in the house!"

Riv calls out to Dagmar: "Dag, another totem in the house! I need you to stay with Jakob here and talk him through staying human. I'm going into the house to destroy the totem."

To Voss: "Keep that silver trained on him, but we're not trying to kill an innocent. You only pull the trigger if he turns, understood?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Orders Given

Orders Given

Dagmar appears in the barn doorway, taking in the scene immediately—the terrified young man, the signs of transformation, the tension in the air.

"Understood. I'll keep him calm." She moves into the barn, setting her bow aside but keeping a knife visible. She sits down about ten feet from Jakob, her posture non-threatening but alert. "Hey Jakob. I'm Dagmar. I'm going to stay here and talk with you while the cleric handles this, alright?"

Jakob nods weakly, grateful not to be alone.

Voss meets your eyes, his expression serious:

"I don't kill innocents, Defender. But I will kill monsters before they hurt good people." He adjusts his aim slightly, keeping the silvered bolt trained but not aggressive. "If he starts to turn, I'll give him one warning. After that..." He doesn't finish, but the meaning is clear.

To Jakob, more gently: "Fight it, son. You've lasted this long—keep fighting."

Dagmar begins talking quietly to Jakob:

"Tell me about your family. What were they like? What did your father teach you?"

You hear Jakob's voice, shaky but responding: "Pa taught me carpentry. He made that little horse carving I found in his hand... he was making it for... for my sister's baby..."

Dagmar keeps him talking, keeps him human, keeps him focused on memories rather than the beast.

Entering the Farmhouse

You step out of the barn and approach the scratched, damaged front door. It's closed but not locked—the Harrows probably tried to barricade themselves inside before being overwhelmed.

You push it open. The hinges creak.

Inside:

The main floor is ransacked but not as blood-soaked as the barn. Furniture overturned, dishes smashed, signs of desperate struggle. A family's life torn apart in minutes.

You can feel it now too—that pull Jakob mentioned. Not as strong for you since you're not cursed, but there's definitely something wrong upstairs. A wrongness in the air, a chill that has nothing to do with temperature.

Dark magic.

The stairs leading up creak under your weight. Each step feels heavier than the last, like the house itself doesn't want you going up there.

Upstairs Landing

Three doors: two bedrooms and a storage room.

The pull is coming from the right-hand bedroom—the master bedroom, presumably. The door is slightly ajar.

As you approach, you hear it: a low, rhythmic humming. Not mechanical. Not natural. Something in between. Like the sound of a thousand insects, or wind through a cave, or voices whispering just below the threshold of understanding.

You push the door open.

The Master Bedroom

The room has been deliberately arranged into a ritual space:

- The bed pushed aside
- A circle drawn on the floor in blood (still wet, gleaming)
- Candles burned down to stubs (long since extinguished)
- And in the center: a carved wooden idol

This one is more elaborate than the crude tokens you've seen before. About a foot tall, carved from dark wood, depicting a bestial humanoid figure with claws and fangs—clearly Malar, the Beastlord.

Around its base: personal items from the Harrow family—a wedding ring, a lock of hair, a child's toy. Binding them to the curse.

The idol pulses with malevolent energy. You can feel it trying to push you away, trying to make you afraid, trying to make you submit.

From downstairs, faintly, you hear Jakob scream:

"It knows! It knows you're there! It's fighting me! I can't—"

Dagmar's voice, firm: "Jakob, look at me! Stay with me!"

The totem is reacting to your presence. And Jakob is running out of time.

You need to destroy this thing. NOW.

How do you do it?

Options:

1. Smash it with your mace (physical destruction, fast but might not fully cleanse the curse)

2. Burn it with holy prayer (ritual cleansing, slower but more thorough—might give Jakob more time to turn)
3. Try to disrupt the ritual circle first (break the binding, might weaken the totem)
4. Channel raw divine energy (risky without spell slots, but Lathander might answer)

What's your move? Jakob is struggling to stay human in the barn below.

You said: Holy prayer is all I have without spell slots.

Holy prayer is all I have without spell slots.

"Lathander, hear me. Your champion has asked for much these past few days. And each time, this Champion has thanked you for his warm meals, his soft bed, and his creature comforts. This is different, Morninglord. This time your champion asks not for his own comforts but for the comforts of a young man fighting for his life. I... I can't save him. He's too far gone. We can destroy this totem holding him under its curse, but even if we do..." Riv's voice trails off and tears fall from his eyes. "I'm scared, Lord Lathander. I don't know what to do. If we can't save him from this curse, we'll have no choice but to end this in bloodshed. Please, guide my hand. Show me how to save this boy from the curse of lycanthropy."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: A Prayer in Desperation

A Prayer in Desperation

You kneel before the cursed idol, tears streaming down your face, your holy symbol clutched in both hands. Your voice breaks with genuine anguish—not the practiced prayers of ritual, but the raw, desperate plea of a man facing his limitations.

"Lathander, hear me..."

As you pray, the idol seems to pulse harder, the humming growing louder, more aggressive. It's fighting you. The curse wants to keep its hold.

But you press on, your faith unwavering even as your voice trembles:

"...I'm scared, Lord Lathander. I don't know what to do..."

And then—

WARMTH.

Not the gentle warmth of sunrise. Not the comfortable glow of divine blessing.

This is the searing heat of the noonday sun. The burning radiance of pure, unyielding dawn.

Your holy symbol blazes with golden light so bright you have to close your eyes. The warmth spreads from your chest through your arms, into your hands, building like pressure behind a dam.

You hear a voice—not words exactly, but a feeling that translates into understanding:

"You cannot save everyone, my Champion. But you can give them the chance to save themselves."

The divine energy explodes from your hands.

The Cleansing

Golden radiance washes over the idol like a tidal wave of dawn. The carved wood catches fire—not normal fire, but holy flame that burns with white-gold intensity.

The idol screams.

Not metaphorically. It actually screams—a horrible, inhuman sound of rage and pain as the curse bound within it is torn apart by divine light.

The blood circle on the floor evaporates like morning dew. The personal items—the ring, the hair, the toy—are bathed in light and suddenly look clean again, freed from corruption.

The idol crumbles to ash. The humming stops.

Silence.

The oppressive weight in the room is gone. The air feels lighter. Cleaner.

From the barn, Jakob's voice—ragged but triumphant:

"It's... it's gone! The pull is GONE!"

Then, more desperately: "But I can still feel the beast! It's still there! I'm still..."

You stagger, exhausted. That wasn't a spell—that was something deeper. Direct divine intervention. Lathander heard your prayer and answered.

But the cost was real. You feel drained, like you've run for miles.

You gain 1 level of Exhaustion (disadvantage on ability checks until you complete a long rest).

You rush downstairs and back to the barn.

Jakob is still there, still human, but the transformation continues—slower now, fighting against itself without the totem's compulsion, but still progressing.

Dagmar looks at you with desperate hope: "The totem?"

"Destroyed," you confirm.

Jakob looks at you, and you can see the internal war raging in him. His eyes keep flickering between brown and yellow. Hair sprouts and recedes along his arms. His breathing is labored.

"I can fight it better now," he gasps. "Without that thing pulling at me. But Voss was right—the bite itself... it's still there. It's still trying to take me."

He meets your eyes: "How long until it wins?"

Voss lowers his crossbow slightly:

"The totem's destruction bought you time, son. But without a Remove Curse spell or something equally powerful..." He looks at you. "Mother Nelle. Does she have that kind of magic?"

You think about Mother Nelle—a priestess of Chauntea, skilled in rituals, experienced with divine magic. She might. It would require powerful ritual work, rare components, time... but she might be able to save him if you can get him back to Thornhaven.

But that's a 3-hour journey. At night. With a partially-transformed werewolf.

Jakob's fate hangs in the balance:

Options:

1. Attempt the journey to Thornhaven tonight - Risk traveling in darkness with Jakob fighting transformation the whole way
2. Stay here until morning - Fortify the farmhouse, let Jakob rest and fight the curse, travel at dawn (but he might not last that long)
3. Restrain Jakob and one person rushes to get Mother Nelle - Split the party, bring help here (faster but leaves Jakob vulnerable)
4. Accept that you've done all you can - The mercy kill option

What do you decide?

You said: "Jakob, you're strong."

"Jakob, you're strong. I've never seen someone fight the curse like you. My God, Lathander, is with us. We cannot fail. And we will save you. But I need you to choose: if you can hold out the night, we'll stay here with you, we'll comfort you, we'll talk to you, we'll guard you. And together we'll travel back to Thornhaven in the daylight. But if you can't make it, if you don't think you'll survive the night, we'll take an hour to rest now, and start making our way back to the village tonight. It's risky, we'll be exposed to werewolves, but we'll figure out our options for you sooner. It's your choice, lad. We're with you either way."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Jakob's Choice

Jakob's Choice

Jakob takes several shuddering breaths, visibly wrestling with the decision and the beast inside him. His hands clench and unclench—you can see the fingernails still elongating, then slowly receding as he fights it back.

"I can feel it," he says quietly. "Every minute, it's there, pushing. Whispering. Promising strength, freedom from pain, freedom from grief." He looks at the barn entrance where his family died. "It tells me I could hunt down the ones who did this. Make them pay."

He's silent for a long moment, then:

"But that's the beast talking. Not me."

He looks at each of you in turn—Dagmar, Voss, then finally you:

"I've lasted this long because I'm stubborn. My Pa always said I was too stubborn for my own good." A ghost of a smile. "I think... I think I can make it through the night. Especially if you're all here. Talking to me. Keeping me... keeping me Jakob."

He nods more firmly: "We stay until dawn. Then we go to Thornhaven together."

Voss's Assessment

"Smart choice. Traveling at night is when we're most vulnerable—both to outside threats and to Jakob's transformation. Werewolves are creatures of the night; the curse strengthens after dark."

He looks around the barn: "We can fortify this place. Bar the doors, set up watch rotations. Keep Jakob talking, keep him focused on his humanity."

Dagmar adds:

"We should take that hour of rest now, while we still have daylight. Eat, recover, prepare for a long night." She looks at you meaningfully. "Especially you, Riv. That divine intervention took something out of you. You need rest."

She's right—you can feel the exhaustion weighing on you, that level of exhaustion from channeling such raw divine power.

Preparing for the Night

The sun is getting low—maybe an hour of daylight remains. You have time to:

1. Take a short rest (you still have 2 Hit Dice available, could recover some HP if needed, though you're at full)
2. Fortify the barn (barricade doors, set up defensive positions)
3. Gather supplies from the farmhouse (food, water, blankets, anything useful)
4. Bury the dead (the Harrow family deserves that much, and it might help Jakob's mental state)
5. Scout the perimeter (make sure no threats are nearby)

You have roughly an hour before sunset. How do you want to spend it, and how do you want to organize the watch rotation for the night?

Current status:

- HP: 30/30
- Spell slots: 0/0 (all expended)
- Hit Dice remaining: 2/3
- Exhaustion level 1 (disadvantage on ability checks)
- Party: You, Dagmar (12 arrows, 3 silvered), Voss (20 bolts, 4 silvered), Jakob (fighting transformation)

You said: "One of us should stay with Jakob at all times."

"One of us should stay with Jakob at all times. I'll stay with him now, give him some food and water, and have some myself. Dag, go search the farmhouse for anything useful and bring it back here over the next hour. If it doesn't take you that long, start fortifying the barn."

Riv takes Voss aside: "Voss, we should bury the dead. I'll say a prayer for their souls, and I think it'll help Jakob fight the beast."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Organizing the Evening

Organizing the Evening

Dagmar nods: "On it. I'll be quick and thorough." She heads toward the farmhouse, moving with purpose.

Voss and the Dead

You pull Voss aside, speaking quietly so Jakob doesn't overhear the details:

"We should bury the dead. I'll say a prayer for their souls, and I think it'll help Jakob fight the beast."

Voss meets your eyes with understanding: "Agreed. The boy shouldn't have to spend the night in a barn with his family's corpses." His voice is gentle despite his gruff exterior. "I'll handle the digging—there's tools in the shed. You focus on Jakob and the prayers."

He pauses: "Three bodies. Old man Harrow outside, the two women in here. I'll start with shallow graves—we don't have time for deep ones before dark—but it'll be respectful."

He heads out, returning moments later with shovels. He gets to work outside first, choosing a spot near a small grove of trees on the property where the ground is softer.

With Jakob

You sit down across from Jakob, pulling out the rations you gathered from Millstone farm—dried meat, cheese, some bread. You offer him water from your waterskin.

"Here. You need to keep your strength up. Fighting the curse takes energy."

Jakob accepts the food but eats slowly, mechanically. His hands shake as he brings the food to his mouth.

"Thank you," he says quietly. "For staying. For not... for not just ending it."

He takes a drink of water, then looks at you:

"Can I ask you something, Cleric?"

When you nod, he continues:

"That merchant you saved—Aldric. You said you broke his curse completely with a scroll. If you'd had another scroll... would it have worked on me?"

His eyes search yours, not accusatory, just... needing to understand.

"I know you would have used it if you could. I'm not blaming you. I just... I need to know if there was ever a chance, or if I was doomed from the moment they bit me."

How do you answer Jakob? And what do you talk about during this hour to keep him focused on his humanity?

Meanwhile, you can hear:

- Voss digging outside, the rhythmic sound of shovel on earth
- Dagmar moving through the farmhouse, gathering supplies
- The nervous bleating of goats in the distance
- Jakob's labored breathing as he fights the transformation

The sun is sinking lower. Darkness approaches.

You said: "That scroll."

"That scroll... I used it in the heat of the moment, saving Aldric from the curse. I should have taken the time to copy it, to study it. It was miraculous, but you're not a goner yet. Just because we don't have the scroll doesn't mean we don't have options. What you've done already is beyond anything I've ever seen. You're resisting a curse! You must have amazing willpower. Have you ever considered becoming a Cleric? Lathander would look very favorably on one as strong as you"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Jakob's Response

Jakob's Response

Jakob looks surprised by the question, then lets out a short, bitter laugh that turns into something more genuine:

"A cleric? Me?" He shakes his head, but there's something thoughtful in his expression. "I'm just a farmer's son, Riv. I know how to fix a fence, birth a goat, read the weather for planting. Never thought much about the gods beyond saying prayers at harvest time."

He's quiet for a moment, then:

"But I've been praying a lot since last night. Praying to anyone who'd listen—Chauntea, Lathander, even gods I barely know the names of." His voice drops. "When the beast pushes at me, when it shows me these... these visions of hunting, of blood, of power... I push back with memories. Ma baking bread. Pa teaching me to carve. Little Sarah laughing..."

His voice breaks on his sister's name, but he steadies himself:

"If prayers and memories are the only weapons I have, then maybe... maybe there is something divine in that fight."

He looks at his hands—still mostly human, though the nails keep elongating and receding with each internal struggle:

"If I survive this. If Mother Nelle can save me..." He meets your eyes. "I don't know if I could be a cleric. But I know I'll never waste another day. Never take another sunrise for granted."

Outside

The sound of digging stops. Voss appears in the barn doorway, covered in dirt and sweat:

"First grave is ready. Old man Harrow." He looks at Jakob. "Son, do you want to be there when the cleric says prayers? Or would you rather remember your father as he was?"

Jakob struggles with the decision, then:

"I... I should be there. He deserves that much."

Dagmar returns carrying an armload of supplies:

"Found some useful things—blankets, rope, two more oil lamps, a half-wheel of cheese, dried herbs, and this." She holds up a small leather-bound book. "Jakob's father kept a journal. Might have information worth reading later."

She sets everything down, then sees the grave outside. Her expression softens with understanding.

The Burial

The four of you gather outside as the sun touches the horizon, painting the sky in golds and reds. Old man Harrow lies in the shallow grave, his weathered face finally at peace.

Jakob stands at the edge, trembling—from emotion or transformation, you can't tell. Probably both.

Voss and Dagmar stand respectfully back, giving you space.

Everyone is looking to you to lead the prayer.

What prayer do you offer for the Harrow family? This is your chance to speak not just to comfort the dead, but to strengthen Jakob's humanity through ritual and remembrance.

Also, after the burial, do you want to:

1. Bury all three together (one large ceremony)
2. Bury each separately (three shorter ceremonies, more personal)

The sun is setting. Night approaches.

You said: We don't have time to bury them separately, sadly.

We don't have time to bury them separately, sadly. We'll have to make a note to return after this whole thing is over and bury them properly.

"I never knew the Harrow family, but my understanding from their neighbors is that they were good people. People of the land, people of faith, people who loved and protected their own. And the family created beautiful, happy memories for their surviving son, Jakob, to carry forward with. Ma's bread, Pa's carpentry. Laughter and love. Lathander, Lord of the Dawn, watch over these wayward souls and protect the son they left behind. Protect this grave, dug in haste, until we return to give them a proper burial, the burial and service they deserve."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Prayer at Sunset

The Prayer at Sunset

Your words carry across the small farm as the last rays of sunlight paint everything in amber and gold. It's a simple prayer, honest and heartfelt—exactly what this moment needs.

As you speak, Jakob's shoulders shake with silent sobs. When you finish, he kneels beside the grave, placing his hand on the disturbed earth:

"I love you, Pa. I'll... I'll make you proud. Somehow."

Voss and Dagmar help move the two women's bodies from the barn to rest beside the old man. It's not proper—it's hasty, shallow, temporary—but it's respectful. It's what can be done.

The three graves are covered as the sun finally dips below the horizon.

Darkness Falls

The world shifts as night takes hold. The temperature drops. Shadows lengthen and deepen. And Jakob gasps, doubling over:

"It's... it's stronger at night. The pull. The hunger."

His eyes flash yellow, staying that way for several heartbeats before he forces them back to brown through sheer willpower.

Voss immediately moves to his side: "Inside. Now. We need you in the barn where we can watch you."

Fortifying for the Night

You all move quickly back into the barn. Dagmar has already begun fortifications:

- Barn doors barricaded with heavy beams and farm equipment
- Oil lamps positioned to provide maximum light
- Blankets and supplies arranged in the center
- Weapons within easy reach

Voss adds his military expertise:

"We set up watch rotation—two-hour shifts, two people awake at all times. One watches Jakob, one watches the perimeter." He looks at each of you. "Who wants first watch?"

Jakob's Condition

As darkness settles, Jakob's struggle intensifies visibly:

- Eyes flickering yellow more frequently
- Claws extending, requiring conscious effort to retract
- Breathing becoming more labored, occasionally growling
- Muscles tensing and spasming

But he's fighting. Every moment he stays human is a victory of will.

"Talk to me," he gasps. "Please. Don't let me think. Don't let the beast have silence."

Watch Rotation Options:

Shift 1 (Now - 2 hours): Who takes first watch? Shift 2 (2-4 hours): Shift 3 (4-6 hours): Shift 4 (6-8 hours until dawn):

Suggested pairings:

- You + Voss (divine support + military experience)

- You + Dagmar (your established partnership)
- Dagmar + Voss (both experienced in wilderness survival)
- Etc.

And what do you talk about with Jakob through the night? What stories, memories, or questions do you use to keep him anchored to his humanity?

The long night begins. Roll me a d20 for how well you handle the exhaustion and the watch—remember you have disadvantage on ability checks due to your exhaustion level.

You said: Four Shifts

Four Shifts

1. Me and Voss - Dag needs rest
2. Me and Dag
3. Vos and Dag
4. Me and Voss again - Dag has had the least rest of any of us since yesterday

I'd like to talk to Jakob about serving Lathander. The qualities I see in Jakob that I think would make him a good Cleric. Some stories of my fellow Clerics and their backgrounds. Some funny stories, some heartfelt ones. I'll let him ask me questions about Lathander and being a Cleric. I know he needs to focus his attention on not transforming, but if he wants to become a Cleric, I will happily offer training, if I can (how does training another character work in 5e?).

I roll a 12 for the exhaustion

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Long Night - Watch Rotation Set

The Long Night - Watch Rotation Set

The rotation is decided:

- Shift 1 (Now-2hrs): You + Voss
- Shift 2 (2-4hrs): You + Dagmar
- Shift 3 (4-6hrs): Voss + Dagmar
- Shift 4 (6-8hrs): You + Voss

Dagmar wraps herself in a blanket near the back of the barn: "Wake me when it's time. And if anything goes wrong before then." Within minutes, her breathing evens out—the sleep of an experienced wilderness traveler who can rest anywhere.

Exhaustion Check: 12

With disadvantage, you roll twice and take the lower. Let's say your second roll is... 8.

Result: $8 + 0$ (no Constitution bonus applies here) = 8

You're tired. The divine intervention earlier, the emotional weight of the day, the constant vigilance—it's all catching up to you. But you push through. Coffee would be amazing right now, but you make do with water and willpower.

Shift 1: You + Voss (First 2 Hours)

Voss sits near the barricaded door, crossbow across his lap, silvered bolt loaded. You sit closer to Jakob, keeping him engaged.

The young man's struggle is visible—every few minutes his features shift slightly, hair sprouting and receding, eyes flashing yellow. But he's holding.

"Tell me about serving Lathander," Jakob says, his voice strained but focused. "What's it like? How did you know it was your calling?"

Your Conversation with Jakob

You begin telling him about your path to Lathander:

"I wasn't born knowing I'd be a cleric. I grew up in [your backstory here - feel free to fill this in however you imagine Riv's past]. But I found Lathander—or he found me—when I needed hope most. The Morninglord doesn't demand perfection. He asks for renewal, for the courage to face each dawn, for the strength to bring light to dark places."

You tell him stories:

Funny story: About a fellow cleric named Brother Tammias who accidentally blessed an entire market's worth of fish, causing them to glow faintly for three days. The fishmongers were furious until they realized the blessed fish stayed fresh twice as long.

Heartfelt story: About Sister Elara, who came to Lathander after losing her entire family to plague. She spent her life healing others, turning her grief into purpose.

Jakob listens intently, occasionally asking questions:

"Do you have to be... perfect? To serve a god?"

"What if you've done things you're ashamed of?"

"If I become... if I survive this curse... would Lathander accept me? Knowing what I almost became?"

About Cleric Training in 5E:

In D&D 5th Edition, multiclassing or training typically happens during downtime between adventures. If Jakob survives:

- He could train as a Cleric over weeks/months of study and devotion
- You could mentor him during downtime in Thornhaven
- Mechanically: He'd start gaining Cleric levels instead of (or in addition to) whatever class levels he might eventually take
- Narratively: It would represent his spiritual transformation from farmer to holy warrior

You could absolutely offer to train him if he survives. It would be meaningful character development for both of you.

Voss Interjects Quietly

During a lull in conversation, Voss speaks from his position by the door:

"Boy—Jakob—you asked if you have to be perfect to serve a god." He doesn't look back, keeps watching the darkness outside. "I'll tell you what I learned in my years fighting monsters: The gods don't need perfect servants. They need willing ones. Broken people who choose to stand anyway. That's what makes a hero—not strength, but the choice to use whatever strength you have for something bigger than yourself."

He glances back: "You're fighting a curse that would have broken most men in hours. You've already proven you have what it takes."

Jakob nods, tears streaming down his face, but his eyes remain brown. Human.

About 90 Minutes Into First Watch

Jakob suddenly tenses, his whole body going rigid:

"Something's outside."

His nostrils flare—enhanced senses from the partial transformation. "Wolves. No... werewolves. Two of them. Maybe three hundred yards out. Moving this direction."

Voss immediately goes alert, peering through gaps in the barricaded door.

"I don't see anything yet, but if the boy can smell them..." He looks at you. "Do we wake Dagmar?"

Potential threats approaching. What do you do?

1. Wake Dagmar (all hands on deck)
2. Let her sleep (you and Voss can handle perimeter watch)
3. Prepare defensively (strengthen barricades, ready spells for morning)
4. Have Jakob communicate with them (he can sense them, maybe they can sense him?)

And how do you respond to Jakob's spiritual questions? His question about whether Lathander would accept him despite the curse is particularly important to answer.

You said: "I wasn't born knowing I'd be a cleric."

"I wasn't born knowing I'd be a cleric. I grew up in a small village, not so different from Thornhaven, but pretty far from here. We worshipped Lathander and I grew up with the prayers. We weren't wealthy by any means. Hells, I could barely read before I had 17 winters under my belt. But I found Lathander—or he found me—when I needed hope most. The Morninglord doesn't demand perfection. He asks for renewal, for the courage to face each dawn, for the strength to bring light to dark places."

Jakob's Question: "Do you have to be... perfect? To serve a god?"

Riv's Answer: "No. I'm far from perfect. I love warm meals and fresh linens and a fresh washbasin every day. I'm not even always doing this for the right reasons, I don't think. I love healing people. I love knowing that I helped someone find peace or find a new reason to live, or tending someone back from death's touch. But I don't always do it because I want to - sometimes I do it out of necessity or because someone's death might make things more difficult."

[Voss's answer here]

Jakob's Question: "What if you've done things you're ashamed of?"

Riv's Answer: "You're young, so here's something you might not know: everyone has something they're ashamed of. And anyone who says differently is lying. Something haunts us all. Lathander doesn't care that you're haunted - Lathander cares more than you find the strength to move on from it and do your best to let your mistakes prevent others from making those same mistakes."

Jakob's Question: "If I become... if I survive this curse... would Lathander accept me? Knowing what I almost became?"

Riv's Answer: "Lathander accepts everyone who works to push back the darkness. That's who He is: the Dawnbringer, the Morninglord. Lathander pushes back the darkness every day - He's a torch, a guiding light. And someone with your willpower? Lathander would never turn away someone with your strength of will."

The werewolves:

"Voss, do you have a clear shot?"

Riv moves to wake Dagmar and tells her to keep an eye on Jakob

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Your Words to Jakob

Your Words to Jakob

Your answers are honest, vulnerable, and real. Jakob listens with desperate intensity, clinging to every word like a lifeline.

When you speak about not being perfect, about loving comfort, about sometimes helping out of necessity rather than pure altruism, Jakob actually seems relieved:

"So... so I don't have to be a saint. I just have to... try?"

When you talk about being haunted, about everyone carrying shame, his eyes well up:

"I'm ashamed I hid. While they killed my family, I hid in the hay like a coward." His voice breaks. "I should have fought. Should have died with them."

But when you tell him Lathander would accept him—that strength of will matters more than perfection—something shifts in his expression. The yellow in his eyes recedes just a bit. His breathing steadies.

"Thank you," he whispers. "I'll... I'll keep fighting. For them. For Lathander. For myself."

The Approaching Threat

You move quickly to wake Dagmar, keeping your voice low:

"Dag. Werewolves outside. Three hundred yards and closing. Jakob can smell them."

Dagmar is awake instantly—that veteran's instinct. She grabs her bow, checks her arrows: "How many?"

"Two. Maybe three."

She positions herself near a gap in the barn wall where she can see out, arrow nocked with one of her precious silvered arrows.

"I've got eyes on Jakob," she confirms. "You two handle the perimeter."

Voss at the Door

You return to Voss, who's peering through a gap in the barricade:

"Do you have a clear shot?" you ask.

"Not yet. Too dark, too much distance." He adjusts his position slightly, crossbow ready. "But if they come closer..."

He pauses, then: "Wait. Movement. Two hundred yards, coming from the northwest."

You can see them now too—two large shapes moving through the darkness, staying low, circling the farm. They're not charging in. They're scouting. Assessing.

Jakob's Warning

"They know I'm here," Jakob says, his voice tight. "They can smell me. Smell the curse in me. They're... they're trying to call to me. Trying to make me come out."

His hands grip the hay beneath him, knuckles white: "It's so hard. They're offering... belonging. Pack. Power. They say the pain will stop if I just... just give in..."

Dagmar speaks firmly without taking her eyes off him: "Jakob. Look at me. You're staying human. You're staying here. You're not going anywhere."

The Werewolves Stop

At about 150 yards out, the two shapes stop moving. They're just... watching. Waiting.

Voss whispers: "They're being cautious. Smart. They don't know how many of us are in here or what weapons we have."

Then, from the darkness, a voice—deep, growling, but intelligible:

"WE SMELL OUR KIN. SEND HIM OUT. HE BELONGS WITH US NOW."

A pause, then:

"OR WE COME IN AND TAKE HIM."

Decision Point

The werewolves are making demands. You have several options:

1. Refuse and fortify - Make it clear you're not giving Jakob up, prepare for assault
2. Negotiate/stall - Try to buy time, keep them talking until dawn
3. Aggressive response - Have Dagmar or Voss take a shot, drive them off
4. Let Jakob respond - He might be able to communicate with them, maybe learn something
5. Something else?

What's your move, Defender?

Also: Do you have any spells or abilities that would be useful here? (You're still at 0 spell slots until you long rest, but you have your voice, your authority, your holy symbol...)

You said: I move back to Dagmar and tell her to line up a shot, then I go to Jakob's side to talk to him:

I move back to Dagmar and tell her to line up a shot, then I go to Jakob's side to talk to him:

"Here's where that strength gets tested, lad. The curse is offering you kinship, but let me make this promise to you here and now, with my God as my witness: when we make it out of this and I have you cured, I will train you as a Cleric of Lathander and you will always have a home and a family. We three here, we will not abandon you. We will protect you to our dying breath.

We need you to talk to them. Convince them that you're alone, or that you've killed us, mauled us within an inch of our lives. They smell us, but they don't know if we're alive or not. Be strong, Jakob. Tell them The Master compelled you to this farm, that Korthak gave the order himself. Be authoritative. Tell me you're in control of the situation and they're free to move on from here."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Jakob's Test

Jakob's Test

Your words hit Jakob like a physical force. He looks up at you with wide, terrified eyes—but also with something else. Hope. Purpose. A lifeline.

"You'd... you'd really train me? Make me part of something?"

When you confirm with absolute conviction, invoking Lathander as your witness, Jakob takes a shuddering breath. The yellow fades from his eyes almost completely. His claws retract.

"A home. A family." He nods, steeling himself. "Okay. Okay, I can do this."

The Deception

Jakob stands on shaky legs, moving toward the barn door. Voss shifts to give him space while keeping his crossbow ready. Dagmar has her silvered arrow trained on the shapes outside, ready to loose if this goes wrong.

Jakob's voice is barely controlled, but he projects authority—or at least tries to:

"I HEAR YOU, KIN!"

His voice cracks slightly, but he pushes through:

"THE MASTER'S WORK IS DONE HERE! KORTHAK SENT ME TO THIS FARM AND I HAVE COMPLETED HIS COMMAND!"

He gestures wildly at the barn interior, where bloodstains from his family's deaths are still visible:

"THESE HUMANS FOUGHT! THEY WOUNDED ME, BUT I KILLED THEM ALL! THE CURSE HAS TAKEN ROOT!"

There's a long, terrible silence from outside.

Then one of the werewolves laughs—a horrible, wet, growling sound:

"YOU LIE, WHELP. WE SMELL THEM. THREE HEARTBEATS. THREE LIVING HUMANS."

Damn. Their senses are better than you hoped.

The voice continues, more aggressive now:

"YOU ARE NEWLY TURNED. WEAK. CONFUSED. THE MASTER SENT US TO COLLECT YOU. TO BRING YOU TO THE PACK."

A pause, then more menacing:

"COME OUT. OR WE COME IN. AND WE KILL YOUR NEW... FRIENDS."

Jakob's Control Slips

The direct confrontation, the threat to you, the pressure—it's too much. Jakob gasps, doubling over. His eyes flash yellow and stay yellow. Claws extend. Hair sprouts along his arms and neck.

"No... no, I'm losing it... Riv, I can't—"

Dagmar's bow creaks as she pulls the string tighter, torn between watching Jakob and watching the threat outside.

Voss's crossbow swings between Jakob and the door: "Defender, we need a decision. NOW."

The werewolves are advancing. You can see them moving closer—100 yards now, 90...

Jakob is on the edge of transformation, fighting desperately but losing ground.

Your options:

1. Order Dagmar to fire - Take out one werewolf, hope it drives the other off
2. Step forward yourself - Confront them directly, use your authority as a cleric
3. Have everyone fire - Coordinated attack, maximum damage
4. Trigger a distraction - Set something on fire, create chaos, buy time
5. Focus on Jakob - Try to talk him down, even if it means the werewolves get closer
6. Something else?

The barn door won't hold if two werewolves hit it together. They're 80 yards out and closing.

What do you do?

You said: "Voss, Dag, open fire" I yell, as I move closer to Jakob, talking him down.

"Voss, Dag, open fire" I yell, as I move closer to Jakob, talking him down. "You did wonderfully, Jakob, and we've got them right where we need them. We're your kin and we will not surrender you without a fight. You just have to keep fighting your own battle!"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Coordinated Response

Coordinated Response

"FIRE!" you roar.

Dagmar's Shot

TWANG!

Her silvered arrow flies true through the darkness.

Attack roll: She rolls naturally high with her expertise... $19 + 5 = 24$. HIT!

The arrow slams into the lead werewolf's chest. Silver burning corrupted flesh. The creature howls in agony, stumbling backward, clawing at the arrow embedded deep.

"ONE DOWN!" Dagmar shouts, already nocking another arrow—a regular one this time, saving her remaining two silvered shots.

Voss's Shot

The veteran hunter doesn't waste his shot. He aims carefully at the second werewolf, now hesitating at seeing its companion wounded.

Attack roll: $16 + 4 = 20$. SOLID HIT!

THUNK!

His silvered crossbow bolt catches the second werewolf in the shoulder, spinning it around. Not a kill shot, but painful. The silver sizzles and smokes.

"GOT THE BASTARD!" Voss is already reloading with practiced speed.

The Werewolves' Reaction

The lead werewolf—Dagmar's target—collapses, the silver arrow too close to its heart. It's not dead yet, but it's dying, thrashing in the dirt, howling in pain and rage.

The second werewolf—wounded but mobile—snarls at the barn, clearly weighing its options:

- Continue the attack alone and wounded
- Flee and regroup
- Try to help its dying companion

It makes its choice: RETREAT.

The wounded werewolf turns and runs, limping badly from Voss's bolt, disappearing into the forest darkness. Its companion's death howls fade as it dies alone in the field.

Silence Falls

Voss keeps his crossbow trained on the darkness: "Think that's it? Or are they regrouping?"

Dagmar scans the perimeter: "I don't see any other movement. Jakob, do you smell anything else?"

Jakob's Struggle

While the battle raged outside, Jakob was fighting his own war inside. Your words—"We're your kin"—anchor him.

His transformation reverses slowly. The yellow fades from his eyes. The claws retract, painfully. Hair recedes. His breathing is ragged, exhausted, but he's still human.

"I... I held it. When they threatened you, when I thought they'd hurt you, I... I pushed back harder." He looks at his hands, trembling but human. "You're right. You're my kin now. Not them."

He collapses back against the hay, utterly spent: "Thank you. Thank you for not giving up on me."

Voss's Assessment

"One dead in the field. One wounded and fled. That was clean work." He looks at you with respect. "Your tactics saved us—and him. Drawing them in, coordinated fire, keeping Jakob grounded... well done, Defender."

He moves to the door cautiously: "Should we go confirm the kill? Or stay fortified until dawn?"

Dagmar adds: "That wounded one might come back with reinforcements. Or it might bleed out and die alone. Hard to say."

Current Situation:

- One werewolf dead in the field (~70 yards out)
- One werewolf fled wounded into the forest
- Jakob stable but exhausted from fighting transformation
- Your party unharmed
- ~6 hours until dawn remains

Remaining resources:

- Dagmar: 11 arrows, 2 silvered
- Voss: 19 bolts, 3 silvered
- You: 0 spell slots, exhausted but functional

Do you:

1. Stay fortified - Don't risk going outside, maintain watch
2. Confirm the kill - Send someone (or go yourself) to check the body
3. Adjust watch rotation - Everyone's awake now, reorganize
4. Something else?

And how do you spend the remaining night? Jakob proved himself, but he's exhausted. The long hours until dawn stretch ahead.

You said: "We resume our vigil."

"We resume our vigil. Jakob needs rest, and the barn is still fortified. Dag, it's still your sleep shift for another hour. Make the most of it"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Resuming the Vigil

Resuming the Vigil

Dagmar nods, though she looks reluctant to stand down after the adrenaline of combat:

"You sure? I'm wired right now."

"Rest while you can," you insist. "We need you sharp for your watches later."

She relents, returning to her bedroll but keeping her bow within arm's reach. "Wake me if anything moves out there." Within minutes, her breathing evens out again—the discipline of someone who's learned to sleep when they can.

Jakob's Exhaustion

The young man is slumped against the barn wall, physically and mentally drained from fighting the transformation during the confrontation:

"I don't know if I can sleep. Every time I close my eyes, I see them. My family. The werewolves. The beast inside me." He looks at you. "Will you... will you keep talking? Your voice helps. Keeps me anchored."

Voss Maintains Overwatch

The veteran positions himself back at the door gap, crossbow ready, scanning the darkness:

"That wounded one is out there somewhere, bleeding. Might die. Might heal—they're resilient bastards. Either way, I doubt it'll try again tonight. Not alone." He glances back. "But I'll watch anyway."

The dead werewolf lies in the field, a dark shape in the moonlight. Voss occasionally checks it to make sure it's not moving.

The Rest of Shift 1 (~45 minutes remaining)

You settle beside Jakob, keeping him engaged despite your own exhaustion:

"Tell me about the good times," you say gently. "Before all this. What was your favorite memory with your father?"

Jakob's voice is hoarse but willing: "He... he taught me to carve when I was eight. We'd sit on the porch after chores, and he'd whittle little animals. Always said the wood already knows what it wants to be—you just have to help it find its shape."

He's quiet for a moment, then: "That horse he was making when he died... it was for Sarah's baby. My nephew. He'll never meet his grandfather now."

You talk him through the grief, through the fear, through the exhaustion. Keeping him human. Keeping him focused.

Shift 1 Ends - Shift 2 Begins (You + Dagmar, 2-4 hours)

Voss shakes Dagmar awake gently: "Your watch."

She rises, stretches, checks her weapons. Voss moves to his own bedroll, though he doesn't remove his armor: "Wake me if you need me." He's asleep within moments—the sleep of a soldier who's learned to rest anywhere.

Dagmar joins you, taking position where she can watch both Jakob and the perimeter:

"How's he holding up?"

"Fighting," you reply. "Every moment."

She nods with respect: "Kid's got steel in him."

The Long Middle Watches

The hours stretch. You and Dagmar keep Jakob talking when he needs it, give him silence when he doesn't. The transformation keeps trying to take hold—waves of it, every 30-40 minutes—but each time Jakob fights back.

At one point, around 3 AM, Jakob asks quietly:

"Riv... when we get to Thornhaven, when Mother Nelle tries to break the curse... what if it doesn't work? What if I'm too far gone?"

How do you answer him? And what do you talk about during these quiet hours to keep both yourself and Jakob alert?

Also, give me another exhaustion check (d20, with disadvantage) to see how you're holding up through the night.

You said: Jakob's Question: "Riv.

Jakob's Question: "Riv... when we get to Thornhaven, when Mother Nelle tries to break the curse... what if it doesn't work? What if I'm too far gone?"

Riv's Answer: "I sent a letter to my order yesterday telling them what we're up against. I don't know if they'll have another scroll like the one I used on Aldric, but they might. My particular order demands that we attempt to resolve things peacefully before going to a combat solution. This sort of scroll may exist in our archives. And if it doesn't... killing you is my absolute last resort. Lathander is known to do incredible things in times of need. Like the destruction of the totem in the house. I had no way to destroy it. I could have smashed it with my mace, but Gods know what that might have done to you. Instead, I spoke to Lathander and told him my plight. I prayed and he answered. It took everything out of me, but it worked. When Mother Nelle tries to break the curse, she won't be alone. I'll be right there, lending her my power and the power of my God. I won't let you drown in this curse."

Exhaustion Check: 16

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Riv's Promise

Riv's Promise

Your words land with the weight of an oath. Jakob looks at you with tears streaming down his face—not tears of despair, but of desperate hope:

"You really believe that? That Lathander will help? That I'm worth saving?"

When you confirm with absolute conviction, Jakob nods shakily:

"Then I'll keep fighting. For dawn. For Mother Nelle's ritual. For the chance you're giving me." His voice grows firmer. "I won't let you down, Riv. I won't let Lathander down."

The transformation recedes again, pushed back by faith and willpower combined.

Exhaustion Check: 16 (with disadvantage)

Roll your second d20... let's say it's a 14.

Taking the lower: 14

You're tired, but holding steady. The adrenaline from the werewolf attack, the importance of keeping Jakob anchored, the knowledge that dawn is coming—it all keeps you alert enough. You're not at your best, but you're functional.

Dagmar notices your fatigue during your shared watch:

"You're running on fumes, Cleric. When we get back to Thornhaven, you need a proper rest. A full night's sleep, not just stolen hours between crises."

She's not wrong. You've been going nearly nonstop since you arrived in Thornhaven.

Shift 3: Voss + Dagmar (4-6 hours)

When the time comes, you gratefully hand off watch to the two veterans. Voss is refreshed from his sleep, and Dagmar is experienced enough to push through fatigue.

"Get some rest, Defender," Voss says. "We've got this. Jakob—" he looks at the young man "—you too. Close your eyes if you can. Fighting the curse takes energy."

Jakob nods: "I'll try."

Your Rest (2 hours)

You lie down on a blanket, your mace within reach, and close your eyes. Sleep doesn't come easily—your mind is racing with plans, contingencies, prayers—but eventually exhaustion wins.

You dream:

Golden light. A sunrise over endless fields. A voice—not words, but feeling—that speaks of renewal, of second chances, of dawn always following darkness. You see Jakob standing in that light, human and whole, wearing the robes of a cleric. Behind him, the Harrow family, at peace.

Then the dream shifts. Korthak waiting at Thornhaven's edge. The Master, faceless and menacing. A coming storm.

But through it all, the sunrise. Always the sunrise.

You wake to Dagmar's hand on your shoulder:

"Riv. Your watch. And..." She smiles slightly. "Look outside."

Shift 4: You + Voss (6-8 hours) - DAWN APPROACHES

You move to the barn door, and through the gaps you can see it:

The eastern horizon is lightening. Not full dawn yet, but the deep black of night is giving way to dark blue. Pre-dawn. The promise of sunrise.

Jakob sees it too, and his entire body seems to relax:

"I made it. I made it through the night." His voice is full of wonder and relief. "The pull... it's weaker now. The beast is quieter."

Voss confirms: "Lycanthropy is strongest at night, especially under the full moon. Dawn weakens it. You've survived the worst of it, son."

30 Minutes Until Sunrise

The sky continues to lighten. Birds begin their morning songs. The world is waking up.

Jakob stands on shaky legs, moving to the barn door to watch the dawn:

"I never thought I'd see another sunrise."

Then, quietly: "Thank you. All of you. You saved me."

The sun breaks the horizon.

Golden light spills across the Harrow farm, touching the three fresh graves, the blood-stained barn, the dark forest beyond. But it also touches Jakob's face, and in that light, he looks human. Tired, grief-stricken, traumatized—but human.

The long night is over.

Current Status:

- Jakob survived - Still cursed, but stable and in control
- Party exhausted but unharmed
- One dead werewolf in the field (you could search it now in daylight)
- 3-hour journey back to Thornhaven ahead
- You need a long rest to recover spell slots and remove exhaustion

What do you want to do now?

1. Search the dead werewolf before leaving
2. Have breakfast, gather supplies from the farm
3. Head out immediately for Thornhaven
4. Something else?

Dawn has come. The journey home awaits.

You said: We should have breakfast and let Jakob search the house for anything he might want to take with him.

We should have breakfast and let Jakob search the house for anything he might want to take with him. We might want to search the dead werewolf and then make haste back to Thornhaven

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Dawn at Harrow Farm

Dawn at Harrow Farm

The golden light of sunrise feels like a benediction after the long, dark night. You can practically feel Lathander's warmth restoring you—not physically healing, but spiritually renewing.

Breakfast

Dagmar starts preparing a simple meal from the supplies she gathered yesterday:

- Bread and cheese from the farmhouse
- Dried meat from your packs
- Water from the farm's well (Voss checks it first—it's clean)
- Some preserved fruit Dagmar found

It's not elaborate, but after the night you've had, it tastes like a feast.

Jakob eats mechanically, his eyes distant. The curse is quieter in daylight, but the grief is still raw.

Jakob's Farewell

"I'd like... I'd like some time in the house," Jakob says quietly. "To gather a few things. Say goodbye."

You nod: "Take what you need. We're not in a rush yet."

Jakob enters the farmhouse alone. Through the windows, you can see him moving slowly through the rooms—touching things, gathering items, saying private goodbyes to the life he had.

After about twenty minutes, he emerges carrying:

- A small wooden box - Contains family keepsakes, letters, his mother's jewelry
- His father's carving tools - The set he learned with
- A quilt his mother made
- The family journal Dagmar found
- A few changes of clothes

His eyes are red from crying, but there's also a kind of... closure in his expression.

"I'm ready," he says simply.

Searching the Dead Werewolf

Voss volunteers: "I'll check the corpse. You all finish eating."

He approaches the body cautiously, crossbow ready in case it's somehow still alive. But no—the silvered arrow did its work. The werewolf is very dead, already beginning to decompose in the morning sun.

After a thorough search, Voss returns:

"Not much. They came as beasts, no gear." He holds up his findings:

1. Crude leather collar - Has a symbol branded into it: Malar's claw mark
2. Scarification on the body - Ritual markings, similar to what you've seen before
3. A silver coin - Oddly, tucked into what might have been a pocket before transformation. It's old, foreign mintage you don't recognize

Voss pockets the coin: "Might tell us something about where this one came from originally. I'll show it to people in Thornhaven, see if anyone recognizes it."

The collar he tosses aside with disgust: "Cult mark. They brand their pack like livestock."

Preparing to Depart

Your party stands ready:

- You: Exhausted (level 1 exhaustion), no spell slots, but spiritually renewed by the sunrise
- Dagmar: 11 arrows (2 silvered), tired but functional
- Voss: 19 bolts (3 silvered), experienced and steady
- Jakob: Carrying his family's legacy, fighting the curse, exhausted but determined

Time: Early morning, maybe 7 AM Journey to Thornhaven: 3 hours on foot through relatively open terrain Threats: Unknown—the wounded werewolf fled last night, other cult members might be active

Voss's Assessment

"Three-hour march. We'll be exposed on the open roads, but it's daylight—that's in our favor. Lycanthropes are weaker in sunlight, less likely to attack openly."

He looks at Jakob: "How are you feeling? Can you make the journey, or do you need to rest more?"

Jakob straightens: "I can make it. The sooner we get to Mother Nelle, the sooner..." He doesn't finish, but the meaning is clear.

Dagmar adds:

"We should move in formation. Jakob in the middle, one of us at point, one watching our rear. Stay alert for ambushes."

She looks at you: "You're the leader here, Defender. What's the marching order?"

How do you want to organize for the journey?

Formation options:

1. Voss (point) → You + Jakob (middle) → Dagmar (rear guard)
2. Dagmar (point/scout) → Voss + Jakob (middle) → You (rear guard)
3. You (point) → Jakob (middle) → Voss and Dagmar (rear/flanking)
4. Other arrangement?

And do you want to:

- Take the main road (faster, more exposed)
- Use forest trails (slower, more cover)
- Something else?

The journey home begins. Let's get Jakob to safety.

You said: "Dag, you take point."

"Dag, you take point. Voss, you're on rear. Jakob, you're right behind Dagmar and i'll follow you. We move quickly and we can be back in Thornhaven with plenty of time to spare."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The March Home

The March Home

Your formation moves out from Harrow farm with military precision:

Formation:

- Dagmar at point, bow ready, scanning ahead
- Jakob behind her, carrying his family's belongings
- You behind Jakob, keeping him in sight
- Voss at rear guard, crossbow covering your backs

Route: You take the main road—faster, and the daylight makes the exposure less concerning than traveling at night would be.

The First Hour

The morning is crisp and clear. The sun climbs higher, warming the autumn air. The open farmland stretches around you—harvested fields, distant tree lines, the occasional abandoned farmstead.

Jakob walks steadily, though you can see the effort it takes. Every so often his step falters, his hand clenches, and you know the curse is pushing at him. But daylight helps. Lathander's sun helps.

Dagmar calls back occasionally with updates:

"Road ahead clear... passing the creek crossing... still no movement..."

Voss checks behind regularly: "Rear secure. No pursuit."

About 90 Minutes In

You're roughly halfway back when Dagmar holds up a fist—the signal to stop.

Everyone freezes. Weapons ready.

"Movement ahead. East side of the road, maybe 400 yards. Multiple figures."

Your heart rate spikes. More werewolves? Cultists?

Then Dagmar relaxes slightly: "Wait... those are wagons. Looks like... it's the Millstones!"

She's right. As you get closer, you can see two familiar wagons traveling north along the road toward Thornhaven. The Millstone family, making their way to safety.

Reunion on the Road

Thomas Millstone spots your group and reins in the horses. His face breaks into a relieved smile:

"Cleric Freeborn! Thank the gods!" He climbs down from the wagon, still moving a bit stiffly from his wounds but clearly much better than yesterday. "We were worried when you didn't return with us yesterday."

Clara appears from the second wagon, relief evident on her face. Jakob (the teenage Millstone, wearing your blessed shield) waves.

Thomas's eyes fall on the young man with you—Jakob Harrow—and his expression shifts to recognition and sympathy:

"Jakob? Is that... young Jakob Harrow?" Then, more quietly, seeing Jakob's haunted expression: "Your family?"

Jakob shakes his head, unable to speak.

Thomas bows his head: "I'm sorry, lad. Truly sorry."

Thomas Addresses You

"We made good time yesterday evening, reached Thornhaven just before full dark. Elder Wren and Garrick got us settled—we're helping with the fortifications." He gestures to his family. "Sarah's been helping with the wounded, Jakob here has been working the forge with Garrick, and I've been organizing supply lines."

He lowers his voice: "The village is ready, Cleric. As ready as we can make it. The ward still holds, but Mother Nelle says it's weakening. Maybe hours now, not days."

"And Aldric?" Thomas continues. "He rode out yesterday morning like a man possessed. If anyone can bring help from Millford, it's him."

Clara Offers

"We have food and water in the wagons. Can we offer you anything? You all look exhausted."

She notices Jakob's condition—the way his hands shake, the yellow that occasionally flickers in his eyes—and her expression fills with understanding and compassion. She was nearly killed by werewolves just yesterday. She knows.

Voss Speaks Up

"How far to Thornhaven from here?"

Thomas answers: "Maybe an hour, hour and a half. We left early this morning to do some supply gathering from our farm—final trip before we abandon it completely."

You're within striking distance of Thornhaven. Jakob has made it this far. The Millstones are proof that your mission yesterday succeeded.

Do you:

1. Accept their offer of food/rest (brief stop, 10-15 minutes)
2. Push on immediately (get Jakob to Mother Nelle ASAP)
3. Ask about Thornhaven's status (gather more intelligence)
4. Travel together the rest of the way (safety in numbers)

What's your call?

You said: (For clarity, we should rename Jakob Millstone.

(For clarity, we should rename Jakob Millstone. He's now... Javik Millstone)

To Thomas: "If you're headed back, Gods know we would ride with you. We need to get young Jakob Harrow to Mother Nelle with utmost haste"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Traveling Together

Traveling Together

(Noted! Jakob Harrow and Javik Millstone—much clearer!)

Thomas nods immediately: "Of course. Climb aboard—we've got room."

He gestures to the wagons. Clara is already making space in the second wagon, moving supplies to create seating.

"We're heading straight back to Thornhaven now. We got what we came for." He glances at the sun's position. "With the wagons, we'll be there in just over an hour. Faster than walking."

Loading Up

Your exhausted party gratefully climbs into the wagons:

- You and Jakob Harrow in the second wagon with Clara and the younger children
- Dagmar stays with the first wagon, keeping watch from the elevated position
- Voss positions himself in the second wagon's rear, crossbow ready

The Millstone family is efficient and welcoming. Sarah hands out waterskins. Javik Millstone (the teenage son with your shield) nods respectfully to you from his position on the first wagon.

Jakob Harrow Settles In

The young man sits heavily, clutching his family's wooden box. The motion of the wagon, the presence of other people, the knowledge that help is close—it all seems to both comfort and overwhelm him.

Clara, with the instinct of a mother, places a blanket around his shoulders: "You're safe now. We'll get you to Mother Nelle."

Jakob nods, tears streaming silently down his face.

The children—curious but sensing the somber mood—stay quiet, occasionally stealing glances at Jakob with a mix of fear and sympathy.

The Final Hour

The wagons roll steadily toward Thornhaven. The sun continues to climb. Farmland gives way to more familiar territory.

About halfway there, Jakob suddenly tenses:

"The pull... it's back. Stronger."

You feel it too—that wrongness in the air, getting stronger as you approach Thornhaven.

Korthak. The Alpha is still there, waiting outside the ward. His presence is like a dark gravitational force, calling to the cursed.

Jakob grips the wagon's side, knuckles white: "He's... he's there. The Alpha. I can feel him. He's calling to me. Commanding me to come to him."

Voss leans forward: "Can you fight it?"

"I... I don't know. It's so much stronger than the others. He's not just calling—he's demanding."

Through the Trees Ahead

You crest a small hill and suddenly Thornhaven is visible in the distance—maybe fifteen minutes away.

Even from here, you can see the changes:

- Barricades are more extensive, creating concentric defensive rings
- Smoke rises from multiple forges—weapons being made

- People moving on the walls—organized watch rotations
- The shimmer of Mother Nelle's ward is visible even in daylight, but it's flickering, like a candle flame in the wind

And there, at the forest edge, barely visible but definitely present:

A massive shape. Korthak. Waiting.

Thomas sees him too: "Gods above. That's the Alpha?"

Jakob is struggling hard now, the Alpha's presence overwhelming his willpower:

"Riv... I can't... he's too strong... I need to go to him... I need to—"

His eyes flash yellow and stay yellow. Claws extend. Hair sprouts.

The children gasp and press against their mother. Clara pulls them close but doesn't panic—she's seen this before.

You're fifteen minutes from Thornhaven. Jakob is losing his fight. The Alpha's presence is overwhelming him.

What do you do?

1. Physical restraint (tie Jakob down, prevent him from jumping off the wagon)
2. Spiritual intervention (pray over him, channel what divine energy you can despite having no spell slots)
3. Speed up (whip the horses, race for the ward's protection)
4. Talk him through it (use your voice, your connection, your promise)
5. Something else?

The final stretch. Don't lose him now.

You said: "Jakob, we've been here before."

"Jakob, we've been here before. Focus on me. Focus on Lathander. Focus on our promise to protect you. You saw that collar the werewolf wore, the one who attacked us last night. That's the only thing waiting for you if you surrender. A life of servitude to the Alpha and whoever controls him. You're human. You're an individual. You make your own choices and you fight this fight. I know you can do this and I'm here with you. We all are."

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: A Battle of Wills

A Battle of Wills

Your voice cuts through Jakob's panic like a blade of light. His yellow eyes snap to yours, finding an anchor in the storm.

"Focus on me. Focus on Lathander. Focus on our promise."

Jakob's breathing is ragged, his whole body trembling as the Alpha's compulsion hammers at his mind. But your words—the reminder of the collar, of slavery, of everything he'd lose—give him something to push against.

"I... I don't want... the collar..." he gasps between clenched teeth. "I won't... be his... slave..."

His claws retract slightly. The hair recedes a fraction.

"Human. Individual. My choice." He's repeating your words like a mantra, using them as weapons against the curse. "My choice. My choice. MY CHOICE."

Clara Helps

The farmer's wife, seeing Jakob's struggle, reaches out and takes his hand—not afraid, despite everything:

"You're Jakob Harrow. Son of craftsmen. Brother. You're a person, not a beast."

The human contact, the kindness, it helps. Jakob's eyes flicker—yellow to brown, brown to yellow, fighting for control.

Approaching the Village

The wagons roll closer. Ten minutes. Five minutes.

You can see people on the barricades now—Garrick, organizing defenders. Elder Wren, coordinating. And there, near the shrine, Mother Nelle standing in her priestess robes, hands raised, clearly channeling energy into the weakening ward.

And at the forest edge, Korthak shifts. The massive Alpha werewolf rises to his full height, clearly sensing Jakob's approach. You can feel his will pressing outward like a physical force.

"COME TO ME, YOUNG ONE. STOP FIGHTING. ACCEPT YOUR NATURE."

The command reverberates through the air—not words exactly, but a psychic pressure that makes everyone in the wagon wince.

Jakob screams, his control slipping—

But Then

The wagon crosses an invisible threshold. The ward's edge.

Suddenly the pressure vanishes. The Alpha's compulsion is cut off like someone slammed a door. Mother Nelle's protective magic, weakened as it is, still holds enough power to block external curses and compulsions.

Jakob collapses, gasping, his transformation reversing rapidly. His eyes fade back to human brown. The claws retract completely. He's shaking like a leaf, sobbing with relief:

"It's... it's gone. I can't feel him anymore. The ward... it blocked him..."

Entering Thornhaven

The wagons roll through the barricades. Defenders call out in welcome and relief. You can see familiar faces:

- Garrick climbing down from the walls, relief evident on his face when he sees you
- Finn, Dagmar's apprentice, waving excitedly
- Tomás and Willem, helping with fortifications
- Village defenders who've been working around the clock

And rushing forward from the shrine, moving faster than you've seen her move:

Mother Nelle.

She reaches the wagon as it stops, her eyes immediately going to Jakob Harrow. She sees the signs—the residual curse, the exhaustion, the desperation.

"This is him? The one you mentioned?" she asks you.

When you confirm, she nods firmly: "Bring him to the shrine. Now. We don't have much time—the ward is failing, and if the Alpha's compulsion can reach him again before I break the curse..."

She doesn't finish. She doesn't need to.

Garrick approaches you, clasping your shoulder:

"Welcome back, Defender. We held the line. You brought survivors." He sees Voss. "And you found another fighter. Good."

Then, more urgently: "The ward has maybe four, five hours left. Six if we're lucky. Korthak hasn't moved, hasn't attacked, just... waits. Like he knows it's about to fall. We're as ready as we can be, but..."

He looks you in the eye: "When that ward drops, he's coming. And he won't be alone."

You're back in Thornhaven. Jakob Harrow needs immediate help. The final confrontation approaches.

What do you do first?

1. Get Jakob to Mother Nelle immediately (priority: save the young man)
2. Report to Elder Wren (leadership update, strategic planning)
3. Check on defenses with Garrick (military assessment)
4. Rest and recover (you desperately need it)
5. Something else?

The endgame is coming. How do you spend these precious hours?

You said: "Mother Nelle, we need to extend the wards."

"Mother Nelle, we need to extend the wards. I need sleep. I'm drained, fully exhausted, and we still have a young man to save. I need to take a long rest or I'll be no help in this fight. I will pray with you to extend the wards another 12 hours, and then I must let sleep take me. Will you do this with me, and will you watch over Jakob while I sleep?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Mother Nelle's Assessment

Mother Nelle's Assessment

The elderly priestess looks at you with both concern and understanding. Her weathered hand touches your arm, and you can feel her sensing your exhaustion—the divine energy expended, the sleepless nights, the weight of leadership.

"Child, you're running on fumes and faith alone. I can see it." Her voice is gentle but firm. "Yes. We'll extend the ward together, then you WILL rest. You're no good to anyone if you collapse."

She looks at Jakob, still trembling in the wagon: "And yes, I'll watch over the boy. Breaking his curse will require powerful ritual work—preparation, components, prayer. It will take hours regardless. He'll be safe in the shrine while I prepare, and you'll be recovered when the time comes."

She turns to Garrick: "Get some of your people to help young Jakob to the shrine. Gently—he's been through hell."

The Ward Extension Ritual

Mother Nelle leads you to the shrine. The building feels different now—the air heavy with divine energy, candles burning low, the smell of incense and blessed herbs. She's clearly been channeling power into the ward constantly.

"This will be similar to what we did before, but more demanding. The ward is weakening, and we're not creating fresh protection—we're reinforcing something that's barely holding."

She arranges the ritual space quickly, her movements practiced despite her age. You can see the toll this is taking on her too—she's exhausted, but determined.

"I'll need a spell slot from you again. First level will suffice, but..." She pauses. "You don't have any left, do you?"

When you confirm, she nods thoughtfully: "Then we do this the hard way. Raw prayer, channeled faith, both of us together. It will work, but it will cost."

She takes your hands, her grip surprisingly strong:

"Are you ready? This will push you to your absolute limit."

The Ritual

You kneel together before the altar. Mother Nelle begins her prayer to Chauntea, and you join with your prayer to Lathander. The two voices intertwine—harvest and dawn, earth and light, renewal and growth.

The shrine fills with golden-green radiance. You feel the divine energy flowing through you, but this time it's different. Without spell slots to buffer the effect, it's raw—like channeling lightning through your body.

Pain. Exhaustion. Your vision blurs.

But you push through, focusing on the ward, on the village, on all the people depending on you.

Mother Nelle's voice: "By grain and harvest, protect this place..."

Your voice: "By dawn and renewal, hold back the darkness..."

The ward flares, visible even in daylight, pulsing with renewed strength. You feel it stabilize, strengthen, extend.

Then—darkness.

You Wake

Soft blankets. The smell of herbs and incense. Muted sounds of activity outside.

You're in a small room off the shrine's main chamber—a simple bed, a washbasin, your armor and weapons neatly arranged nearby.

How long were you out?

You check the light through the window. Late afternoon sun. You've been asleep for... 8 hours? Maybe 10?

A Long Rest

Your body feels restored:

- Full HP recovered (30/30)
- All spell slots recovered (4x 1st level, 2x 2nd level)
- Exhaustion removed
- Hit dice recovered (regained 1, now at 3/3)

You feel like yourself again. Strong. Clear-headed. Ready.

Mother Nelle Enters

She's carrying a tray with bread, cheese, and water:

"You're awake. Good." She sets the tray down. "You collapsed the moment the ritual finished. I had Garrick carry you in here—you needed proper rest."

She sits wearily in a chair: "The ward is holding. We bought ourselves twelve hours, maybe a bit more. But Riv..." Her expression is grave. "It's late afternoon now. The ward will fail sometime tonight or early tomorrow morning at the latest."

She pauses: "Jakob is in the main chamber. I've been preparing the curse-breaking ritual all day. I have the components, the prayers, the structure. But it will take both of us—your power and mine together. And even then..."

She doesn't finish, but you understand. Even with both of you, breaking a lycanthropic curse this advanced is not guaranteed.

"He's been remarkably strong," she continues. "Fighting it every moment. But he's weakening. We should attempt the ritual soon, before he loses the fight entirely."

She stands: "Eat. Recover your strength. Then come to the main chamber. It's time to save that boy—or try to."

Current Status:

- Time: Late afternoon (maybe 4-5 PM)
- Ward: Will fail tonight or early tomorrow
- You: Fully rested and recovered
- Jakob: Holding on, but weakening
- Korthak: Still waiting outside the ward

What do you do?

1. Eat and immediately attempt Jakob's ritual (priority: save him before he turns)
2. Check on village defenses first (see what's been built while you slept)
3. Talk to Garrick/Elder Wren (strategic update)
4. Visit Jakob before the ritual (give him encouragement)
5. Something else?

The final hours approach. What's your priority?

You said: Have I advanced to level 4 yet?

Have I advanced to level 4 yet? We've been through several fights today and I'm sure some of what I've done has earned XP, right?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Great question!

Great question! Let's assess your XP gains.

You're absolutely right—you've accomplished a LOT since we started Session 3. Let me calculate what you've earned:

SESSION 3 ACCOMPLISHMENTS:

Combat Encounters:

- Millstone Farm: 2 werewolves defeated (with help from Dagmar, Voss, Thomas, Jakob Millstone)
- Harrow Farm: 1 werewolf killed with ambush shot (Dagmar's kill, but you led the tactics and blessed her)
- Harrow Farm Defense: 2 werewolves engaged, 1 killed, 1 driven off

Non-Combat Achievements:

- Saved the Millstone family (8 people)
- Destroyed cult totem at Millstone farm
- Recruited Henrik Voss (experienced monster hunter)
- Saved Jakob Harrow from transformation (kept him human through the night)
- Destroyed cult totem at Harrow farm (direct divine intervention)
- Successfully returned Jakob to Thornhaven
- Extended the ward (again)

Story Milestones:

- Gathered crucial intelligence on cult operations
 - Prevented multiple farmsteads from being completely lost
 - Added significant combat strength to Thornhaven's defense
 - Demonstrated exceptional leadership and tactical skill
-

XP CALCULATION:

In 5E, the XP to reach Level 4 from Level 3 is 2,700 total XP (you need 1,800 more from level 3).

Given your accomplishments—multiple combat encounters, saving lives, major story progress, exceptional roleplay with Jakob—you've definitely earned enough for Level 4.

YOU ADVANCE TO LEVEL 4!

New Benefits:

- +5 Max HP (roll 1d8 + Constitution modifier, or take the average of 5)
 - Ability Score Improvement OR Feat (your choice!)
 - One additional prepared spell (now 7 spells prepared instead of 6)
 - All spell slots increase to Level 4 capacity
-

Let's handle this:

1. Hit Points: Would you like to roll 1d8 for your HP increase, or take the average of 5?

2. Ability Score Improvement (ASI) or Feat:

Option A - ASI: Increase two ability scores by +1 each, or one by +2

- Popular choices: +2 Wisdom (better spellcasting), +2 Constitution (more HP), or split between them

Option B - Feat: Take a feat instead

- Popular cleric feats: War Caster, Resilient (Constitution), Lucky, Inspiring Leader

What would you like to do?

You said: Hit Points: I rolled a 7

Hit Points: I rolled a 7

I'll need to consider possible feats! We never truly rolled a new character when we began. Maybe we should do that now and lay out all my feats and skills and ability scores before we move forward?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Excellent roll!

Excellent roll! $7 + 2$ (Constitution modifier) = 9 HP gained!

New Max HP: 39 (was 30)

Absolutely! Let's properly build out Riv Freeborn's full character sheet now that we're at Level 4. This is a perfect time to formalize everything.

RIV FREEBORN - LEVEL 4 HUMAN CLERIC (LIGHT DOMAIN)

ABILITY SCORES

Let's establish these properly. In our sessions, I've been assuming:

- Wisdom: 14-16 (your primary spellcasting ability)
- Constitution: 14 (decent HP, you've survived several fights)
- Strength: 10-12 (you wear chain mail and use a mace effectively)
- Dexterity: 10 (chain mail limits this anyway)
- Intelligence: 10 (average, you're educated enough)
- Charisma: 12-14 (you're an inspiring leader)

Using Standard Array (15, 14, 13, 12, 10, 8) + Human Racial Bonus (+1 to all stats):

My suggestion:

- STR: 11 (10+1)
- DEX: 9 (8+1)
- CON: 14 (13+1)
- INT: 11 (10+1)
- WIS: 16 (15+1) - Primary stat
- CHA: 13 (12+1)

Does this work for you, or would you like to adjust anything?

PROFICIENCIES

Armor: Light, Medium, Shields Weapons: Simple weapons Tools: None (standard for clerics)

Saving Throws: Wisdom, Charisma

Skills (pick 2 from Cleric list):

- Religion (almost certainly)
- Insight, Medicine, Persuasion, or History?

What skills do you want Riv to have?

LIGHT DOMAIN FEATURES

You already have these from Level 1-3:

- Bonus Cantrip: Light
- Warding Flare (use Reaction to impose disadvantage on attack against you, Wis mod times per long rest)
- Channel Divinity: Turn Undead
- Channel Divinity: Radiance of the Dawn (30-foot radius, 2d10+Cleric level radiant damage, can destroy magical darkness)

LEVEL 4 CHOICE: ASI OR FEAT?

Option A - Ability Score Improvement:

- +2 Wisdom (16→18): Better spell attack bonus, higher spell save DC, more prepared spells
- +2 Constitution (14→16): +4 max HP retroactively, better concentration saves
- +1 Wis/+1 Con: Balanced approach

Option B - Feat Options:

War Caster (excellent for clerics in combat):

- Advantage on Constitution saves to maintain concentration
- Can perform somatic components with weapons/shield in hand
- Can cast a spell as an opportunity attack

Resilient (Constitution):

- +1 Constitution (14→15)
- Proficiency in Constitution saves (huge for concentration)

Lucky:

- 3 luck points per long rest
- Reroll any d20 or force enemy to reroll

Inspiring Leader (fits your leadership role):

- Spend 10 minutes inspiring up to 6 allies

- They gain temporary HP = your level + Charisma modifier

What appeals to you? ASI for raw power, or a feat for versatility?

You said: Can I roll my stats?

Can I roll my stats? Is that something I can do in 5e?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Absolutely!

Absolutely! Rolling stats is a classic D&D method!

In 5E, the standard rolling method is:

Roll 4d6, drop the lowest die, take the sum. Do this 6 times to generate your six ability scores.

This can create higher (or lower) stats than Standard Array, and it's more exciting/random.

Let's roll for Riv!

Roll 4d6 six times, and for each roll, tell me all 4 dice. I'll help you drop the lowest and calculate.

For example, if you roll: 5, 4, 3, 2 → drop the 2 → total is 12

Go ahead and roll your six sets of 4d6!

(Note: Some DMs use different methods like "reroll if total is below 70" or "reroll 1s" to prevent too-weak characters, but let's see what you get first!)

ROLL 1 (4d6, drop lowest):

ROLL 2 (4d6, drop lowest):

ROLL 3 (4d6, drop lowest):

ROLL 4 (4d6, drop lowest):

ROLL 5 (4d6, drop lowest):

ROLL 6 (4d6, drop lowest):

Give me all your dice results and we'll build Riv's stats from there!

You said: Roll 1: 4, 2, 3, 2

Roll 1: 4, 2, 3, 2

Roll 2: 3, 6, 2, 5

Roll 3: 2, 5, 2, 5

Roll 4: 6, 2, 5, 6

Roll 5: 4, 5, 1, 3

Roll 6: 6, 3, 4, 3

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Let's calculate your rolls!

Let's calculate your rolls!

Roll 1: 4, 2, 3, 2 → Drop lowest (2) → 9 Roll 2: 3, 6, 2, 5 → Drop lowest (2) → 14 Roll 3: 2, 5, 2, 5 → Drop lowest (2) → 12 Roll 4: 6, 2, 5, 6 → Drop lowest (2) → 17 ★ Roll 5: 4, 5, 1, 3 → Drop lowest (1) → 12 Roll 6: 6, 3, 4, 3 → Drop lowest (3) → 13

Your rolled stats: 17, 14, 13, 12, 12, 9

Total: 77 (pretty solid! Standard Array totals 72)

Now add your Human racial bonus (+1 to all stats):

Final Stats: 18, 15, 14, 13, 13, 10

Now we assign them to abilities!

As a Cleric, you'll want:

- Wisdom as your highest (spellcasting)
- Constitution second (HP and concentration)
- Strength or Dexterity for combat (you wear medium/heavy armor and use a mace)

My suggestion:

- WIS: 18 (your best roll - amazing for a Level 4 Cleric!)
- CON: 15 (great HP and concentration saves)
- STR: 14 (can wear chain mail without penalty, decent melee)

- CHA: 13 (you're an inspiring leader)
- DEX: 13 (helps with initiative and AC slightly)
- INT: 10 (you're not a scholar, but competent)

Does this distribution work for you, or would you prefer something different?

(Note: With WIS 18, your spell save DC is 14 and spell attack bonus is +6 - very strong!)

You said: I'd like to make DEX my 10 and INT my 13.

I'd like to make DEX my 10 and INT my 13. My character's background says that he pursues knowledge whenever possible. To me that speaks of a higher Intelligence.

Talk me through backgrounds in 5e and how those change my ability scores, my skills, and my feats

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Perfect! Let's swap those:

- WIS: 18 ★
- CON: 15
- STR: 14
- INT: 13 (knowledge seeker)
- CHA: 13
- DEX: 10

BACKGROUNDS IN 5E

Backgrounds don't change ability scores, but they provide:

1. Skill Proficiencies (usually 2)
2. Tool Proficiencies and/or Languages
3. Equipment (starting gear)
4. Feature (special ability/benefit)

BACKGROUND OPTIONS FOR RIV

Based on "pursues knowledge" and being on a pilgrimage:

ACOLYTE (most thematic for a cleric on pilgrimage)

- Skills: Insight, Religion
- Languages: 2 of your choice
- Feature: Shelter of the Faithful - You can receive free healing/care at temples of your faith, and those who share your religion will support you at a modest lifestyle
- Equipment: Holy symbol, prayer book, incense, vestments, common clothes, belt pouch with 15 GP

SAGE (fits "pursues knowledge")

- Skills: Arcana, History
- Languages: 2 of your choice
- Feature: Researcher - You know where to find information; can access libraries, scriptoriums, universities, and sages who might have knowledge you seek
- Equipment: Bottle of ink, quill, small knife, letter from dead colleague with unanswered question, common clothes, belt pouch with 10 GP

HERMIT (withdrawn study, then emerged to help)

- Skills: Medicine, Religion
- Tool: Herbalism kit
- Languages: 1 of your choice
- Feature: Discovery - You've uncovered something unique during your seclusion - a cosmic truth, forgotten lore, or artifact location
- Equipment: Scroll case with notes, winter blanket, common clothes, herbalism kit, 5 GP

CLOISTERED SCHOLAR (scholarly temple education)

- Skills: History, plus choice of Arcana, Nature, or Religion
- Languages: 2 of your choice
- Feature: Library Access - Access to most libraries and can convince scholars to help you
- Equipment: Scholar's robes, writing kit, borrowed book, common clothes, belt pouch with 10 GP

MY RECOMMENDATION FOR RIV:

Modified Acolyte/Sage Hybrid (many DMs allow this):

- Skills: Religion, History (knowledge pursuit + faith)
 - Languages: 2 additional (maybe Celestial for divine texts, and Dwarvish/Elvish?)
 - Feature: Shelter of the Faithful (fits pilgrimage narrative)
-

SKILL PROFICIENCIES TOTAL

You get skills from:

1. Background: 2 skills
2. Class (Cleric): Choose 2 from: History, Insight, Medicine, Persuasion, Religion

If we go with Acolyte background:

- From Background: Insight, Religion
- From Class: Choose 2 more (I'd suggest Medicine + Persuasion or History)

Total: 4 skill proficiencies

Which background appeals to you? And which 2 skills do you want from your Cleric class?

Once we nail this down, we'll finalize your character sheet and handle your Level 4 ASI/Feat choice!

You said: I like Acolyte/Sage hybrid, let's do Celestial and Elvish languages.

I like Acolyte/Sage hybrid, let's do Celestial and Elvish languages. For my 2 Class skills, I'd take Medicine and Persuasion. How about my feats thus far? What are my choices?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Perfect! Here's what we have so far:

BACKGROUND: ACOLYTE/SAGE HYBRID

- Skills: Religion, History
- Languages: Common (human), Celestial, Elvish
- Feature: Shelter of the Faithful

CLASS SKILLS (CLERIC):

- Medicine, Persuasion

TOTAL SKILL PROFICIENCIES:

History, Insight, Medicine, Persuasion, Religion

FEATS IN 5E

Important: In 5E, you don't get feats automatically. Instead, at certain levels (including Level 4), you choose between:

Option A: Ability Score Improvement (ASI) - Increase ability scores Option B: Take a Feat - Special ability instead of ASI

You get this choice at levels: 4, 8, 12, 16, 19

YOUR LEVEL 4 CHOICE

You must choose ONE of the following:

OPTION A - ABILITY SCORE IMPROVEMENT:

+2 to one ability or +1 to two abilities

Examples:

- WIS 18→20 (max it out early! +1 to spell save DC, attack bonus, prepared spells)
- CON 15→17 (+1 HP per level, better concentration)
- WIS 18→19, CON 15→16 (balanced, both get +1 modifier)

OPTION B - TAKE A FEAT:

Here are the best feats for your Riv:

WAR CASTER ★ (highly recommended for clerics in combat)

- Advantage on Constitution saves to maintain concentration on spells
- Can perform somatic components even with weapons/shield in hands
- Can cast a spell as an opportunity attack instead of melee

RESILIENT (CONSTITUTION)

- Gain +1 Constitution (15→16)
- Gain proficiency in Constitution saving throws
- Great for concentration, but War Caster is usually better

LUCKY (universally good)

- 3 luck points per long rest

- Can reroll any attack roll, ability check, or saving throw
- Can force enemy to reroll attack against you

INSPIRING LEADER (fits your leadership role)

- Give a 10-minute speech
- Up to 6 creatures gain temp HP = your level + Charisma mod (currently 4+1=5, decent)

HEALER (maximize your medicine skill)

- Can use healer's kit to restore 1d6+4+target's max HD in HP
- Each creature can only benefit once per short rest
- Makes mundane healing very strong

RITUAL CASTER (more utility magic)

- Learn ritual spells from another class
- Cast them as rituals without using spell slots

MY RECOMMENDATIONS:

For Combat Power:

1. War Caster - You're in melee range often, this keeps your concentration spells like Bless and Spiritual Weapon active
2. +2 WIS (18→20) - Maximizes your spellcasting immediately

For Roleplay/Leadership:

1. Inspiring Leader - Very thematic for "Defender of Thornhaven"
 2. Lucky - Fits a chosen champion of Lathander
-

What appeals to you? ASI for raw power, or a feat for special abilities?

You said: Can you explain Ritual spells?

Can you explain Ritual spells?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Great question!

Great question! Ritual spells are a special category in 5E.

HOW RITUAL SPELLS WORK

Ritual Tag: Some spells have a "ritual" tag in their description. These spells can be cast in two ways:

Method 1 - Normal Casting:

- Uses a spell slot
- Takes the spell's normal casting time (usually 1 action)
- Must have the spell prepared (for Clerics)

Method 2 - Ritual Casting:

- No spell slot required! (Free casting)
 - Takes 10 minutes longer than normal casting time
 - Clerics can cast ANY ritual spell on the Cleric spell list, even if not prepared, as long as you have it in your prayer book/holy texts
-

CLERIC RITUAL SPELLS

Here are ritual spells you can already cast (you don't need the Ritual Caster feat):

1st Level:

- Ceremony (you used this for the ward!)
- Detect Magic
- Detect Poison and Disease
- Purify Food and Drink

2nd Level:

- Augury (divine yes/no answers about future actions)
- Gentle Repose (preserves corpse, prevents undead rising)

3rd Level:

- Water Walk
- Speak with Dead (ask corpse 5 questions)

Higher Levels:

- Divination (4th) - More powerful future-sight
 - Commune (5th) - Ask your deity three yes/no questions
-

RITUAL CASTER FEAT

This feat lets you cast rituals from a different class's spell list (Wizard, Bard, Druid, etc.).

What it gives:

- Learn 2 ritual spells from another class (must be spells you could cast)
- Can find and copy more ritual spells into your ritual book (costs 50 GP per spell level)
- Can cast these spells as rituals (no slot needed)

Popular choices for Clerics:

- Wizard rituals: Find Familiar, Identify, Alarm, Detect Thoughts, Leomund's Tiny Hut
 - Druid rituals: Detect Thoughts, Animal Messenger
-

WHY IT MATTERS FOR YOU

As a Cleric, you ALREADY have ritual casting built into your class! You can cast any Cleric ritual spell without using slots, even unprepared ones.

The Ritual Caster feat would only help if you want access to another class's rituals (like getting a Wizard's Find Familiar or Identify).

MY TAKE:

For Riv, Ritual Caster probably isn't your best choice because:

1. You already have ritual casting
2. Cleric has good ritual spells
3. Other feats (War Caster, Inspiring Leader, Lucky) would benefit you more in combat/leadership

But if you want utility/flavor (like having a celestial familiar or being able to identify magic items), it's a valid choice!

Does this help clarify? Still deciding between ASI and feats?

You said: Let's add 2 points to my Wisdom Score.

Let's add 2 points to my Wisdom Score. That seems like the best bet right now. Can you also add all my available spells and rituals to my character sheet so I can keep that in front of me?

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Excellent choice!

Excellent choice! Maxing out your primary stat early is very strong.

WIS: 18 → 20

This gives you:

- Spell Save DC: 15 (8 + 4 proficiency + 5 Wis modifier)
- Spell Attack Bonus: +7 (+4 proficiency + 5 Wis modifier)
- Prepared Spells: 9 (5 Wis modifier + 4 Cleric level)

RIV FREEBORN - COMPLETE CHARACTER SHEET

LEVEL 4 HUMAN CLERIC (LIGHT DOMAIN)

ABILITY SCORES

- STR: 14 (+2)
- DEX: 10 (+0)
- CON: 15 (+2)
- INT: 13 (+1)
- WIS: 20 (+5) ★
- CHA: 13 (+1)

CORE STATS

- HP: 39/39 (current: 39/39)
- AC: 16 (chain mail)
- Proficiency Bonus: +2
- Speed: 30 ft
- Initiative: +0

SAVES

- Wisdom: +7 (proficient)
- Charisma: +3 (proficient)

SKILLS (Proficient)

- History: +3 (INT +1, Prof +2)
- Insight: +7 (WIS +5, Prof +2)
- Medicine: +7 (WIS +5, Prof +2)
- Persuasion: +3 (CHA +1, Prof +2)
- Religion: +3 (INT +1, Prof +2)

LANGUAGES

Common, Celestial, Elvish

BACKGROUND: ACOLYTE/SAGE

Feature - Shelter of the Faithful: You can receive free healing and care at temples of Lathander. Followers of your faith will support you at a modest lifestyle and provide assistance.

COMBAT STATS

Weapons:

- Mace: +4 to hit (STR +2, Prof +2), 1d6+2 bludgeoning damage

Armor Class: 16 (chain mail)

CLASS FEATURES

LIGHT DOMAIN (Level 1)

Bonus Cantrip: Light

Warding Flare (Reaction):

- When attacked by a creature within 30 ft that you can see
- Impose disadvantage on attack roll
- Uses: 5 per long rest (Wis modifier)

CHANNEL DIVINITY (Level 2) - 1 use per short/long rest

Turn Undead:

- 30-foot radius
- Undead must make WIS save (DC 15) or be turned for 1 minute
- Turned creatures must use movement to get away, can't willingly move closer
- Can't take reactions, can only Dash or try to escape

Radiance of the Dawn (Light Domain):

- 30-foot radius centered on you
- Each creature of your choice takes 2d10+4 radiant damage (half on CON save DC 15)
- Dispels magical darkness in the area

SPELLCASTING

Spell Save DC: 15 Spell Attack Bonus: +7

Spell Slots:

- 1st Level: 4 slots
- 2nd Level: 3 slots

CANTRIPS (Always Prepared)

You know 4 cantrips:

1. Light (from Light Domain)
2. Sacred Flame - Target makes DEX save or takes 1d8 radiant damage (ignores cover)
3. Spare the Dying - Touch stabilizes dying creature
4. Guidance - Touch ally, they add 1d4 to next ability check (lasts 1 min, concentration)

(Suggest these, but you can swap for: Mending, Resistance, Thaumaturgy)

DOMAIN SPELLS (Always Prepared)

These don't count against your prepared spells limit:

1st Level:

- Burning Hands - 15-foot cone, 3d6 fire damage (DEX save for half)
- Faerie Fire - 20-foot cube, creatures outlined in light, attacks against them have advantage (1 min, concentration)

2nd Level:

- Flaming Sphere - Create 5-foot sphere of fire, 2d6 fire damage, can move it as bonus action (1 min, concentration)
 - Scorching Ray - Make 3 ranged spell attacks, 2d6 fire damage each hit
-

PREPARED SPELLS (Choose 9 from Cleric List)

Currently Prepared (from Session 3):

1st Level:

1. Bless - 3 creatures add 1d4 to attack rolls and saves (1 min, concentration)
2. Cure Wounds - Touch, heal 1d8+5 HP
3. Guiding Bolt - Ranged attack, 4d6 radiant damage, next attack on target has advantage
4. Healing Word - Bonus action, 60 ft range, heal 1d4+5 HP
5. Shield of Faith - Bonus action, target gets +2 AC (10 min, concentration)

2nd Level: 6. Lesser Restoration - Touch, end one disease or condition (blinded, deafened, paralyzed, poisoned) 7. Spiritual Weapon - Bonus action summon, bonus action attack for 1d8+5 force damage, flies independently (1 min)

Additional Slots (you can prepare 2 more):

Some strong options:

- Aid (2nd) - Increase max HP of 3 creatures by 5 for 8 hours
- Hold Person (2nd) - Paralyze humanoid (WIS save, concentration)
- Prayer of Healing (2nd) - 10 min cast, heal up to 6 creatures for 2d8+5 HP each
- Sanctuary (1st) - Protect creature, attackers must make WIS save or choose new target
- Detect Magic (1st, ritual) - Sense magic within 30 feet
- Command (1st) - One-word command, target must obey (WIS save)

What 2 additional spells would you like to prepare for the upcoming battle?

RITUAL CASTING

You can cast ANY Cleric spell with the (ritual) tag as a ritual (takes 10 extra minutes, no spell slot), even if not prepared:

Available Cleric Rituals:

1st Level:

- Ceremony - Various rites (ward, funeral, marriage, etc.)
- Detect Magic - Sense magic within 30 ft, learn school of magic
- Detect Poison and Disease - Sense poisonous/diseased creatures or substances within 30 ft
- Purify Food and Drink - Remove poison/disease from food/water

2nd Level:

- Augury - Ask deity about results of specific action in next 30 minutes (weal/woe/both/nothing)
- Gentle Repose - Preserve corpse for 10 days, prevent it becoming undead

3rd Level (when you reach it):

- Water Walk
- Speak with Dead

EQUIPMENT

Weapons: Mace, (formerly had shield - gave to Jakob Millstone)

Armor: Chain mail

Holy Symbol: Lathander sun-burst medallion, Bronze medallion of Village Defender

Gear:

- Healer's kit
- 3 vials blessed water
- 1 pouch healing herbs
- 50 feet rope
- Waterskin
- Rations (3 days)

- Bedroll
- Travel pack
- Regional map (detailed)
- Thomas Millstone's journal
- Improved traveling cloak (waterproof)
- Silver necklace (from Millstone farm)
- Oil lantern + flask of oil
- Whetstone
- Coil of good rope (50 ft, high quality)

Gold: 69.5 GP + 12 SP set aside for Millstone family

CURRENT STATUS

- HP: 39/39
 - Spell Slots: 4/4 (1st), 3/3 (2nd)
 - Channel Divinity: 1/1
 - Warding Flare: 5/5
 - Conditions: None (fully rested!)
-

There's your complete character sheet! What 2 additional spells would you like to prepare for the final battle?

You said: Command and Hold Person

Command and Hold Person

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect choices!

Perfect choices!

Command gives you battlefield control with a bonus action, and Hold Person can completely shut down a humanoid enemy (like cultists or human-form werewolves).

UPDATED PREPARED SPELLS (9 total)

1st Level (5 spells):

1. Bless
2. Cure Wounds
3. Guiding Bolt
4. Healing Word
5. Shield of Faith
6. Command ★ (new)

2nd Level (3 spells): 7. Lesser Restoration 8. Spiritual Weapon 9. Hold Person ★ (new)

Plus your Domain Spells (always prepared):

- Burning Hands, Faerie Fire (1st)
 - Flaming Sphere, Scorching Ray (2nd)
-

You're fully prepared now! Let's get back to the story.

BACK TO THORNHAVEN - JAKOB'S RITUAL

You've eaten Mother Nelle's simple meal and feel restored. Your divine power flows through you again—stronger than ever with your perfected wisdom.

Mother Nelle is waiting in the main shrine chamber. You can see she's prepared extensively:

- A ritual circle drawn in blessed salt
- Candles arranged at cardinal points
- Healing herbs burning in braziers (the ones she gathered while you were gone)
- Holy symbols of both Chauntea and Lathander positioned around the space
- Jakob Harrow sitting in the center, looking exhausted but determined

The young man looks up when you enter:

"Riv. You're here." Relief floods his face. "Mother Nelle says... says you can help break the curse. Is it... is it really possible?"

Mother Nelle turns to you, her expression grave:

"I've done everything I can to prepare. But Riv, this is advanced lycanthropy—eight to ten hours old, partially transformed multiple times. Breaking it will require both of us channeling everything we have."

She gestures to the ritual space:

"Here's what we're attempting: A combined cleansing ritual, using your connection to Lathander's renewal and my connection to Chauntea's natural order. We'll essentially be asking our deities to burn away the curse while simultaneously restoring Jakob's natural human state."

She meets your eyes:

"It will require:

- Both of us using Channel Divinity simultaneously
- You expending at least one 2nd-level spell slot (maybe more if the first attempt fails)
- Jakob's willpower to accept the healing and reject the beast

There's no guarantee. The curse is strong. But..." she looks at Jakob with compassion "...it's his best chance."

Jakob speaks up:

"I'm ready. I've fought this thing for a full day and night. I'm not giving up now." His hands are shaking, but his voice is firm. "Whatever you need me to do, I'll do it."

Mother Nelle looks to you:

"Are you ready, Defender? Once we begin, we can't stop halfway. It's all or nothing."

How do you want to approach this ritual?

1. Proceed immediately with the ritual as Mother Nelle described
2. Ask Jakob questions first (anything you want to say to him before beginning?)
3. Suggest modifications to the ritual (any ideas?)
4. Pray to Lathander for guidance before beginning

This is a critical moment. How does Riv prepare himself and Jakob?

You said: "Jakob, you can do this."

"Jakob, you can do this. Together, we'll bring the light back into you. I saw this ritual in a dream and I know it will work. I've got you, lad. We've got you."

Riv closes his eyes and offers a silent prayer to Lathander detailing their plan. He prays for the Morninglord's protection for Jakob and offers his intention to train Jakob in Lathander's name when they succeed

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Riv's Prayer

Riv's Prayer

You close your eyes, holy symbol warm against your chest, and reach out to Lathander with your heart and mind:

"Morninglord, Lord of Dawn, Bringer of Renewal—I come before you with a request born of faith and promise. This young man, Jakob Harrow, has fought the darkness within him with strength I have rarely witnessed. He has chosen light over shadow, humanity over beast, hope over despair.

We seek to cleanse him of this curse, to burn away the corruption of Malar and restore what was stolen from him. Guide our hands, strengthen our spirits, and let your dawn break through the darkness that binds him.

If we succeed—when we succeed—I pledge to train him in your service. To teach him your ways, to help him transform his suffering into purpose, his survival into strength. Let him become a beacon of your light, a living testament that no curse is beyond your power to break.

Grant us your blessing, Morninglord. Let this be his dawn."

The Response

As you pray, you feel warmth—not just physical, but spiritual. The kind of warmth that comes with absolute certainty.

The candles in the shrine flare brighter for just a moment. Mother Nelle gasps softly, and even Jakob opens his eyes in wonder as golden light fills the room.

You feel Lathander's presence, and with it comes a feeling—not words, but understanding:

"I am with you, my Champion. Bring him home."

The Ritual Begins

Mother Nelle's eyes are wide: "Did you feel that? Lathander answered you directly." She takes a deep breath, steadying herself. "Then we have his blessing. Let's begin."

She positions you on one side of the circle, herself on the other, with Jakob in the center.

"Jakob, lie down. This will be... intense. The curse won't leave willingly."

Jakob obeys, lying back in the center of the ritual circle. His breathing is rapid, nervous, but he nods: "I'm ready."

Mother Nelle begins her chant:

"By root and soil, by grain and growth, By Chauntea's hand, I call thee forth, Natural order, human form, Restore what was, before the storm..."

She gestures to you: "Now, Riv. Channel Divinity—Radiance of the Dawn. Pour it into him, not as damage, but as cleansing fire."

Your Turn

You raise your holy symbol, channeling Lathander's divine power. But instead of the usual destructive radiance meant to harm enemies, you focus it inward—directing it entirely at Jakob, at the curse corrupting him.

Golden radiance explodes from you, washing over Jakob in waves of holy fire.

Jakob screams—not in pain exactly, but in the agony of something being torn from him. The curse fights back.

You can see it now—dark, shadowy tendrils wrapped around Jakob's soul, and your light is burning them away. But they're deep. Entrenched.

Mother Nelle pours green-golden energy from her own Channel Divinity, stabilizing Jakob's body as your light tears at the curse.

The Struggle

For a moment, it seems to be working. The darkness recedes. Jakob's eyes—which had flashed yellow—stay brown. The claws retract.

Then the curse surges back, fighting harder. Jakob convulses, his body trying to shift.

"It's not enough!" Mother Nelle shouts. "Riv—the spell slot! Now!"

You must expend a 2nd-level spell slot (Lesser Restoration won't work—this requires raw divine power).

You channel the energy, pushing everything you have into the ritual. Your voice joins Mother Nelle's in prayer:

"LATHANDER, MORNINGLORD, BURN AWAY THIS DARKNESS! LET YOUR DAWN BREAK THE NIGHT! RENEW THIS SOUL!"

Roll a Wisdom check (Religion):

This represents your faith, your connection to Lathander, your ability to channel divine power beyond normal spellcasting.

Roll d20 + your Religion skill (+3)

But you also have advantage on this roll because:

- Lathander directly blessed this attempt
- Jakob is actively fighting the curse
- Mother Nelle is supporting you

Roll 2d20, take the higher, add +3. What do you get?

You said: 17 and 18, wow!

17 and 18, wow!

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: $18 + 3 = 21$.

$18 + 3 = 21$. OVERWHELMING SUCCESS!

The Breaking of the Curse

Your faith, perfected through rest and prayer, channels Lathander's power with absolute clarity. The golden radiance doesn't just wash over Jakob—it ignites him from within, burning with the intensity of a thousand sunrises.

The dark tendrils wrapped around his soul scream (you can hear it, feel it, a sound that exists beyond normal hearing) as they're consumed by holy fire.

Jakob arches his back, every muscle tensed, but his eyes—his eyes remain human. Brown. Clear. Focused.

Mother Nelle's green-gold energy flows through him like spring water through parched earth, restoring what the curse tried to corrupt, healing what it damaged, renewing his natural human essence.

The curse makes one final attempt—you see it gather, coiling like a wounded serpent, trying to sink deeper into Jakob's core—

But you and Mother Nelle push harder.

Your combined voices thunder:

"BY LATHANDER'S ETERNAL DAWN!"

"BY CHAUNTEA'S ENDLESS RENEWAL!"

"WE CAST YOU OUT!"

The Final Moment

There's a sound like glass shattering, like chains breaking, like a thunderclap and a whisper all at once.

The darkness explodes from Jakob in a burst of shadow that dissipates the moment it touches your holy light. The curse is destroyed—not suppressed, not contained, but utterly annihilated.

Jakob collapses back onto the floor, gasping, sobbing, but human. Completely, undeniably human.

The ritual circle glows one final time, then fades. The candles burn steady. The herbs smell sweet rather than acrid.

Silence.

Jakob's Transformation

The young man lies there for a long moment, breathing hard, tears streaming down his face. Then he looks at his hands—completely human. No claws. No hair. No yellow in his eyes.

He sits up slowly, checking himself, hardly daring to believe:

"It's... it's gone. I can't feel it anymore. The pull, the hunger, the beast... it's GONE."

He looks at you with absolute wonder and gratitude:

"You did it. You actually did it."

Mother Nelle

The elderly priestess staggers, catching herself on the altar. You feel it too—exhausted, like you've run for miles. Channel Divinity expended, spell slot used, but it worked.

"Merciful gods," she breathes. "I've never seen a curse broken so completely. Riv, what you just did..." She shakes her head in amazement. "Lathander's power flows through you like I've rarely witnessed."

She moves to Jakob, checking him carefully—feeling his pulse, looking at his eyes, examining where the bite wound was. It's now just a clean scar, no corruption, no curse.

"He's clean. Completely clean." She smiles, exhausted but triumphant. "The boy is saved."

Jakob Stands

He gets to his feet shakily, and suddenly he's hugging you—this young man who lost everything, who fought the darkness for a full day and night, who faced his own damnation and won.

"Thank you. Thank you, thank you, thank you." He's sobbing into your shoulder. "You gave me my life back. More than my life—you gave me myself back."

He pulls away, wiping his eyes:

"You said... you said you'd train me. That if we succeeded, you'd teach me to serve Lathander." His voice is thick with emotion. "I meant what I said in the barn. I want to help others. I want to bring light to dark places, like you did for me. Will you... will you still teach me?"

Outside, you hear shouting

Garrick's voice: "DEFENDER! MOTHER NELLE! THE WARD IS FAILING! WE'VE GOT MAYBE TWO HOURS!"

Current Status:

- Jakob Harrow: SAVED, curse completely broken
- Your resources:
 - Channel Divinity: 0/1 (expended)

- Spell Slots: 4/4 (1st), 2/3 (2nd) - used one 2nd level
 - HP: 39/39
 - Time: Evening, ward failing in ~2 hours
 - Korthak: Still waiting outside
-

What do you say to Jakob? And what do you do next?

The final battle approaches.

You said: "Jakob, I vow to bring you into my order and train you as a Cleric of Lathander."

"Jakob, I vow to bring you into my order and train you as a Cleric of Lathander. How do you feel? Will you fight by our side this night?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Jakob's Response

Jakob's Response

Jakob straightens, wiping the last of his tears away. There's something different in his bearing now—no longer the terrified farmer's son fighting an internal battle, but someone who's been forged through suffering and emerged stronger.

"I feel... alive. Clear. For the first time since that night, my mind is my own." He looks at his hands, then meets your eyes with determination. "They killed my family. They tried to make me one of them. They failed."

His voice grows firmer:

"I'll fight. I have to. For Ma, Pa, and Sarah. For everyone in this village who's shown me kindness. For you and Mother Nelle who gave me a second chance." He pauses. "I'm not trained. I don't have your skills or power. But I can hold a weapon, I can stand on a wall, and I can face them without fear—because I've already beaten the worst thing they could do to me."

He kneels before you, hand over his heart in a gesture of oath-taking:

"Riv Freeborn, Defender of Thornhaven, Champion of Lathander—I pledge myself to your service and your god's. Train me, lead me, and I will follow. Starting tonight."

Mother Nelle

The priestess puts her hand on Jakob's shoulder as he rises:

"You've earned your place here, young man. But remember—courage doesn't mean you won't be afraid. It means you fight anyway." She looks at you. "He'll need a weapon and armor. His father's tools won't be enough for what's coming."

Garrick Bursts In

The blacksmith appears in the shrine doorway, urgent but not panicked:

"Defender! Good, you're here. The ward is flickering badly—Mother Nelle, you need to see this." He notices Jakob. "Harrow? You're... you look better. Did it work?"

When you confirm, Garrick nods approvingly: "Good. We need every fighter we can get."

He turns back to you:

"Status update: The ward will fail in about two hours, maybe less. When it does, Korthak will attack—we're certain of it. We've fortified the barricades, organized the defenders, stockpiled weapons and medical supplies in The Sleeping Giant as fallback. The Millstones are helping coordinate."

He counts off on his fingers:

"We have:

- 40-45 able-bodied fighters (villagers with weapons, mostly untrained)
- Harlon organizing the militia
- Dagmar and Finn with bows on elevated positions
- Voss positioned at the main approach with his crossbow
- The Millstone family armed and ready (including young Javik with your blessed shield)
- Now Jakob if you deem him fit

"We don't have:

- Any sign of Aldric's return from Millford (he's been gone over a day)
- Enough silver weapons (I made three more silvered arrowheads, but that's it)
- Knowledge of Korthak's full strength (is he alone? Does he have the cult with him?)

Garrick looks at you seriously:

"Elder Wren is calling a final war council in ten minutes. We need your strategic input, Defender. What's our plan when that ward drops?"

Before the Council

You have about 10 minutes before the war council. You could:

1. Equip Jakob - Get him basic armor and weapon from the armory
2. Scout the perimeter - See what Korthak is doing
3. Talk to key individuals - Voss, Dagmar, the Millstones, etc.
4. Prepare yourself - Pray, strategize, gather your thoughts
5. Check on specific defenses - The barricades, The Sleeping Giant, etc.

What do you want to do in these crucial minutes before the war council?

You said: To Garrick: "See that Jakob is given a weapon and one of those shields you made.

To Garrick: "See that Jakob is given a weapon and one of those shields you made. Leather armor, if any is available. Put him somewhere useful, but watch out for him. He's my responsibility now and I won't have him dying on me after what we just went through. I'll see you at the council in 10 minutes."

Riv walks out of Mother Nelle's hut and heads straight for Dagmar on the walls. To Dagmar: "Tell me what you see." Riv peers into the distance at Korthak and checks things out himself.

He leaves the battlements and returns to his room at the Sleeping Giant. He washes his face, adjusts his kit, and heads back downstairs to the war council

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Garrick's Acknowledgment

Garrick's Acknowledgment

"Consider it done." Garrick clasps Jakob's shoulder. "Come on, lad. Let's get you equipped. You survived the curse—let's make sure you survive the battle too."

Jakob follows Garrick out, looking back at you with gratitude and determination.

On the Walls with Dagmar

You climb the reinforced barricades where Dagmar has positioned herself with a clear view of the forest edge. The sun is setting, painting the sky in oranges and purples. Twilight approaches.

Dagmar doesn't look away from her watch position as you approach:

"Defender. Glad you made it. The Harrow boy?"

"Saved," you confirm.

She allows herself a small smile: "Good. We need all the hope we can get."

What You See

Dagmar points toward the forest edge, about 200 yards out:

"There. He hasn't moved in hours."

Korthak stands at the tree line—massive, easily eight feet tall in his hybrid werewolf form. Even from this distance, you can see:

- Ritualistic scars covering his body, clearly visible even through his fur
- A crude greatsword strapped to his back—sized for his werewolf form
- Absolute stillness - He's not pacing, not prowling. Just... waiting
- His eyes occasionally catch the fading light, glowing yellow

"He's been like that since mid-afternoon," Dagmar continues quietly. "Just watching. Waiting for the ward to fall. It's unnerving—most werewolves would be circling, testing defenses, trying to intimidate. This one? He's patient. Disciplined."

She adjusts her bow: "I've got a clear shot whenever the ward drops. Voss does too from his position. But Riv..." She looks at you seriously. "I don't think he's alone."

Dagmar's Observations

"About an hour ago, I saw movement in the forest behind him. Multiple shapes. Too far to count, but at least four, maybe six. Could be more werewolves. Could be cultists. Could be both."

She traces the tree line with her finger:

"They're staying back, staying hidden. Korthak is the bait—the obvious threat. The question is: when the ward falls and we focus on him, what comes from the flanks?"

She looks at you: "Your tactical read? What's his play?"

Your Perception

You study Korthak and the forest. Roll a Perception check (d20 + 5) to see if you notice anything Dagmar might have missed.

What do you roll?

(Meanwhile, I'll set up your arrival at the war council after you make this check and have your moment of preparation at The Sleeping Giant)

You said: I rolled a 16 on perception

I rolled a 16 on perception

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Perception Check: $16 + 5 = 21$.

Perception Check: $16 + 5 = 21$. EXCELLENT SUCCESS.

What Riv Sees

Your enhanced wisdom and divine connection sharpen your senses. As you study the forest and Korthak, several details become clear:

Korthak's Position:

- He's not just waiting randomly—he's positioned directly opposite the main gate, where your strongest defenses are concentrated
- His stance suggests he wants you to see him, to focus on him
- Every few minutes, he shifts slightly, always ensuring he remains the most visible threat

The Forest: Dagmar was right about movement, but you see more:

- At least 8-10 shapes moving in the darkness behind the tree line, not just 4-6
- They're spreading out in a wide arc, flanking positions on both north and south sides
- The movements are coordinated—this isn't random pack behavior, this is tactical positioning

The Real Threat: Then you notice something that makes your blood run cold:

The western approach—the side closest to Darkwood Forest and furthest from the main gate—has NO visible movement. Too quiet. Too empty.

Your tactical mind puts it together instantly:

Korthak is a distraction. When the ward falls:

1. Korthak attacks the main gate (where most defenders are)
2. The flanking forces hit north and south (split the defense)
3. The real assault comes from the west—the "quiet" side—where they've been positioning without being noticed

It's a three-pronged attack with a feint.

Dagmar Sees Your Expression

"You see it, don't you? Something I missed."

When you explain your read, her face goes pale:

"Gods. The west side. We've got it defended, but not heavily—we focused everything on the main approaches because that's where Korthak was visible." She curses. "Classic misdirection. He's smarter than we gave him credit for."

She looks at you: "You need to tell the council. We need to reinforce the west, but not so obviously that they know we've figured out their plan."

Back to The Sleeping Giant

You descend from the walls and make your way to your room. The tavern is bustling—nervous energy, people preparing, families huddled together.

In your small room, you:

- Wash your face in the basin—the cool water helps clear your mind
- Check your gear methodically: mace, holy symbol, chain mail, healer's kit
- Take a moment to breathe, to center yourself

You can hear the war council gathering downstairs—voices, the scrape of chairs, maps being unrolled.

You look at yourself in the small mirror. The face that looks back is tired, but determined. You've saved lives, destroyed totems, broken curses, recruited allies.

Now comes the real test.

The War Council

You descend the stairs to the main common room. It's been converted into a command center:

People Present:

- Elder Wren at the head of the table, looking exhausted but resolute
- Garrick with maps and weapon inventories spread out
- Mother Nelle still recovering from the ritual but present
- Harlon (Garrick's deputy), weathered and experienced
- Voss cleaning his crossbow methodically
- Dagmar entering right behind you
- Thomas Millstone representing the refugee families
- Aldric—wait, Aldric? He's here, covered in road dust, looking exhausted but triumphant

Everyone turns as you enter.

Elder Wren: "Defender Freeborn. Thank the gods. We've been waiting for you."

Aldric stands, grinning despite his obvious exhaustion: "Riv! I made it back. And I didn't come alone."

Before you can ask, there's movement outside.

Through the windows, you see torches approaching from the south road. Many torches.

Aldric's eyes shine: "I found help. Real help."

The reinforcements have arrived.

Do you:

1. Go outside immediately to see who Aldric brought

2. Stay for the council first, get the full report
3. Send someone else to check while you brief the council on Korthak's strategy

What's your call?

You said: Go outside - who is approaching?

Go outside - who is approaching? "Aldric, you must have a horse made of lightning to move so quickly! I must know, who have you brought?"

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Outside The Sleeping Giant

Outside The Sleeping Giant

You stride out into the torchlit evening, Aldric at your side, the rest of the council following close behind. The entire village seems to be gathering, hope and fear mixed on their faces.

The southern road is lit with at least two dozen torches approaching in organized formation. As they get closer, you can make out details:

What Aldric Brought

"I rode like a man possessed," Aldric says, pride and exhaustion in his voice. "Reached Millford in record time, went straight to the garrison. The captain I mentioned—Captain Theron Blackwood, retired but still respected—he listened. Really listened."

The column comes into clear view now:

Military Force:

- 20 soldiers from Millford's garrison—professional fighters in leather and chain, carrying spears, swords, and shields
- Captain Theron Blackwood at their head—a grizzled man in his fifties, scarred and capable-looking, wearing well-maintained half-plate armor
- 2 mounted scouts on horseback, already surveying the perimeter

Supplies:

- A wagon loaded with weapons, medical supplies, rations
- Bundles of arrows (you count at least 200)
- Six silvered weapons—three shortswords, two spears, one warhammer

Specialists:

- A cleric in the blue-and-silver robes of Torm (god of duty and protection)—middle-aged woman with a stern but kind face
 - Two healers with medical kits
 - A quartermaster already organizing supply distribution
-

Captain Blackwood Approaches

He dismounts and walks straight to you, sizing you up with experienced eyes. His handshake is firm:

"You must be Riv Freeborn, the Defender Aldric told me about. Captain Theron Blackwood, Millford Garrison. Retired, technically, but this sounded like it needed doing."

He gestures to his troops: "Twenty of Millford's finest. We left a skeleton crew to guard the town—this is everything I could muster on short notice. Aldric's description of the threat was... compelling."

His expression grows serious: "Organized werewolf cult, led by an Alpha who's been turned for twenty years, attacking a farming village with military tactics. That's not a local problem—that's a regional threat. If we don't stop them here, they'll be at Millford's gates next month."

He looks toward where Korthak waits in the distance: "So. Where do you need us, Defender?"

The Torm Cleric Steps Forward

"Sister Mara Ironvow," she introduces herself with a slight bow. "Cleric of Torm, Second Circle. I've brought healing magic, protective blessings, and twenty years of battlefield experience."

She studies the flickering ward: "That protection won't last much longer. When it falls, you'll need every divine caster you have. I'm at your service."

Elder Wren Steps Forward

The elderly village leader looks like she might cry from relief:

"Captain Blackwood. Sister Mara. On behalf of Thornhaven, thank you. We've been preparing to face this alone. Your arrival is... it's an answer to prayer."

Aldric looks at you with satisfaction: "I told you I'd bring help. The Captain owed me a favor from years back—called it in. And the silver weapons? I emptied my purse and convinced a smith to work through the night. Cost me everything I had, but..." He shrugs. "What good is gold if you're dead?"

Your Reinforcements - Summary

New Assets:

- 20 trained soldiers (professional fighters)
- Captain Blackwood (experienced military commander)
- Sister Mara (Cleric of Torm - healing and protection)
- 2 healers
- 6 silvered weapons
- Substantial supplies (arrows, rations, medical supplies)

Your Total Force Now:

- ~65-70 fighters (40-45 villagers + 20 soldiers)
- 3 divine casters (you, Mother Nelle, Sister Mara)
- Multiple experienced leaders (Garrick, Voss, Captain Blackwood, Harlon)
- Solid ranged support (Dagmar, Finn, soldiers with bows)

Captain Blackwood Cuts to Business

"Aldric briefed me on the ride here, but I need your tactical assessment, Defender. You've been here, you've fought these things, you know the terrain."

He pulls out a map: "Show me your defenses, your weak points, and where you expect the attack to come from. My men are tired from the march, but we've got maybe an hour before that ward fails. Tell me where you need us."

The full war council is assembled now:

- Elder Wren, Garrick, Mother Nelle, Harlon (Thornhaven leadership)
- You, Voss, Dagmar (your core team)
- Captain Blackwood, Sister Mara (Millford reinforcements)
- Thomas Millstone, Aldric (key allies)

Everyone is looking to you for the tactical plan.

What's your strategy? Where do you:

1. Position the professional soldiers?
2. Assign the silvered weapons?
3. Deploy the divine casters?
4. Address the western approach weakness you identified?
5. Plan for Korthak himself?

This is your moment, Defender. How do you prepare Thornhaven for the final battle?

You said: "Four days ago, we didn't know one another.

"Four days ago, we didn't know one another. I was just another traveler coming into a town that had a wolf problem. We didn't know how serious it was and we didn't know who to trust. In four days, we assessed the situation, forged bonds, found friends, rescued kin, lost... too many to count. But we banded together to fight for what we hold dear. We've seen some truly miraculous things together and we've done some amazing feats that will be talked about in legends for generations.

But first, we must fight one more fight. Our enemies are at our gates. We've planned, we've prepared, we've turned this village into a fortification for the ages. We have good news, and we have bad news. The bad news first: Dagmar and I have identified a crucial weakness in our defenses - the western approach. We focused our attention on the biggest target, but we've left our flank relatively open and the enemy took notice. The good news is, we did notice. And now, with Captain Blackwood and the Millford Company, we can do something about it.

We have four approaches to defend. Korthak at our main gate, flanking forces to the north and south, but the real assault is coming from the west. We have two hours until the ward falls.

Captain Blackwood: please spend a few minutes talking with Garrick and Harlon. Decide how to spread your forces and our forces between our defensive positions.

Dagmar: collaborate with Thomas, Clara, Voss, and Finn. Find positions that make sense to our ranged guard and make sure each defensive position is covered. I want Voss in particular watching Korthak.

Mother Nelle: You must take Sarah Millstone and village volunteers and prepare to run healing to those in need. Remove anyone from the battlefield back to The Sleeping Giant for triage when needed. Your vigilance will save lives this night.

Sister Mara: You and I will focus our healing arts where they're most needed. Rove between the North and West gates. I'll take the East and South. Use cantrips when possible to inflict small damage to the enemy, but our focus together is keeping our defenders alive.

Garrick: We need to set a surprise for our western approach. Are those bear traps still functional? Can we set them out in time? Do we have any oil barrels? Setting up an oil trap or two would give Finn something fun to shoot with flaming arrows, right Finn?

We were strangers once. We are strangers no more. We fight for friend and family. We fight for life and limb. We fight to bring the dawn. Lathander be praised, we fight in his holy name!"

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: The Speech

The Speech

Your words ring out across the assembled defenders. You can see the effect immediately:

- Villagers who looked terrified now stand straighter, gripping their weapons with renewed determination
- The Millford soldiers nod with professional respect—they've heard battle speeches before, but yours carries genuine weight
- Your companions—Dagmar, Voss, Garrick—smile with pride and camaraderie
- Jakob Harrow, now equipped with leather armor, a sword, and one of Garrick's shields, looks at you with absolute devotion

Elder Wren's eyes glisten with tears: "Four days ago, you were a stranger. Now you're our defender in truth. Lathander chose well."

The Council Responds

Captain Blackwood salutes sharply: "Clear orders, sound strategy. I like working with someone who knows their business." He turns to Garrick and Harlon: "Gentlemen, let's talk force distribution. I'm thinking ten of my men reinforce the west—that's where the real fight will be. Five each to north and south. We keep the main gate looking strong but know it's a feint."

Garrick nods: "Agreed. And yes, those bear traps are still good. We've got three of them—I'll have them set on the western approach, concealed. As for oil..." He grins darkly. "We've got four barrels. Two for the west, one each for north and south. Finn's going to enjoy this."

Dagmar clasps your shoulder: "Smart play. I'll coordinate the archers." She turns to the group: "Thomas, Clara—you've both handled bows. Clara, you're on the north wall with me. Thomas, south wall with two Millford archers. Finn, you're west with the oil barrels—make those shots count. Voss..." She looks at the veteran. "Main gate. You and I both know Korthak is the real threat regardless of where he attacks. Put a silvered bolt in him the moment that ward drops."

Voss loads his crossbow with one of his precious silvered bolts: "With pleasure."

Mother Nelle nods wearily: "Sarah is a good girl, smart and quick. We'll set up triage stations at each approach and in The Sleeping Giant. I'll coordinate the wounded evacuation." She looks at you seriously. "Riv, don't be a hero. If you're hurt, let us heal you. You're no good to anyone dead."

Sister Mara studies you with professional assessment: "A sound plan, Defender. Roving healers covering different zones—classic battlefield medicine." She hefts her warhammer (Torm's clerics are warriors as much as healers). "I'll keep the north and west alive. You handle east and south. If either of us gets overwhelmed, we signal and converge."

She pauses: "One question—when Korthak falls, assuming we can bring him down, what happens to the pack? Do they break and run, or fight harder?"

Finn practically vibrates with nervous energy: "Flaming arrows into oil barrels? That's... that's actually brilliant and terrifying." He looks at Dagmar. "Master, I won't let you down."

Dagmar ruffles his hair: "I know you won't, kid."

Garrick's Trap Setup

"Give me thirty minutes," Garrick says, already moving. "I'll have those bear traps hidden on the western approach—anyone charging through there in beast form is going to have a bad time. The oil barrels will be positioned behind the barricades, ready to dump or light. We'll turn the western approach into a kill zone."

He looks at Jakob Harrow: "Harrow, you're with the western defense. You've earned your place. Stay behind the veterans, watch and learn, but don't hesitate when the time comes."

Jakob nods firmly: "I won't, sir."

The Silvered Weapons

Captain Blackwood gestures to the weapons his people brought:

"Six silvered weapons total. I suggest:

- Voss gets a silvered bolt (already has four of his own = 5 total)
- Dagmar gets three silvered arrows (already has 2 = 5 total)
- Two silvered shortswords go to your best melee fighters at the western approach
- One silvered spear for the main gate reserves
- One silvered warhammer for Sister Mara (she's a Torm cleric—she'll be in melee)

"Sound reasonable?"

Final Preparations - 90 Minutes Remaining

The council disperses to their tasks. You can see the village transforming:

- Soldiers taking positions with professional efficiency
- Bear traps being carefully set on the western approach
- Oil barrels positioned and covered
- Archers finding elevation and clear fields of fire
- Healing stations being established
- Families evacuating to The Sleeping Giant's reinforced interior

The sun is setting. Twilight is here. The ward flickers visibly now, like a candle in wind.

And at the forest edge, Korthak remains. Waiting.

Aldric Approaches You

The merchant looks exhausted but satisfied:

"Riv, I did what I could. The rest is up to you fighters." He holds out something: "My merchant journal—it has trade routes, contacts, information that might help rebuild after this. If I don't make it, give it to Elder Wren."

He clasps your hand: "You saved my life, my soul. Whatever happens tonight, know that you changed me. Made me want to be more than just a merchant chasing coin."

You have about 60-90 minutes before the ward fails.

Do you:

1. Make final rounds (visit each defensive position, inspire the troops)
2. Pray with the other clerics (you, Mother Nelle, Sister Mara - combined blessing ritual?)
3. Talk to specific individuals (Jakob, Dagmar, Voss, anyone?)
4. Prepare yourself personally (meditation, prayer, gear check)
5. Something else?

The final hour approaches. How does Riv spend it?

You said: Riv's answer to Sister Mara: "We've seen them do both, but I think they'll cut and run."

Riv's answer to Sister Mara: "We've seen them do both, but I think they'll cut and run. He's our priority target, particularly if he makes it inside the walls. If that happens, our triage team will handle the wounded - you and I have holy arts that will be needed against Korthak."

Riv's answer to Captain Blackwood: "Sound strategy, Captain."

Riv's answer to Aldric: "Aldric, you are a valued friend. Thank you for everything you've done. Please, get yourself to safety in the Sleeping Giant. I'm sure Gerda will put you to some sort of task there. We both have a bright future ahead of us. Take care, friend. I'll see you after the battle."

Riv invites his boon companions to him. "Voss, Dagmar, Finn, Garrick, and Jakob. We've been through fights before. We know what to do. We have a strength most don't and you are each more than just friends to me. I couldn't wish for better companions. Lathander's light shines for each of us. We will make it through this night."

Riv steps off on his own, staring down Korthak. He closes his eyes and issues a prayer to Lathander.

"These are good people, o, Morninglord. You called your champion here and I will defend them with all I have. And when this night is past and the dawn comes again, we will discover who The Master is. We will seek out their evil, we will end their plans. We will deal with the cultists of Malar. And I will make good on the promise I made to you all those years ago."

(The promise, which took place a decade in the past, revolved around Riv building his own Order of Lathander specifically dedicated to rooting out evil like werewolves and cultists. Riv has felt this whole encounter was Lathander placing these threats in front of him to push him in that direction, but he hasn't addressed it to his God until right now. He knows that this is his calling and everyone he's met (Aldric, Jakob, Voss, Dagmar, Finn, Javik, and Garrick) seems to fit his ideal warband to transform into this new Order of Lathander. This is just background information though)

Show more

Dec 7, 2025

Claude responded: Sister Mara's Response

Sister Mara's Response

The cleric of Torm nods approvingly: "Good. Target priority established. If Korthak breaches the walls, we converge and bring him down together. Torm's duty and Lathander's light—should make for an effective combination."

She hefts her new silvered warhammer: "I'll keep our people alive. You make sure that Alpha doesn't."

Captain Blackwood

"Excellent. My people know their business—we'll hold those walls." He pauses, then adds with respect: "I've seen a lot of young officers fresh from training who couldn't organize a picnic, let alone a defense. You've got good instincts, Defender. Don't waste them by dying tonight."

Aldric's Farewell

The merchant's eyes are wet, but he smiles: "A bright future. I like the sound of that." He grips your hand one more time. "After this is done, I'm thinking about staying in Thornhaven. Helping rebuild. Maybe opening a proper trading post. These people... they're worth fighting for."

He heads toward The Sleeping Giant, looking back once: "Give them hell, Defender."

Your Companions

You gather your core group—the ones who've fought beside you from the beginning, and the new allies who've proven themselves.

Voss checks his crossbow one last time: "Been fighting monsters for fifteen years. Never had a commander worth following before." He meets your eyes. "If this is my last fight, I'm glad it's with you, Cleric."

Dagmar adjusts her quiver: "Four days. Feels like a lifetime." She smiles—rare for her. "You know what? I think we might actually pull this off. And if we don't..." She shrugs. "Well, at least it'll be a hell of a story."

Finn tries to look brave, but his hands shake slightly: "Master Dagmar, Defender Riv... I won't let you down. I promise."

Garrick grips your shoulder with his smith's strength: "Brother, when this is over, first round's on me. And I'm forging you a proper weapon—something worthy of what you've done for us."

Jakob Harrow stands straighter in his borrowed armor: "You gave me my life back. My humanity. My future." His voice is firm despite the fear in his eyes. "I'll stand with you. Today and every day after. That's my oath."

They disperse to their positions, each carrying a piece of your faith with them.

Facing Korthak

You walk to the main barricade, away from the others, and look out at the massive Alpha werewolf waiting in the twilight. He's perfectly still, a statue of muscle and menace.

For a moment, your eyes meet across the distance. You can feel his hatred, his certainty that he'll destroy you and everyone you're protecting.

But you don't look away.

You close your eyes and let the prayer flow from your heart:

Riv's Prayer

"These are good people, O Morninglord. You called your champion here and I will defend them with all I have. And when this night is past and the dawn comes again, we will discover who The Master is. We will seek out their evil, we will end their plans. We will deal with the cultists of Malar.

And I will make good on the promise I made to you all those years ago."

The promise hangs in the air between you and your god—the vow you made a decade past, when you were younger, more idealistic, less scarred by the world. To build an Order. Not just another temple or monastery, but a warrior order dedicated to hunting darkness wherever it breeds.

Werewolves. Cultists. Creatures that prey on the innocent.

And now, here, in this moment—you can feel it. This is where it begins.

- Aldric, the merchant saved from the curse, who wants to be more than he was
- Jakob, forged through suffering into something stronger
- Voss, the veteran monster hunter seeking purpose
- Dagmar and Finn, master and apprentice bound by respect and skill
- Garrick, the smith-warrior who leads with strength and heart

- Even young Javik Millstone, wearing your blessed shield

They don't know it yet, but you do. These are the seeds of your Order.

Lathander's Response

As your prayer ends, you feel it—warmth. Not the blazing heat of divine intervention, but the gentle warmth of sunrise. The feeling of potential, of beginnings, of dawn breaking after the longest night.

And with it comes certainty:

"Yes, my Champion. Here. Now. This is where your true work begins. Survive this night. Build what I have shown you. Bring my light to the darkest places."

Your holy symbol grows warm against your chest. You open your eyes, and for just a moment, everything seems clearer. The path ahead. The purpose. The calling.

The Ward Flickers

Behind you, Mother Nelle's voice rings out: "THIRTY MINUTES! THE WARD IS FAILING!"

The protective barrier that's kept Korthak at bay is dying. You can see it now—golden-green light flickering like a dying candle, holes appearing and closing, weakening with each passing moment.

Korthak sees it too. The Alpha raises his head, sniffing the air. Then he howls—a long, triumphant sound that echoes across the valley.

From the forest, answering howls. Multiple voices. The pack is ready.

Final Positions

Across Thornhaven, your defenders take their places:

Main Gate (East):

- Voss with crossbow, silvered bolt loaded
- 5 Millford soldiers
- 10 village militia
- Captain Blackwood in reserve

North Wall:

- Dagmar with bow
- Clara Millstone with bow
- 5 Millford soldiers
- Village defenders

South Wall:

- Thomas Millstone with bow
- 5 Millford soldiers
- Harlon commanding village defenders

West Wall (The Real Target):

- Finn with bow and oil barrels
- 10 Millford soldiers (the most experienced)
- Garrick commanding
- Jakob Harrow and village defenders
- 3 concealed bear traps
- 2 oil barrels ready to ignite

Roving/Reserve:

- You (covering east and south)
- Sister Mara (covering north and west)
- Mother Nelle coordinating healing stations
- Sarah Millstone and healers for triage

Fallback Position:

- The Sleeping Giant (fortified, supplied, ready)
- Non-combatants sheltering inside
- Gerda organizing final defenses

With a sound like breaking glass amplified a thousand times, the ward fails.

The golden-green barrier explodes into sparks of fading light and disappears.

For one heartbeat, everything is silent.

Then Korthak roars and charges.

ROLL INITIATIVE: d20 + 0 (your DEX modifier)

The Battle for Thornhaven begins.

What do you roll?

You said: 12

12

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Initiative: 12

Initiative: 12

A solid, middle-of-the-pack roll. You're not the fastest to react, but you're ready when it counts.

ROUND 1 - THE BATTLE BEGINS

THE ENEMY STRIKES

As the ward shatters, chaos erupts from multiple directions simultaneously—exactly as you predicted.

MAIN GATE (KORTHAK'S FEINT) - Initiative 20

Korthak charges toward the main gate with terrifying speed, his massive greatsword drawn. He's not alone—two werewolves emerge from the shadows behind him, running in hybrid form.

But they don't commit fully. At about 100 yards, Korthak stops, raising his sword and howling. The two werewolves fan out, circling but not attacking.

It's a feint, just as you predicted. Korthak wants attention on him.

Voss (Initiative 18) doesn't take the bait. He keeps his crossbow trained but holds his shot, waiting for a better opportunity. "Not yet... not yet..."

NORTH WALL - Initiative 19

From the northern tree line, four werewolves burst from cover, charging straight at the barricades. They're covering ground fast—250 yards... 200... 150...

Dagmar (Initiative 17) calls out: "NORTH WALL! FOUR CONTACTS!"

She looses an arrow—THUNK—catches one in the shoulder. It staggers but keeps coming.

Clara and the Millford archers fire—a volley of arrows. Two more hits. One werewolf goes down hard, an arrow through its throat. The other three keep charging.

100 yards... 75...

SOUTH WALL - Initiative 16

Three werewolves come from the south, moving low and fast through the harvested fields.

Thomas Millstone and the southern defenders open fire. One werewolf takes an arrow to the leg and stumbles. The other two keep coming, now 50 yards out.

WEST WALL (THE MAIN ASSAULT) - Initiative 14

This is where the real attack hits.

From the Darkwood Forest, EIGHT WEREWOLVES plus SIX HUMAN CULTISTS in dark robes charge the western approach. The cultists are chanting, and you can see dark magic swirling around them.

This is the force that was hiding. The real threat.

Garrick (Initiative 15) roars: "WEST WALL! CONTACT! MULTIPLE HOSTILES!"

Finn looses arrows as fast as he can. The Millford soldiers brace behind the barricades.

The first werewolf hits a bear trap—SNAP—the jaws close around its leg. It howls in agony, thrashing.

A second werewolf leaps over the trapped one—and hits another trap. Two down, trapped and screaming.

But six werewolves and six cultists are still coming. 60 yards... 50... 40...

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

You're positioned between the east and south walls as planned. You can:

SEE:

- Main gate: Korthak and 2 werewolves hanging back (100 yards)
- North wall: 3 werewolves charging (75 yards from barricade)
- South wall: 2 werewolves charging (50 yards from barricade)
- West wall: 6 werewolves + 6 cultists charging (40 yards from barricade), 2 trapped werewolves screaming

YOUR OPTIONS:

1. Move to reinforce a specific wall (you can cover ~30 feet per turn while acting)
2. Cast a spell - Your range options:
 - Guiding Bolt (120 ft range) - 4d6 radiant, next attack has advantage
 - Sacred Flame (60 ft range, cantrip) - 2d8 radiant, DEX save
 - Scorching Ray (120 ft range, Domain spell) - Three attacks, 2d6 fire each
3. Hold position and prepare - Ready an action for when enemies get closer
4. Coordinate/Command - Use your action to direct defenders (Help action for allies)

The west wall is about to be hit HARD in the next 6 seconds. The north and south walls are seconds behind.

What do you do?

You said: I reinforce the South Wall.

I reinforce the South Wall. If we can take out those two, we can focus on the West Wall with more force

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Moving to South Wall

Moving to South Wall

You sprint toward the southern barricade, chain mail clinking, holy symbol blazing with golden light. Your voice carries across the defenders:

"HOLD THE LINE! LATHANDER'S LIGHT IS WITH US!"

The southern defenders—Thomas Millstone, Harlon, five Millford soldiers, and a handful of village militia—brace as you arrive.

The two werewolves are now 30 yards out and closing fast. You can see their yellow eyes, slavering jaws, muscles bunching for the final leap over the barricades.

YOUR ACTION - ATTACK

You have a moment to act before they hit the wall. What do you do?

Option 1: GUIDING BOLT (120 ft, 1st-level spell slot)

- Ranged spell attack (+7 to hit)
- 4d6 radiant damage
- Next attack against target has advantage
- Takes one werewolf out of the fight or weakens it significantly

Option 2: SACRED FLAME (60 ft, cantrip - save resources)

- Target makes DEX save (DC 15)
- 2d8 radiant damage
- No spell slot used

Option 3: SCORCHING RAY (120 ft, 2nd-level spell slot - your Domain spell)

- Make THREE ranged spell attacks (+7 to hit)
- Each hit deals 2d6 fire damage
- Could potentially damage both werewolves or focus-fire one

What do you cast, and at which werewolf (the one with an arrow in its leg, or the healthy one)?

Meanwhile, the battle rages:

WEST WALL - The main assault hits. You hear Garrick roar, the clash of steel, Finn's arrows whistling, the screams of werewolves and men.

NORTH WALL - Dagmar's bow sings as the three werewolves close to melee range.

MAIN GATE - Korthak remains at distance, watching, waiting for something.

What's your attack?

You said: Can I use Sacred Flame?

Can I use Sacred Flame?

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Absolutely!

Absolutely! Sacred Flame is a cantrip - you can use it as much as you want without consuming spell slots. Smart choice to conserve resources for the long fight ahead.

SACRED FLAME

You raise your holy symbol, calling down divine fire. Radiant light blazes from above, seeking to engulf one of the charging werewolves.

Which one do you target?

1. The wounded one (already has arrow in leg, likely easier to take down)
2. The healthy one (full strength, bigger threat)

Once you choose, the werewolf makes a DEX save (DC 15).

Let me roll for it...

(I'll roll after you tell me which one you're targeting)

Meanwhile, 20 yards out and closing...

Thomas shouts: "Defender, they're almost on us!"

The Millford soldiers brace with spears, ready for impact.

Which werewolf gets the Sacred Flame?

You said: I'll target the wounded one

I'll target the wounded one

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SACRED FLAME - Targeting the Wounded Werewolf

SACRED FLAME - Targeting the Wounded Werewolf

You point at the limping werewolf with the arrow protruding from its leg. Radiant fire blazes down from above like a pillar of golden light.

Werewolf DEX Save: Rolling... 8

FAIL! (needs 15)

The wounded werewolf can't dodge in time with its injured leg. The sacred flame engulfs it, radiant energy searing corrupted flesh.

Damage: Roll 2d8 radiant damage!

What do you roll?

(While you roll, the second werewolf is now 15 yards out and will hit the barricade in seconds...)

You said: 3 and 5

3 and 5

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Sacred Flame Damage: 3 + 5 = 8 radiant damage

Sacred Flame Damage: 3 + 5 = 8 radiant damage

The pillar of holy fire consumes the wounded werewolf. Combined with the arrow wound and now the radiant burning, the creature's charge falters. It stumbles, tries to keep running, then collapses in a smoking heap 20 yards from the barricade.

One down.

Thomas Millstone shouts: "NICE SHOT, DEFENDER!"

But the second werewolf is RIGHT THERE.

10 yards... 5 yards...

It leaps over the barricade with a roar, landing among the defenders. Massive claws swing at a Millford soldier—

CLANG! The soldier's shield deflects the blow, but he's thrown backward.

Harlon and two other defenders close in with spears, jabbing at the beast. One spear finds flesh—the werewolf howls but stays up, thrashing.

ROUND 1 CONTINUES

WEST WALL - The Main Assault Hits (Initiative 13-10)

You hear the CRASH of impact as six werewolves and six cultists slam into the western barricade.

Finn's voice, high with adrenaline: "OIL! NOW!"

WHOOSH!

One of the oil barrels ignites—flames erupt across the approach. Two werewolves are caught in the blaze, screaming. One cultist goes down, burning.

But the others push through. Werewolves leap the barricade. Cultists chant dark magic—you see shadowy tendrils reaching for Garrick and Jakob.

Garrick (Initiative 11): "HOLD THE LINE!" His silvered blade flashes, catching a werewolf across the chest. It reels back, silver burning.

Jakob Harrow (Initiative 9): The young man's first real battle. A werewolf lunges at him—he raises the shield Garrick made, deflects claws, then counters with his sword. Not a killing blow, but he holds his ground.

NORTH WALL (Initiative 8-6)

Three werewolves hit the northern barricade simultaneously.

Dagmar drops her bow, draws her hunting knife, and stabs a werewolf that tried to leap over. It crashes down, wounded.

Clara Millstone screams as claws rake toward her—a Millford soldier interposes, taking the hit on his shield.

The defenders are holding, but it's desperate, chaotic melee.

SISTER MARA (Initiative 7)

The Cleric of Torm sprints toward the north wall, her silvered warhammer gleaming. She arrives just as a werewolf breaks through the line.

"TORM'S DUTY!"

CRACK!

Her hammer smashes into the werewolf's skull. Silver + divine power. The creature drops, dead before it hits the ground.

MAIN GATE - KORTHAK (Initiative 5)

The Alpha has been watching. Waiting. Learning your defenses.

Now he moves.

But not toward the main gate. He circles south—toward your position.

He's coming for you, Defender.

Voss shouts: "RIV! KORTHAK'S FLANKING! HE'S COMING YOUR WAY!"

The massive Alpha werewolf is 80 yards out and closing fast, his two pack members following behind him.

ROUND 1 ENDS - ROUND 2 BEGINS

BATTLEFIELD STATUS:

South Wall (Your Position):

- 1 werewolf dead (your Sacred Flame)
- 1 werewolf in melee with defenders (wounded but fighting)
- Korthak + 2 werewolves approaching (60 yards out now)

West Wall:

- 2 werewolves trapped in bear traps (screaming, injured)
- 2 werewolves burning in oil (one might be dead)
- 2 werewolves + 6 cultists in melee with Garrick, Jakob, Finn, and soldiers
- Desperate fighting, holding but taking casualties

North Wall:

- 1 werewolf dead (Sister Mara's kill)
- 2 werewolves in melee with Dagmar, Clara, and defenders
- Holding but pressed

Main Gate:

- Currently clear (Korthak moved south)

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

Current Status:

- HP: 39/39
- Spell Slots: 4/4 (1st), 3/3 (2nd)
- Position: South Wall, one werewolf in melee with your defenders, Korthak 60 yards out and closing

What do you do?

1. Engage the werewolf in melee at your position (attack with mace)
2. Cast a spell at the approaching Korthak (Guiding Bolt, Scorching Ray, etc.)
3. Buff your defenders (Bless, Shield of Faith on yourself/ally)
4. Call for reinforcements to your position
5. Something else?

Korthak is coming for you personally. This is the confrontation you knew was coming.

You said: I cast Guiding Bolt on Korthak and yell to Sister Mara - this is our shot

I cast Guiding Bolt on Korthak and yell to Sister Mara - this is our shot

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: GUIDING BOLT AT KORTHAK

GUIDING BOLT AT KORTHAK

You step up onto the barricade, fully visible, holy symbol blazing in your hand. Your voice rings out across the battlefield:

"SISTER MARA! KORTHAK! THIS IS OUR SHOT!"

Then you thrust your symbol toward the charging Alpha, channeling Lathander's wrath:

"BY THE MORNINGLORD'S LIGHT—FALL!"

A bolt of brilliant radiant energy erupts from your holy symbol, streaking across the battlefield like a miniature sun.

GUIDING BOLT ATTACK

Roll d20 + 7 (spell attack bonus)

What do you roll?

Sister Mara hears you from the north wall. She turns, sees Korthak charging your position, understands immediately.

"TORM GUIDE MY HAND!"

She's already moving, sprinting toward the south wall to support you.

Korthak sees the radiant bolt coming but doesn't slow. The massive Alpha charges straight at you, his yellow eyes locked on yours, greatsword raised.

50 yards... 40...

Roll your attack!

You said: 7

7

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Attack Roll: $7 + 7 = 14$

Attack Roll: $7 + 7 = 14$

The radiant bolt blazes through the air toward Korthak—

MISS.

The Alpha dodges at the last second with terrifying agility for something so massive. The bolt of holy light sears past him, scorching the ground where he was a heartbeat before.

Korthak doesn't even slow. If anything, your attack seems to have enraged him further. He roars, a sound of pure hatred and challenge.

"YOU WILL DIE SCREAMING, PRIEST!"

Spell Slot Used: 3/4 (1st level) remaining

The Werewolf at Your Position (Initiative 11)

The werewolf currently engaged with your defenders lashes out at Harlon, who's jabbing at it with a spear.

Claw attack: The beast rolls... 16 to hit

Harlon's AC is probably around 14-15. HIT.

The claws rake across Harlon's shoulder—he grunts in pain, stumbling back. Blood flows, but he stays up, gritting his teeth.

Thomas Millstone and a Millford soldier press in, keeping the creature occupied.

KORTHAK AND HIS PACK CLOSE IN (Initiative 10)

Korthak is now 30 yards away. His two pack werewolves fan out on either side of him, forming a three-pronged assault on your position.

They'll be in melee range next round.

Behind you, you hear defenders calling out nervously:

"The Alpha's coming!"

"Hold the line!"

"Defender, what do we do?!"

WEST WALL (Initiative 9-7)

The western battle is brutal:

- Garrick trades blows with a werewolf, his silvered blade holding it at bay
- Jakob is knocked down by a cultist's dark magic but scrambles back up, shield raised
- Finn switches to his knife, stabbing a cultist who got too close
- One Millford soldier goes down with a scream—claws across his chest
- Another soldier runs a werewolf through with a silvered spear—the beast collapses, dead

The oil fires are dying down. Two werewolves dead (burned), two trapped and helpless. But two werewolves and five cultists are still fighting fiercely.

Casualties mounting. But they're holding.

NORTH WALL (Initiative 6)

Dagmar grapples with a werewolf that tried to drag her over the barricade. She manages to stab it in the throat with her knife—it releases her, gurgling.

The last werewolf on the north wall is being swarmed by soldiers and goes down under multiple spear thrusts.

North wall is clear! But at a cost—you see two defenders down, one not moving.

SISTER MARA (Initiative 5)

She's sprinting toward your position but won't arrive until next round. "HOLD, DEFENDER! I'M COMING!"

VOSS (Initiative 4)

From his position at the main gate, Voss has a clear shot at Korthak now that the Alpha has moved south.

"RIV! GET DOWN WHEN I SAY!"

He's lining up with his silvered crossbow bolt.

ROUND 2 ENDS - ROUND 3 BEGINS

YOUR POSITION:

- One werewolf in melee with your defenders (Harlon wounded)
 - Korthak + 2 werewolves 30 yards out (will be in melee next turn)
 - Voss has a shot lined up
 - Sister Mara one round away
-

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

Current Status:

- HP: 39/39
- Spell Slots: 3/4 (1st), 3/3 (2nd)
- Channel Divinity: 1/1 available
- Position: South wall barricade, highly visible

Options:

1. Drop prone (let Voss take his shot at Korthak without you in the way)
2. Cast Shield of Faith on yourself (AC 16→18, prepare for melee)
3. Cast Bless on yourself + defenders (add 1d4 to attacks and saves)
4. Attack the werewolf in melee with your mace (help clear it before Korthak arrives)
5. Use Channel Divinity: Radiance of the Dawn (when Korthak gets close, hit all three with 2d10+4 radiant)
6. Something else?

Korthak will be on you in 6 seconds. What do you do?

You said: I drop at Voss' word and cast bless on myself and nearby defenders, Sister Mara included

I drop at Voss' word and cast bless on myself and nearby defenders, Sister Mara included

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: "DOWN!"

"DOWN!"

Voss's command cuts through the chaos. You drop flat behind the barricade without hesitation.

TWANG!

The silvered crossbow bolt screams through the space where your head was a heartbeat before, streaking toward Korthak.

Voss's Attack (Silvered Bolt)

The veteran hunter's aim is true.

Attack roll: Natural 18 + 4 = 22. SOLID HIT.

The silvered bolt slams into Korthak's shoulder, punching deep. Silver sears corrupted flesh—smoke rises from the wound.

Korthak roars in pain and rage, stumbling mid-charge. The bolt won't kill him, but it hurts.

"COWARDS! HIDING BEHIND WALLS AND TRICKS!"

He tears the bolt free, black blood streaming, but his charge has slowed. 20 yards out now instead of 10.

BLESS CAST

Still prone, you grip your holy symbol and channel divine power:

"LATHANDER, GRANT US YOUR FAVOR! BLESS THESE DEFENDERS!"

Golden light washes over you and radiates outward, touching three nearby allies:

Who do you target with Bless? (Choose 3 creatures within 30 feet)

Options:

- Yourself (definitely)
- Harlon (fighting the werewolf at your position, already wounded)
- Thomas Millstone (defending nearby)
- Sister Mara (approaching fast, will be in melee soon)
- Millford soldiers at your position

Pick your three targets!

Spell slot used: 2/4 (1st level) remaining

Bless Effect: For 1 minute (10 rounds), the three targets add 1d4 to attack rolls and saving throws. This is huge for keeping people alive and hitting back.

Concentration: You're now concentrating on Bless. If you take damage, you'll need to make a Constitution save to maintain it.

Korthak and his pack are 20 yards out. They'll be on you next round.

Who gets blessed?

You said: Sister Mara, Thomas Millstone, Harlon

Sister Mara, Thomas Millstone, Harlon

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: BLESS - Divine Favor Granted

BLESS - Divine Favor Granted

Golden light flows from you to your chosen allies:

Sister Mara - Sprinting toward you, she feels Lathander's blessing merge with Torm's protection. Her eyes flash with holy fire. "COMBINED MIGHT!"

Thomas Millstone - The farmer-turned-defender steadies, his hands firming on his bow. The blessing washes away his fear.

Harlon - The wounded veteran gasps as divine energy courses through him. His spear comes up stronger despite his bleeding shoulder.

All three now add 1d4 to all attack rolls and saving throws for the next minute.

SOUTH WALL WEREWOLF (Initiative 11)

The werewolf engaged with your defenders lunges at a Millford soldier—

Attack roll: $13 + 4 = 17$

HIT. Claws tear into the soldier's side. He cries out but stays up, backing away bleeding.

Harlon counters with his spear:

Attack: $d20 + \text{modifier} + 1d4 \text{ (Bless)} = \text{Let me roll... } 16 \text{ total. HIT!}$

The spear punches into the werewolf's flank. It howls, badly wounded now.

KORTHAK'S CHARGE (Initiative 10)

The Alpha and his two pack werewolves close the final distance.

10 yards... 5 yards...

Korthak leaps over the barricade, landing with earth-shaking impact right in front of you. Up close, he's even more terrifying—eight feet of muscle, scars, ritual brands, yellow eyes burning with hatred.

His greatsword swings down at you—

YOU'RE STILL PRONE FROM DROPPING FOR VOSS'S SHOT!

Attacks against prone targets have advantage.

Korthak's Attack (with advantage):

- First roll: 18
- Second roll: 12
- Takes higher: $18 + 6 = 24$ to hit

Your AC is 16. HIT.

The massive blade comes down. You try to roll aside, but—

Damage: The greatsword deals $2d6 + 4 =$ Rolling... 9 slashing damage!

The blade crashes into your shoulder, tearing through chain mail. Pain explodes through you. Blood flows.

HP: 30/39 (took 9 damage)

The two pack werewolves land beside Korthak, snarling. One lunges at Thomas, the other at Harlon.

Werewolf 1 vs. Thomas: Attack: $15 + 4 = 19$. HIT. Thomas takes a nasty claw across his arm—he staggers back.

Werewolf 2 vs. Harlon: Attack: $12 + 4 = 16$. HIT. Harlon, already wounded, takes another hit. He's barely standing.

WEST WALL (Initiative 9-7)

The western battle turns:

Garrick drives his silvered blade through a werewolf's heart—it collapses. "ONE MORE DOWN!"

Jakob is fighting desperately, shield battered, but he's still standing. A cultist tries to flank him—Finn puts an arrow through the cultist's throat.

But casualties are mounting. Another Millford soldier falls. A village defender screams.

Still: 1 werewolf, 4 cultists fighting there, plus the 2 trapped/helpless in bear traps.

SISTER MARA ARRIVES (Initiative 5)

The Cleric of Torm crashes into the melee at your position, silvered warhammer swinging.

"TORM'S JUSTICE!"

She targets one of Korthak's pack werewolves:

Attack: $d20 + \text{modifier} + 1d4 \text{ (Bless)} = 19 \text{ total. HIT!}$

SMASH! The silvered hammer connects with brutal force. The werewolf's skull cracks. It drops, dead instantly.

Sister Mara positions herself beside you, protecting your flank.

ROUND 3 ENDS - ROUND 4 BEGINS

YOUR IMMEDIATE SITUATION:

You're on the ground (prone), wounded (30/39 HP), bleeding, with Korthak standing over you.

One pack werewolf left (the one fighting Thomas). The south wall werewolf is badly wounded.

Sister Mara is here. Harlon and Thomas are wounded but blessed.

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

You need to:

1. Stand up (costs half your movement, but you can still act)
2. Stay prone (attacks against you have advantage, but you have disadvantage attacking)

Then choose an action:

Offensive:

- Channel Divinity: Radiance of the Dawn - 30-foot radius, $2d10+4$ radiant to all enemies (Korthak, the pack werewolf, the wounded werewolf)
- Spiritual Weapon (2nd level) - Create floating weapon, bonus action attacks
- Guiding Bolt at point-blank range

Defensive:

- Shield of Faith on yourself (AC 18 for 10 minutes)
- Cure Wounds on yourself (heal $1d8+5$)

What do you do? Korthak is RIGHT THERE, his blade dripping with your blood.

You said: I stand up and say to Korthak "Korthak.

I stand up and say to Korthak "Korthak. I, " I say, through ragged breaths, "I am Riv Freeborn. I am a holy champion of Lathander. And you.... will... FALL" At this, I cast Channel Divinity on the three werewolves in front of me

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: STAND AND DECLARE

STAND AND DECLARE

You push through the pain, planting your mace against the ground and forcing yourself upright. Blood runs down your armor from the shoulder wound, but your eyes blaze with holy fire.

Face to face with the Alpha, you speak through gritted teeth:

"Korthak. I am Riv Freeborn. I am a holy champion of Lathander. And you.... will... FALL!"

CHANNEL DIVINITY: RADIANCE OF THE DAWN

You thrust your holy symbol skyward. Your voice becomes a thunderous command:

"BY LATHANDER'S ETERNAL LIGHT—DAWN BREAKS!"

The night explodes with radiance.

A sphere of brilliant golden light erupts from you in a 30-foot radius—pure, searing, divine sunrise concentrated into a single devastating moment.

TARGETS IN RADIUS:

- Korthak (directly in front of you)
- Pack werewolf (fighting Thomas)
- Wounded south wall werewolf (fighting Harlon)

DAMAGE: 2d10 + 4 radiant

Roll 2d10!

Each target makes a CON save DC 15. On a success, they take half damage.

THE EFFECT

The radiance is blinding. Your allies shield their eyes. The werewolves scream as holy light burns corrupted flesh.

Korthak throws his arm up, roaring in pain and fury.

Roll those dice! What's the damage?

Channel Divinity used: 0/1 remaining

You said: 5 and 7

5 and 7

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: RADIANCE OF THE DAWN: $5 + 7 + 4 = 16$ radiant damage

RADIANCE OF THE DAWN: $5 + 7 + 4 = 16$ radiant damage

The golden light detonates outward like a divine bomb.

SAVING THROWS:

Korthak (CON save): Rolling... 18. SUCCESS. The Alpha is incredibly resilient. He twists away, taking only 8 radiant damage (half). The light sears his flesh, smoking and burning, but he stays standing, snarling through the pain.

Pack Werewolf (CON save): Rolling... 9. FAIL. Full 16 radiant damage. The creature shrieks as holy fire consumes it. Already wounded from Sister Mara's previous attacks, it collapses, smoking and dead.

South Wall Werewolf (CON save): Rolling... 7. FAIL. Full 16 radiant damage. Already badly wounded from Harlon's spear, the radiant burst incinerates it. The werewolf drops, lifeless.

THE AFTERMATH

When the light fades:

Two werewolves are dead, their bodies smoking on the ground.

Korthak stands, wounded (he's taken the silvered bolt + 8 radiant = significant damage), but very much alive. His yellow eyes lock onto yours with pure hatred.

"You... you DARE?!"

The defenders around you—Thomas, Harlon, Sister Mara, the soldiers—stare in awe at what you just did. Two werewolves obliterated in an instant.

Sister Mara grins fiercely: "WELL STRUCK, BROTHER!"

KORTHAK'S TURN (Initiative 10)

The Alpha is enraged. Wounded. Humiliated. His pack is being destroyed.

He could flee. Cut his losses.

But his pride, his fury, his devotion to Malar won't allow it.

"I WILL TEAR OUT YOUR HEART, PRIEST!"

He swings his greatsword in a massive overhead chop aimed at splitting you in half—

Attack roll: $16 + 6 = 22$ to hit

Your AC is 16. HIT.

Damage: $2d6 + 4 =$ Rolling... 11 slashing damage!

The blade crashes down onto your shoulder again—the same wounded spot. You feel something crack. The pain is excruciating.

HP: 19/39 (took 11 damage, down to less than half HP)

You stagger, barely staying upright. Blood pours freely now.

CONCENTRATION CHECK FOR BLESS

You took 11 damage. You must make a CON save DC 10 (half the damage, minimum 10) to maintain concentration on Bless.

Roll $d20 + 2$ (CON modifier)

What do you roll?

If you fail: Bless ends immediately (Thomas, Harlon, and Sister Mara lose the 1d4 bonus)

If you succeed: Bless continues (they keep the bonus)

You said: 11

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: CONCENTRATION CHECK: $11 + 2 = 13$.

CONCENTRATION CHECK: $11 + 2 = 13$. SUCCESS!

Despite the agony of Korthak's blade tearing into you again, you grit your teeth and hold onto the divine magic. The golden light of Bless continues to shimmer around Thomas, Harlon, and Sister Mara.

"Not... yet..." you gasp.

WEST WALL (Initiative 9-7)

The western battle is turning in your favor:

Garrick catches a cultist with his silvered blade—the man goes down screaming. "PRESS THEM!"

Jakob blocks a werewolf's claws with his shield, then counters with his sword—a solid hit to the beast's leg. It limps back, wounded.

Finn puts two arrows into the last standing werewolf—it staggers but stays up.

Millford soldiers swarm the remaining cultists. One cultist tries to flee—a soldier cuts him down.

Remaining at West Wall: 1 wounded werewolf, 2 cultists, plus the 2 helpless in bear traps

They're breaking. The west wall assault is failing.

NORTH WALL - CLEAR

Dagmar wipes blood from a cut on her cheek, bow back in hand: "North is secure! Do we reinforce?!"

She can see your situation from her position—Korthak standing over you, you bleeding badly.

THOMAS MILLSTONE (Initiative 8)

Thomas, blessed and determined, drops his bow and draws a hunting knife. He lunges at Korthak from the side, trying to help you.

Attack (with Bless bonus): $d20 + 1d4$... Rolling... 17 total. HIT!

The knife finds a gap in Korthak's defenses—Thomas drives it into the Alpha's side. Not deep, not silver, but it bleeds.

Korthak backhands Thomas casually, sending the farmer sprawling. But Thomas bought you a moment.

HARLON (Initiative 7)

The wounded veteran, also blessed, jabs his spear at Korthak's legs, trying to trip or wound the massive Alpha.

Attack (with Bless): Rolling... 14. MISS.

Korthak deflects the spear with his sword, snarling.

SISTER MARA (Initiative 5)

"GET AWAY FROM HIM!"

Sister Mara swings her silvered warhammer at Korthak's back:

Attack (with Bless): d20 + 1d4... Rolling... 21. SOLID HIT!

CRACK! The silvered hammer smashes into Korthak's spine. The Alpha roars, arching in pain. Silver burns. Bones crack.

He stumbles forward, away from you, turning to face this new threat.

VOSS (Initiative 4)

From the main gate, Voss is reloading—he used his silvered bolt earlier. "I need thirty seconds to reload! HOLD HIM!"

ROUND 4 ENDS - ROUND 5 BEGINS

BATTLEFIELD STATUS:

Your Position (South Wall):

- You: 19/39 HP, bleeding heavily, Bless active (concentration), standing but barely
- Korthak: Wounded (silvered bolt, radiant damage x2, knife wound, silvered hammer), enraged, now focused on Sister Mara
- Thomas and Harlon wounded but fighting

- All other werewolves at this position: DEAD

West Wall:

- 1 wounded werewolf, 2 cultists fighting
- 2 werewolves helpless in traps
- Cult assault breaking

North Wall:

- CLEAR - Dagmar asking if she should reinforce
-

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

Current Status:

- HP: 19/39 (badly wounded)
- Spell Slots: 2/4 (1st), 3/3 (2nd)
- Channel Divinity: 0/1 (used)
- Bless: Active (concentrating)
- Warding Flare: 5/5 uses available

You're in bad shape, but Korthak is wounded too. Sister Mara is engaging him in melee.

Options:

1. Heal yourself - Cure Wounds (1d8+5) or Healing Word (bonus action, 1d4+5)
2. Attack Korthak - Melee with mace, or spell at close range
3. Support Sister Mara - Cast Shield of Faith on her, or use Help action
4. Spiritual Weapon - Create floating weapon to attack as bonus action
5. Fall back - Let Sister Mara handle Korthak while you heal/regroup

What do you do?

You said: I cast Spiritual Weapon.

I cast Spiritual Weapon. This fight could kill me, but I won't back down

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SPIRITUAL WEAPON

SPIRITUAL WEAPON

Blood streaming down your armor, breathing ragged, you refuse to retreat. Instead, you raise your holy symbol with a trembling hand and channel divine power:

"Lathander... grant me... your blade..."

A glowing golden warhammer materializes in the air beside Korthak—translucent but solid, radiating holy light. It hovers at shoulder height, waiting for your mental command.

Spiritual Weapon created (2nd-level spell slot used: 2/3 remaining)

- Lasts 1 minute
 - Bonus action to attack each turn
 - 1d8+5 force damage on hit
 - Flies independently, 20-foot movement
-

BONUS ACTION: SPIRITUAL WEAPON ATTACKS

You mentally command the floating hammer to strike Korthak from behind while he's focused on Sister Mara.

Attack roll: d20 + 7 (spell attack bonus)

What do you roll?

Korthak is caught between:

- Sister Mara in front with her silvered warhammer
- Your spectral hammer behind him
- Thomas and Harlon flanking
- You, bloodied but defiant, still channeling divine power

The Alpha realizes he's surrounded. His yellow eyes flick between threats, calculating.

Roll your Spiritual Weapon attack!

You said: 16!

16!

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SPIRITUAL WEAPON ATTACK: $16 + 7 = 23$.

SPIRITUAL WEAPON ATTACK: $16 + 7 = 23$. SOLID HIT!

The golden hammer crashes into Korthak's back with divine force.

Damage: Roll $1d8 + 5$

What do you roll?

The spectral weapon strikes with a sound like thunder. Korthak staggers forward, his back smoking where the holy energy impacted. He's being hammered from all sides now—literally.

"ENOUGH!" he roars, spittle flying.

The Alpha is wounded, bleeding from multiple injuries:

- Voss's silvered bolt
- Your radiant bursts (8 damage)
- Thomas's knife
- Sister Mara's silvered hammer
- Now your Spiritual Weapon

He's tough—incredibly tough—but even he has limits.

Roll that damage!

You said: 3

3

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SPIRITUAL WEAPON DAMAGE: $3 + 5 = 8$ force damage

SPIRITUAL WEAPON DAMAGE: $3 + 5 = 8$ force damage

The hammer strikes true, divine force cracking into Korthak's already battered spine. He stumbles, snarling in pain.

The Alpha is badly wounded now—bleeding from multiple injuries, burned by radiant energy, battered by silver weapons. But he's still standing, still dangerous.

KORTHAK'S DECISION (Initiative 10)

The Alpha's tactical mind works through his situation:

- His pack is destroyed (dead or dying)
- The cult assault on the west wall is breaking
- He's surrounded and wounded
- You're still channeling divine power despite being half-dead

For a moment, you see calculation in those yellow eyes. Then rage wins over tactics.

"IF I DIE, PRIEST, YOU DIE WITH ME!"

He ignores Sister Mara entirely and lunges at you with desperate fury, greatsword raised for a killing blow.

Attack roll: $19 + 6 = 25$ to hit

CRITICAL THREAT. His blade comes down with all his remaining strength—

DO YOU USE WARDING FLARE?

You have Warding Flare (5/5 uses remaining) - Your Light Domain ability!

As a REACTION, you can impose disadvantage on this attack (force him to reroll and take the lower result).

This could be the difference between life and death.

Do you use Warding Flare? (Yes/No)

You said: Yes

Yes

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: WARDING FLARE - REACTION

WARDING FLARE - REACTION

As Korthak's blade descends toward your skull, you thrust your holy symbol forward. Blinding golden light erupts directly into the Alpha's eyes.

"LATHANDER'S LIGHT!"

Korthak flinches, the radiance searing his vision. His strike goes wild.

Warding Flare used: 4/5 remaining

REROLL WITH DISADVANTAGE

Second roll: $8 + 6 = 14$ to hit

Taking the lower result: 14

Your AC is 16. MISS!

The greatsword crashes into the barricade beside you, splintering wood. You feel the wind of the blade passing inches from your face, but it doesn't connect.

Korthak roars in frustration, momentarily blinded, his killing blow thwarted by divine light.

WEST WALL (Initiative 9-7)

The western assault collapses completely:

Garrick runs the last wounded werewolf through with his silvered blade. "THAT'S THE LAST OF THEM!"

Jakob and Finn corner the final two cultists—the cultists throw down their weapons, surrendering.

The two werewolves trapped in bear traps are killed by Millford soldiers.

WEST WALL: SECURED

Garrick immediately starts organizing: "Dagmar! Finn! SOUTH WALL! THE DEFENDER NEEDS US!"

THOMAS (Initiative 8)

Thomas, blessed and brave, scrambles back to his feet and grabs his bow. At point-blank range, he fires an arrow at Korthak's back:

Attack (with Bless): Rolling... 16 total. HIT!

The arrow punches into Korthak's shoulder blade. The Alpha howls.

HARLON (Initiative 7)

The wounded veteran drives his spear at Korthak's leg:

Attack (with Bless): Rolling... 18. SOLID HIT!

The spear finds flesh—Korthak's leg buckles slightly. He's limping now.

SISTER MARA (Initiative 5)

"TORM'S FINAL JUDGMENT!"

Sister Mara swings her silvered warhammer with everything she has:

Attack (with Bless): Rolling... 20. CRITICAL HIT!

CRACK!

The hammer shatters Korthak's ribs with a sickening crunch. The Alpha coughs blood, staggering.

He's on his last legs. Barely standing. But still alive, still fighting.

DAGMAR ARRIVES (Initiative 3)

Dagmar sprints from the north wall, bow in hand, one of her precious silvered arrows nocked.

She slides to a stop, draws, and fires at Korthak's exposed back:

Attack: Natural 17 + modifiers = Hit!

The silvered arrow punches through Korthak's back, emerging from his chest. Silver burns from within.

The Alpha staggers, dropping to one knee. Blood pours from multiple wounds.

ROUND 5 ENDS - ROUND 6 BEGINS

KORTHAK IS DYING

The mighty Alpha, the twenty-year champion of Malar, is on his knees. Bleeding from a dozen wounds. Silver burning in his flesh. Surrounded by enemies.

But he's not dead yet.

He looks up at you with fading yellow eyes, blood on his lips:

"The Master... will avenge... this defeat... Your light... will be... extinguished..."

He tries to raise his sword one more time—

YOUR TURN (Initiative 12)

You can finish him.

Current Status:

- HP: 19/39
- Spell Slots: 2/4 (1st), 2/3 (2nd)
- Spiritual Weapon: Active (bonus action available)
- Bless: Still active

How do you end Korthak?

1. Spiritual Weapon - Let the divine hammer finish him
2. Melee attack - Walk up and strike him down with your mace personally
3. Sacred Flame - Holy fire from above
4. Guiding Bolt - One final radiant bolt
5. Something else?

This is your moment, Defender. How does the Alpha fall?

You said: "Korthak", I say, my breathing ragged, my words barely audible, "your Master holds no dominion here".

"Korthak", I say, my breathing ragged, my words barely audible, "your Master holds no dominion here". I cast Sacred Flame and order my Spiritual Weapon to attack

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: THE END OF KORTHAK

THE END OF KORTHAK

You stand over the kneeling Alpha, blood dripping from your wounds, but your voice carries absolute conviction despite its weakness:

"Korthak... your Master holds no dominion here."

You raise your holy symbol. Your spectral hammer positions itself above the Alpha's head.

"Lathander's dawn has come."

SACRED FLAME

Divine fire blazes down from above, a pillar of radiant light descending on Korthak.

Korthak's DEX Save: Rolling... 4. FAIL.

The Alpha, too wounded to dodge, is engulfed.

Damage: Roll 2d8

What do you roll?

SPIRITUAL WEAPON (BONUS ACTION)

Simultaneously, you mentally command the golden hammer to strike.

Attack: $d20 + 7 =$ Rolling... 19. HIT!

Damage: Roll $1d8 + 5$

Roll both sets of dice!

The battlefield holds its breath. Every defender watches as divine judgment falls on the cult champion who terrorized them for weeks.

You said: Sacred Flame: 6 and 2

Sacred Flame: 6 and 2

Spiritual Weapon: 4

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SACRED FLAME: $6 + 2 = 8$ radiant damage

SACRED FLAME: $6 + 2 = 8$ radiant damage SPIRITUAL WEAPON: $4 + 5 = 9$ force damage

Total: 17 divine damage

THE FALL OF KORTHAK

The pillar of holy fire engulfs Korthak from above while the golden hammer crashes down upon his skull. Divine light and force combine in a devastating finale.

The Alpha tries to howl one last time—a defiant roar to Malar, to his Master, to the darkness he served for twenty years.

But the sound dies in his throat.

His yellow eyes fade to brown, then to nothing. The greatsword slips from his fingers, clattering to the ground. His massive form—eight feet of muscle, scars, and hatred—collapses forward, crashing face-first into the blood-soaked earth.

Korthak, the Alpha, Champion of Malar, is dead.

SILENCE

For one heartbeat, the battlefield is absolutely silent.

Then—

"THE ALPHA IS DOWN!"

"KORTHAK IS DEAD!"

"THE DEFENDER DID IT!"

THE REMAINING CULTISTS BREAK

At the west wall, the two surrendered cultists see their leader fall. One screams and tries to run—Garrick cuts him down. The other falls to his knees, sobbing, begging for mercy.

The battle is over.

YOU COLLAPSE

The adrenaline that kept you standing drains away all at once. Your legs give out. You drop to your knees beside Korthak's corpse, vision swimming, blood loss catching up to you.

HP: 19/39 - You're conscious but barely

Sister Mara is beside you instantly: "Easy, Defender! I've got you!"

She channels healing magic, golden-blue light washing over you:

Cure Wounds (her spell): She rolls... You regain 12 HP

HP: 31/39

The worst of your wounds close. You can breathe without agony. The bleeding stops.

Mother Nelle arrives, running from the healing station: "Riv! Oh thank the gods—" She places her hands on you, channeling more healing energy.

THE AFTERMATH

As you catch your breath, supported by the two priestesses, you see:

CASUALTIES:

- 3 Millford soldiers dead
- 5 village defenders dead
- Many wounded (Harlon, Thomas, Clara, a dozen others)

ENEMY:

- Korthak: Dead
 - All werewolves: Dead (you count at least 12-15 bodies)
 - Cultists: 1 captured alive, rest dead
-

YOUR COMPANIONS GATHER

Garrick limps over, bleeding from a gash on his arm but grinning: "You did it, you crazy bastard. You actually did it."

Dagmar kneels beside you, checking you over with a tracker's eye: "Thought we were going to lose you there. Don't do that again."

Voss approaches, crossbow still in hand: "That was the finest defensive stand I've seen in fifteen years of monster hunting."

Jakob Harrow, armor dented, shield cracked, but alive: "Master... you saved us all."

Captain Blackwood surveys the battlefield with professional assessment: "Defender Freeborn. That was... extraordinary. My report to Millford will reflect that Thornhaven held because of your leadership."

Aldric emerges from The Sleeping Giant, tears streaming: "Riv... Riv, you did it. The village is saved."

ELDER WREN

The elderly leader walks slowly through the carnage, taking in the cost, the victory, the bodies of neighbors and strangers who gave everything.

She stops before you, places both hands on your shoulders:

"Riv Freeborn. Four days ago, you were a stranger passing through. Tonight, you are the savior of Thornhaven. We owe you everything—our lives, our homes, our future."

She looks around at the gathered defenders:

"All of you. You fought with courage that will be remembered for generations. Tonight, we grieve our fallen. Tomorrow, we rebuild. But right now..."

She helps you to your feet:

"Right now, we celebrate that we're alive. That dawn will come. That the darkness was driven back."

The eastern sky is beginning to lighten. Not full dawn yet, but the promise of it.

You did it. Thornhaven survived.

What does Riv do in this moment? What does he say?

You said: To Captain Blackwood: "Haul that cultist away somewhere safe."

To Captain Blackwood: "Haul that cultist away somewhere safe. We'll talk to him in the morning."

To everyone else: "Drinks are on me! Tonight - we celebrate! To the Sleeping Giant!"

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: CAPTAIN BLACKWOOD

CAPTAIN BLACKWOOD

The military man nods sharply: "Consider it done." He gestures to two of his soldiers. "Take the prisoner to the grain storehouse. Guard him well. No one talks to him until the Defender says so."

The cultist is hauled away, still sobbing, realizing he's the only one of his order left alive.

TO EVERYONE ELSE

You raise your voice—still weak, still bleeding in places, but triumphant:

"DRINKS ARE ON ME! TONIGHT—WE CELEBRATE! TO THE SLEEPING GIANT!"

A roar of approval erupts from the defenders. Exhausted, wounded, grieving—but alive. The relief, the joy, the sheer disbelief that they survived crashes over everyone at once.

Garrick throws his arm around your shoulders (carefully, mindful of your wounds): "FIRST ROUND'S ON THE DEFENDER! THE REST ARE ON ME!"

Dagmar actually laughs—a sound you've rarely heard from her: "Gods, I need a drink. Several drinks."

Voss grins: "Been a long time since I celebrated a victory like this. Let's make it count."

Jakob looks at you with absolute devotion: "Master, I'll follow you anywhere."

THE SLEEPING GIANT

The tavern's doors are thrown wide. Gerda emerges, tears streaming down her face, already organizing:

"Food! Drink! Every barrel I've got! Tonight, no one pays!" She looks at you. "Defender, your money's no good here. Not tonight. Not ever."

Inside, the tavern transforms from fortress to celebration hall. Tables are righted. Candles lit. The surviving defenders pour in—soldiers, villagers, hunters, healers—all of them alive against impossible odds.

THE CELEBRATION BEGINS

Ale flows freely. Gerda and her staff somehow produce food—stew, bread, cheese, roasted meat saved for emergencies.

Stories begin immediately:

A Millford soldier: "Did you see the Defender's radiant burst? Two werewolves just... gone!"

A village woman: "Garrick killed three himself! Three!"

Thomas Millstone: "Jakob Harrow held the line! The boy who was cursed just yesterday!"

Sister Mara, drink in hand, finds you: "Brother Freeborn of Lathander—it was an honor to fight beside you. Torm's servants recognize true warriors when we see them."

TOASTS

Someone—you're not sure who—raises a mug:

"TO THE DEFENDER!"

"TO RIV FREEBORN!"

The tavern erupts in cheers. Your name echoes off the walls.

Then Garrick raises his mug:

"TO THE FALLEN! MAY THEY REST IN LATHANDER'S LIGHT!"

The mood shifts—solemn, respectful. Mugs raised to those who didn't make it. A moment of silence.

Then Mother Nelle, tears on her cheeks, raises her cup:

"TO THORNHAVEN! TO SURVIVAL! TO DAWN!"

And the celebration resumes, louder than before.

LATER IN THE EVENING

As the night wears on and exhaustion starts to claim the revelers, your core group gathers around a table:

- You (bandaged, drink in hand, exhausted but satisfied)
- Garrick (arm in a sling, grinning)
- Dagmar (nursing her ale, surprisingly relaxed)
- Voss (cleaning his crossbow even while drinking)
- Jakob (still in awe, trying to process everything)
- Finn (excited, talking a mile a minute about his flaming arrows)
- Aldric (merchant's journal open, already planning rebuilding efforts)

Garrick looks at you seriously:

"Riv. We held. But you heard Korthak's last words. 'The Master will avenge this.' This isn't over, is it?"

Dagmar nods: "We cut off a limb. But the head of this cult is still out there."

Voss adds: "And they know about Thornhaven now. About you. They'll come back, eventually."

Jakob speaks quietly: "What do we do?"

They're all looking at you.

The celebration continues around you, but your inner circle knows the truth: tonight was a victory, but the war isn't over.

What does Riv say? What's his vision for what comes next?

You said: "Ten years ago, I made a promise."

"Ten years ago, I made a promise. I promised Lathander that I would raise an Order of Knights - true believers and devoted souls - who would scour the land of evil in his name. I've spent 10 years as a defender of the dawn, researching forgotten knowledge in libraries, traveling from town to town, healing those that I could, fighting when necessary. In all that time, I never found a place I wanted to raise my Order.

When Lathander brought me here, I thought it would be just another stop along the way. But now I see it for what it is. My holy mission has begun and each of you played a crucial part. I think each of you still has a crucial part to play, if you accept it. Tonight, we celebrate. Tomorrow, we help rebuild Thornhaven. The day after that? We search for the spot we will build our fortress and we build the Order I've dreamt of for 10 years. We will found the Order of Dawn's Light. Who's with me?"

Show more

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: A Moment of Destiny

A Moment of Destiny

Your words hang in the air. The celebration continues around you—laughter, music, relief—but at this table, silence falls.

You can see it in their faces: the realization that you're not just talking about hunting down a cult. You're talking about something permanent. Something bigger.

GARRICK is the first to speak, his voice thick with emotion:

"Ten years I've been the village smith. Good work, honest work. But when those werewolves came, when I had to lead defenders with barely any training against monsters... I realized I was meant for more than horseshoes and plowshares."

He stands, places his hand over his heart:

"I'm with you, Riv. I'll forge weapons for your Order. I'll train fighters. I'll stand on that wall again and again if that's what it takes. Count me in."

DAGMAR leans back, studying you with her sharp hunter's eyes:

"I've been a tracker for hire my whole life. No roots, no purpose beyond the next contract. Just me and Finn against the world." She looks at her apprentice. "But these past four days... fighting for something that matters... it felt right."

She nods slowly: "You'll need scouts. Trackers. Someone who can find evil before it finds innocent people. Finn and I are in."

Finn practically bounces in his seat: "Really, Master? We're joining an Order of Knights?! That's amazing!"

VOSS takes a long drink, then sets his mug down carefully:

"I've spent fifteen years hunting monsters alone. Thought that's all I was good for after the war. Just me, my crossbow, and whatever creature needed killing." His scarred face softens slightly. "But tonight, fighting alongside you all... I remembered what it felt like to be part of something. To have brothers- and sisters-in-arms."

He extends his hand: "You want someone who knows how to hunt lycanthropes, vampires, aberrations—all the things that go bump in the night? I'm your man. The Order of Dawn's Light has its monster hunter."

JAKOB looks overwhelmed, tears in his eyes:

"Yesterday I was a farmer's son. This morning I was cursed, dying, losing myself. Tonight..." He looks at his hands—human, clean, free. "Tonight I'm alive because of you. Because Lathander answered your prayer."

He drops to one knee, formal and solemn:

"Master Riv, I have nothing left. No family, no home, no future except what you've given me. I pledge myself to your Order. Train me. Make me worthy. Let me help others the way you helped me. I swear by Lathander's light—I am yours."

ALDRIC closes his merchant journal slowly:

"I'm not a fighter. Not really. I can swing a sword if I must, but that's not my strength." He taps the journal. "But I know trade routes, suppliers, contacts across three provinces. I know how to acquire rare materials, how to negotiate with nobles, how to manage coin."

He smiles: "Every Order needs someone to handle the logistics. The boring stuff that keeps warriors fed, armed, and housed. I can do that. And..." His voice drops. "You saved my soul, Riv. I owe you everything. Let me help build this."

OTHERS APPROACH

From nearby tables, others have been listening:

Captain Blackwood walks over, his professional demeanor serious:

"Defender, I'm a soldier of Millford. I have duties there. But..." He pauses. "What you're proposing—a dedicated order to hunt cults and monsters? That's not just Thornhaven's need. That's a regional need. A kingdom's need."

He offers his hand: "I can't join permanently, but I can help you establish your Order. Training, contacts with other garrisons, military supplies. And when you need reinforcements for big threats, send word to Millford. I'll come."

Sister Mara approaches, Torm's symbol gleaming:

"Brother Freeborn, our faiths serve different gods, but we serve the same cause—protecting the innocent, driving back evil, upholding duty and justice." She clasps your shoulder. "I'll return to my temple, but know this: when the Order of Dawn's Light calls, Torm's servants will answer. You have allies in us."

MOTHER NELLE, watching from nearby, smiles warmly:

"Riv, child, I'm too old to go gallivanting around fighting monsters. But Thornhaven will always be your home. This village owes you everything. When you need a safe place to rest, to heal, to plan—our doors are open. Always."

ELDER WREN steps forward:

"Defender Freeborn, you've saved us. Now you're proposing to build something that will protect not just Thornhaven, but others like us. Villages too small, too remote, too forgotten for help to reach them in time."

She looks around the tavern at the celebrating survivors:

"We'll help you build your fortress. Our craftsmen, our labor, our resources—whatever you need. And..." She smiles. "I suspect young people from Thornhaven will want to join your Order. You've inspired them."

YOUR INNER CIRCLE ASSEMBLED

You look around the table at the people who've pledged themselves to your dream:

CORE MEMBERS:

- Garrick Ironheart - Master Smith & Combat Trainer
- Dagmar & Finn - Master Scout & Apprentice
- Henrik Voss - Monster Hunter & Veteran Warrior
- Jakob Harrow - Cleric Initiate (your first true apprentice)
- Aldric Thorne - Quartermaster & Logistics

ALLIES:

- Captain Blackwood (Millford military connection)
- Sister Mara (Torm's temple alliance)
- Mother Nelle (Thornhaven spiritual support)
- Elder Wren (Thornhaven political support)

Plus the Millstone family, still recovering but already talking about how they can help.

Garrick raises his mug one more time:

"To the Order of Dawn's Light! May we bring Lathander's fire to every dark corner!"

Everyone at the table—your founding members—raises their drinks:

"TO THE ORDER OF DAWN'S LIGHT!"

The eastern sky through the tavern windows is truly lightening now. Dawn is coming.

You've won the battle. Saved the village. And found the beginning of something greater.

CAMPAIGN MILESTONE ACHIEVED

The Order of Dawn's Light is founded.

What does Riv do as the first light of dawn breaks through the windows?

You said: Riv smiles, tears in his eyes.

Riv smiles, tears in his eyes. He swallows down the last drops from his mug, shakes the hands of those surrounding him, and thanks Gerda for her hospitality. As he walks up the stairs to his room, he looks out over the gathered crowd: farmers, villagers, friends. This is the start of something truly miraculous. And he owes it all to Lathander's guidance. He opens the door to his room, shrugs out of his armor, washes up in the wash basin, and settles in for his evening prayer.

"My Lord, Lathander. Thank you for seeing us through this night. Thank you for your guidance and your strength. Thank you for the soft linens, the warm mead, the friendships and the new family I've found. I remain your humble servant. May your light shine upon me, always."

Let's wrap the session there, accounting for any loot or new levels first

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: The Perfect Ending

The Perfect Ending

Riv climbs the stairs, exhaustion finally catching up to him. The celebration continues below—laughter, songs, the clinking of mugs—but he needs this moment of quiet.

In his room, he carefully removes his battered chain mail, noting the new dents and tears from Korthak's blade. The wash basin's cool water stings the minor cuts still healing, but it feels cleansing. Purifying.

He kneels before the window, where dawn's first light is breaking over Thornhaven. Golden rays illuminate the village—scarred by battle, yes, but alive. Smoke rises from cook fires. People move about, already beginning the work of healing and rebuilding.

His prayer is simple, heartfelt, exactly who Riv is:

"My Lord, Lathander. Thank you for seeing us through this night. Thank you for your guidance and your strength. Thank you for the soft linens, the warm mead, the friendships and the new family I've found. I remain your humble servant. May your light shine upon me, always."

The sunrise seems to answer—warm, golden, full of promise.

Riv Freeborn, founder of the Order of Dawn's Light, falls asleep as dawn breaks fully over his new home.

SESSION 3 WRAP-UP

EXPERIENCE & LEVELING

SESSION 3 ACCOMPLISHMENTS:

Major Combat:

- Millstone Farm: 2 werewolves defeated
- Harrow Farm: 1 werewolf killed, protected Jakob through the night
- Henrik Voss recruited
- Battle of Thornhaven: Defeated Korthak + 15+ werewolves + 6 cultists

Story Achievements:

- Saved two families (Millstone, Harrow)
- Broke Jakob's curse completely
- Recruited Aldric's reinforcements from Millford
- Successfully defended Thornhaven with minimal losses
- Founded the Order of Dawn's Light

Leadership & Strategy:

- Identified enemy tactics (three-pronged assault)
- Coordinated multiple defensive positions
- Inspired diverse groups to work together
- Made critical tactical decisions under pressure

You've already advanced to Level 4 mid-session.

For this much additional content, you're absolutely ready for LEVEL 5!

LEVEL 5 ADVANCEMENT

New Benefits:

1. +5 HP (roll 1d8 + CON modifier OR take average of 5)

2. Proficiency Bonus increases to +3 (better at everything!)
3. 3rd-level spell slots! (2 slots)
4. New spells available:
 - Beacon of Hope, Revivify, Spirit Guardians, etc.
5. Destroy Undead (Channel Divinity improvement - CR 1/2 undead)

Do you want to roll for HP (1d8+2) or take the average (5+2=7)?

LOOT & REWARDS

From Korthak:

- Ritual-scarred greatsword (massive, sized for werewolf form, could be reforged)
- Cult medallion (symbol of high rank in Malar's cult)
- Crude map showing cult territory (intelligence about their organization)

From the Battle:

- 6 silvered weapons (3 shortswords, 2 spears, 1 warhammer - kept by your Order)
- Cultist robes and items (ritual components, dark texts)
- One living cultist prisoner (for interrogation tomorrow)

From Thornhaven:

- Your room at The Sleeping Giant (permanent, no cost)
- Unlimited access to village resources (forge, supplies, labor)
- 200 gold pieces from Elder Wren (village treasury contribution to your Order)
- Bronze Medallion of Village Defender (already have this)

From Your Allies:

- Garrick's promise to forge you a proper weapon
- Aldric's merchant connections (trade networks, suppliers)
- Captain Blackwood's military contacts
- Sister Mara's temple alliance

CURRENT STATUS - END OF SESSION 3

Riv Freeborn - Level 5 Human Cleric (Light Domain)

Stats:

- HP: 39/39 (will increase with level 5)
- AC: 16 (chain mail)
- Spell Save DC: 15
- Spell Attack: +7 (becomes +8 at level 5)

Ability Scores:

- STR 14, DEX 10, CON 15, INT 13, WIS 20, CHA 13

Gold: 69.5 GP personal + 200 GP from Thornhaven = 269.5 GP

Key Items:

- Chain mail (damaged, needs repair)
- Mace
- Holy symbol of Lathander
- Bronze Medallion (Village Defender)
- Regional map
- Healer's kit
- Merchant journal (Aldric's)
- Cult intelligence (maps, tokens destroyed)

THE ORDER OF DAWN'S LIGHT - FOUNDING MEMBERS

Leadership:

- Riv Freeborn - Founder, Commander, Master Cleric

Core Members:

1. Garrick Ironheart - Master Smith & Arms Trainer
2. Dagmar - Master Scout & Reconnaissance

3. Finn - Scout Apprentice
4. Henrik Voss - Monster Hunter & Veteran Warrior
5. Jakob Harrow - Cleric Initiate (your first apprentice)
6. Aldric Thorne - Quartermaster & Logistics Master

Allied Support:

- Thornhaven (home base, resources, recruits)
 - Millford Garrison (Captain Blackwood)
 - Temple of Torm (Sister Mara)
-

NEXT STEPS (For Future Sessions)

1. Interrogate the cultist prisoner (learn about "The Master")
 2. Choose location for your fortress (within a day's travel of Thornhaven)
 3. Begin construction (using Thornhaven's resources and labor)
 4. Train Jakob as your first true cleric apprentice
 5. Hunt down the remaining cult (they'll retaliate eventually)
 6. Establish the Order's reputation (word will spread)
-

FINAL QUESTION

For Level 5 HP increase: Do you want to roll 1d8+2, or take the guaranteed 7?

Once we decide that, we'll have your complete updated character sheet for future sessions!

This was an AMAZING session. You founded an Order, saved a village, defeated a twenty-year veteran Alpha werewolf, and assembled a fellowship of incredible characters. Well done, Defender!

You said: I rolled a 4 for HP

I rolled a 4 for HP

Talk me through the new spells I can choose from for Level 5

I also want to talk about multiclassing. The way I see it, Riv has spent a good deal of time with Garrick, Voss, and Dagmar. I figure there's a good chance he's picked up something of their classes

along the way, particularly from Dagmar (we've already mentioned how they tend to scout together). I'm thinking about multiclassing into Ranger - talk to me about that decision

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: HP Increase: $4 + 2 = 6$ HP gained

HP Increase: $4 + 2 = 6$ HP gained

New Max HP: 45 (was 39)

Great roll! You're getting tougher.

LEVEL 5 CLERIC SPELLS

At Level 5, you gain access to 3rd-level spells and get 2x 3rd-level spell slots.

Your total prepared spells increases to 10 (5 WIS modifier + 5 Cleric level).

You currently have 9 spells prepared, so you can add 1 more, plus you get access to higher-level options.

YOUR DOMAIN SPELLS (Always Prepared - Don't Count Against Limit)

New at 3rd Level:

- Daylight - 60-foot radius bright light, dispels magical darkness, lasts 1 hour
- Fireball - 20-foot radius, 8d6 fire damage (DEX save for half) - This is huge!

These are automatically added to your prepared spells.

BEST 3RD-LEVEL CLERIC SPELLS

Here are the top options for your character:

MUST-CONSIDER:

Revivify (200 GP diamond consumed)

- Bring a dead creature back to life (if dead less than 1 minute)
- Touch range, 1 action
- This is THE resurrection spell for combat
- You'll want this eventually, especially as leader of an Order

Spirit Guardians (Concentration)

- 15-foot radius around you
- 3d8 radiant damage to enemies who start turn in area
- Difficult terrain for enemies
- Lasts 10 minutes
- AMAZING for Clerics who fight in melee

Beacon of Hope (Concentration)

- Give allies advantage on WIS saves and death saves
- Healing spells restore maximum HP on them
- Incredible support spell

STRONG OPTIONS:

Mass Healing Word (Bonus Action)

- Heal up to 6 creatures for 1d4+5 each
- 60-foot range
- Great emergency healing for your Order

Protection from Energy

- Resistance to one damage type for 1 hour
- Good prep spell before known threats

Remove Curse

- You needed this for Jakob! Now you can break curses yourself
- No more relying on scrolls

Speak with Dead

- Ask corpse 5 questions
- Great for investigations (like interrogating dead cultists)

Dispel Magic

- End spells, very versatile utility
-

MY RECOMMENDATION FOR YOUR BUILD:

Given you're leading an Order and will be in the thick of combat:

Add to prepared spells:

- Spirit Guardians - Your new signature combat spell
- Remove Curse - You'll need this

Eventually get:

- Revivify (when you can afford the diamond)
-

MULTICLASSING INTO RANGER

This is a very cool idea narratively! Let's break down the mechanics and implications.

MULTICLASSING REQUIREMENTS

To multiclass into Ranger, you need:

- DEX 13 - You have DEX 10 ❌ (You don't meet the requirement)
- WIS 13 - You have WIS 20 ✅

Unfortunately, you don't currently meet the DEX requirement for Ranger multiclassing.

BUT THERE ARE ALTERNATIVES:

Option 1: Take a Different Multiclass That Fits

FIGHTER (STR 13 or DEX 13 required)

- You have STR 14 ✅
- Represents training with Garrick and Voss
- Gives you: Fighting Style, Second Wind, Action Surge later
- Mechanically strong for a melee cleric

Benefits:

- Fighting Style - Defense (+1 AC) or Dueling (+2 damage with one-handed weapons)
- Second Wind - Bonus action heal yourself 1d10+1

- More martial prowess without sacrificing spell progression too much

Option 2: Stay Pure Cleric, Flavor It as Cross-Training

You don't need to multiclass mechanically to represent learning from your companions. You can:

- Describe your combat style as influenced by them
- Take feats later that reflect martial training (like War Caster or Martial Adept)
- Your high WIS and proficiency in Medicine/Survival already makes you scout-capable

Pure Cleric benefits:

- Level 6: 4th-level spells (like Guardian of Faith, Death Ward)
- Level 7: More Domain features
- Level 8: Another ASI/Feat + Destroy Undead improves
- Higher-level spells come faster

Option 3: Plan for Future ASI to Enable Multiclass

At Level 8, you get another ASI. You could:

- +2 DEX (10→12) - Still doesn't meet requirement
- +1 DEX, +1 CON (10→11, 15→16) - Still doesn't work

To get DEX 13, you'd need to invest heavily, which would sacrifice your primary stats.

MY RECOMMENDATION:

Stay Pure Cleric (at least for now), but flavor your abilities narratively:

Here's how:

1. Your spell choices reflect your training:
 - Taking guidance from Dagmar on tracking → Prepare spells like Locate Object, Find Traps
 - Training with Garrick → Emphasize melee combat spells like Spirit Guardians, Spiritual Weapon
 - Learning from Voss → Knowledge of monster tactics reflected in your strategic choices
2. At Level 8, consider the Martial Adept feat:

- Gives you Battle Master maneuvers
 - Represents tactical training from Voss and Garrick
 - You learn Commander's Strike, Rally, etc.
3. Your fighting style is already developing:
- You fight in melee with your mace
 - You coordinate with allies
 - You're tactical and strategic
 - This is already Ranger-like behavior!
4. Future possibility:
- If you really want Ranger eventually, at Level 12 you could use ASI to boost DEX
 - But honestly, pure Cleric is very strong and fits your role as Order leader
-

THE NARRATIVE SOLUTION:

You don't need Ranger levels to be influenced by Dagmar.

Think of it this way:

- Dagmar teaches you tracking → You're proficient in Survival (already part of your skills)
- Voss teaches you monster lore → You're proficient in Religion (know about curses, undead, fiends)
- Garrick teaches you combat → You fight with mace and wear heavy armor
- You teach them divine magic → Jakob is becoming a Cleric

You're all learning from each other, but that doesn't mean you need their class levels—you're becoming a more well-rounded Cleric.

FINAL RECOMMENDATION:

Stay Cleric 5 → Cleric 6+

Prepare these spells for Level 5:

1. Bless
2. Command

3. Cure Wounds
4. Guiding Bolt
5. Healing Word
6. Shield of Faith
7. Hold Person
8. Lesser Restoration
9. Spiritual Weapon
10. Spirit Guardians (NEW - your signature 3rd-level combat spell)

Domain Spells (free):

- Burning Hands, Faerie Fire, Flaming Sphere, Scorching Ray
- Daylight, Fireball (NEW at level 5)

What do you think? Stay pure Cleric, or do you want to explore Fighter multiclass instead?

You said: I'll take Remove Curse, since I can reasonably build it into the canon that the ritual Mother Nelle and I used to break the curse on Jakob sank into my mind af...

I'll take Remove Curse, since I can reasonably build it into the canon that the ritual Mother Nelle and I used to break the curse on Jakob sank into my mind afterwards and embedded itself as this spell. I get one spell or two? If I get two, I'll also take Spirit Guardians, which sounds awesome.

Ok, I'll stay pure Cleric.

Let's also talk about Jakob. I imagine after today's session we can give him one level of Cleric, right? Or maybe we give him one level of Fighter and multiclass him into Cleric when we get there narratively? After all, he fought in the battle with a sword and shield. Surely that means he must have worked towards Fighter?

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect narrative reasoning for Remove Curse!

Perfect narrative reasoning for Remove Curse! That ritual with Mother Nelle was powerful and personal—absolutely makes sense it would crystallize into a spell you now understand.

YOUR PREPARED SPELLS

At Level 5, you prepare 10 spells (5 WIS + 5 Cleric level).

You currently have 9 prepared, so you can add 2 new spells:

✓ Remove Curse (from the Jakob ritual) ✓ Spirit Guardians (your new signature combat spell)

Your complete prepared spell list is now:

1st Level (6):

1. Bless
2. Command
3. Cure Wounds
4. Guiding Bolt
5. Healing Word
6. Shield of Faith

2nd Level (3): 7. Hold Person 8. Lesser Restoration 9. Spiritual Weapon

3rd Level (2): 10. Remove Curse ★ 11. Spirit Guardians ★

Plus Domain Spells (always prepared, don't count against limit):

- 1st: Burning Hands, Faerie Fire
- 2nd: Flaming Sphere, Scorching Ray
- 3rd: Daylight, Fireball (NEW!)

Spirit Guardians is INCREDIBLE for you. As a melee-fighting cleric who leads from the front, having a 15-foot radius of holy damage around you at all times is perfect. Enemies take 3d8 radiant damage just for being near you, and it's difficult terrain for them. Combined with Spiritual Weapon, you become a battlefield control monster.

JAKOB'S ADVANCEMENT

Great question! Let's think about Jakob narratively and mechanically.

JAKOB'S JOURNEY SO FAR:

Day 1: Farmer's son, no combat training Day 2: Family murdered, bitten by werewolves, fought the curse for 24 hours Day 3: Curse broken, given basic gear, thrown into the Battle of Thornhaven
Result: Survived his first battle, held the line with a shield and sword

THE MULTICLASS QUESTION:

You're absolutely right that Jakob fought as a warrior in this battle. He used sword and shield, not divine magic. So does that make him a Fighter first?

Here's how I see it:

Option A: Fighter 1 → Eventually Cleric

Narrative: Jakob learns to fight first (survival, practical), then you train him in divine magic

Mechanics:

- Start as Fighter 1
- Gets Fighting Style, Second Wind
- Better HP (d10 vs d8)
- Proficient with all armor and weapons
- Then multiclass into Cleric when training begins

Pros: Represents his combat baptism, makes him tougher Cons: Delays his divine spellcasting

Option B: Cleric 1 (Light Domain like you)

Narrative: The ritual that saved him awakened something divine in him; Lathander touched him directly Mechanics:

- Already connected to Lathander through your curse-breaking
- Can cast spells immediately
- Gets Warding Flare (like you)
- Still proficient with shields and simple weapons (including his sword as a club/mace)

Pros: He can start learning divine magic right away, mirrors your path Cons: Slightly less martial initially

Option C: Fighter 1 / Future War Cleric or Tempest Cleric

Narrative: He's a warrior-priest, not a pure healer like you Mechanics:

- Fighter 1 for foundation
 - Eventually takes Cleric levels in a more martial domain
 - Becomes the "tank" to your "support/damage" role
-

MY RECOMMENDATION: Start Him as Cleric 1

Here's why:

1. The curse-breaking was transformative - Lathander's direct intervention touched Jakob's soul. That's not just healing, that's a divine calling.
 2. He pledged himself to you as "Master" - He wants to learn what you do, not just how to swing a sword.
 3. He can still fight in melee - Clerics get shields, medium armor, simple weapons. He's not suddenly a frail wizard.
 4. It creates beautiful symmetry - You were saved by Lathander, now you're training someone else who was saved by Lathander through you.
 5. Your Order needs clerics - Garrick, Dagmar, and Voss are already warriors/scouts. Jakob fills the "second divine caster" role.
-

JAKOB HARROW - LEVEL 1 CLERIC (LIGHT DOMAIN)

Narrative Justification: When you broke his curse, Lathander's power didn't just cleanse him—it awakened something inside him. During the battle, when Jakob raised that shield and stood his ground, he whispered prayers he didn't know he knew. The divine spark was already there.

Now you'll train him to channel it properly.

Starting Stats (I'll keep them reasonable):

- Class: Cleric 1 (Light Domain)
- HP: 10 (8 + 2 CON)
- AC: 16 (chain mail borrowed from Thornhaven's supplies, shield)
- Spells Known: 2 cantrips (Light from domain + Sacred Flame), prepares 3 spells

Equipment:

- Chain mail (or scale mail)
 - Shield (one of Garrick's)
 - Mace or longsword
 - Holy symbol of Lathander (you'll give him one)
-

His Role in the Order:

- Your first apprentice
 - Learning divine magic and combat from you
 - Will eventually become a full cleric capable of leading missions
 - The "proof of concept" that the Order can train new members
-

JAKOB'S FUTURE PATH:

Short term (Levels 1-3): Pure Cleric, learning from you Medium term (Level 4+): Possibly multiclass into Fighter if he wants to be more martial Long term: Either stays pure Cleric (like you) or becomes a Cleric/Fighter hybrid (War Priest type)

Does this work for you? Jakob starts as Cleric 1, representing the divine spark Lathander ignited in him when you broke the curse?

We can always have him take Fighter levels later if his story goes that direction, but starting him as Cleric makes the most narrative and mechanical sense for your Order's first apprentice.

You said: Ok, I like him as a Level 1 Cleric, moving towards multi-classing in the longer term.

Ok, I like him as a Level 1 Cleric, moving towards multi-classing in the longer term.

What can we do about my companions? Can I choose their leveling paths without playing them directly? I like them being NPCs (played by you), but I still want to pick their leveling paths from here out now that we're all part of the same order

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Absolutely!

Absolutely! This is a great approach.

Since your companions are key NPCs in your Order, but you're not directly controlling them in combat, we can handle their advancement collaboratively:

HOW WE'LL HANDLE NPC COMPANION LEVELING

I'll suggest leveling paths based on:

- Their established character/personality
- Their role in the Order
- Mechanical effectiveness
- Story arcs

You approve or adjust based on:

- Your vision for the Order
- How you want the team composition to work
- Cool character moments you want to see

Then I'll run them in combat/scenes using those builds.

THE ORDER OF DAWN'S LIGHT - LEVELING PATHS

Let me propose advancement tracks for each core member:

1. GARRICK IRONHEART

Current Status: Experienced fighter, master smith, wore armor and used silvered blade effectively

Proposed Build: Fighter (Battle Master)

Level Progression:

- Current: Fighter 3 (Battle Master)
- Next: Fighter 4 (ASI - +2 STR or feat)
- Long-term: Pure Fighter to 5-6, maybe dip into Artificer for smithing magic

Role in Order:

- Master-at-Arms (trains recruits)
- Heavy melee fighter
- Tactical maneuvers (Commander's Strike, Rally, Tactical Assessment)
- Master Smith (crafts weapons and armor)

Key Features:

- Action Surge (extra action in combat)

- Second Wind (self-heal)
- Maneuvers (tactical combat options)

Sound good for Garrick?

2. DAGMAR

Current Status: Expert tracker, master hunter, deadly with bow, teaches Finn

Proposed Build: Ranger (Hunter or Gloom Stalker)

Level Progression:

- Current: Ranger 4 (Hunter conclave - Colossus Slayer for extra damage)
- Next: Ranger 5 (Extra Attack - crucial!)
- Long-term: Pure Ranger to 8-10, focuses on being the Order's reconnaissance leader

Role in Order:

- Master Scout
- Reconnaissance & Intelligence
- Ambush specialist
- Trains scouts/rangers

Key Features:

- Favored Enemy: Monstrosities (werewolves, etc.)
- Natural Explorer (advantage in wilderness)
- Hunter's Mark (extra damage)
- Colossus Slayer (extra 1d8 per turn to wounded enemies)

Alternative: Gloom Stalker (better at ambushes, darkness fighting)

Which Ranger subclass for Dagmar?

3. FINN

Current Status: Young apprentice, learning from Dagmar, proved himself with the flaming arrows

Proposed Build: Ranger (following Dagmar's path)

Level Progression:

- Current: Ranger 2 (still learning, not specialized yet)
- Next: Ranger 3 (chooses Hunter conclave, same as Dagmar)
- Long-term: Ranger with possible Rogue multiclass later (Scout archetype)

Role in Order:

- Scout Apprentice
- Will eventually become a full scout
- Younger generation of the Order

He's mechanically weaker but growing. Does this fit?

4. HENRIK VOSS

Current Status: 15-year veteran monster hunter, knows lycanthrope weaknesses, tactical mind

Proposed Build: Ranger (Monster Slayer) with possible Fighter levels

Level Progression:

- Current: Ranger 5 (Monster Slayer) - specialized in hunting specific creature types
- Next: Ranger 6 or Fighter 1 (represents his military background)
- Long-term: Ranger 6-8 / Fighter 2-3 split (balanced monster hunter/veteran soldier)

Role in Order:

- Monster Hunter Specialist
- Tactical Advisor
- Trains members in fighting specific threats
- The "expert" on supernatural creatures

Key Features:

- Hunter's Sense (identify creature resistances/immunities)
- Slayer's Prey (extra damage against chosen target)
- Supernatural Defense (advantage against monster abilities)

- His military experience suggests some Fighter levels

Sound appropriate for Voss?

5. JAKOB HARROW

We've decided: Cleric 1 (Light Domain), will multiclass Fighter later

Proposed Path:

- Current: Cleric 1 (Light Domain)
- Next: Cleric 2-3 (Channel Divinity, more spells)
- Later: Fighter 1-2 (if his story goes martial)
- Long-term: Cleric 5-6 / Fighter 2-3 (War Priest build)

Role in Order:

- Your First Apprentice
 - Secondary Divine Caster
 - Proof the Order can train new members
 - Eventually: Full cleric or cleric/fighter hybrid
-

6. ALDRIC THORNE

Current Status: Merchant, not a fighter, logistics genius, saved from curse

Proposed Build: Rogue (Mastermind) or Bard (Lore)

Level Progression:

- Current: Rogue 3 (Mastermind) - represents his merchant cunning and social skills
- Alternate: Bard 3 (Lore) - "knows a little about everything," inspiring presence
- Long-term: Stays support/skill-focused, never becomes primary combatant

Role in Order:

- Quartermaster
- Logistics & Supply Chain
- Diplomatic Contact

- Information Gathering
- Not a frontline fighter

Key Features (if Rogue):

- Expertise in Persuasion, Insight, Investigation
- Help action as bonus action (battlefield support)
- Master of tactics and intrigue

Key Features (if Bard):

- Bardic Inspiration (buffs allies)
- Jack of All Trades
- Expertise in social skills

Which fits better? Mastermind Rogue or Lore Bard?

SUMMARY - PROPOSED ORDER COMPOSITION

Frontline Fighters:

- Garrick (Fighter - Battle Master) - Heavy melee, tactical leader
- Jakob (Cleric/Fighter) - Divine warrior, your apprentice

Divine Casters:

- You (Cleric 5 - Light Domain) - Leader, primary healer/blaster
- Jakob (Cleric 1+) - Apprentice, secondary support

Scouts/Rangers:

- Dagmar (Ranger 4 - Hunter/Gloom Stalker) - Master Scout
- Finn (Ranger 2) - Scout Apprentice
- Voss (Ranger 5 / Fighter X - Monster Slayer) - Specialist Hunter

Support/Logistics:

- Aldric (Rogue 3 or Bard 3) - Quartermaster, non-combatant support
-

YOUR INPUT NEEDED:

1. Dagmar: Hunter or Gloom Stalker ranger?
2. Voss: Pure Ranger or Ranger/Fighter multiclass?
3. Aldric: Mastermind Rogue or Lore Bard?
4. Any changes to these paths?

Once you approve, I'll track their progression and run them as effective NPCs in future sessions!

You said: Garrick: I love the idea of multi-classing him into Artificer to enhance his smithing.

Garrick: I love the idea of multi-classing him into Artificer to enhance his smithing. That makes sense.

Dagmar: I'm researching subclasses for a Ranger and I like Hunter for Dagmar. Thematically, I think it makes the most sense.

Finn: Now, Finn would make for a more interesting subclass. I'd like to build him as a Gloom Stalker or Monster Slayer.

Voss: Monster Slayer sounds right. He was a Fighter in the Army, though, right? Maybe that would make sense too.

Jakob: Light Domain Cleric / Champion Fighter? Or maybe Oath of Devotion Paladin?

Aldric: Love the combo of Rogue and Bard. If I had to choose, I would take Rogue, but we can just leave Aldric as a Merchant NPC. I think that's the more likely use of his character.

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect!

Perfect! Let's finalize these builds:

FINALIZED ORDER MEMBER BUILDS

1. GARRICK IRONHEART

Build: Fighter (Battle Master) → Artificer (Armorer or Battle Smith)

Progression:

- Fighter 3 (Battle Master) - Current
- Fighter 4 (ASI) - Next level
- Fighter 5 (Extra Attack) - Critical milestone

- Then: Artificer 1-3 (magical smithing begins)

Narrative: As he crafts more weapons for the Order, he begins infusing them with minor enchantments. His forge becomes a place where mundane meets magical.

Role: Master-at-Arms, Master Smith, Heavy Fighter, eventually crafts +1 weapons and magical items

✓ Approved

2. DAGMAR

Build: Ranger 4 (Hunter)

Current Features:

- Hunter's Mark
- Colossus Slayer (extra 1d8 to wounded enemies)
- Favored Enemy: Monstrosities
- Expert tracker and ambusher

Next: Ranger 5 (Extra Attack - huge power spike)

Role: Master Scout, Reconnaissance Leader, Finn's Mentor

✓ Approved - Hunter subclass

3. FINN

Build: Ranger (Gloom Stalker or Monster Slayer)

Current: Ranger 2 (hasn't chosen subclass yet)

Next: Ranger 3 - Subclass choice!

Option A: Gloom Stalker

- Specializes in darkness/ambush fighting
- +1 attack on first turn, extra damage
- Invisible to darkvision in darkness
- Theme: The shadow to Dagmar's light, learns to be the unseen blade

Option B: Monster Slayer

- Learns to identify and exploit monster weaknesses
- Follows Voss's teachings more than Dagmar's
- Theme: The next generation monster hunter

My recommendation: Gloom Stalker - Creates nice contrast with Dagmar (both rangers, different specialties), and the young scout who learned to use darkness as a weapon during the werewolf crisis is a great arc.

Your call: Gloom Stalker or Monster Slayer for Finn?

4. HENRIK VOSS

Build: Fighter (military background) / Ranger (Monster Slayer)

Proposed Split: Fighter 3 / Ranger 5 (current effective level 8)

Fighter side:

- Battle Master or Champion
- Represents 15 years of military service before he started hunting monsters
- Action Surge, Second Wind, Fighting Style

Ranger side:

- Monster Slayer subclass
- Hunter's Sense, Slayer's Prey
- Specialized in creature weaknesses

Narrative: "I was a soldier first, learned to hunt monsters later"

Role: Monster Hunter Specialist, Tactical Advisor, Military Veteran

 Approved - Fighter/Ranger multiclass

5. JAKOB HARROW

Build: Light Domain Cleric / ???

You suggested three paths:

Option A: Cleric / Champion Fighter

- Simple, effective

- Extra fighting style and crit range
- Becomes durable frontline cleric

Option B: Cleric / Any Fighter

- Battle Master would give him tactics
- Protection fighting style to defend allies

Option C: Pure Paladin (Oath of Devotion)

- Wait, this is interesting!
- He pledged himself to you and to Lathander
- Paladins are literally powered by sacred oaths
- Gets divine smite, lay on hands, heavy armor
- Very thematic for someone reborn through divine intervention

Here's the thing with Option C: If Jakob becomes a Paladin instead of Cleric, it changes his arc significantly:

Cleric Path: "I want to be like Riv, learn to channel Lathander's magic like he does"

Paladin Path: "I swore an oath to Lathander and to Riv. I am a holy warrior bound by sacred vow"

Both work, but they're different characters.

My recommendation:

- Short term: Keep him Cleric 1-3 (he's learning from you)
- Medium term: He could realize his calling is as an oath-bound warrior rather than a learned priest
- Around Level 4-5: He takes Paladin levels (Oath of Devotion), representing his vow to the Order

This makes him: Cleric 3 / Paladin X (War Priest build)

- Has cleric spells and Channel Divinity from his training with you
- Has Paladin smites and oath features from his personal conviction
- Unique hybrid that no one else in the Order has

What do you think? Cleric/Fighter or Cleric/Paladin for Jakob?

6. ALDRIC THORNE

Status: Merchant NPC (not a leveled combatant)

Role: Quartermaster, handles logistics, supplies, contacts, trade

He'll have some skill proficiencies (Persuasion, Insight, etc.) but won't have a combat class progression. He's support staff, not a field agent.

✓ Approved - stays NPC merchant

DECISIONS NEEDED:

1. Finn: Gloom Stalker or Monster Slayer?
2. Jakob: Cleric/Fighter or Cleric/Paladin (or pure Paladin)?

Once you decide these, we'll have the complete Order roster locked in!

You said: For Finn, I like Gloom Stalker

For Finn, I like Gloom Stalker

For Jakob, I like the idea of him starting as a Cleric and becoming the Divine Protector of my order as a Paladin. Maybe something happens later on that drives him down that path?

Now that we've finished this session and decided on the character sheets for our Order, can you build an artifact that shows all the character sheets so we can keep track of it? I'll put it into a document and upload it to the project so the next session will be aware of it

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: Perfect choices!

Perfect choices!

Finn: Gloom Stalker - The shadow scout of the Order Jakob: Cleric → Paladin transition - His oath will come from a future defining moment

Great narrative hooks there. Maybe Jakob witnesses something that crystallizes his calling, or takes a formal oath in front of the Order at a crucial moment.

THE ORDER OF DAWN'S LIGHT - CHARACTER ROSTER

Founded: After the Battle of Thornhaven

Base of Operations: Thornhaven (temporary), future fortress TBD

Mission: Hunt evil wherever darkness breeds - werewolves, cultists, monsters that prey on the innocent

FOUNDER & COMMANDER

RIV FREEBORN

Race: Human

Class: Cleric 5 (Light Domain)

Role: Founder, Commander, Master Cleric

Ability Scores:

- STR 14 (+2) | DEX 10 (+0) | CON 15 (+2)
- INT 13 (+1) | WIS 20 (+5) | CHA 13 (+1)

Combat Stats:

- HP: 45/45
- AC: 16 (chain mail)
- Proficiency Bonus: +3
- Spell Save DC: 15
- Spell Attack Bonus: +8

Proficiencies:

- Saves: Wisdom +8, Charisma +4
- Skills: History +4, Insight +8, Medicine +8, Persuasion +4, Religion +4
- Armor: Light, Medium, Shields
- Weapons: Simple weapons
- Languages: Common, Celestial, Elvish

Class Features:

- Warding Flare: 5/long rest, reaction to impose disadvantage on attack within 30 ft
- Channel Divinity (1/short rest):
 - Turn Undead (WIS save DC 15 or turned 1 min)

- Radiance of the Dawn (30-ft radius, 2d10+5 radiant damage, CON save for half, dispels magical darkness)
- Destroy Undead: CR 1/2 or lower undead automatically destroyed by Turn Undead

Spells:

- Cantrips (4): Light, Sacred Flame, Spare the Dying, Guidance
- Spell Slots: 4/4/3/2 (1st/2nd/3rd)

Prepared Spells (10):

- 1st: Bless, Command, Cure Wounds, Guiding Bolt, Healing Word, Shield of Faith
- 2nd: Hold Person, Lesser Restoration, Spiritual Weapon
- 3rd: Remove Curse, Spirit Guardians

Domain Spells (always prepared):

- 1st: Burning Hands, Faerie Fire
- 2nd: Flaming Sphere, Scorching Ray
- 3rd: Daylight, Fireball

Equipment:

- Chain mail (needs repair)
- Mace
- Holy symbol of Lathander
- Bronze Medallion (Village Defender of Thornhaven)
- Healer's kit
- Regional map
- Aldric's merchant journal
- Standard adventuring gear

Gold: 269.5 GP (personal) + access to Thornhaven resources

Background: Acolyte/Sage

- Feature: Shelter of the Faithful

Personality:

- Devoted to Lathander, values comfort and learning
 - Pragmatic yet compassionate
 - Natural leader who inspires through action
 - Promised Lathander he'd build an Order 10 years ago - now fulfilling that vow
-

CORE MEMBERS

GARRICK IRONHEART

Race: Human

Class: Fighter 3 (Battle Master) → Artificer multiclass planned

Role: Master-at-Arms, Master Smith, Heavy Fighter

Ability Scores (estimated):

- STR 18 | DEX 12 | CON 16 | INT 13 | WIS 12 | CHA 10

Combat Stats:

- HP: ~35
- AC: 18 (chain mail + shield)
- Primary Weapon: Silvered longsword (or greatsword)

Key Features:

- Fighting Style: Defense (+1 AC, already included)
- Second Wind: 1/short rest, bonus action heal 1d10+3
- Action Surge: 1/short rest, take additional action
- Battle Master Maneuvers: 4 superiority dice (d8)
 - Commander's Strike, Rally, Riposte, Precision Attack

Progression Plan:

- Fighter 4 (ASI) → Fighter 5 (Extra Attack) → Artificer 1-3 (magical smithing)

Personality:

- Loyal, brave, protective of Thornhaven

- Takes pride in his craft
 - Natural teacher and mentor
 - "Brother" relationship with Riv
-

DAGMAR

Race: Human

Class: Ranger 4 (Hunter)

Role: Master Scout, Reconnaissance Leader

Ability Scores (estimated):

- STR 12 | DEX 18 | CON 14 | INT 12 | WIS 16 | CHA 10

Combat Stats:

- HP: ~32
- AC: 15 (studded leather)
- Primary Weapon: Longbow
- Arrows: 12 total (2 silvered remaining)

Key Features:

- Favored Enemy: Monstrosities (advantage on tracking, additional language)
- Natural Explorer: Expertise in wilderness navigation and tracking
- Fighting Style: Archery (+2 to ranged attacks)
- Hunter's Mark: Bonus action, 1d6 extra damage, advantage on tracking
- Colossus Slayer: Once per turn, extra 1d8 damage to wounded enemy

Spells Known (2):

- Hunter's Mark, Cure Wounds

Spell Slots: 3 (1st level)

Next Level: Ranger 5 (Extra Attack - huge power spike)

Personality:

- Pragmatic, efficient, rarely shows emotion

- Fiercely protective of Finn
 - Respects Riv's tactical mind
 - Dry sense of humor
-

FINN

Race: Human

Class: Ranger 2 → Gloom Stalker at level 3

Role: Scout Apprentice, Dagmar's student

Ability Scores (estimated):

- STR 10 | DEX 16 | CON 12 | INT 11 | WIS 14 | CHA 10

Combat Stats:

- HP: ~18
- AC: 14 (leather armor)
- Primary Weapon: Shortbow

Key Features:

- Fighting Style: Archery (+2 to ranged attacks)
- Learning from Dagmar
- Proved himself with flaming arrows at west wall

Next Level: Ranger 3 (Gloom Stalker subclass)

- Dread Ambusher (extra attack + damage first turn)
- Umbral Sight (invisible to darkvision in darkness)

Personality:

- Young, eager, nervous but brave
 - Hero-worships Dagmar and Riv
 - Growing into confidence
 - "The kid" of the group
-

HENRIK VOSS

Race: Human

Class: Fighter 3 (Battle Master or Champion) / Ranger 5 (Monster Slayer)

Role: Monster Hunter Specialist, Tactical Advisor, Veteran

Ability Scores (estimated):

- STR 14 | DEX 16 | CON 16 | INT 14 | WIS 15 | CHA 8

Combat Stats:

- HP: ~50 (tough veteran)
- AC: 16 (studded leather + DEX)
- Primary Weapon: Crossbow (4 silvered bolts remaining)
- Secondary: Longsword

Key Features (Fighter):

- Fighting Style: Archery or Defense
- Second Wind
- Action Surge

Key Features (Ranger):

- Hunter's Sense: Bonus action, learn creature's resistances/immunities/vulnerabilities
- Slayer's Prey: Bonus action, deal extra 1d6 damage per attack against chosen target
- Supernatural Defense: Advantage on saves against target's abilities
- Extra Attack

Favored Enemy: Undead and Monstrosities

Spells: Utility-focused (Detect Magic, Protection from Evil and Good)

Personality:

- Gruff, experienced, seen it all
 - 15 years of monster hunting, former soldier
 - Rarely smiles, but deeply loyal once trust is earned
 - Mentor figure, especially for tactical thinking
-

JAKOB HARROW

Race: Human

Class: Cleric 1 (Light Domain) → Future Paladin multiclass

Role: First Apprentice, Riv's student, Future Divine Protector

Ability Scores (estimated):

- STR 14 | DEX 10 | CON 14 | INT 10 | WIS 16 | CHA 12

Combat Stats:

- HP: 10
- AC: 16 (chain mail + shield borrowed from Garrick)
- Primary Weapon: Mace or longsword

Class Features:

- Warding Flare: 3/long rest (WIS modifier)
- Domain Spells: Burning Hands, Faerie Fire

Spells:

- Cantrips: Light (domain), Sacred Flame
- Prepared Spells (3): Bless, Cure Wounds, Shield of Faith
- Spell Slots: 2 (1st level)

Background:

- Lost entire family to werewolves
- Was cursed, fought transformation for 24 hours
- Saved by Riv's curse-breaking ritual
- Survived Battle of Thornhaven
- Pledged himself to Lathander and to Riv

Future Path:

- Cleric 2-3 (learn divine magic, Channel Divinity)
- Major moment triggers oath → Paladin multiclass
- Becomes Cleric 3 / Paladin X (Oath of Devotion)

- Role: Divine Protector, frontline defender, embodiment of the Order's oaths

Personality:

- Earnest, devoted, grateful
 - Determined to prove himself worthy
 - Sees Riv as savior and master
 - Carries grief but channels it into purpose
 - Still learning, still growing
-

ALDRIC THORNE

Race: Human

Status: NPC Merchant (not leveled combatant)

Role: Quartermaster, Logistics Master, Supply Coordinator

Skills:

- Persuasion, Insight, Investigation
- Knowledge of trade routes, suppliers, contacts
- Merchant connections across region

Background:

- Was cursed by werewolf bite, saved by Riv with Remove Curse scroll
- Rode to Millford, recruited Captain Blackwood and reinforcements
- Spent his fortune on silvered weapons and supplies
- Now dedicated to supporting the Order

Role in Order:

- Handles acquisition of supplies, weapons, materials
- Manages finances and budget
- Negotiates contracts and agreements
- Not a field agent - stays at base managing logistics

Personality:

- Grateful, transformed by experience
 - Practical merchant mind applied to holy cause
 - Wants to be more than he was
 - Loyal to Riv absolutely
-

ALLIED SUPPORT

Captain Theron Blackwood

- Affiliation: Millford Garrison (retired captain, still influential)
- Contribution: Military training, reinforcements when needed, garrison contacts
- Status: Ally, not member

Sister Mara Ironvow

- Affiliation: Temple of Torm
- Class: Cleric 5+ (War Domain or similar)
- Contribution: Healing support, inter-temple alliance
- Status: Ally, can be called upon for major threats

Mother Nelle

- Affiliation: Shrine of Chauntea, Thornhaven
- Role: Spiritual advisor, healing, village priestess
- Contribution: Ritual magic, healing supplies, spiritual guidance
- Status: Mentor figure, permanent ally

Elder Wren

- Affiliation: Thornhaven leadership
- Contribution: Political support, village resources, recruits
- Status: Patron

The Millstone Family

- Thomas, Clara, Javik, Sarah, Helena, young children
- Saved by the Order
- Contributing to village defense and rebuilding

- Javik wears Riv's blessed shield
 - Potential future recruits from this family
-

ORDER RESOURCES

Current Assets:

- 269.5 GP (Riv's personal funds)
- 200 GP (Thornhaven contribution)
- Access to Thornhaven's forge, supplies, labor
- 6 silvered weapons (3 shortswords, 2 spears, 1 warhammer)
- Military supply wagon from Millford
- Aldric's trade network and contacts

Base of Operations:

- Temporary: Thornhaven (The Sleeping Giant tavern, free lodging)
- Future: Fortress to be built within a day's travel of Thornhaven

Available Labor:

- Thornhaven villagers willing to help build
 - Garrick's smithing expertise
 - Aldric's supply connections
-

CURRENT THREATS

Immediate:

- 1 cultist prisoner (awaiting interrogation)
- Korthak's body and cult intelligence to analyze

Ongoing:

- "The Master" - Cult leader, identity unknown, promised revenge
- Remaining Malar cult members (unknown number)
- Regional werewolf threat not fully eliminated

Future Hooks:

- Build fortress
 - Hunt remaining cult
 - Establish Order's reputation
 - Train new recruits
 - Respond to calls for aid from other villages
-

ORDER PRINCIPLES

Mission: Hunt darkness wherever it breeds - monsters, cultists, evil that preys on the innocent

Methods:

- Seek to cure/redeem when possible (Aldric, Jakob precedents)
- Eliminate threats that cannot be redeemed (Korthak, true believers)
- Protect the vulnerable and forgotten
- Bring Lathander's light to dark places

Structure:

- Riv as Founder and Commander
 - Core members with specialized roles
 - Future: Recruit and train new members
 - Establish chapter houses/fortresses across region
-

This is the complete roster as of the end of Session 3. Save this document and upload it to the project for future sessions!

You said: Can you also generate a Session 3 Summary?

Can you also generate a Session 3 Summary?

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SESSION 3 SUMMARY - THE BATTLE OF THORNHAVEN

SESSION 3 SUMMARY - THE BATTLE OF THORNHAVEN

Date of Play: December 2024

Character Level: Started at 3, ended at 5

Session Length: Epic extended session

OPENING SITUATION

Riv Freeborn woke at The Sleeping Giant after Session 2, having just destroyed the cult totems and driven off Korthak the Alpha. The divine ward protecting Thornhaven's center was weakening (36-48 hours remaining). Korthak waited at the forest edge, patient and deadly.

Elder Wren called an emergency council to plan the village's defense against the inevitable assault when the ward fell.

MAJOR EVENTS

War Council & Strategic Planning

Riv organized Thornhaven's defense with:

- Elder Wren (village leadership)
- Garrick Ironheart (blacksmith, militia leader)
- Mother Nelle (priestess of Chauntea)
- Dagmar & Finn (hunters)
- Harlon (Garrick's deputy)

Riv's orders:

- Evacuate non-combatants, elderly, and children south to Millford
 - Send Aldric Thorne (the cured merchant) ahead on horseback to request aid
 - Fortify The Sleeping Giant as fallback position
 - Investigate marked farmsteads on the cult map to warn/rescue targets
-

Mission to Millstone Farm

Party: Riv, Dagmar

Objective: Investigate marked farmstead, save survivors

Journey:

- 3-hour trek east to the Millstone farm
- Discovered tracks: werewolves had already attacked
- Approached tactically: Dagmar provided overwatch while Riv approached openly

Millstone Farm Battle:

- Found Thomas Millstone critically wounded with werewolf bite
- 2 werewolves attacked the farm
- Combat highlights:
 - Riv cast Cure Wounds (11 HP healed), saving Thomas from death
 - Riv cast Lesser Restoration, successfully purging the lycanthropy curse before it took hold
 - Riv and Dagmar killed both werewolves
 - Jakob Millstone (teenage son) fought bravely with Riv's blessed shield

Rescued: Millstone family (8 people total) - sent them to Thornhaven in wagons

Intelligence Gathered:

- Another cult totem (destroyed by Riv)
- 3 vials of alchemical transformation enhancers
- Crude map confirming cult's systematic targeting

Recruiting Henrik Voss

Location: Isolated cabin in the woods (between Millstone and Harrow farms)

Encounter:

- Tracked lone werewolf to Voss's area
- Henrik Voss: Grizzled monster hunter, 15-year veteran, living in self-imposed isolation
- Riv blessed Dagmar with Bless spell
- Dagmar killed the werewolf with a single silvered arrow (one-shot kill)
- Voss impressed by the tactical coordination and divine blessing

- Voss recruited to help defend Thornhaven and warn the Harrow family
-

Mission to Harrow Farm

Party: Riv, Dagmar, Voss

Objective: Warn Harrow family, investigate cult activity

Discovery:

- Farm already attacked the previous night
- 5 werewolves had slaughtered the family
- Found Jakob Harrow (early 20s) hiding in barn, partially transformed
- Jakob had been bitten 8-10 hours ago, actively fighting the curse

The Night Vigil:

- Cult totem discovered in farmhouse (calling Jakob to complete transformation)
- Riv destroyed totem with divine intervention (no spell slot, pure prayer)
 - Lathander answered directly: "You cannot save everyone, but you can give them the chance to save themselves"
 - Cost: 1 level of Exhaustion
- Jakob fought transformation through entire night with party's support
- 2 werewolves attacked at night (pack sent to collect Jakob)
 - Dagmar killed one with blessed shot
 - Second werewolf fled wounded
- Jakob survived until dawn as a human

Key Moment: Riv promised Jakob training as a Cleric of Lathander if he survived

Return to Thornhaven

Morning after the vigil:

- Met Millstone family on the road (heading to Thornhaven)
- They confirmed: village fortified, ward weakening rapidly
- Arrived in Thornhaven with Jakob

Breaking Jakob's Curse

Participants: Riv, Mother Nelle, Jakob

Location: Shrine of Chauntea

Ritual Requirements:

- Both clerics using Channel Divinity simultaneously
- Riv expending 2nd-level spell slot
- Jakob's willpower to accept healing and reject the beast

Prayer: Riv prayed to Lathander, pledging to train Jakob as a cleric if successful

Result:

- Religion check with advantage: $18+3 = 21$ (Overwhelming Success)
- Lathander directly answered the prayer
- The curse was completely destroyed (not suppressed—annihilated)
- Jakob fully human, no trace of lycanthropy remaining

Jakob's Oath: Pledged himself to Riv and Lathander's service

Aldric's Return

While Riv slept (long rest), Aldric returned from Millford with:

Military Reinforcements:

- 20 Millford soldiers (professional fighters)
- Captain Theron Blackwood (retired garrison captain, experienced commander)
- 2 mounted scouts

Divine Support:

- Sister Mara Ironvow (Cleric of Torm, 2nd Circle, battlefield healer)
- 2 healers with medical supplies

Supplies:

- Supply wagon with weapons, arrows (200+), rations

- 6 silvered weapons (3 shortwords, 2 spears, 1 warhammer)

Cost: Aldric spent his entire fortune and called in old favors

THE BATTLE OF THORNHAVEN

Timing: Ward failed at nightfall

Defenders: ~65-70 total (20 soldiers, 40-45 villagers, core team)

Pre-Battle Intelligence

Riv's Perception check: 21 (Excellent)

- Identified Korthak's strategy: three-pronged assault with feint
- Main gate: Korthak + 2 werewolves (feint to draw attention)
- North/South walls: 3-4 werewolves each (flanking attacks)
- West wall: The real assault (8 werewolves + 6 cultists, hidden force)

Riv's Defense Strategy

Battle Speech: "Four days ago, we didn't know one another... We fight for friend and family. We fight to bring the dawn!"

Force Deployment:

- Main Gate (East): Voss + 5 soldiers + militia (hold the feint)
- North Wall: Dagmar, Clara Millstone + 5 soldiers
- South Wall: Thomas Millstone, Harlon + 5 soldiers
- West Wall (Primary Defense): Garrick, Jakob Harrow, Finn + 10 soldiers
 - 3 bear traps set (concealed)
 - 2 oil barrels positioned for Finn's flaming arrows

Roving Healers:

- Riv (covering East/South)
- Sister Mara (covering North/West)
- Mother Nelle (triage coordination)

Silvered Weapon Distribution:

- Voss: 5 silvered crossbow bolts total

- Dagmar: 5 silvered arrows total
- Sister Mara: Silvered warhammer
- 2 silvered shortswords to west wall defenders
- 1 silvered spear to reserves

The Ward Shatters

At nightfall, the ward exploded into sparks and failed.

Enemy Forces:

- Korthak + 2 pack werewolves (main gate feint)
- 4 werewolves (north wall)
- 3 werewolves (south wall)
- 8 werewolves + 6 cultists (west wall - main assault)

Total: 15 werewolves + 6 cultists + Korthak

Battle Highlights - By Location

SOUTH WALL (Riv's Position)

Round 1:

- 2 werewolves charged the position
- Riv cast Sacred Flame on wounded werewolf: 8 radiant damage (killed)
- Second werewolf breached barricade, engaged defenders in melee

Korthak's Flanking Maneuver:

- Alpha circled south toward Riv's position (targeting the commander)
- Riv cast Guiding Bolt at range: MISS (14 vs. high AC)
- Voss shot Korthak with silvered bolt: HIT for significant damage

Round 3 - Korthak Arrives:

- Korthak + 1 pack werewolf reached Riv's position
- Korthak attacked Riv: 24 to hit, 9 slashing damage (Riv: 30/39 HP)
- Sister Mara arrived, killed pack werewolf with silvered warhammer

- Thomas Millstone and Harlon fought bravely

Round 4 - Riv's Stand:

- Riv cast Bless on Sister Mara, Thomas, Harlon (+1d4 to attacks/saves)
- Korthak attacked again: 24 to hit, 11 slashing damage (Riv: 19/39 HP, badly wounded)
- Concentration check for Bless: 13 SUCCESS (maintained spell despite massive damage)

Round 5 - Divine Wrath:

- Riv stood and declared: "Korthak. I am Riv Freeborn. I am a holy champion of Lathander. And you will FALL!"
- Cast Channel Divinity: Radiance of the Dawn
 - 30-foot radius, 2d10+4 = 16 radiant damage
 - Korthak saved (tough), took 8 damage
 - Both other werewolves at position: FAILED, killed instantly
- Korthak attacked again: 22 to hit, 11 damage
- Riv used Warding Flare (reaction): Forced disadvantage, attack MISSED
- Sister Mara CRITICAL HIT with silvered warhammer, massive damage
- Dagmar arrived, shot silvered arrow into Korthak's back

Round 6 - Korthak's End:

- Korthak on his knees, dying, final words: "The Master will avenge this defeat..."
- Riv: "Your Master holds no dominion here. Lathander's dawn has come."
- Cast Sacred Flame: 8 radiant damage
- Spiritual Weapon (bonus action): 9 force damage
- KORTHAK DEFEATED - collapsed dead

WEST WALL (Main Assault)

Initial Contact:

- 8 werewolves + 6 cultists charged
- 2 werewolves caught in bear traps (screaming, helpless)

- Finn lit oil barrels: 2 werewolves burned to death

Melee:

- Garrick with silvered blade fought brilliantly
- Jakob Harrow (first real battle) held the line with shield
- Finn switched to knife when enemies got close
- Millford soldiers fought professionally

Casualties:

- 2 Millford soldiers killed
- Several villagers wounded
- But the line held

Final Result:

- All 8 werewolves: DEAD
 - 5 cultists: DEAD
 - 1 cultist: CAPTURED ALIVE
-

NORTH WALL

Assault:

- 4 werewolves attacked
- Dagmar dropped one with arrows
- 3 werewolves reached melee
- Sister Mara arrived: killed werewolf with silvered warhammer (one-shot)
- Defenders swarmed remaining two

Casualties:

- 1 Millford soldier killed
- 2 village defenders wounded

Result: Wall held, all werewolves DEAD

BATTLE OUTCOME

Victory Conditions Met:

- Korthak DEAD
- All 15+ werewolves DEAD
- Cult assault force DESTROYED
- Thornhaven DEFENDED

Casualties (Defenders):

- 3 Millford soldiers killed
- 5 village defenders killed
- Many wounded (recovered through healing)

Enemy Losses:

- Korthak (Alpha, 20-year cult champion)
- 15+ werewolves
- 5 cultists killed
- 1 cultist captured

Intelligence Gained:

- Living cultist prisoner for interrogation
- Korthak's ritual scarring and cult medallion
- Crude map of cult territory
- Evidence of "The Master" (cult leader, still at large)

POST-BATTLE EVENTS

Celebration at The Sleeping Giant

Riv's Declaration: "Drinks are on me! Tonight—we celebrate!"

Thornhaven erupted in relief and joy. The tavern became a celebration hall.

Toasts:

- "To the Defender!"
- "To the Fallen!"
- "To Thornhaven! To Dawn!"

The Founding of the Order

Riv's Speech to His Inner Circle:

"Ten years ago, I made a promise. I promised Lathander that I would raise an Order of Knights—true believers and devoted souls—who would scour the land of evil in his name. When Lathander brought me here, I thought it would be just another stop along the way. But now I see it for what it is. My holy mission has begun... We will found the Order of Dawn's Light. Who's with me?"

Founding Members Who Pledged:

1. Garrick Ironheart - "I'll forge weapons for your Order. Count me in."
2. Dagmar & Finn - "You'll need scouts. Finn and I are in."
3. Henrik Voss - "The Order of Dawn's Light has its monster hunter."
4. Jakob Harrow - "I pledge myself to your Order. I am yours." (knelt formally)
5. Aldric Thorne - "Every Order needs logistics. Let me help build this."

Allied Support Pledged:

- Captain Blackwood (military training and reinforcements)
- Sister Mara (Temple of Torm alliance)
- Mother Nelle (spiritual guidance and healing)
- Elder Wren (Thornhaven's resources and labor)

Toast: "To the Order of Dawn's Light! May we bring Lathander's fire to every dark corner!"

Riv's Evening Prayer

Alone in his room as dawn broke, Riv prayed:

"My Lord, Lathander. Thank you for seeing us through this night. Thank you for your guidance and your strength. Thank you for the soft linens, the warm mead, the friendships and the new family I've found. I remain your humble servant. May your light shine upon me, always."

He fell asleep as the sun rose over Thornhaven—his new home, and the birthplace of his Order.

CHARACTER ADVANCEMENT

Riv Freeborn:

- Advanced from Level 3 → Level 5
- Level 4 ASI: +2 Wisdom (18→20)
- Level 5 Benefits:
 - Max HP: 45 (gained 11 total)
 - Proficiency Bonus: +3
 - 3rd-level spell slots gained
 - New spells: Remove Curse, Spirit Guardians, Daylight, Fireball
 - Destroy Undead (CR 1/2)

Jakob Harrow:

- Advanced to Level 1 Cleric (Light Domain)
- First apprentice of the Order
- Future path: Cleric → Paladin multiclass

LOOT & REWARDS

From Battle:

- Korthak's ritual greatsword (can be reforged)
- Cult medallion (high-rank symbol)
- Crude map of cult territory
- 6 silvered weapons (Order's armory)
- Cultist prisoner (for interrogation)

From Thornhaven:

- Permanent room at The Sleeping Giant (free lodging)
- 200 GP from village treasury
- Access to all village resources

- Political authority as Village Defender

From Allies:

- Garrick's promise to forge a weapon for Riv
- Aldric's merchant network
- Military and temple alliances

Total Gold: 269.5 GP personal + 200 GP Order funds

UNRESOLVED THREATS

Immediate:

- Cultist prisoner awaiting interrogation (knows about "The Master")
- Korthak's final words: "The Master will avenge this defeat"

Ongoing:

- "The Master" - Cult leader, identity unknown, promised revenge
 - Unknown number of Malar cultists still active
 - Regional werewolf threat not fully eliminated
-

NEXT SESSION PRIORITIES

1. Interrogate the cultist prisoner (learn about The Master and cult structure)
 2. Choose location for Order's fortress (within day's travel of Thornhaven)
 3. Begin fortress construction (Thornhaven will provide labor)
 4. Train Jakob as first cleric apprentice
 5. Establish Order's reputation (word will spread)
 6. Plan hunt for remaining cult (they will retaliate)
-

KEY RELATIONSHIPS

Riv's Core Team ("The Founding Six"):

- Garrick Ironheart (brother-in-arms, master smith)

- Dagmar (trusted partner, master scout)
- Finn (eager apprentice, growing warrior)
- Henrik Voss (veteran mentor, monster expert)
- Jakob Harrow (first true apprentice, saved soul)
- Aldric Thorne (quartermaster, devoted supporter)

Allies:

- Captain Blackwood (military connection)
- Sister Mara (temple alliance)
- Mother Nelle (spiritual mentor)
- Elder Wren (political patron)
- Millstone family (grateful survivors)

THEMES & CHARACTER DEVELOPMENT

Riv's Arc:

- Transformed from wandering cleric to Order founder
- Fulfilled 10-year-old promise to Lathander
- Found family and purpose
- Proved leadership through both combat prowess and strategic thinking

Order's Foundation:

- Built on redemption (Aldric, Jakob saved from curses)
- Values curing over killing when possible
- Protects the vulnerable and forgotten
- Brings Lathander's light to dark places

Major Decisions:

- Chose to cure rather than kill whenever possible
- Risked everything to save Jakob through the night

- Led from the front despite being severely wounded
 - Built coalition of diverse allies united by common cause
-

EPIC MOMENTS

1. Breaking Jakob's curse through combined ritual and prayer
 2. Riv's battle speech before the final fight
 3. Standing wounded before Korthak: "Your Master holds no dominion here"
 4. Radiance of the Dawn obliterating two werewolves instantly
 5. Founding the Order with all core members pledging their service
 6. The sunrise prayer - quiet, grateful, perfectly in character
-

SESSION STATISTICS

Combat Encounters: 4 major (Millstone, ambush, Harrow vigil, Thornhaven battle)

Enemies Defeated: 20+ werewolves, 5+ cultists, 1 Alpha

Lives Saved: 30+ (Millstone family, Jakob, Thornhaven defenders)

Major NPCs Recruited: 5 (Voss, Jakob, reinforcements)

Curses Broken: 2 (Thomas Millstone, Jakob Harrow)

Alliances Formed: 3 (Millford, Temple of Torm, Thornhaven)

Orders Founded: 1 ★

END OF SESSION 3

Status: Order of Dawn's Light established, Thornhaven saved, cult crippled but not destroyed, The Master still at large.

Next Session Preview: Interrogate prisoner, choose fortress location, begin building the Order's future.

You said: Using what you know of Sessions 1 and 2, can you generate summaries of those sessions as well, in the same format?

Using what you know of Sessions 1 and 2, can you generate summaries of those sessions as well, in the same format?

Dec 8, 2025

Claude responded: SESSION 1 SUMMARY - ARRIVAL IN THORNHAVEN

SESSION 1 SUMMARY - ARRIVAL IN THORNHAVEN

Date of Play: December 2024

Character Level: Started at 2

Session Length: Full session

OPENING SITUATION

Riv Freeborn, a human cleric of Lathander on a pilgrimage through the countryside, arrived in the small farming village of Thornhaven. He was seeking a warm meal, a soft bed, and perhaps a few days' rest before continuing his journey.

What he found was a village under siege.

ARRIVAL & INVESTIGATION

The Sleeping Giant Tavern

Riv entered Thornhaven's only tavern, run by Gerda, a burly, no-nonsense woman. The atmosphere was tense—locals spoke in hushed voices, fear evident in their expressions.

Cost: 5 silver pieces for room, meal, and breakfast

The Village's Problem

While eating, Riv noticed a reward posting on the tavern board:

- 50 gold pieces for solving mysterious livestock disappearances
- Strange howls from Darkwood Forest at night
- Increasing fear among villagers

Elder Wren's Request: The village leader personally asked Riv to investigate. The situation was worsening, and Thornhaven had no defenders capable of handling supernatural threats.

Key NPCs Introduced

Elder Wren - Village leader, elderly but sharp, desperate for help

Gerda - Tavern owner, practical and direct

Mother Nelle - Elderly priestess of Chauntea (goddess of agriculture), tended the village shrine

Garrick Ironheart - Village blacksmith, strong and protective, had a family heirloom: a silvered shortsword passed down for generations

Dagmar - Expert tracker and hunter, lived on village outskirts with her apprentice

Finn - Young hunter's apprentice, Dagmar's student, eager but inexperienced

INVESTIGATION BEGINS

Gathering Information

Riv spoke with villagers and learned:

- Attacks began 3 weeks ago
- Livestock killed and partially eaten
- Howls heard at night from the western forest
- One villager, Marcus, went missing 3 weeks ago while hunting
- Pattern: Attacks every few nights, escalating in boldness

Meeting Dagmar

Dagmar, the village's best tracker, had been investigating. She showed Riv:

- Wolf tracks near attack sites, but unnaturally large
- Signs of intelligence in the hunting patterns
- Evidence pointing to werewolves, not natural wolves

Dagmar's Assessment: At least one, possibly two werewolves. Attacks coordinated and purposeful.

The Silvered Sword

Garrick showed Riv his family's silvered shortsword - one of the few weapons that could permanently harm lycanthropes. He offered it for the hunt, revealing it had been in his family for three generations, originally made to fight "things that walk on two legs and four."

THE PROTECTIVE WARD RITUAL

Mother Nelle's Proposal

The priestess of Chauntea suggested a combined ritual to create a protective ward around the village center:

- Blend Lathander's light (Riv) with Chauntea's harvest protection (Mother Nelle)
- Create temporary sanctuary for villagers
- Buy time to hunt the werewolves

The Ceremony

Location: Village shrine

Participants: Riv and Mother Nelle

Requirements: Both clerics channeling divine power simultaneously

Religion Check (Riv): Strong success

Result:

- Golden-green barrier created around village center
- Protective ward covering approximately 200-yard radius
- Duration: Several days (would weaken over time)
- Effect: Supernatural creatures would find it difficult/impossible to enter

Cost: Riv's spell slot and significant effort from both clerics

The ritual was successful. The village center was now protected, but outlying farms remained vulnerable.

THE FIRST ENCOUNTER

Night Attack

That same evening, as darkness fell, howls erupted from just beyond the village edge.

Defenders Assembled:

- Riv (with mace and holy symbol)
- Garrick (with silvered shortsword and shield)
- Dagmar (with bow and arrows)

The Ward's Edge: Two massive shapes emerged from the darkness, testing the barrier. The protective ward held them at bay, glowing brighter wherever they approached.

Combat - Two Werewolves

Werewolf 1 (The Original):

- Massive, scarred, clearly the alpha
- Intelligent eyes, calculating
- Stayed at range, testing defenses
- Escaped after seeing its companion killed

Werewolf 2 (Marcus - The Turned Villager):

- Recently transformed (3 weeks)
- Less controlled, more feral
- Recognized by villagers despite monstrous form
- Charged recklessly

Combat Highlights:

Round 1:

- Marcus charged outside the ward perimeter
- Dagmar's arrows struck but didn't drop him (not silver)
- Garrick moved to intercept

Round 2:

- Riv cast Guiding Bolt at Marcus
 - 4d6 radiant damage - solid hit
 - Marcus badly wounded, staggered
 - Next attack against him would have advantage

Round 3:

- Garrick engaged with silvered sword
- Cut deep, silver burning the werewolf's flesh
- Marcus howled in pain and rage

Round 4:

- Riv's second Guiding Bolt - KILL SHOT
- Radiant energy consumed Marcus
- He collapsed, transforming back to human form as he died

The Original Werewolf:

- Watched Marcus fall
- Made eye contact with Riv - intelligence and hatred

- Fled into Darkwood Forest
 - Clear message: This wasn't over
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THE AFTERMATH

Marcus's Body

The villagers gathered around the corpse. In death, Marcus had reverted to human form:

- Mid-thirties, farmer, known as a good man
- Had been missing for 3 weeks
- Family was devastated

Mother Nelle's Examination:

- Bite marks on his shoulder (3 weeks old, healed)
- He'd been cursed, not born a werewolf
- The transformation had been forced upon him

Village Reaction:

- Grief for Marcus (he'd been a victim)
- Fear of the original werewolf (still out there)
- Relief that the village center was now protected
- Determination to end the threat

Riv's Reflection

This wasn't a simple monster hunt. Marcus had been an innocent victim, turned against his will. The real threat was the original werewolf - whoever or whatever had cursed Marcus in the first place.

PLANNING THE HUNT

Dagmar's Tracking

The next morning, Dagmar tracked the original werewolf's retreat:

- Headed northeast into Darkwood Forest
- Trail led to a cave system approximately 2 miles in
- Rocky outcrop, defensible position

- This was its lair

Setting Bear Traps

Garrick and villagers prepared:

- 3 bear traps set near the cave entrance
- Hidden under leaves and brush
- Designed to slow or injure the werewolf if it fled

The Hunting Party

Assembled Team:

- Riv Freeborn (Cleric, holy magic and healing)
- Garrick Ironheart (Silvered shortsword, shield, heavy fighter)
- Dagmar (Bow, tracking expertise)
- Finn (Dagmar's apprentice, backup archer)

Silvered Ammunition:

- Garrick's shortsword (only silvered melee weapon)
- Dagmar had managed to silver 7 arrows using what silver she could acquire
- These were precious - every shot had to count

Strategy Discussion

Riv's Approach: Try to talk first, gather information

- Who/what created the original werewolf?
- Is there a larger threat?
- Can it be reasoned with or cured?

Backup Plan: If negotiation fails, eliminate the threat

PREPARATION & GEAR CHECK

Riv's Equipment:

- Chain mail armor (AC 16)
- Mace (primary weapon)
- Holy symbol of Lathander

- Healer's kit
- Rope, waterskin, rations
- Spell components

Garrick's Shop Inventory:

- Shields available - Riv purchased a wooden shield (10 GP) - AC now 18
- Limited supplies (small village forge)
- Bear traps (already deployed)

Riv's Gold: Started with ~89.5 GP, spent 10 GP on shield = 79.5 GP remaining

SESSION END - DAWN EXPEDITION

The Morning

Dawn broke over Thornhaven. The hunting party assembled at the village edge:

- Ward still holding strong
- Village secured behind them
- Darkwood Forest ahead, misty and ominous

Dagmar's Final Brief: "Two miles northeast. Cave in rocky outcrop. We've got bear traps set. Last chance to change the plan, Cleric. Are we still trying to talk first?"

Riv's Response: "We are, yes. We need to find out where this werewolf came from, who they were, and who else we're up against. I have high hopes we'll discover something worthwhile."

Heading Into Darkwood

The party set out into the forest:

- Dagmar at point (tracking)
- Riv and Garrick following
- Finn watching their rear
- Heading toward the werewolf's lair
- Goal: Confront the creature, learn the truth, end the threat

The forest was eerily quiet. No birdsong. No small animals. Just the crunch of frost beneath boots and the knowledge that something dangerous waited ahead.

KEY DISCOVERIES

1. Werewolves are attacking Thornhaven (at least 2, possibly more)
2. Marcus was cursed 3 weeks ago (victim, not willing participant)
3. Original werewolf is intelligent (calculated, tactical retreat)
4. A lair exists in Darkwood (2 miles northeast, cave system)
5. The ward protects the village center (but not outlying areas)
6. Limited silver weapons (Garrick's sword, 7 arrows total)

CHARACTER RELATIONSHIPS ESTABLISHED

Riv & Mother Nelle:

- Spiritual allies
- Successfully performed combined ritual
- Mutual respect between divine casters

Riv & Garrick:

- Warrior partnership forming
- Garrick respects Riv's courage
- Fighting side-by-side

Riv & Dagmar:

- Tactical coordination
- Riv defers to her tracking expertise
- Beginning of strong partnership

Riv & Thornhaven:

- Village defender emerging
 - 50 GP reward offered
 - Trust being earned
-

THEMES INTRODUCED

1. Redemption vs. Elimination: Marcus was a victim - when can cursed beings be saved?
 2. Strategic Thinking: Riv uses wards, preparation, and tactics rather than rushing in
 3. Community Defense: Village coming together, each contributing their strengths
 4. Information Gathering: Riv wants to understand threats before destroying them
 5. Divine Calling: Hints that Lathander brought Riv here for a reason
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COMBAT STATISTICS

Enemies Defeated: 1 werewolf (Marcus - turned villager)

Enemies Escaped: 1 werewolf (original, intelligent alpha)

Spell Slots Used: 2-3 (ward ritual + combat)

Damage Dealt: Significant (Guiding Bolt kills)

Damage Taken: Minimal (stayed at range)

LOOT & REWARDS

Acquired:

- Wooden shield (10 GP purchase)
- Village's gratitude and trust
- Information about werewolf threat

Promised:

- 50 GP reward (not yet claimed)
- Garrick's silvered sword available for the hunt
- Village support and resources

Gold Remaining: 79.5 GP

UNRESOLVED MYSTERIES

1. Who/what is the original werewolf? (Intelligent, escaped)
2. Why did it come to Thornhaven 3 weeks ago? (Timing?)
3. Are there more werewolves? (Pack behavior?)

4. Is there a larger threat? (Cult? Master? Organization?)
 5. Can the curse be broken? (Or only death ends it?)
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SESSION 1 ACHIEVEMENTS

- ✓ Established Thornhaven and key NPCs
 - ✓ Created protective ward (village center secured)
 - ✓ Defeated first werewolf (Marcus)
 - ✓ Gathered intelligence on the threat
 - ✓ Assembled hunting party
 - ✓ Prepared for expedition to werewolf lair
 - ✓ Built relationships with Garrick, Dagmar, Mother Nelle
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END OF SESSION 1

Status: Village protected (temporarily), one werewolf dead, original threat identified and tracked to lair, dawn hunt about to begin.

Next Session Preview: Venture into Darkwood Forest, confront the werewolf in its lair, discover the truth behind the attacks.

SESSION 2 SUMMARY - THE HUNT & THE CULT REVEALED

Date of Play: December 2024

Character Level: 2-3

Session Length: Full session

OPENING SITUATION

Dawn broke over Thornhaven. The hunting party—Riv Freeborn (Cleric), Garrick Ironheart (Fighter/Blacksmith), Dagmar (Ranger/Tracker), and Finn (Scout Apprentice)—prepared to track the werewolf to its lair in Darkwood Forest.

Objective: Confront the intelligent werewolf, learn who/what created it, eliminate the threat to Thornhaven.

Resources:

- 1 silvered shortsword (Garrick)
- 7 silvered arrows (Dagmar and Finn)

- 3 bear traps set near the cave
 - Riv's holy magic
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MOTHER NELLE'S PREPARATIONS

Before Departure

Mother Nelle took Riv aside, offering supplies:

Available Items:

- Blessed water (3 vials, 2 GP) - Riv purchased
- Healing herbs (1 pouch, 2 GP) - Riv purchased

Riv's Private Request: He pulled Mother Nelle aside, expressing concern: "I have this... feeling. I fear things may become worse before they become better. Could you gather medicinal herbs while we're gone? Maybe wood to carve holy symbols? I fear we may need stockpiles before this nightmare ends."

Mother Nelle's Response: She recognized the wisdom in Riv's instincts—clerics learn to trust such feelings. She agreed to organize gathering parties while the hunters were away.

Donation: Riv gave Mother Nelle 10 GP for her aid and the village

Remaining Gold: 69.5 GP

INTO DARKWOOD FOREST

The Journey

Distance: 2 miles northeast through dense forest

Travel Time: ~40 minutes of careful hiking

Terrain: Ancient oaks and pines, heavy canopy blocking light

Atmosphere:

- Eerily quiet - no birdsong, no small animals
- Unnatural silence suggesting predator presence
- Frost-covered leaves crunching underfoot
- Growing sense of being watched

Approaching the Lair

Dagmar's Tracking (Survival Check):

- Fresh tracks leading to the cave
- Werewolf returned here after fleeing last night
- Estimated 3-4 hours old
- Rocky outcrop ahead, dark cave entrance visible
- Bear traps positioned 30 feet out in triangle formation

Tactical Decision: Riv chose to approach openly, calling out, attempting negotiation before violence. Dagmar and Finn positioned with bows, ready to provide covering fire if things went wrong.

THE CAVE - ALDRIC'S RESCUE

Discovery

As Riv approached the cave entrance, calling out peacefully, he heard:

- Weak coughing from inside
- A human voice: "Help... please..."
- Not the werewolf's voice

Inside the Cave

The party found:

- A human man, mid-thirties, chained to the cave wall
- Emaciated, wounded, clearly imprisoned for days
- Dried blood, signs of torture
- The werewolf was not present

The Prisoner: Name: Aldric Thorne

Occupation: Traveling merchant

Situation: Attacked on the road 10 days ago, bitten by werewolf, brought here as prisoner

Aldric's Story

Timeline:

- 10 days ago: Attacked while traveling to Millford
- Werewolf (named Gareth) bit him deliberately
- Brought to cave, chained, tormented

- Forced to transform repeatedly
- Fed scraps, kept barely alive
- Purpose: Gareth was testing the curse, studying transformation

Critical Information:

- Gareth left 2 days ago, said he had "work to do"
- Mentioned "The Master's plan" for Thornhaven
- Spoke of "spreading the gift" to the village
- Aldric was meant to be another attack dog for the cult

Aldric's Curse:

- Bitten 10 days ago
- Had transformed multiple times
- Curse was fully established
- He was terrified he'd lose himself completely

Riv's Critical Decision

Riv had obtained a Remove Curse scroll during his travels (found in a library years ago, kept for emergencies). This was his only one.

The Choice:

- Use it now on Aldric (save him, but have no backup)
- Save it for potential future need
- Try other methods first

Riv's Action: He chose to use the scroll immediately. Aldric was an innocent victim who'd suffered enough.

Breaking Aldric's Curse

Scroll Use:

- Riv read the ancient script carefully
- Combined scroll magic with prayer to Lathander
- Golden-white light surrounded Aldric

- The curse fought back (dark tendrils visible)
- Aldric screamed as lycanthropy was torn from his soul

Result: SUCCESS

- The curse was completely broken
- Aldric collapsed, gasping, but human
- No trace of lycanthropy remained
- He wept with relief and gratitude

Cost:

- Scroll consumed (one-time use)
- Significant spell energy from Riv
- No Remove Curse capability remaining

Aldric's Gratitude

Immediate:

- Pledged his life to Riv
- Offered his merchant journal (contacts, trade routes, valuable information)
- Gave Riv 30 gold pieces (everything he had on him)
- Swore to help Thornhaven however he could

Key Quote: "You saved my life. My soul. I won't forget this. Whatever you need, whenever you need it—I'm yours."

SEARCHING THE CAVE

Evidence Found

Gareth's Belongings:

- Travel pack with supplies
- Crude map with locations marked
- Wooden token carved with profane symbol (Malar - god of the hunt and bloodlust)
- Journal fragments mentioning "The Master" and "the pack"

Intelligence Gathered:

1. Gareth was part of a cult worshipping Malar
2. Multiple locations marked on map (isolated farmsteads)
3. Thornhaven wasn't random - it was targeted
4. Systematic plan to create werewolf pack
5. "The Master" was organizing everything

Riv's Realization: This wasn't one rogue werewolf. This was an organized cult operation to build a werewolf army using forced transformations.

GARETH'S RETURN & DEATH

The Ambush

As the party prepared to leave with Aldric, Gareth returned to the cave:

- Heard voices
- Realized his prisoner had been freed
- Attacked immediately in rage

Combat

Gareth (Werewolf Form):

- Large, scarred, experienced fighter
- Intelligent and tactical
- Vulnerable to silver

Battle Highlights:

Round 1:

- Gareth charged
- Triggered one of the bear traps - SNAP!
- Leg caught, howling in pain and fury
- Thrashing, trying to escape

Round 2:

- Still trapped but attacking from prone position
- Clawed at Garrick who got too close
- Dagmar circled for clear shot

Round 3:

- Dagmar fired silvered arrow - SOLID HIT
- Silver burned, smoke rising from the wound
- Gareth screaming curses about "The Master" and "the pack"

Round 4:

- Gareth tore free of the bear trap (mangled leg)
- Tried to flee despite injuries
- Garrick pursued

Round 5:

- Riv cast Guiding Bolt (4d6 radiant damage)
- CRITICAL MOMENT: The radiant energy struck true
- Combined with silver arrow wounds and bear trap injuries
- Gareth collapsed, dying

Gareth's Final Words

As he lay dying, reverting to human form:

- "The Master... will finish what I started..."
- "Thornhaven will burn... the pack will feast..."
- "You're too late... they're already there..."
- Then death claimed him

The Party's Horror: If Gareth had confederates and they were "already there" - Thornhaven was under attack RIGHT NOW.

RACE BACK TO THORNHAVEN

The Sprint

The party ran back through Darkwood:

- Carrying/supporting Aldric (weak from captivity)
- 2-mile forest sprint
- Growing sounds of alarm bells in distance
- Smoke visible above the trees

Mid-Journey Complication: They encountered a farmstead on fire - the Tomás family farm.

TOMÁS FARM ASSAULT

The Scene

Tomás's Farm (outlying homestead, outside the ward's protection):

- House surrounded by 4 werewolves
- Family trapped inside (Tomás, his wife, young son Willem)
- Werewolves systematically attacking, trying to break in
- Sun was setting - maybe 20 minutes of daylight left

Riv's Decision

Option 1: Rush to Thornhaven (village under major attack)

Option 2: Save this family (but delay aid to village)

Riv chose: Save the family - couldn't leave them to die

Battle at Tomás Farm

Tactical Situation:

- 4 werewolves surrounding house
- Party of 4 (Riv, Garrick, Dagmar, Finn) plus Aldric (unarmed, weak)
- Limited silver ammunition (5 arrows remaining)
- Approaching sunset

Strategy:

- Dagmar and Finn: Ranged support from treeline

- Riv and Garrick: Draw werewolves away from house
- Aldric: Stay hidden and safe

Combat Highlights

Round 1-2: Initial Engagement

- Dagmar's silvered arrow dropped one werewolf (instant kill)
- Other three turned to face the party
- Garrick engaged with silvered shortsword

Round 3-4: Desperate Fighting

- Riv cast Spiritual Weapon (glowing divine hammer)
- Bashed one werewolf repeatedly
- Garrick trading blows, taking damage but holding
- Finn's arrow caught one werewolf in the shoulder

Round 5-6: The Tide Turns

- One werewolf broke away, tried to reach Riv
- Riv cast Guiding Bolt - HIT
- Werewolf dropped, smoking from radiant damage
- Garrick finished another with silvered blade through the heart

Round 7: Final Werewolf

- Last werewolf attempted to flee
- Dagmar's final silvered arrow (her last one) struck it in the back
- Creature collapsed mid-run, dead before hitting the ground

All four werewolves: DEAD

Tomás Family Rescued

Survivors:

- Tomás (father, late 30s, wounded - claw marks across shoulder)
- Wife (name not specified, shaken but alive)

- Willem (son, 8 years old, terrified but unharmed)

Tomás's Injuries:

- Deep claw wounds
- Blood loss
- Not bitten (no lycanthropy risk)
- Needed immediate medical attention

Riv's Healing:

- Cast Cure Wounds on Tomás (1d8+WIS healed)
- Stabilized him enough to move
- Used healer's kit to dress wounds properly

Intelligence from the Farm

Evidence Found in Barn:

- Another wooden token (Malar symbol)
- Crude map similar to what was in Gareth's cave
- Three farmsteads marked including this one
- Werewolves were following a plan - systematic targeting

Tomás's Account:

- Werewolves arrived at dusk
- They seemed to know the farm was there
- Moved with purpose and coordination
- This wasn't random hunting - this was an operation

RETURNING TO THORNHAVEN

Approach at Dusk

Timeline: Sun touching horizon, twilight approaching

What They Saw:

- Village alarm bell ringing urgently

- Barricades being erected at village center
- Defenders scrambling to positions
- Multiple werewolves circling the village (just outside ward range)

Garrick at the Gates: The blacksmith was directing defenders, saw the party returning, and had the barricade opened immediately.

"HOLD! IT'S RIV! OPEN THE GATE!"

The party (plus Tomás family) was pulled through to safety inside the ward's protection.

THE SIEGE BEGINS

The Village Center (Inside the Ward)

Defensive Preparations:

- Barricades of wagons, lumber, furniture at main approaches
- ~50 villagers sheltering in protected area
- Armed defenders (pitchforks, axes, hunting bows, kitchen knives)
- Healing station set up in grain storehouse
- Mother Nelle and Gerda organizing civilians

Key NPCs Present:

- Elder Wren (coordinating)
- Mother Nelle (healing/prayer)
- Gerda (tavern owner, distributing food)
- Garrick (returned, immediately took command of defense)
- Aldric (cleaned up, already helping reinforce barricades)
- Various villagers

The Werewolf Pack

As full darkness fell, the attack began:

Enemy Forces:

- 5-6 werewolves circling the village

- Moving with coordinated tactics
- Testing the ward, looking for weaknesses
- Howling in sequence (communication)

The Pack's Behavior:

- Intelligent and patient
- Not charging recklessly
- Waiting for something
- Almost like they were herding the villagers

The Howls

Three distinct howls, from different directions:

- North: Long, mournful call
- East: Answering howl
- South: Third response

Garrick's Assessment: "They're circling us. Multiple contacts. They're... they're talking to each other."

THE CURSED TOTEMS

Mother Nelle's Discovery

While organizing the healing station, Mother Nelle detected something wrong:

- Unnatural cold near the shrine
- Dark magic she could sense but not identify
- Something was corrupting the area

Investigation: Riv, Mother Nelle, and Garrick investigated the shrine together.

Hidden Corruption

Found concealed in the shrine's storage room:

1. Cursed idol - crude wooden carving of Malar (foot-tall)
2. Wooden token - similar to those found at the caves and Tomás's farm
3. Ritual circle drawn in blood on the floor (dried, days old)

Realization:

- Someone had planted these in the shrine days or weeks ago
- They were drawing the werewolves to Thornhaven
- The totems were beacons and anchors for the curse
- This was why the attacks had been escalating

The Cult's Plan:

1. Plant cursed totems in target locations
 2. Totems draw werewolves and amplify lycanthropic magic
 3. Use werewolves to terrorize and convert villagers
 4. Build an army of forced transformations
 5. Spread across the region systematically
-

THE RITUAL TO DESTROY THE TOTEMS

Mother Nelle's Warning

"These can't just be smashed or burned. The curse is woven into them. We need a cleansing ritual to destroy them properly, or the corruption will linger and spread."

The Combined Ritual

Participants: Riv and Mother Nelle

Location: Village shrine

Time: 12-15 minutes (dangerous delay during siege)

Cost: Divine energy from both casters

Garrick's Promise: "Do what you need to do. We'll hold them off."

He took command of the barricades, organizing desperate defense.

The Cleansing

Process:

- Riv and Mother Nelle prayed in tandem
- Lathander's light and Chauntea's earth magic combined
- Golden-green radiance filled the shrine
- The totems fought back - dark smoke, whispers, promises of power

Religion Check (Riv with advantage from Mother Nelle's aid): Roll: 19 + 5 = 24. CRITICAL SUCCESS!

Divine Annihilation

The shrine EXPLODED with golden radiance:

- Windows shattered outward, blessed glass raining down
- The totems didn't just break - they disintegrated
- Cursed idol and wooden token reduced to ash
- Corruption obliterated completely
- Divine shockwave pulsed outward through entire village

Effect on Werewolves: The pack SCREAMED as the compulsion was severed:

- The totems had been controlling them
- Many of these werewolves were victims like Aldric
- Forced to attack by the cult's magic
- Now freed from compulsion

Four werewolves FLED into the forest, confused and panicked

One remained

KORTHAK THE ALPHA

The True Believer

While the others fled, one massive werewolf remained at the forest edge.

Description:

- Eight feet tall in hybrid form
- Covered in ritualistic scars and brands
- Twenty years of service to Malar carved into his flesh
- Wielding a crude greatsword forged for werewolf hands
- Eyes burning with fanatical devotion

Not a victim. A TRUE BELIEVER.

Korthak's Declaration

He spoke, voice a deep growl carrying across the square:

"PRIEST."

Everyone fell silent.

"You have destroyed my Master's tools. Freed his slaves. You have made this... personal."

"I am Korthak, First of the Pack. I have served the Beastlord for twenty years. I have brought his gift to hundreds."

He drew his massive greatsword.

"Your ward will not hold forever, priest. And when it falls, I will kill everyone in this village. Starting with you."

Then he turned and walked back into the forest.

Not fleeing. Just... waiting.

THE IMMEDIATE AFTERMATH

Situation Assessment

Mother Nelle's Verdict: "The ward will hold for a day. Maybe two if we're lucky. It was meant to be temporary."

The Threat:

- Totems destroyed (no more compulsion)
- Four werewolves fled (scattered and confused)
- Korthak remains - veteran cult champion, waiting for the ward to fail
- "The Master" still out there - cult leader, identity unknown

Status:

- One werewolf corpse at the barricades (killed during panic)
- Several hours until dawn
- Riv exhausted, no spell slots remaining
- Everyone wounded, terrified, but alive

RIV'S SPEECH

Riv addressed the gathered villagers:

"People, we have won a victory tonight that will be felt for generations to come. We have held out against insurmountable odds. We are alive tonight because of you and your devotion to our Gods. We praise Chauntea and Lathander this night for their gifts."

"So rest. Enjoy the comfort of your loved ones. Our ward will hold tonight and under its protection, we are safe. Tomorrow, however, the real work begins."

To Elder Wren:

"I have no intention of moving on until this crisis is dealt with. If you grant me office within the village, I will pledge myself to your cause. We will forge Thornhaven into an impenetrable stronghold against the werewolf threat."

THE TITLE GRANTED

Elder Wren's Response

The elderly leader placed both hands on Riv's shoulders:

"Riv Freeborn, Cleric of Lathander. You came to us a stranger. In two days, you have saved us twice—once from the curse, once from annihilation."

"By the authority vested in me as Elder of Thornhaven, I grant you the title of Village Defender and seat you on our council."

She placed a bronze medallion around his neck - symbol of Thornhaven (sheaf of wheat crossed with oak branch).

"Your word carries weight in this village now. Your plans will have our support. We are yours to lead in this fight."

Grants and Benefits

Political Power:

- Seat on village council
- Authority in defensive matters
- Can requisition resources
- Bronze medallion (symbol of office)

Practical Benefits:

- Free room and board at The Sleeping Giant (indefinitely)
- Access to village forge, supplies, labor

- Villagers will volunteer to help
- First claim on useful items

Social Capital:

- Respected by all village leaders
 - Trusted completely
 - Authority to command
-

NOTABLE RELATIONSHIPS

People Riv Saved/Helped:

- Aldric Thorne: Cured from lycanthropy, deeply grateful, pledged support
 - Tomás, Wife, and Willem: Rescued from werewolf attack
 - Mother Nelle: Spiritual ally, ritual partner, mentor figure
 - Garrick: Trusted warrior, "brother-in-arms"
 - Dagmar & Finn: Respect Riv's tactical mind and courage
-

SESSION END - PREPARATIONS

The Night Winds Down

- Garrick organized watch rotations
- Dagmar and Finn scouted perimeter at dawn
- Villagers sheltered in tavern and surrounding buildings
- The werewolf corpse was burned
- Tomás and Willem given room to rest

Riv's Rest

Mother Nelle insisted Riv get proper rest: "Before you make grand plans for tomorrow, child, you need REST. You're wounded, you've expended every ounce of divine power you possess, and you've barely slept in two days."

Riv was given a room at The Sleeping Giant. He fell asleep exhausted but victorious.

Status:

- Village saved (for now)
 - Cult's immediate plan disrupted
 - Four werewolves scattered
 - Korthak waiting outside the ward
 - 1-2 days until ward fails
 - Tomorrow: fortification and preparation
-

LOOT & REWARDS

From Aldric's Cave:

- Aldric's merchant journal (trade route info)
- 30 gold pieces from Aldric
- Small coinpurse

From Tomás's Farm:

- Hunting crossbow + 3 dozen bolts (now in village armory)
- Tools, lumber, nails (for fortifications)
- Crude map (marked farmsteads - intelligence)
- 3 vials dark liquid (alchemical transformation enhancers)
- Second Malar token (destroyed in ritual)

Current Gold: 69.5 GP (after donations and purchases)

THREATS REMAINING

Immediate:

- Korthak the Alpha (waiting outside ward)
- 4 fled werewolves (scattered, no longer compelled but still dangerous)
- Ward expires in 1-2 days

Larger Threat:

- "The Master" (cult leader, identity unknown, now personally aware of Riv)

- Unknown number of cult members
 - Systematic plan to spread lycanthropy
 - Regional threat, not just Thornhaven
-

KEY DISCOVERIES

1. Organized cult worshipping Malar (god of bloodlust/hunt)
 2. Cursed totems draw and control werewolves
 3. Systematic targeting of isolated communities
 4. Forced transformations creating unwilling werewolf army
 5. "The Master" leads the cult
 6. Korthak is veteran champion (20 years serving Malar)
 7. Multiple marked farmsteads exist (not just Thornhaven)
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THEMES & CHARACTER DEVELOPMENT

Riv's Choices:

- Used his only Remove Curse scroll on Aldric (no backup plan)
- Chose to save Tomás family despite village being under attack
- Risked the ritual during siege (trusted Garrick to hold)
- Accepted responsibility and title as Village Defender

Moral Complexity:

- Not all werewolves are evil (victims vs. true believers)
- Korthak vs. the freed pack (different threats)
- Cult using forced conversion (violation of free will)

Leadership Emerging:

- Riv making command decisions
- Others naturally following his lead
- Balancing tactical and ethical considerations

LEVEL ADVANCEMENT

Riv Freeborn advanced to Level 3

New Features:

- 2nd-level spell slots (2 slots)
- More prepared spells available
- Channel Divinity gained additional use options

COMBAT STATISTICS

Enemies Defeated:

- Gareth (original werewolf from Session 1)
- 4 werewolves at Tomás farm
- 1 werewolf at village (during panic)
- Total: 6 werewolves

Enemies Fled: 4 werewolves (freed from compulsion)

Enemies Remaining: Korthak + unknown cult members

SESSION 2 ACHIEVEMENTS

- ✓ Rescued Aldric, broke his curse completely
- ✓ Defeated Gareth, ended immediate werewolf threat from cave
- ✓ Saved Tomás family from farm attack
- ✓ Discovered cult organization and Malar connection
- ✓ Destroyed cursed totems, freed controlled werewolves
- ✓ Granted title of Village Defender
- ✓ Identified Korthak as primary remaining threat
- ✓ Learned of "The Master" and larger conspiracy

END OF SESSION 2

Status: Village saved for now, ward weakening, Korthak waiting, cult awareness established, Riv accepted leadership role, preparations must begin for final confrontation.

Next Session Preview: Dawn breaks on new Thornhaven, fortifications must be built, allies gathered, and the village prepared for Korthak's inevitable assault when the ward falls.

All three session summaries complete! These can be saved to the project for reference in future sessions.